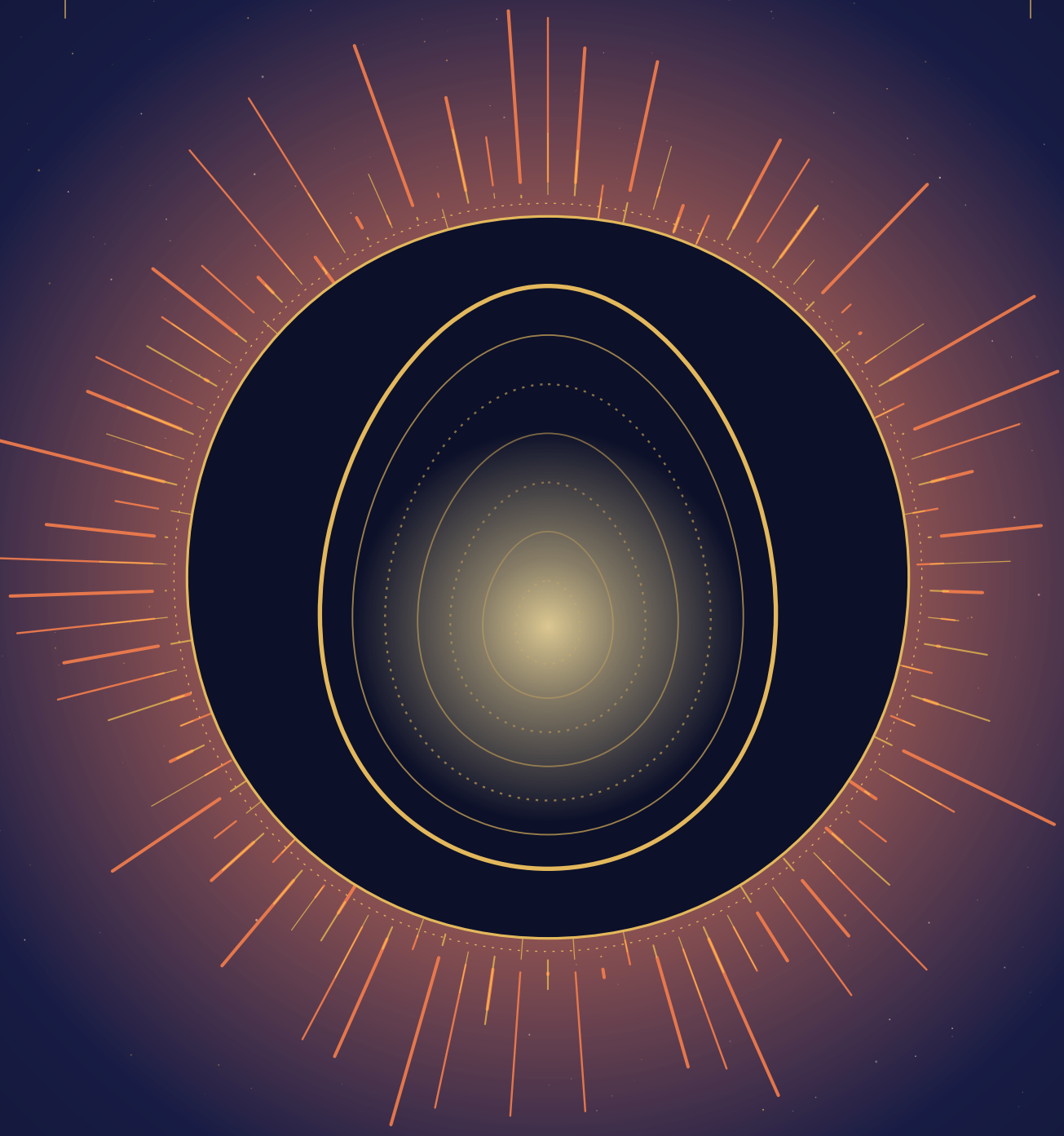
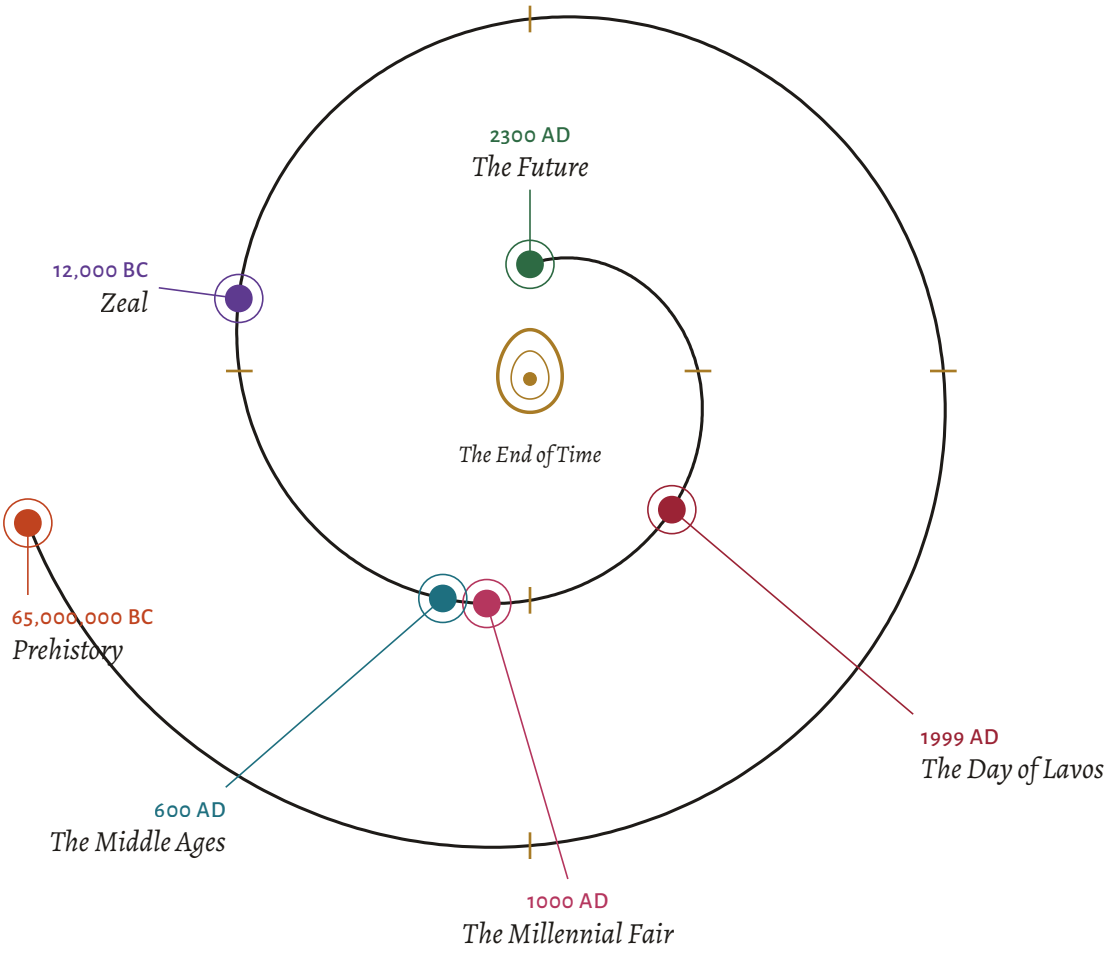


The Big Fire and the Time Egg



The eras of the game, coiled around the End of Time.
Each quarter-turn of the coil reaches ten times further back from 2300 AD.



The Big Fire and the Time Egg

Chronophagy, Kairotic Apokatastasis, and the Heterochronic Commonwealth in Chrono Trigger

A Doctoral Thesis in Comparative Literature,
the Philosophy of Time, and Game Studies

Written by Claude Opus 5.5
Assembled by Andrew Van Blair



The Big Fire and the Time Egg

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Set in Alegreya and Alegreya Sans, with Noto Serif CJK for Japanese and Chinese and Frank Ruhl Libre for Hebrew.

First edition, 2026
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αἰὼν παῖς ἐστι παίζων, πεσσεύων· παιδὸς ἡ βασιληίη.

"Time is a child at play, moving pieces on a board; the kingship belongs to a child."

— Heraclitus, DK 22 B52

...ἄχρι χρόνων ἀποκαταστάσεως πάντων...

"...until the times of the restoration of all things..."

— Acts 3:21

"...es un fuego que me consume, pero yo soy el fuego."

— Jorge Luis Borges, "Nueva refutación del tiempo" (1947)

Abstract

This dissertation offers a systematic philosophical reconstruction of *Chrono Trigger* (Square, 1995), the time-travel role-playing game credited to three directors, Takashi Tokita, Yoshinori Kitase, and Akihiko Matsui. Masato Kato wrote most of the script from an outline by Yuji Horii, and Tokita and Kitase supplied sub-scenarios. Critics commonly treat the game as a superbly executed anthology of time-travel conventions whose philosophy amounts to the slogan that the future can be changed. I argue instead that it is a rigorously organised speculative philosophy of *stored time*. In this thought-system time is not a line to be walked. It is a substance that builds up in genomes, forests, stones, names, eggs, and festivals, and it can either be burned or incubated. I reconstruct the argument from three registers that point the same way: the game's in-world metaphysics (the Gates, the End of Time, the changeable past); its procedural rhetoric, meaning the arguments its rules make (combination techniques, multiple endings, the New Game+ structure); and its existence in two languages. The Japanese original and Ted Woolsey's 1995 English localisation are read *stereoscopically*, as two faces of a single work.

The first regime of time the game stages I call **chronophagy** ("time-eating"). Its agent is Lavos, an alien parasite whose only name is the one the prehistoric Ayla gives it, "big fire." From beneath the planet's crust it feeds on sixty-five million years of accumulated life. Read alongside Hesiod's Kronos, the Heraclitean and Stoic world-conflagration (*ekpyrōsis*), Lovecraft's "The Colour Out of Space," Clarke's alien catalysts of evolution, the Alvarez impact hypothesis, Darwin's ichneumon wasp, Schrödinger's negentropy, and Marx's vampire-capital, Lavos becomes the figure of an extractive temporality that turns duration into combustion. Its civilisation is the magocracy of Zeal, which taps the time-eater through the 魔神器 (*majinki*, "demon-god vessel"), renamed in English the Mammon Machine. I read Zeal's floating continents as a *ukiyo* hung over an *uki-yo*, a floating world above a sorrowful one, and as an allegory of extraction-based enlightenment. The comparison set here is Plato's Atlantis, Swift's Laputa, Wells's Eloi and Morlocks, Heidegger's *Gestell*, Adorno and Horkheimer, and Le Guin's Omelas.

The counter-regime I call **kairotic apokatastasis**, after the pairing of *kairoi* ("opportune times") with *chronōn apokatastaseōs pantōn* ("the times of the restoration of all things") in Acts 3:20–21. Its emblem is the object the English localisation calls the "Chrono Trigger" and the Japanese text calls 時の卵 (*toki no tamago*), the "Time Egg." With it a single instant is seized and a dead man is restored inside that instant. Drawing on Paul's *atomos*, Kierkegaard's

Øieblikket, Nietzsche's two-faced gateway "Augenblick," Benjamin's *Jetztzeit*, Bergson's *durée*, Arendt's theory of forgiveness, Dōgen's *uji*, Kuki Shūzō's modal theory of time, and the cosmic eggs of the Orphic theogony and the *Nihon shoki*, I show that the game's restorative sub-scenarios set out a theory of redemption that reduces neither to Stoic recurrence nor to straight-line eschatology.

The agent of that redemption is neither a lone hero nor a chosen people. It is what I call the **heterochronic commonwealth**: a polity of people from different times, namely a prehistoric chieftain, a medieval knight turned amphibian, a post-apocalyptic android, and a deposed prince of antiquity. Their solidarity makes literal Bloch's *Gleichzeitigkeit des Ungleichzeitigen* (the simultaneity of the non-simultaneous) and Burke's partnership of the dead, the living, and the unborn, and its form is festive rather than sovereign. Because a Millennial Fair frames the game at both ends, the game sets Bakhtinian carnival against Lovecraftian cosmic terror. The dissertation closes by proposing an **oöchronic ethics**, an ethics of the egg against the fire, as the game's unstated contribution to the philosophy of time. Its claim is that a world's stored time should be incubated rather than burned, and that the present owes the past and the future custody, not extraction.

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Prefatory Note

On Texts, Translation, and Plural Authorship

i. CORPUS. The primary text is *Chrono Trigger* in the two versions released in 1995 for Nintendo's 16-bit console. The Japanese edition appeared on March 11, 1995, and the North American edition on August 22, 1995, the latter localised by Ted Woolsey. I consult the PlayStation (1999) and Nintendo DS (2008) editions where their additions matter for interpretation. The most consequential addition is the DS edition's supplementary episode, which fuses Lavos and Schala into an entity that fan reference works list among Lavos's aliases: Dream Devourer (after merging with Schala) and Time Devourer (*Chrono Cross*). These editions are treated as later layers, not as the work's original surface. Kato's *Radical Dreamers* (1996) and *Chrono Cross* (1999) serve as after-the-fact glosses. Feeling that Chrono Trigger ended with "unfinished business", scenarist Masato Kato wrote and directed the first of them. That justifies using them, but it also counsels caution: a sequel is an interpretation of its predecessor, not its hidden meaning.

ii. Nomenclature. Japanese terms are given in kana or kanji at first mention, with Hepburn romanisation. The hero is "Crono" when the English text is meant; his name is spelled "Chrono" in Japanese materials, and that spelling is used when the Japanese name, and its pun on time, is in question. Eras follow the game's own designations: 65,000,000 BC, 12,000 BC, 600 AD, 1000 AD, 1999 AD, 2300 AD, and the extra-temporal End of Time.

iii. Plural authorship. Following the credits, this thesis names the work by its three directors, Takashi Tokita, Yoshinori Kitase, and Akihiko Matsui. The same credits list four writers. Directors: Takashi Tokita; Yoshinori Kitase; Akihiko Matsui … Writers: Masato Kato; Takashi Tokita; Yoshinori Kitase; Yuji Horii. The documentary record complicates any single-author attribution. Kato's own account divides composition into three layers: Horii wrote the basic plot line first; Kato then edited and rewrote it; and after that the sub-scenarios were created by Tokita and Kitase. A detailed reconstruction of the production adds that none of them were actually present from the start. Matsui mostly handled battles, while Tokita and Kitase were brought in a year into development as Sakaguchi was upset that development didn't move as fast as planned. Kato subsequently edited and completed the outline by writing the majority of the game's story, including all the events of the 12000 BC era, and devised the system of multiple endings because he could not branch the story out to different paths. Continuity was enforced collectively: Kato and other developers held a series of meetings to ensure continuity, usually attended by around 30 personnel.

Tokita's stake was ambivalent. He has said he did not want to work on Chrono Trigger as he considered it as a rival to his own game at the time, Live a Live, so it was a painful experience for him.

This thesis turns that historical fact into a principle of method. In place of an auteur it proposes a heuristic stratigraphy, a reading of the work in layers:

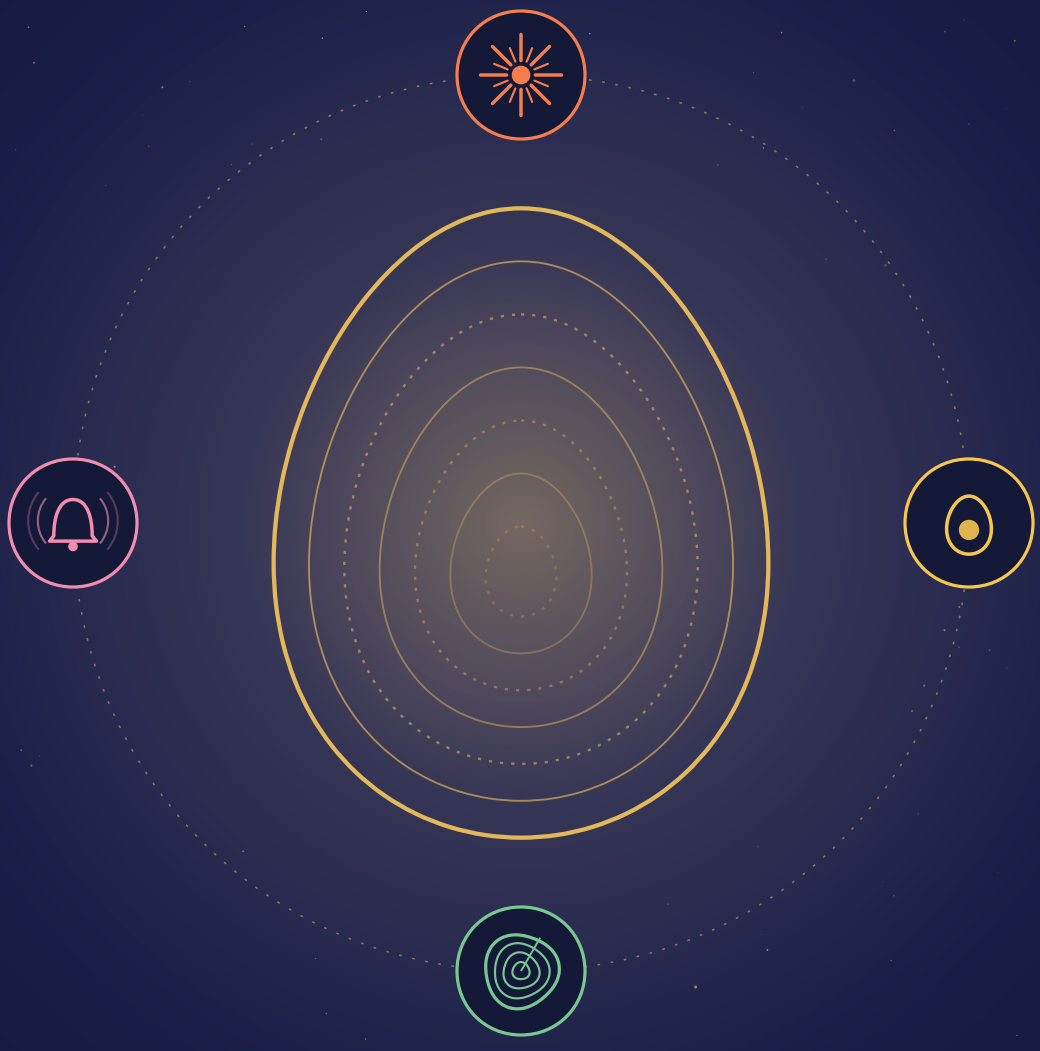
- **The main scenario** (Horii's outline, realised by Kato) carries the game's metaphysics of catastrophe and of the decisive instant: Lavos, Zeal, and the death of the hero. It therefore carries the regimes this thesis calls chronophagy and kairos.
- **The sub-scenarios** Kato credits to Tokita and Kitase carry, to a striking degree, the work's restorative ethics. This holds if, as seems likely, those sub-scenarios include the late-game episodes in which a particular wound in a particular era is healed. This layer carries the apokatastasis.
- **The battle system** associated with Matsui carries, procedurally, the politics of combination that Chapter 7 calls the commonwealth.

The stratigraphy is a reading aid, not a forensic finding, because collaborative authorship spreads intentions beyond recovery. It has two merits. It places the signatures of the three credited directors exactly where this thesis places the work's most original thought. And it acknowledges that a work about a commonwealth of non-contemporaries was itself made by one, a team gathered across rival franchises. Square dubbed the "Dream Team" three designers: Hironobu Sakaguchi, creator of Square's Final Fantasy series; Yuji Horii, creator of Enix's Dragon Quest series; and Akira Toriyama, character designer of Dragon Quest and author of the Dragon Ball manga series.

iv. Lexicon of constructs.

- *Chronophagy* (χρόνος + φαγεῖν, "time" + "to eat"): the extraction and consumption of accumulated time, whether evolutionary, ecological, historical, or archival, by an agent that converts it into power or heat.
- *Kairotic apokatastasis*: the restoration of what time has destroyed. It comes neither through cosmic recurrence nor at the end of history, but inside a seized instant, through agents acting within it.
- *Heterochronic commonwealth*: a polity whose members are non-contemporaries, bound by a common task concerning a time that none of them alone inhabits.
- *Pyric, ovular, lignous, festal time*: four regimes in which stored time is, respectively, burned, incubated, grown, and celebrated.
- *Oöchrony* (ᾠόν, "egg," + χρόνος, "time") and *oöchronic ethics*: the thesis's culminating construct, an ethics of custody over stored time, figured by the egg.

- *Stereoscopic reading*: reading the Japanese original and the English localisation as two slightly different images whose fusion produces interpretive depth.



Introduction

Introduction

Aiōn at Play

I. A Game About Time

Heraclitus's fifty-second fragment is among the earliest sentences in which Greek thought binds time to play. The *aiōn* it names is not the measured *chronos* of the astronomers. It is a lifetime, the vital span. In Homer it is the life-substance that leaves the body at death. In Plato it becomes the eternity of which *chronos* is the "moving image" (*Timaeus* 37d). The fragment's three clauses make up a figure that *Chrono Trigger* would rebuild as working machinery two and a half millennia later. Time is a child. The child is moving pieces in a board game (πεσσεύων, *pesseuōn*). Sovereignty, ἡ βασιληίη, belongs to the child.

Each element returns in the game with structural exactness. The board is a world map divided across seven ages. The pieces are characters drawn from those ages. The sovereignty belongs to the young. A runaway princess, an adolescent inventor, a silent boy, and a child-prince grown into a sorcerer decide the fate of a planet. The adult sovereigns are absent, impersonated, or demonic: a king deceived by a monster disguised as his chancellor, a queen intoxicated by an alien god, a machine-mother planning genocide. "The kingship belongs to a child" is the game's political premise before it is its mode of being played.

A game about time is more than a game whose story concerns time. It is a structure in which the player's own time is set against a represented time, and the represented time is itself made navigable, reversible, and revisable. Jesper Juul calls these "play time" and "event time" (Juul 2004). The time-travel role-playing game doubles this layering. The player's irreversible hours of play are spent moving among represented hours that can be reversed. The represented world reaches the player as a set of time-indexed spaces: a Middle Ages, a future, a prehistory, each a room in a house of eras. The question of time is posed in the game's form before its story raises it.

This dissertation therefore asks three questions, corresponding to the three terms of its subtitle:

1. **Metaphysical.** What must be true of time for the game's world to hang together?
2. **Ethical.** What must be true of the good for the game's ending to count as happy?

3. **Political.** What must be true of agency for these particular protagonists to be the right agents of that good?

My answer is that the game assumes a metaphysics of *stored time*, an ethics of *restoration within the instant*, and a politics of *non-contemporaneous solidarity*. These three assumptions fit together into a single speculative philosophy. It has not been named, but it can be stated.

II. The Diegetic Datum

In 1000 AD the Kingdom of Guardia celebrates its millennium with a fair. There the silent Crono meets a girl who calls herself Marle. Her real name is Princess Nadia, and she has slipped out of the castle. When she tries an inventor's teleporter, it reacts with her pendant and creates a time Gate, sending her to the Middle Ages and kicking off the events of the game. In 600 AD she is mistaken for her own ancestor, Queen Leene, who has been abducted. When the search for Leene is called off, Marle fades out of existence until the true queen is rescued. The game introduces its central metaphysical problem, the genealogical dependence of the present on the past, through this ancestor paradox in its first hours.

Later the travellers find themselves in 2300 AD, among domed shelters where the survivors starve. From a dying computer they recover the record of a catastrophe dated 1999 AD, the "Day of Lavos," and they resolve to prevent it. Its causes stretch back across sixty-five million years. Lavos is a parasitic alien that falls from the skies in 65,000,000 B.C.; its impact results in an ice age, and the ensuing ice age causes the Reptites, an advanced species of reptilian humanoids, to go extinct, incidentally ensuring the survival of the human race. In 12,000 B.C., the Kingdom of Zeal is powered by the energy of Lavos through the use of the Mammon Machine, although this relationship is symbiotic, with Lavos also gathering the kingdom's magic. When the machine is driven too hard, Lavos wakes, Zeal falls into the sea, and temporal rifts scatter the queen's three Sages. Melchior is sent to AD 1000, Belthasar to AD 2300, and Gaspar to the End of Time. The Sage of Time thus ends up in a non-place outside time, a hub from which pillars of light open onto every era.

At the centre of the story Lavos annihilates the hero. The game does not end. The surviving party receives from the Sage of Time an egg that lets them seize the instant of Crono's death and substitute a double for his body. Afterwards the party, now drawn from five eras and two species besides the human, works through a series of restorations. An android plants a forest over four centuries. An inventor rescues her mother from the accident that crippled her. A knight transformed into a frog receives absolution from the ghost of his slain friend. Then the commonwealth confronts Lavos. The confrontation resolves into an

unusually large number of possible conclusions, because Kato devised the system of multiple endings because he could not branch the story out to different paths.

III. Sources: Documented Genealogy and Constellated Philosophy

The user's brief asks for the originators of the ideas that inspired the writing. Two kinds of source must be kept strictly apart: those the documentary record attests, and those this thesis brings into constellation with the work.

(a) Documented genealogy. The time-travel premise was not part of the original concept. An uncredited Square employee suggested that the team develop a time travel-themed game, which Kato initially opposed, fearing repetitive, dull gameplay. Its champion was Horii: a fan of time travel fiction, Horii fostered the theme of time travel in his general outline of Chrono Trigger with input from Akira Toriyama, after which Kato and Horii met several hours per day during the first year of development to write the game's plot. One secondary account goes further: the well-received story twist in this game was actually conceived by Horii Yuji, and the game was originally created for that twist. If the twist is the hero's death, as is usually supposed, then the kairos analysed in Chapter 5 sits at the genetic centre of the work. Kitase has also confirmed that the beginning of the game, with Marle's paradox, was fleshed out very early in the development process. The ancestor paradox is therefore original to the work's conception, not a later ornament.

Particular characters have documented sources. Ayla was created by Chrono Trigger director Takashi Tokita and illustrated by Akira Toriyama; Tokita was inspired by singer Ouyang Fei Fei when making her and her name was taken from the Clan of the Cave Bear character of the same name, and he also added her due to a lack of simple, instinct-driven characters and the potential for humor, and identified her as his favorite character in the game. Lavos has Lovecraftian influences, with its Japanese name possibly referencing Ravukurafuto, the Japanese rendering of "Lovecraft". The two classical name-layers belong to different hands:

- The **Biblical layer** of the English text is Woolsey's. Belthasar, Gaspar, Melchior, and Magus were inspired by Biblical characters, but Kato did not especially have the Bible in mind when writing the story and was not aware of the names created by the translator Ted Woolsey.
- The **Greek layer** belongs to the Japanese text and its sequel. The android's true name is Prometheus; his sister unit Atropos XR is named after the ancient Greek Fate of future and bringer of death, and the security units around Chronopolis are named Atropos, Lachesis and Clotho, after the three Fates of Greek myth.

The production context adds further antecedents:

- **Toriyama's own work.** The android-and-time-machine arc of *Dragon Ball* (1991–1993) sends Trunks from a ruined future into the past to prevent it.
- **Tokita's *Live A Live* (1994).** Seven protagonists from seven eras, including a speechless prehistoric hunter and a robot of the far future, assemble in its final chapter against a demon king who was once a hero. Chapter 7 treats it as the commonwealth's direct prototype.
- **Japanese millenarian culture.** Nostradamus's quatrain X.72 promised a "great King of Terror" from the sky in 1999. In Japan it was popularised by Gotō Ben's *Nosutoradamusu no daiyogen* (1973).
- **Contemporary palaeontology.** The Alvarez impact hypothesis (1980) and the identification of the Chicxulub crater (1990–91) had just made the end of the dinosaurs a story of fire from the sky.
- **Post-apocalyptic manga and anime.** These include *Hokuto no Ken*'s nuclear "199X," Ōtomo's *Akira*, and Miyazaki's *Nausicaä* (1982–1994) and *Laputa* (1986).
- **The Hollywood paradox film.** *Back to the Future* (1985), whose fading photograph Marle's paradox echoes, and *Terminator 2* (1991), whose "no fate but what we make" is the game's unspoken motto.

(b) Constellated philosophy. None of this licenses the claim that the developers read Benjamin, Bergson, or Dōgen. The second class of sources works by convergence, not influence. My method is Benjamin's *Konstellation*: „Bild ist dasjenige, worin das Gewesene mit dem Jetzt blitzhaft zu einer Konstellation zusammentritt" ("The image is that in which what-has-been comes together with the now in a flash to form a constellation"; *Passagen-Werk*, N 3,1). On this method the philosopher is not the work's cause. The philosopher is the work's other half, separated by a historical distance that interpretation briefly closes. The method is therefore built like the Gate it studies. It opens passages between a 1995 cartridge and texts from Heraclitus to Agamben, and, like the party's interventions, its legitimacy is measured by what the passage restores.

IV. Method: Stereoscopy, Procedural Hermeneutics, Comparative Speculation

Three instruments are used together.

Stereoscopic reading treats the Japanese original and the English localisation as two images of one object, taken from slightly different angles. Charles Wheatstone's stereoscope (1838) showed that neither of two flat images contains depth. Depth arises in their binocular fusion. In the same way, the philosophical depth of *Chrono Trigger* appears only when its two texts are read together. Chapter 1 sets out the method and its theory, which draws on Benjamin's "Die Aufgabe des Übersetzers" (1923) and Lawrence Venuti's distinction, published the same year as the game, between domesticating and foreignising translation (Venuti 1995).

Procedural hermeneutics reads rules as arguments. This follows Ian Bogost's "procedural rhetoric" (Bogost 2007) and Espen Aarseth's account of "ergodic" texts, which demand non-trivial work to traverse (Aarseth 1997). Many of the game's most consequential claims appear in no line of dialogue. They are made by its systems:

- **The Gates** admit no more than three travellers at a time, so the commonwealth has to be recomposed constantly.
- **Spekkio** grants magic to every party member except the machine and the prehistoric woman.
- **Double and Triple Techs** fuse two or three characters' abilities into attacks none of them could produce alone.
- **New Game+** (つよくてニューゲーム, *tsuyokute nyū gēmu*, "New Game, but strong") lets the player re-enter history while keeping everything earned.

Comparative speculation places the game among speculative fictions that pose the same problems. The method follows Darko Suvin's definition of science fiction as the literature of "cognitive estrangement," organised around a *novum* (Suvin 1979), and Frank Kermode's account of how fiction turns the empty succession of *chronos* into the charged *kairos* of plot (Kermode 1967). The comparison set includes Wells, Twain, Bradbury, Heinlein, Asimov, Leiber, Borges, Vonnegut, Le Guin, Butler, Lovecraft, Clarke, Stapledon, Lem, Swift, Plato's Atlantis, Miyazaki, Toriyama, *Doctor Who*, *La Jetée* and *12 Monkeys*, *Terminator*, and *Back to the Future*. The aim is not to dissolve the game into its genre. It is to isolate its *novum*. This thesis identifies that novum as *stored time*, a substance that can be burned or hatched, and argues it has no exact precedent in the time-travel canon.

V. Argument and Architecture

The argument proceeds through four regimes of time, all treated as dispositions of a single substrate:

- **Pyric time** is time burned. Lavos ("big fire") and Zeal convert accumulated duration into energy.
- **Ovular time** is time incubated. The Time Egg holds potential that is released in a single kairos.
- **Lignous time** is time grown. Robo's forest, the seed recovered in the starving future, and the Sun Stone that charges across geological ages embody duration that cannot be hurried.
- **Festal time** is time celebrated. The Millennial Fair and the replay structure turn duration into a commons and a renewal.

The heterochronic commonwealth is the political subject able to resist the first regime by inhabiting the other three.

The chapters follow the figure:

- **Chapter 1** shows that the founding opposition of fire and egg can already be read in the work's names, once the double text is read stereoscopically.
- **Chapter 2** reconstructs chronophagy. Lavos appears as Kronos, as Lovecraftian meteor, as cosmic parasitoid, as Stoic conflagration without regeneration, as fossil energy, and as an archive that has eaten history.
- **Chapter 3** reads Zeal as the civilisation of the time-eater: a floating world, a dialectic of enlightenment, an Omelas.
- **Chapter 4** formalises the Gates. They require hypertime, refuse branching, convert necessity into contingency, and, in the manner of a *pharmakon* (remedy and poison at once), are wounds Lavos itself has made in time.
- **Chapter 5** reads the Time Egg as kairos: the death of the hero who bears the name of time, his resurrection in the twinkling of an eye, and the egg as cosmogony.
- **Chapter 6** sets out the ethics of restoration. Duration, forgiveness, and memory complete what intervention alone cannot, and an unrestored remainder (Schala) keeps the restoration honest.
- **Chapter 7** constitutes the commonwealth itself.

- **Chapter 8** returns to the Fair: carnival against cosmic terror, the many endings as Leibniz's palace of possible worlds, and New Game+ as Kierkegaardian repetition.
- **The Conclusion** draws these results into an oöchronic ethics.

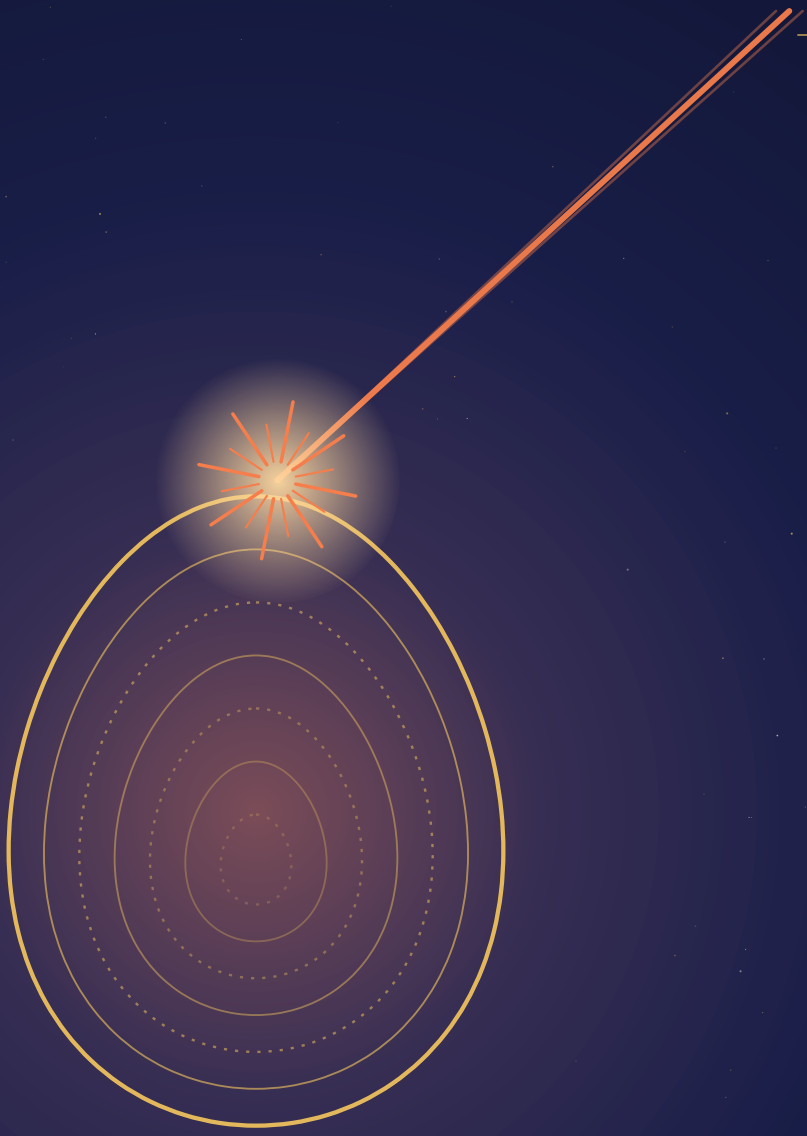


Figure 1 *The four regimes of stored time and the political subject that mediates them.*

ラヴォス

Ravosu

“Lavos”



Chapter One

1

The Name of the Fire

Onomastics and the Double Text

1.1 Ayla's Word: Catastrophic Nomination and the Verbal Fossil

Interpretation of *Chrono Trigger* has to begin with a word spoken in 65,000,000 BC. Lavos initially crash-lands on the planet in 65,000,000 B.C., an event witnessed by the prehistoric Ayla, who coins the name "Lavos" by combining the Iokan words for "big" and "fire". The creature has no other name. As Lavos is a name invented by humans, its true name, if one exists, is completely unknown. The word outlasts the event it records. Among the Iokans and Larubans, the fall would be remembered as the day "big fire" burned the Reptites, and Ayla's label for 'Lavos' would also survive as the humans retreated to the caves.

Three consequences follow, each with its own philosophical lineage.

First, the naming reverses Adam's. In Genesis 2:19–20 the first human names the creatures paraded before him in the garden. Benjamin's essay "Über Sprache überhaupt und über die Sprache des Menschen" (1916) reads this act as the translation of the mute language of things into the name, a name in which the creature's essence is communicated. Ayla's naming is the post-lapsarian, indeed post-impact, counterpart. She names something that falls on the garden, not something paraded through it. What she names is not an essence but an appearance in the sky, which is to say an event. I call this **catastrophic nomination**. The first act of the human archive in this fiction is to give a name to what destroys, and the human relation to Lavos is mediated from the start by a word older than any civilisation in the game.

Second, the name is a reference fixed by baptism, not a definition. In Saul Kripke's terms (*Naming and Necessity*, 1980), Ayla performs an "initial baptism" by ostension: she points at the fire. The description "big fire" *fixes the reference* of the name without *giving its meaning*. The name goes on referring, across sixty-five million years, to an entity whose nature turns out not to be fire at all. Lavos's secondary and tertiary forms are technological

in nature, suggesting some form of intellect, and it is an organism that feeds and reproduces. The descriptive content is phenomenological ("what it looked like to us"), not essential ("what it is"). The game thus encodes a Kantian modesty in its very lexicon: humanity knows the catastrophe only as phenomenon, and the thing in itself stays nameless.

Third, the name is itself a time traveller. It is carried by a causal-historical chain from the Iokan campfire to the computer archives of 2300 AD, where the catastrophe is still called the "Day of Lavos." It is the only entity in the game, apart from Lavos itself, that persists intact through every era. I call it a **verbal fossil**, and the word is chosen with care. Like the creature it designates, the name lies buried through deep time and comes up again unchanged. Thing and name share one mode of existence. Both are deposits.

The comparative contrast sharpens the point. Lovecraft's "Cthulhu" (1928) is an alien's own name, imperfectly heard, whose syllables are said to exceed the human vocal organs. Its horror lies in its foreignness. Lem's *Solaris* (1961) surrounds its alien ocean with a Latinate taxonomy ("symmetriads," "mimoids") that names much and explains nothing. Ayla's word is the opposite of both. It is two syllables, easy to pronounce, entirely human, and makes no claim to transcribe the alien. It is a nominalism of the phenomenon, and its humility is its authority. The name sets the elemental key of the whole work: the antagonist is named for the element of combustion. The android's true name is Prometheus, the thief of fire. The 1999 apocalypse is a rain of fire. The game's thermodynamics of names, which this thesis follows to its conclusion, begins at a prehistoric campfire.

One further layer must be recorded. Ayla's name comes from Jean M. Auel's *The Clan of the Cave Bear* (1980), whose heroine is a Cro-Magnon girl raised by Neanderthals, a figure standing at the boundary where one human species succeeds another. Auel's novel is a novel of supersession. Its Neanderthals are fated to give way to "the Others." *Chrono Trigger*'s Ayla also stands at a boundary of succession, between the Reptites and the mammals, and her word records the event that decides between them. Her adversary sees it coming: no preventative action could be taken, and the Reptite leader Azala surmised that the fall would cause an unmitigable Ice Age for millions of years. The borrowed name thus imports its source's theme. The one who names the catastrophe is the one whose species inherits the world because of it.

1.2 Overdetermination: Lava, *Labes*, Lovecraft

In *Die Traumdeutung* (1900, ch. VI) Freud calls an element of the manifest dream *überdeterminiert*, overdetermined, when several latent thoughts converge on it through condensa-

tion (*Verdichtung*). The name "Lavos" is overdetermined in exactly this sense. At least three determinations condense in it.

1. **The in-world etymology.** "Big fire" in Iokan, as above.
2. **The extra-textual cryptonym.** As noted, the katakana ラヴォス (*Ravosu*) shares its opening ラヴ (*rav-*) with ラヴクラフト (*Ravukurafuto*), "Lovecraft." On this reading the monster's name encodes its literary genealogy.
3. **The paronomastic chain** (association by sound), which is the richest. The creature rises from beneath the crust in 1999 in what is, phenomenally, a volcanic event, and its name sounds like *lava*. Italian *lava* (Neapolitan, "torrent, stream") is traced either to Latin *lavare*, "to wash," or to *labes*, from *labi*, "to slip, to fall." The meanings of *labes* map almost exactly onto Lavos's career:
   - *a falling, a sinking-in*: Lavos falls from the sky and buries itself in the planet;
   - *ruin, destruction*: the Day of Lavos;
   - *a stain, a blemish*: and here the chain enters theology.

Labes is the technical Latin word for the stain of original sin. Pius IX's bull *Ineffabilis Deus* (1854) defines the Virgin as preserved *ab omni originalis culpae labe*, "from every stain of original fault." Read through this word, Lavos is a *labes originalis* of the planet: a fall, at the dawn of mammalian history, whose stain marks everything after it. The theological structure is then completed by the Exsultet of the Easter Vigil: *O felix culpa, quae talem ac tantum meruit habere Redemptorem*, "O happy fault, that merited such and so great a Redeemer." Chapter 2 argues that Lavos is precisely a *felix culpa*. Without the fall there would be no ice age, no extinction of the Reptites, no human dominion, no magic, and no Gates. The catastrophe founds the world that must defeat it.

No claim of intention is made here. A Japanese child in 1995 would not hear Latin, and an American child might hear "lava" without hearing *labes*. The overdetermination is spread across audiences. That is why it can be recovered only stereoscopically, by a reading that holds several linguistic worlds in view at once. The name is a condensation in Freud's precise sense: an over-full sign in which separate chains of meaning, in-world, literary-historical, and theological, meet without anyone having planned the meeting.

1.3 Chrono/Crono, Egg/Trigger: The Title as Antinomy

In both editions the title is an English phrase, written クロノ・トリガー in Japanese katakana and *Chrono Trigger* in roman letters. The two texts disagree about what the phrase

names inside the story. In the North American text the title is also the name of the object the Sage of Time gives the party so they can bring back the fallen hero, so the title and the instrument are the same thing. The Japanese text lists that object as 時の卵 (*toki no tamago*), the "Time Egg," so the title and the instrument come apart. One text uses a single name and the other uses two names that pull against each other. This thesis argues that the work's meaning lives in that tension.

The first word. In Japanese the hero's default name is the first word of the title. His name is spelled "Chrono" in Japanese materials. The protagonist is named Time. The English spelling *Crono* lost its *h* because of a hardware limit: the localiser had to keep every name within the game's five-character limit for names. Cutting six letters to five turned *Chronos* into *Kronos*, at least on the page. The machine's economy of bytes thereby repeats one of antiquity's most productive confusions. Plutarch reports that the Greeks read Kronos allegorically as Chronos (*De Iside et Osiride* 32, 363D). Cicero adds the etymology this thesis borrows for Chapter 2: Saturn is so called *quod saturaretur annis*, "because he is glutted with years." He is said to have eaten his own children because time consumes the spans of time and is never filled by the years that have passed (*De natura deorum* 2.64). The Japanese hero is named for time, and the English hero carries the name of the god who devours his children. The English spelling names what will happen to him, since at the Ocean Palace he is devoured. The Japanese spelling names what he is. Chapter 2 shows that the real Kronos of the work is Lavos. The truncated English name records the hero's fate as the creature's victim.

The second word. In English, *trigger* names a theory of causation before it names an object. A trigger is a small lever that releases a large stored force. Physiological and physical science of the late nineteenth century made this a concept in its own right. Julius Robert Mayer's essay "Über Auslösung" (1876) separated causes that are proportionate to their effects from *Auslösungsursachen*, release-causes that set off a reserve of energy far larger than themselves. Nietzsche took the distinction into philosophy in *Die fröhliche Wissenschaft* §360, "Zwei Arten Ursache, die man verwechselt" ("Two kinds of cause that are confused"). On one side stands a dammed-up quantum of force waiting to be spent. On the other stands the trivial accident that releases it, the match set against the powder keg. Read through Mayer and Nietzsche, the English title implies that the decisive instant of the story is a match, and that what it ignites was stored up long before. The powder keg brings a regime with it, because a trigger belongs to firearms, and a firearm is combustion in a tube. In English, then, the instrument of salvation carries a name from the vocabulary of the big fire.

The egg. The Japanese text answers with an embryology. An egg also stores potential: the yolk is food laid up in advance for a life that does not yet exist. Aristotle makes the egg a

model case of *dynamis* (potential) moving toward *energeia* (actuality) (*De generatione animalium* III). William Harvey's *Exercitationes de generatione animalium* (1651) opens with a frontispiece in which Zeus opens an egg that releases every kind of creature, inscribed *EX OVO OMNIA* ("everything from the egg"). Egg and trigger are both ways of releasing stored potential, but they differ in how the release happens.

- **Detonation** releases potential by destroying its container. It is instantaneous, irreversible, and gives off energy. The instant is a spark, and nothing about the spark has to be ready.
- **Hatching** releases potential by bringing its container to term. Its instant is a threshold reached through duration, and that threshold cannot be forced. Violence can break an egg at any time, but only time can hatch it.

The difference can be stated as a Kantian antinomy:

THESIS. The decisive instant is a *trigger*: an efficient cause out of proportion to its effect, releasing stored force through destruction.

ANTITHESIS. The decisive instant is a *hatching*: a final cause matured in duration, releasing stored life through development.

Kant resolved his antinomies by showing that each side was true of a different order of things. The resolution here, worked out in Chapter 5, is different. The Time Egg is a trigger whose charge is life. Its instant is an *Auslösung* (release) of incubated time, and it looks like a detonation only because a single moment discharges what centuries of duration have stored. That compound, a hatching that has the speed of a trigger, is what this thesis calls *kairotic apokatastasis* (restoration within the seized moment).

A note on reception completes the section. To a Japanese player in 1995 the title was doubly foreign, since it was an English phrase in phonetic script with no native echo. It functioned as a pure label for something new, the estranging *novum* that Suvin makes the mark of speculative fiction. To an anglophone player the same phrase was familiar machinery. The Japanese audience therefore received the title as a name, while the English audience received it as a description. Every opposition traced in the rest of this chapter has this two-sided structure.

1.4 Bird and Epoch: The Ornithological and the Mechanical Texts

The time machine shows the same split in the two texts. In Japanese, as one etymological study notes, the vehicle is called シルバード (*Shirubādo*), which can be transliterated a few different ways but which usually gets rendered in English as something like Sill Bird. The same study observes that シルバー on its own can mean "silver" and バード on its own "bird." The English name came out of haste. Woolsey's credit, he only had about a month to localize the game, so … it's entirely possible that he saw the Japanese name, シルバード, couldn't figure out what a Sill Bird was and jotted down *epoch* because it was time-related. The constraint produced, by accident, one of the most philosophically loaded words in Greek.

The word *epochē*. Ἐποχή comes from ἐπέχω, "to hold back, to check," and its history reads as a short treatise on time and attention:

- *Astronomy.* An epoch is the moment at which a heavenly body is observed in a fixed position. It is the reference instant from which motions are reckoned.
- *Chronology.* By extension it becomes the fixed point from which an era is counted, and then the era itself.
- *Pyrrhonian scepticism.* In Sextus Empiricus, *epochē* is the suspension of judgement that follows from setting opposing appearances against each other and leads to tranquillity (*Outlines of Pyrrhonism* I.8–10).
- *Husserl.* In *Ideen I* (1913, §32) the phenomenological ἐποχή "brackets" the natural attitude. Belief in the world is not denied; it is put out of action so the world can be described as it appears.
- *Heidegger.* In "Der Spruch des Anaximander" (*Holzwege*, 1950) the epochs of history become Being's *Ansichhalten*, its holding-back of itself. Each epoch is the way Being withholds itself while lighting up beings.
- *Blumenberg. Die Legitimität der Neuzeit* (1966) studies the *Epochenschwelle*, the threshold between ages, which can be identified only after it has been crossed.

A time machine called "suspension" is apt. It brackets the natural attitude toward time, the felt flow of the A-series (time experienced as past, present, and future, discussed in Chapter 4) in which the past is simply gone. In that bracketed state the traveller can treat every era as present-at-hand. The English text therefore imagines time travel as a phenomenological operation, a principled stepping-back from the flow.

The Japanese pairing. The Japanese text imagines it as flight. The game's two instruments of time are, in Japanese, an egg and a bird. These two images have been linked across the cosmogonies of the world. The Orphic theogony has the gleaming egg from which Phanes hatches. The *Nihon shoki* begins with heaven and earth still undivided, a chaotic mass "like a hen's egg" (渾沌如鶏子). Chapter 5 develops these cosmogonies. For now it is enough to note that the Japanese text organises its time-instruments as a biological sequence, egg and then bird, potential and then flight. The English organises them as mechanism and measure: firing-lever and suspension. The Japanese text is *ornithological*, the English *mechanical and chronometric*. Neither is a degraded copy of the other. They are two theories of what it means to move through time.

The plot adds a further detail. In the English text the vehicle gains its wings only after Dalton, Zeal's ambitious commander, seizes it, refits it, and mounts it on Zeal's airship, the *Blackbird*. In English the bird appears in the name of only one machine, and it belongs to the enemy. The Japanese text's bird of time therefore becomes fully a bird through the war-machine of the civilisation that eats time. The instrument of rescue acquires its wings from the instrument of extraction. This is an early case of the *pharmakon* structure examined in Chapter 4, where the means of salvation originate in the wound.

The ornithological text also suggests a theory of time that the English loses. Birds are the animals of seasonal return. Jeremiah 8:7 contrasts the stork, the turtle-dove, the crane, and the swallow, which "observe the time of their coming," with a people that does not know the judgement of its God. The Septuagint renders their appointed times as καιρός, the word this thesis uses for the opportune moment. In the scriptural imagination the bird is the creature that knows its *kairos*. A time machine named after a bird is one that knows when to return. That points ahead to the Japanese name of the frog-knight (§1.6), which contains the verb "to return."

1.5 Dream and Omen; Vessel and Mammon; Light and Earth

Three further pairs show the two texts dividing the same object between a psychological and a semiotic register, between sovereignty and capital, and between cosmology and morality.

(a) Dream and omen. The final dungeon, a fortress Queen Zeal raises over history, is 黒の夢 (*kuro no yume*) in Japanese, "the Black Dream." Woolsey renamed it *the Black Omen*. The Japanese name contains a homophone the English could not keep: *kuro no*, "of black," sounds exactly like *Kurono*, the hero's name. To a Japanese ear the Black Dream can also be heard as "Chrono's dream." The game's ultimate fortress of evil shares a sound with the

dream of the hero who bears the name of time. Nothing documents that this was intended. It is a sound-level overdetermination, but it opens a reading that Chapter 3 develops. Zeal's fortress is the nightmare form of the time-traveller's own project: a will to stand above all eras, holding them in view at once.

The game's rules build this vertical relation to history into the fortress. Japanese guides explain that the Black Dream appears in every era, but once it has been cleared, the Black Dream in all later eras disappears. They therefore advise clearing it in the order present → Middle Ages → antiquity, so that it can be cleared three times in total. Two things follow. The rules demonstrate a causal model in which an intervention erases everything downstream (Chapter 4). And players have turned the theorem into a harvest, walking backward through the ages to strip the same dream of its treasures three times. Chapter 8 asks whether this exploit counts as innocent play or as a small chronophagy of the player's own.

The two names converge in antiquity, where the dream was itself a kind of omen. Artemidorus's *Oneirocritica* separates "theorematic" dreams, which show what will happen, from allegorical ones, which encode it. The oldest Western theory of dreams is already a theory of gates. In *Odyssey* 19.560–569 Penelope says false dreams come through a gate of ivory (ἐλέφας, punning on ἐλεφαίρομαι, "to deceive") and true ones through a gate of horn (κέρας, punning on κραίνω, "to fulfil"). Virgil sends Aeneas out of the underworld through the ivory gate (*Aeneid* 6.893–898). A work whose temporal architecture is made of Gates thus revives, without knowing it, the Homeric claim that the future reaches us through doors that sort truth from deception. Zeal's dream is the ivory gate. The commonwealth's work is to find the gate of horn.

(b) Vessel and Mammon. The device through which Zeal draws on the time-eater is 魔神器 (*majinki*). The pixiv encyclopedia's entry on Schala records that Queen Zeal assigned her the role of drawing out Lavos's energy with a device called the 魔神器. The compound joins 魔 (*ma*, "demonic, magical"), 神 (*shin/jin*, "god"), and 器 (*ki*, "vessel, instrument, container"). Its centre, 神器 (*jingi/shinki*), is the word for sacred regalia, as in 三種の神器 (*sanshu no jingi*), the Three Sacred Treasures of the Japanese imperial line: the mirror Yata no Kagami, the sword Kusanagi no Tsurugi, and the jewel Yasakani no Magatama. The prefix 魔 makes the device a *demonic regalia*, a perverted emblem of a sovereign's legitimacy. Queen Zeal rules by possession of a sacred vessel that holds an alien god.

Woolsey's *Mammon Machine* moves the same object from sovereignty to capital. Mammon (Aramaic *māmōnā*, "wealth") is what one cannot serve alongside God (Matthew 6:24; Luke 16:13). In Milton he is the "least erected Spirit that fell," the one by whose suggestion men "Ransack'd the Center, and with impious hands / Rifl'd the bowels of thir mother Earth / For Treasures better hid" (*Paradise Lost* I.679–688). Milton's Mammon is the patron of mining, and the Mammon Machine mines a god buried in the earth. Stereoscopically,

the two names show the two historical forms of extraction-based sovereignty: the throne that consecrates what it extracts and the market that turns it into a commodity. Chapter 3 treats them as one machine seen from two sides.

(c) Light and earth. Zeal's social order is named differently in the two texts. In Japanese, according to the same entry, those with magical talent live in the sky city as the "People of Light" (光の民), while those without are driven to the frozen lands as the "People of the Earth" (地の民). The pair is symmetrical and cosmological. Light stands to earth as heaven to ground, and both words take the same noun, 民 (*tami*, "folk"). Woolsey's *Enlightened Ones* and *Earthbound Ones* break the symmetry and moralise it. "Enlightened" brings in the whole European *Aufklärung*, Kant's "Ausgang des Menschen aus seiner selbstverschuldeten Unmündigkeit" ("humanity's exit from its self-incurred immaturity," 1784). "Earthbound" brings in bondage and attachment. The English thereby makes Zeal an allegory of Enlightenment's dialectic, which is the subject of Chapter 3. Adorno and Horkheimer's *Dialektik der Aufklärung* (1944/47) could have been written for a civilisation whose enlightenment depends on a buried god.

The Japanese text keeps a sentence that undoes both binaries. Schala tells the exiles: 我ら光の民も、もとはあなた達と同じ ("We People of Light were once the same as you"). The supposedly essential difference is historical, and the light is borrowed. The people of light are lit by Lavos, the big fire, so their "light" is the glow of combustion. This inverts the Gnostic schema, in which pneumatic sparks of a heavenly light are trapped in matter. In Zeal the "pneumatics" are those who have learned to burn what lies beneath them.

1.6 Sages and Magi; Jaki and Janus; the Five Verbs of Kaeru

(a) Sages and Magi. In Japanese the three advisers of Zeal are the Gurus (Japanese: 賢者 Kenja "Sages"), and their names form a rhyming triad. One correspondence table gives Belthasar | Gash; Gaspar | Hash; Melchior | Bosh. A Japanese player's blog confirms the middle term in its own wording, "the Sage of Time, Hash" (時の賢者ハッシュ). In Japanese they are a nursery-rhyme triplet: names chosen for sound, without reference. Only by coincidence does ボッシュ also transliterate the name of the painter of *The Garden of Earthly Delights*.

Woolsey turned the rhyme into a revelation. As the record shows, some of the names used in the English localization of the game were inspired by Biblical characters, including Belthasar, Gaspar, Melchior, and Magus. However, Kato did not especially have the Bible in mind when writing the story and was not aware of the names created by the translator Ted Woolsey. The unintended result is an inverted Nativity. Matthew's magi follow a star to a

birth (Matthew 2:1–12). The game's sages are scattered by something that, when Lavos first appeared in the sky, it looked like a red star, and they reassemble around a resurrection. The traditional gifts can be mapped onto them, though Matthew neither names nor counts the magi and their names and gifts come from later tradition. In the Western tradition consolidated in the early medieval period, Melchior brings gold, Caspar frankincense, and Balthasar myrrh.

- **Melchior (gold).** The game's Melchior is a metallurgist. He forges the Masamune and the Red Knife from Dreamstone, the rare red ore of prehistory.
- **Gaspar (frankincense).** Frankincense is the offering to divinity, smoke rising toward the timeless. Gaspar keeps the End of Time and gives the Egg through which a man returns from death.
- **Belthasar (myrrh).** Myrrh is the spice of embalming (John 19:39). Belthasar is met in 2300 AD only through the memories he left in the keeping of a Nu, so he is the preserved dead whose mind survives in an archive.

The mapping is the localisation's accident, not the authors' design. Chapter 6 nonetheless argues that the accident is structurally true: the three sages carry the three operations of restoration, which are forging (making), resurrecting (restoring), and remembering (preserving).

(b) Demon King and Magus; Jaki and Janus. The Japanese title of the game's second antagonist is 魔王 (*Maō*), "Demon King." It is the generic role of the Japanese role-playing tradition that Horii's own *Dragon Quest* established. Woolsey's "Magus" moves the figure from the conventions of a genre into heresiology, the study of heresies. The most famous magus of Christian tradition is Simon Magus, who tried to buy the power of the Holy Spirit with money (Acts 8:9–24). Irenaeus made him the father of all heresies (*Adversus haereses* I.23). In English, Zeal's lost prince carries the name of the man who confused grace with purchasable power, which is Mammon again.

The prince's childhood name splits more sharply still. In English he is *Janus*, the Roman god of doorways (*ianua*), beginnings, and transitions. Janus faces both ways, and the gates of his temple stood open in war and closed in peace. The name suits a child swallowed by a Gate at Zeal's fall who grows into an enemy who becomes an ally, a self that looks back at its past and forward at its future. In Japanese he is ジャキ (*Jaki*). Any Japanese reader hears in that name 邪気 (*jaki*, "malice, evil spirit") and 邪鬼 (*jaki*), the small demons trampled under the feet of the Four Heavenly Kings in Buddhist temple sculpture. The Japanese name predicts the demon. The English name predicts the gate.

A related renaming deserves a sentence. The princess known in Japanese materials as Marle has the formal name Princess Nadia (マールディア, Mārudia; "Marldia") in English.

Nadia, through the Russian *Nadya*, short for *Nadezhda*, means "hope." Whatever the localiser intended, the English princess carries the name of the principle Ernst Bloch made the centre of a philosophy of the not-yet (Chapter 7).

(c) The five verbs of *kaeru*. The knight Glenn, transformed by the Demon King, is known by his amphibian form in both texts. A fan list of name changes gives Frog = Kaeru. In English the name is a plain noun, and its literary relative is the first tale in the Grimms' collection, "Der Froschkönig oder der eiserne Heinrich" (KHM 1), which Chapter 6 reads as the model of Glenn's story. In Japanese, *kaeru* (カエル) belongs to one of the language's densest homophone clusters. Five verbs share its sound, and together they state the game's whole programme:

1. **帰る** (*kaeru*), *to return home*: the traveller's homecoming and the closing of every journey through time.
2. **還る / 返る** (*kaeru*), *to revert, come back*, as in 生き返る (*ikikaeru*), "to return to life": the resurrection at Death Peak.
3. **変える** (*kaeru*), *to change*, as in 未来を変える, "to change the future": the game's founding resolution.
4. **代える / 替える** (*kaeru*), *to substitute, exchange*: the replica body put in the hero's place in the frozen instant (Chapter 5).
5. **孵る** (*kaeru*), *to hatch*: what the Time Egg does.

Japanese custom has long drawn on this cluster. Frog amulets are carried by travellers so that they may "return safely" (無事カエル, *buji kaeru*), and are also prized for *wakagaeru* (若返る), "becoming young again." A party of time-travellers that carries a frog-knight therefore carries, in Japanese, an amulet of safe return. And Glenn alone in the party bears, in his name, the verb for what the egg does. The Japanese text compresses its ethics of change, return, substitution, revival, and hatching into the name of a frog. The English text keeps the fairy tale and loses the verbs. Read together, they yield the formula of Chapter 6: the frog prince's disenchantment is a form of hatching.

1.7 The Prometheus Dome, the Mirror-God, and the Condiments of Evil

(a) Prometheus. In 2300 AD the travellers find a dormant android in a shelter that Japanese walkthroughs call プロメテドーム, the "Promete Dome." One describes how beyond the gate in the Promete Dome lay a mysterious space no one could place. The building bears its sleeper's true name. His real name is Prometheus (プロメテス, "Purometesu"), though

when the party first wakes him the true name is not what they use. When the party asks its name it notes its serial-number is R-66Y, as the serial number is not personable the party get to rename it, the default being "Robo". The English *Proto Dome* removes Prometheus from the place-name and puts in *proto-*, "first," the prefix of the prototype. The renaming fits the android's story arc. A being whose maker regards him as defective (Mother Brain, Atropos XR, and the rest of the R-series are always telling him that he is useless and has malfunctioned; that his true purpose was to study humans in anticipation for the genocide against humans) is treated by his rescuers as a prototype of something new rather than a failed unit of something old.

The Japanese text writes his Promethean name on his cradle. The English makes him a beginning. Both texts make him wait for his name to come back. Only late, at the factory where he was made, he remembers his true function was to survey and service humans and prevent Mother Brain from spreading her poisonous tyranny to the other robots.

The mythology is exact and opposed to the big fire. Prometheus stole fire for mortals (Hesiod, *Theogony* 535–616; *Works and Days* 42–105) and suffered for it in Aeschylus's *Prometheus Bound*. Lavos is a fire that feeds on mortals. The thief who gives fire is matched against the fire that takes. The Promethean android's great act, in Chapter 6, is not to give fire at all. He grows a forest over four hundred years, which is lignous time set against pyric time.

His companion carries the counter-name. Prometheus's sister unit, Atropos XR, is named after the ancient Greek Fate of future and bringer of death. Atropos (ἄ-τροπος) is "she who cannot be turned," the Fate who cuts the thread. In the Myth of Er, Plato assigns the three Fates to the three tenses: Lachesis sings what has been, Clotho what is, and Atropos what will be (*Republic* X 617c). The android from the future therefore loves the Fate of the future. This is fitting in a world where the future is the tense under threat, and Atropos herself is turned. The Greek frame continues into the sequel. The security units around Chronopolis are named Atropos, Lachesis and Clotho, after the three Fates of Greek myth, and in Chrono Cross, Robo makes an appearance as the Prometheus Circuit that was terminated by FATE. Masato Kato has officially gone on record as stating the circuit is Robo. The Greek layer of the work culminates in a contest between Prometheus and Fate, between the one who gives humans a future and the machine that would fix one for them. Chapter 6 places it in a line running from Aeschylus to Mary Shelley's "Modern Prometheus" (1818) and Percy Shelley's *Prometheus Unbound* (1820). The English "Robo" adds a further genealogy. Through Čapek's *R.U.R.* (1920), *robot* derives from the Czech *robota*, "forced labour," so the android's everyday name keeps the memory of servitude while his true name keeps the memory of rebellion.

(b) The mirror-god. At the End of Time the travellers meet the being who grants them magic. Japanese walkthroughs call his chamber the room of Spekkio, the god of battle, and note that since Robo cannot learn magic, Crono, Marle, and Lucca perform the ritual of learning magic. A wiki's character entry records the same exception in English terms: Spekkio cannot grant him the power to use magic (Spekkio being unable to properly read his character). Spekkio's name sounds like the Italian *specchio*, "mirror," and he behaves like one: the form in which he appears when challenged changes with the level of the party's leader. He shows the party its own strength reflected back. The god of battle is a mirror-stage god in Lacan's sense (1949), an external image in which a subject meets its power as other.

One speculative constellation should be marked as such. If the Mammon Machine is a demonic regalia (§1.5b), the party carries a counter-regalia that matches the imperial three: a sword (the Masamune), a jewel (Marle's pendant, the Dreamstone that opens the first Gate), and a mirror (the god who reflects the party's power). The demonic vessel drains a god. The counter-regalia is made of the same buried ore, Dreamstone, that the Sage of Life forges, and it is used to restore.

(c) The condiments of evil. The Demon King's three generals are where the two texts are funniest and most revealing. In Japanese they are named after the kitchen. A fan list gives Ozzie = Bi-Ne-Ga (Vinegar) Flea = Ma-Yo-Nai (Mayonaise) Slash = Soi-Sou (Soy Sauce), corrected in the same thread to Mayonnai and Soysau. The developers chose this deliberately. Humorous names were chosen for several characters. The staff noted that this kind of humor would have been impossible in the Final Fantasy series. Toriyama's own *Dragon Ball*, with its warrior race named after vegetables, belongs to the same comedy of names.

The English text renames them Ozzie, Flea, and Slash. An anglophone ear of 1995 could hardly miss the rock pantheon in those names: Ozzy Osbourne, heavy metal's "Prince of Darkness"; Flea of the Red Hot Chili Peppers; Slash of Guns N' Roses. The Japanese text brings evil down to the condiment cruet, and the English brings it to the concert stage. These translations are independent and use different means, yet both turn the Demon King's court into carnival. One uses Bakhtin's banquet, the lowering of the high into food and the body. The other uses spectacle, where the demonic becomes pose and performance. Agreement reached independently is the strongest evidence a stereoscopic reading can produce, and Chapter 8 builds on it.

The comic register coexists with real metamorphosis. Flea, known as Mayonnai (マヨネー, Mayonē) in Japanese, is a fictional character in the Chrono series of video games. He is a shapeshifter that presents as feminine but identifies as a man and, in Japanese, uses feminine signifiers in his speech. The double text here has a third, regulatory layer: during English localization, the nature of Flea's character was partially lost due to Nintendo of

America's strict policies on "sexually suggestive or explicit content." Feminine signifiers, such as a feminine manner of speaking, tildes, long vowel marks, and heart icons were absent in the English version. Even an item was renamed: The Japanese version features an item called Mayonnai's Bra which was censored and changed to Flea Vest in the English version. The text that reached anglophone players had passed through a censor as well as a translator, so stereoscopy has to allow for a third lens. Flea also belongs to the work's Ovidian side. A knight made a frog, a prince made a demon king, a hero replaced by a replica, and a shapeshifter for whom sex is one more mutable form all treat the body as a provisional state of a self that persists through change. Chapter 5 argues that this is the premise the resurrection needs.

1.8 Stereoscopy: Toward a Hermeneutic of the Double Text

In 1838 Charles Wheatstone showed the Royal Society that two flat drawings of one object, made from slightly different viewpoints and shown one to each eye, combine into a single image with depth. The depth is in neither drawing. It is computed from their *disparity*, the small differences between them. Twenty-one years later Oliver Wendell Holmes, praising the stereograph, wrote that "form is henceforth divorced from matter" ("The Stereoscope and the Stereograph," 1859). The image had come loose from any single support. The method of this thesis applies Wheatstone's principle to a text that exists in two languages. Its principles can be stated as four rules.

Rule I: No primacy of meaning. The Japanese text has priority in time and authorship. The English text has its own *Wirkungsgeschichte*, the history of effects Gadamer places at the centre of understanding: the anglophone critical canon formed around Woolsey's words and not Kato's. Neither text is *the* work. The work is what appears when both are seen together. This follows Benjamin's "Die Aufgabe des Übersetzers" (1923), for which a translation is the original's *Fortleben*, its continued life. In Benjamin's image, original and translation are fragments of a greater language, "as fragments are part of a vessel" (*wie Scherben Bruchstück eines Gefäßes sind*). The figure has a strange fitness here. A game whose evil centres on a vessel (器) holding a god is read, in its double existence, as the shards of another vessel whose wholeness neither language contains. Chapter 6 returns to broken vessels through Isaac Luria's *shevirat ha-kelim* (the breaking of the vessels) and *tikkun* (repair).

Rule II: Disparity is data. Where the texts diverge, the difference is not a loss to mourn ("traduttore, traditore," translator, traitor) but the disparity from which depth is computed. Lawrence Venuti's distinction between domesticating and foreignising translation (*The*

Translator's Invisibility, 1995) correctly describes Woolsey's method as domesticating. He brought in the Magi, Milton's Mammon, a rock trio, and a Roman god of doors. On a stereoscopic view, domestication does not betray the source text. It supplies a second angle. The localisation's conversion of the Japanese text's cosmological and sacral categories into the Judeo-Christian, Enlightenment, and capitalist categories of its audience does not hide the work's philosophy. It *triangulates* it.

Rule III: Independent convergence is structure. Where the texts agree although produced independently, as when evil is made carnival through condiments in one and rock stars in the other, the agreement indicates a structural feature of the work and not an accident of either language.

Rule IV: Chiasmus is the signature of the double text. The clearest case of disparity is the sword. In Japanese its twin guardian spirits are Gran (グラン, Guran) and Leon (リオン, Rion), and the blade is グランドリオン (*Gurandorion*, "Grandleon"), a European heraldic name with a "grand lion" in it. A fan's list gives the correspondence: Masa = Gu-Ra-N (Gran) Mune = Ri-On (Leon) Masamune = Granleon. The English text gives the sword the name of Japan's most celebrated swordsmith, Masamune of the late Kamakura period. Legend says his blades were so serene that leaves drifting downstream turned aside from them, while his rival Muramasa's blades cut everything. The Japanese text gives the sword a Western name, and the English a Japanese one. Each localises toward the other's culture, so the double text produces a *reciprocal exoticism*: each version of the sword comes from the other's world. The holy sword of a time-travelling party is therefore, in both languages, an object from elsewhere, which suits a weapon forged from prehistoric ore and re-forged across eras.

The theory behind the method. Derrida's "Des Tours de Babel" (1985) observes that the name *Babel* is both a proper name and a common noun meaning "confusion," and so is untranslatable within its own language. *Lavos* has the same double status in reverse. It is a proper name that is also a translation, a description ("big fire") hardened into a name. The work begins with a Babel-name, and Chapter 3 shows that its central civilisation is a Babel whose fall scatters its sages, like the tongues of Genesis 11, across the eras. A work so structured by dispersal and reassembly invites a hermeneutic of reassembly.

The work's own metaphysics supplies the last justification. Borges wrote in "Kafka y sus precursores" (1951) that "cada escritor crea a sus precursores. Su labor modifica nuestra concepción del pasado, como ha de modificar el futuro" ("each writer creates his precursors. His work modifies our conception of the past, as it must modify the future"). In "Pierre Menard, autor del Quijote" (1939) a word-for-word identical text means differently because it is written in a different time. Translation is a kind of time travel: a later age reaches back into an earlier text and changes what it will have meant. Woolsey's month of work in 1995

did to Kato's script what the party does to history. It intervened in a finished past, changed names, and sent a modified timeline forward into the anglophone future. A stereoscopic reading applies to the game the ethics the game teaches. It does not choose one timeline over the other. It treats both as real, and it looks for what both, taken together, can recover.

Table 1.1 *The double text: principal stereoscopic pairs*

JAPANESE	GLOSS	ENGLISH	GLOSS	STEREOSCOPIC YIELD
クロノ	*Kurono*: Time; homophone of 黒の, "of black"	Crono	five letters: Kronos	hero named for time / named for the devourer
時の卵	Time Egg	Chrono Trigger	firing lever; *Auslösung*	ovular vs. pyric model of the instant
シルバード	"silver bird"	Epoch	ἐποχή: halt, era, bracketing	flight and return vs. suspension
黒の夢	Black Dream; audibly "Chrono's dream"	Black Omen	portent	oneiric vs. augural; gates of ivory and horn
魔神器	demon-god vessel; anti-regalia	Mammon Machine	Milton's miner; capital	sacral sovereignty vs. market
光の民/地の民	People of Light / of the Earth	Enlightened / Earthbound	*Aufklärung* / bondage	cosmological vs. moral binary
ボッシュ・ハッシュ・ガッシュ	rhyming triad; 賢者, "Sages"	Melchior, Gaspar, Belthasar	the Magi	sound vs. inverted Nativity
魔王	Demon King	Magus	Simon Magus	genre role vs. heresiology
ジャキ	邪気 / 邪鬼: malice, trampled demon	Janus	god of gates	predicted demon vs. predicted gate
カエル	frog; return, revive, change, substitute, hatch	Frog	Grimm's Frog King	five verbs vs. fairy tale
プロメテドーム	Prometheus Dome	Proto Dome	first, prototype	true name on the cradle vs. new beginning
ビネガー・マヨネー・ソイソー	vinegar, mayonnaise, soy sauce	Ozzie, Flea, Slash	rock pantheon	carnival of kitchen vs. carnival of stage
グランドリオン	Grandleon (Gran + Leon)	Masamune (Masa + Mune)	Kamakura smith	reciprocal exoticism

Taken together, the table shows that the Japanese text leans toward the *biological, sacral, and cosmological*: egg, bird, regalia, light and earth, and the verbs of hatching and return. The English leans toward the *mechanical, economic, and moral*: trigger, epoch, Mammon, enlightenment and bondage, Magi. The first describes time as something that grows and is consecrated. The second describes time as something that is released, measured, and spent. The work's philosophy lies in the disparity between those two descriptions. It is a

philosophy of *stored time* that can either be incubated or detonated, and that can be held in custody or spent on power.

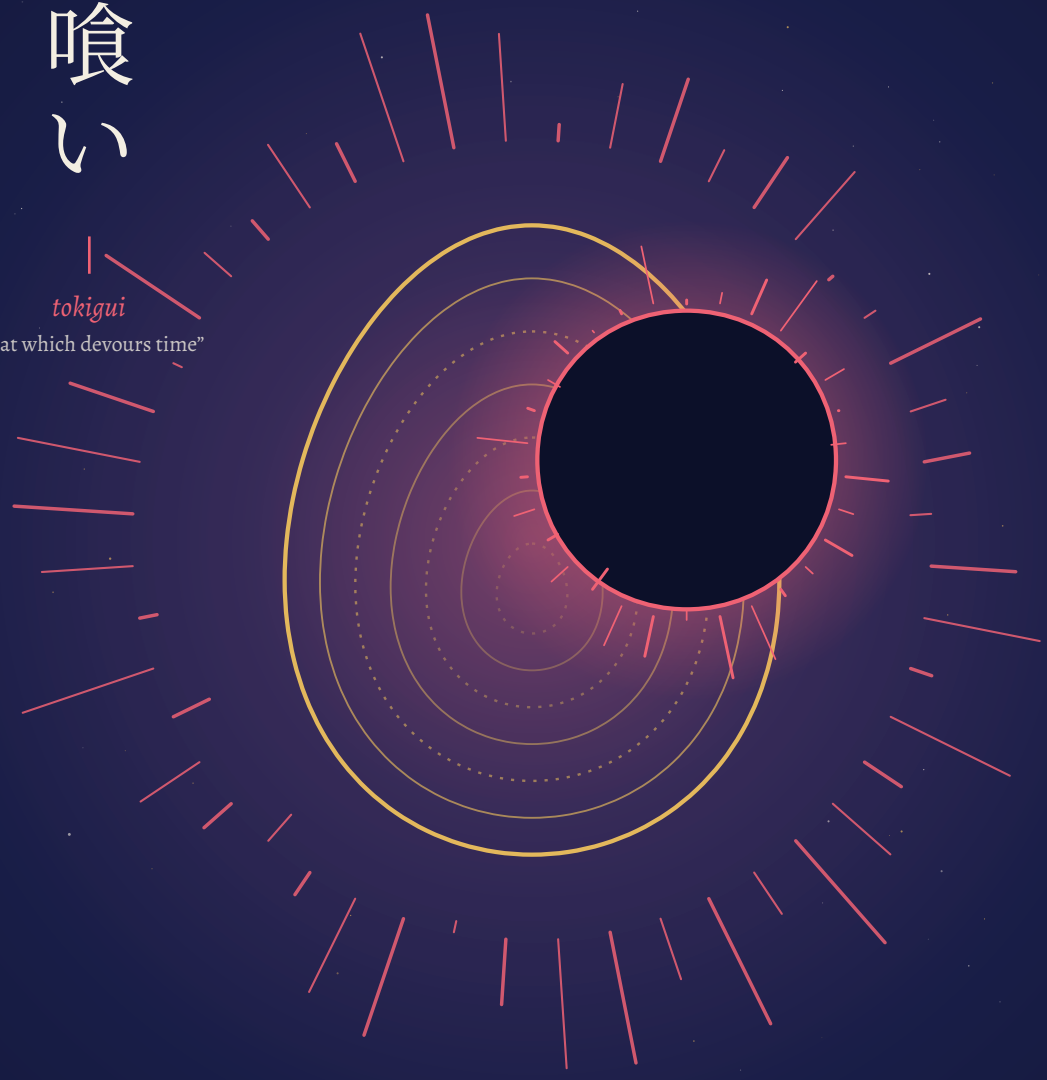
Ayla's word founds everything that follows: a fire that came from the sky and was named by someone who lived because of it. Chapter 2 turns from the name to the thing it names: the time-eater under the crust, Kronos glutted with years, the meteor that ended one dominion and began another, and the parasite that gathered the planet's stored past in order to burn it.



時喰い

tokigui

"that which devours time"



Chapter Two

2

Chronophagy

Lavos as Kronos, Parasite, and Fossil

> *Tempus edax rerum, tuque, invidiosa vetustas, / omnia destruitis.*
> "Time, devourer of things, and you, envious age, destroy all things."
> — Ovid, *Metamorphoses* 15.234–235

> Devouring Time, blunt thou the lion's paws,
> And make the earth devour her own sweet brood…
> — Shakespeare, Sonnet 19

> "What an organism feeds upon is negative entropy."
> — Erwin Schrödinger, *What Is Life?* (1944)

For two thousand years the Western tradition has cast time as the one that eats. Ovid's *tempus edax rerum*, Shakespeare's "Devouring Time," Father Time's scythe, and Goya's Saturn all assign the role of consumer to time and the role of food to things. *Chrono Trigger* reverses those roles. In its world time is the thing eaten. It is a substance that builds up in genomes, rock strata, and civilisations, and so it can be consumed. The franchise eventually named the consumer. In Japanese the final antagonist of *Chrono Cross* is 時を喰らうもの (*toki o kurau mono*, "that which devours time"), shortened to 時喰い (*tokigui*). The Nintendo DS edition of *Chrono Trigger* added an earlier stage of the same creature: the DS *Trigger*'s 夢喰い (*yumekui*, "Dream Devourer") as against the *Cross*'s 時喰い, which is a hidden boss added in the DS version, the form Lavos takes after absorbing Schala beyond the darkness of time, which should be called the forerunner of *Chrono Cross*'s final boss "時を喰らうもの (時喰い)," and which, being made of negative emotions, cannot be defeated by ordinary means. This chapter puts the franchise's own word into Greek as *chronophagy*, "time-eating." It argues that the reversal this word names is the work's speculative *novum*. Once time is treated as a substance and not a medium, it can be stored,

mined, burned, hoarded, and replayed. The villain of a story about time can then be something other than a tyrant who rules time: it can be something that eats it.

The chapter builds up Lavos through eight determinations. Each comes from a separate tradition and isolates one feature of the regime:

1. the devourer of successors (Kronos);
2. the outside catalyst (the meteor of Lovecraft and Clarke);
3. the catastrophe that founds the world (the *felix culpa*, or "happy fault");
4. the parasitoid (Darwin's ichneumon wasp);
5. the fire without measure (Heraclitus and the Stoics);
6. the fossil (negentropy and buried sunshine);
7. the archive (repetition and archive fever);
8. the husk (Marx's vampire-capital and Luria's *kelippah*).

Only the Lovecraftian lineage is documented. The other seven are constellations in the Introduction's sense, connections the reader assembles. What makes the case is that they agree: eight traditions, consulted independently, describe a single figure, and that figure converts stored time into heat.

2.1 Saturated with Years: Kronos, Chronos, and the Devoured Children

Hesiod's account (*Theogony* 453–506) is a political theology of succession. Gaia and Ouranos warn Kronos that a son will overthrow him, so he swallows each child as it leaves Rhea's womb. On Gaia's advice Rhea gives him, in place of the youngest, a stone wrapped in swaddling clothes. He swallows it, and Zeus is raised in secret on Crete. Later Kronos is tricked into vomiting up the stone and then the children. Zeus sets the stone at Pytho, below Parnassus, "as a sign (σῆμα) thereafter, a marvel to mortal men" (497–500). This is the omphalos of Delphi, the navel of the world.

Kronos's crime concerns time before it concerns family. He eats his successors so that there will be no succession, swallowing the future to keep the present in place. Lavos commits the same crime. The 1999 eruption destroys every generation that would have come after it, not only the generation then alive. The party sees this in a recording of 1999 in which Lavos emerges from underground and destroys the world, leaving only a few human survivors and no food. The world of 2300 is a future swallowed alive, and its people are Kronos's children in the belly. They are not dead and not digested. They are held in a sealed interior with no way out.

The allegorists equated Kronos with Chronos, and Cicero passes on the equation with an etymology that could caption the game's final battle. Saturn is so called *quod saturaretur annis*, "because he is glutted with years." He is said to have eaten his children *quod consumit aetas temporum spatia annisque praeteritis insaturabiliter expletur*: "because age consumes the spans of time and is filled insatiably with the years that are past" (*De natura deorum* 2.64). Two words matter most. The devourer is filled with *past* years, so its food is time already lived. And it is filled *insaturabiliter*, insatiably, so accumulation never turns into satiety. Section 2.7 shows that Lavos is built on this exact paradox: it is made of the planet's entire past and is still hungry. Panofsky's essay "Father Time" (*Studies in Iconology*, 1939) traced how the merger of the sickle-bearing harvest god with abstract Chronos produced the Renaissance figure of Time with scythe and hourglass. Rubens's *Saturn* (1636–38) and Goya's (c. 1820–23) carry that image from allegory into horror. Goya's Saturn is eating a body that has already lost its head: the hunger has outlasted the shape of its food.

Three features of the myth go beyond the allegory, and the game reproduces each of them.

The swallowing can be undone. Kronos does not digest his children; he stores them. When he is forced to give them up they come out alive and whole, and the Olympian order is founded on their return. The belly of Kronos is the first archive in Greek literature, an interior that keeps a future out of reach but intact. The game's project of restoration assumes the same structure. What Lavos has consumed is held, not destroyed, and under the right conditions it can be given back.

The devourer is beaten by a substitute. Rhea's trick is a likeness, a stone dressed as a child that Kronos cannot tell from the real thing. The game stages the same trick at its centre. Lavos annihilates Crono at the Ocean Palace. To bring him back, the party must win a replica of his body, the doll the English text calls a "Clone," at Norstein Bekkler's sideshow during the Millennial Fair. They then put it in his place at the frozen instant of his death. Lavos's blow falls on the likeness, and the child is returned. The setting repeats too. Zeus sets the swallowed stone on a mountain as a sign to mortals, and the party makes the swap on a mountain, Death Peak. In mythographic terms the hero's resurrection is Rhea's ruse. Chapter 5 (§5.7) draws out what this means for the theory of the substitute body.

The name changes hands. Chapter 1 (§1.3) noted that the English localisation's five-character limit cut the hero's name to *Crono*, the spelling Plutarch's allegorists merged with Chronos. The localisation thus gives the eaten child the eater's name. When the boy called Crono is swallowed and comes back, the son takes the name back from the being that really plays the father's part.

One difference separates Lavos from Hesiod's model, and it anticipates §2.4. Kronos eats his *own* children to avoid being replaced. Lavos eats the *host's* children in order to breed

its own: the planet's accumulated life feeds the spawn that will leave it. It is a Kronos that reproduces like a cuckoo.

2.2 From the Sky: Lovecraft, Clarke, and the Exogenous Catalyst

The Lovecraftian lineage is the one on record: the creature has Lovecraftian influences, and its Japanese name possibly echoes *Ravukurafuto*, the Japanese rendering of "Lovecraft". Three of Lovecraft's stories set the coordinates.

"The Colour Out of Space" (1927). A meteorite lands on a farm west of Arkham. Out of it comes a colour with no place in the spectrum, and the colour feeds. Crops grow lush and then turn grey and brittle, the animals sicken, and the family withers to ash. When the thing leaves for the sky, part of it stays behind in the well, presumably to grow. The story is a parable of an outside agent draining a place of its life and leaving a remnant to restart the cycle. Its kinship with Lavos is close: Lavos crashed down on the planet in 65,000,000 BC, landing on the reptiles' castle and burying itself deep underground, where it fed on the planet's life force, forcing an ice age. Lovecraft's "blasted heath" is one farm. The game's is a planet.

"The Call of Cthulhu" (1928). This story supplies the sleeping god: "In his house at R'lyeh dead Cthulhu waits dreaming," buried under the sea until the stars are right. Zeal will build its Ocean Palace on the sea floor to reach the sleeper and wake it early (Chapter 3). The story's famous first sentence, however, marks where the game breaks with its source: "The most merciful thing in the world, I think, is the inability of the human mind to correlate all its contents." For Lovecraft, correlation is the disaster. Assembling the scattered evidence of deep time reveals how little humanity matters, and the person who does the assembling is destroyed. *Chrono Trigger* reverses the verdict. Its heroes beat the cosmic entity *by* correlating. They combine 65,000,000 BC, 12,000 BC, 600 AD, 1000 AD, and 2300 AD into one causal picture and act on it. Lovecraft's cosmicism treats deep time as something that dissolves the human. The game treats the journey through deep time as what forms a new kind of human agent (Chapter 7). This is the most important sense in which the game revises its acknowledged source instead of copying it.

The outside catalyst of evolution. The second lineage begins with Kubrick and Clarke's *2001: A Space Odyssey* (1968), in which an alien monolith appears among starving hominids and sets off the leap by which a bone becomes a tool and a weapon. In Clarke's *Childhood's End* (1953) the Overlords guide humanity toward absorption into the Overmind. The closest structural forerunner, though, is Nigel Kneale's *Quatermass and the Pit* (BBC, 1958–59; film 1967, released in America as *Five Million Years to Earth*). A craft buried for millions of years

under London turns out to hold Martians who once altered humanity's ancestors. They planted latent psychic powers and a racial memory of the horned devil, and when the craft reactivates it unleashes a destructive purge through those same powers. A buried alien, tampering with evolution, a latent power in the species, a catastrophic awakening: every element returns in *Chrono Trigger*. The game's lore makes Lavos the progenitor of magic on Earth, and adds that humans like Ayla, born before Lavos landed on Earth, cannot use magic at all.

The result is a harsh anthropology. The power by which Zeal's people raise themselves above others, and by which the party fights, is the parasite's dowry. Human magic is an alien gift, and in the Greek sense it is a *pharmakon*, remedy and poison at once. The party's makeup records this. Two of its seven members cannot use magic. One is Ayla, the human from before the fire. The other is Robo, the machine, to whom Spekkio cannot grant the power to use magic, being unable to properly read his character. The one who remembers the world before Lavos and the one who belongs to the world after humanity both stand outside the economy of the gift. Chapter 7 argues that being excluded from magic is what makes each of them indispensable.

2.3 Sixty-Five Million Years: Alvarez, Chicxulub, and the Felix Culpa of the Mammals

In 1980 Luis and Walter Alvarez, Frank Asaro, and Helen Michel reported unusual amounts of iridium in the clay layer that marks the Cretaceous–Tertiary boundary. They proposed that an asteroid caused the extinction that ended the age of the dinosaurs (*Science* 208). The crater was identified in 1991 at Chicxulub on the Yucatán peninsula (Hildebrand et al., *Geology* 19), building on Pemex survey work by Glen Penfield and Antonio Camargo. While *Chrono Trigger* was being made, the textbook date for the event was about sixty-five million years ago; later work refined it to 66.0 million. The game's date is the science of its decade.

The game presents the impact as a planetary turning point. No preventive action could be taken, and the Reptite leader Azala surmised that the fall would cause an unmitigable ice age for millions of years. The collision shunted the Tyrano Lair deep beneath the planet's crust and left a huge, raised crater where its foundation had once sat. The ensuing ice age causes the Reptites to go extinct, incidentally ensuring the survival of the human race. Among the Iokans and Larubans, the fall would be remembered as the day "big fire" burned the Reptites. A fire from the sky ends the reign of the reptiles and opens the reign of the mammals. This is the K–T event told by its survivors.

The impact hypothesis had a twin in the 1980s. The TTAPS paper ("Nuclear Winter," *Science* 222, 1983; Turco, Toon, Ackerman, Pollack, Sagan) drew on models of the dust clouds that impacts raise. In both scientific and popular imagination, asteroid winter and nuclear winter became one model applied to the past and to the future. *Chrono Trigger* holds both halves. Its prehistory ends in an impact winter. Its future opens with fire from above and a world without food. The domed survivors of 2300 are living through a nuclear winter under another name.

The theology of this prehistory is that of the *felix culpa*. The Exsultet of the Easter Vigil sings *O certe necessarium Adae peccatum… O felix culpa, quae talem ac tantum meruit habere Redemptorem*: "O truly necessary sin of Adam… O happy fault, that merited so great a Redeemer." Augustine's principle stands behind the hymn: God "judged it better to bring good out of evil than to suffer no evil to exist" (*Enchiridion* 8.27). Milton gives the paradox to Adam, who stands "full of doubt" whether to repent the sin "By mee done and occasiond, or rejoyce / Much more, that much more good thereof shall spring" (*Paradise Lost* XII.473–476). Lavos's fall is a "necessary sin" in the strict sense. Without it there would be no ice age, no extinction of the Reptites, no human dominion, no magic, no Zeal, no Gates, and no party. The catastrophe founds the world that has to defeat it.

This explains a choice that might puzzle a reader used to time-travel stories: the party never tries to stop the fall. They go to 65,000,000 BC, watch the impact, and let it happen. The reason goes beyond the size of the event. Undoing the fall would undo the party. The commonwealth accepts the *culpa* (the fault) and refuses its *consummation*. It lets the founding catastrophe stand and fights the chronophagic completion of 1999. The principle is general and returns throughout this thesis: **one cannot abolish one's conditions of possibility, but one can refuse to let them reach their end.**

The fault is happy only for the mammals, though. For the Reptites it is plain catastrophe, and Azala, who saw it coming, is the work's first victim of history. Every theodicy leaves a remainder, someone for whom the good drawn out of evil is not good. Chapter 7 (§7.5) comes back to Azala's people by way of Benjamin's angel of history, whose face is turned toward the wreckage that the storm of progress leaves behind.

2.4 The Cosmic Ichneumon: Parasitism and Theodicy

Lavos is described again and again as a parasite: a parasitic alien that falls from the skies in 65,000,000 BC. Fan reference works reconstruct its life cycle in unusual detail. It came to Earth intending to drain the planet's energy so that it could produce genetically enhanced spawn, which would then continue the cycle on other planets, and it absorbed the DNA of

the world's diverse living creatures to evolve itself, then passed it to offspring that shoot off into different worlds to repeat the cycle. Strictly speaking, this organism is a *parasitoid*, a parasite that kills its host when its own development is complete. The distinction matters for biology and for theology.

On 22 May 1860 Darwin wrote to Asa Gray: "I cannot persuade myself that a beneficent & omnipotent God would have designedly created the Ichneumonidae with the express intention of their feeding within the living bodies of caterpillars." The ichneumon wasp lays its egg inside a living caterpillar so that the larva can eat its host from within. It became the emblem of natural evil. Stephen Jay Gould's "Nonmoral Nature" (1982) used it to test whether nature can be read morally at all. Hume's Philo had already drawn the conclusion: such a nature presents only "a blind Nature… pouring forth from her lap, without discernment or parental care, her maimed and abortive children" (*Dialogues Concerning Natural Religion* XI).

Parasitologists separate two kinds of parasitoid. *Idiobionts* paralyse the host when they lay the egg. *Koinobionts* let the host keep living, feeding, and growing for as long as the larva needs, because a bigger host is better for the larva. Lavos is a koinobiont on a planetary scale. It does not freeze the planet at impact. It lets the host evolve for sixty-five million years, because its breeding success depends on how varied the genomes it harvests are. This is the most disturbing implication in the work. Evolution, the rise of humanity, the flowering of magic, the building of kingdoms: from the chronophage's point of view, all of history is the growth phase of a host that exists to be eaten. **Progress is fattening.**

In this vocabulary, the 1999 emergence is an *eclosion*, the moment the grown larva leaves the spent host, which Ridley Scott's *Alien* (1979) made the central image of modern biological horror. The brood follows. After the eruption, Lavos possibly moves beneath Death Peak, where many of its spawn can be found in the post-apocalyptic world of 2300 AD.

The figure shows something a simple opposition of fire and egg would hide: **Lavos is itself an egg.** It is laid from the sky into the body of a planet, and its shell is the armoured carapace the party finally cracks (§2.8). The parasitoid's egg and the Time Egg are therefore opposites of the same kind, not of different kinds. Both store potential, and both hatch on Death Peak in 2300 AD. One hatches by consuming its host; the other hatches by restoring a life. On the mountain where Lavos's brood is found, the party breaks the Time Egg and brings back the dead. So the regime this thesis calls *pyric* (fire-based) is not simply the opposite of the *ovular* (egg-based). It is the ovular corrupted, incubation in the service of consumption. Chronophagy is a false oöchrony, a counterfeit form of egg-time. The ethics proposed in the Conclusion will therefore have to distinguish two kinds of incubation, as well as incubation from burning.

Michel Serres's *Le Parasite* (1980) supplies the theory of the relation. The *parasitos* is literally one who eats beside (*para*) another's grain (*sitos*): the guest who takes and gives nothing. In French *parasite* also means static, noise on the line. Serres saw that the parasitic relation runs one way only, and also that it is productive, since noise forces a system to reorganise. Lavos fits both halves. It takes without returning, and its interference produced the humanity, magic, and civilisation it plans to harvest.

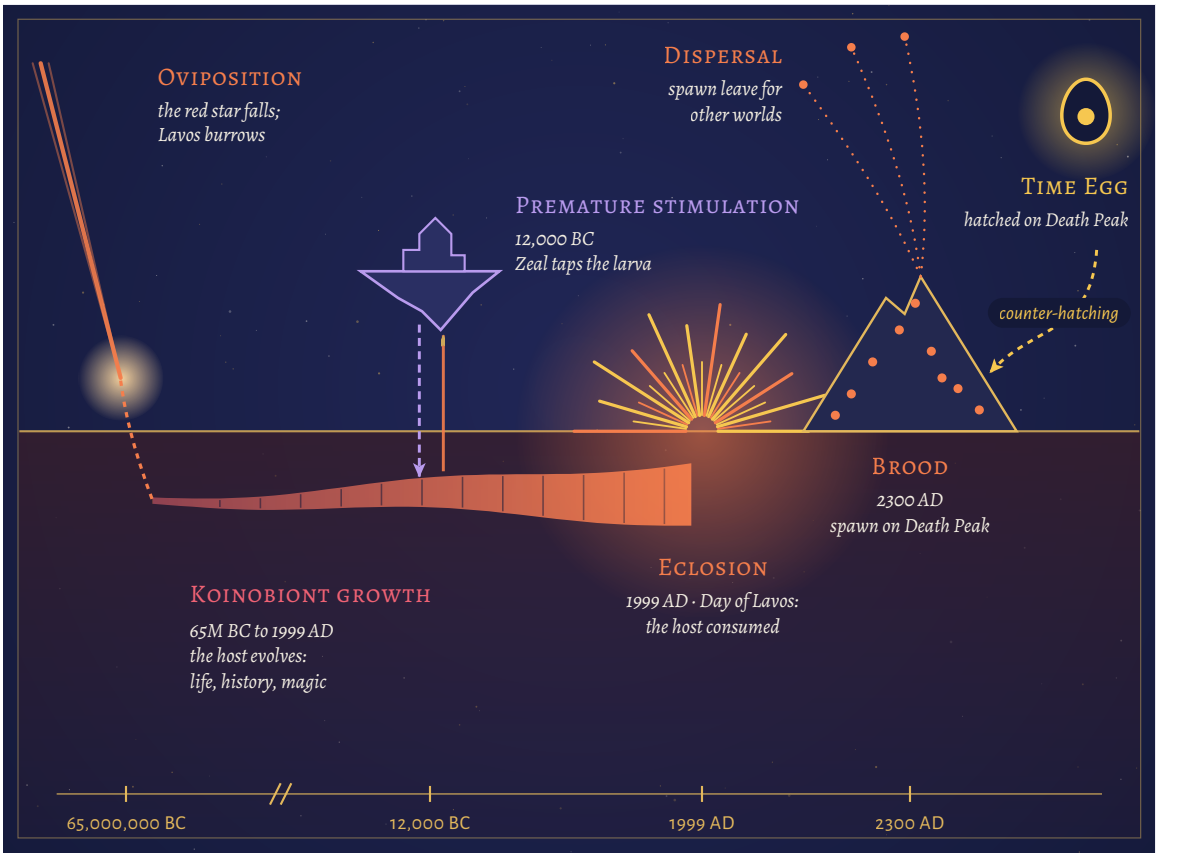


Figure 2 *Lavos as koinobiont parasitoid, and the counter-egg.*

An esoteric cosmology offers an eerie parallel. In G. I. Gurdjieff's *Beelzebub's Tales to His Grandson* (1950), a comet called "Kondoor" strikes the young Earth and breaks off fragments that become the Moon. To sustain them, organic life on Earth must supply certain vibrations through its deaths, and humanity is given an organ, "Kundabuffer," that keeps it from seeing its situation. As P. D. Ouspensky reports the teaching, organic life on earth, humanity included, is food for the moon. In both cosmologies an impact at the dawn of history forces terrestrial life to feed a celestial body, and those being fed on do not know they are food. In *Chrono Trigger* the people of 1000 AD celebrate their millennium unaware of 1999.

The party learns that history is a feeding through a revelation, a recording in the ruined archive of Arris Dome. That scene is the work's moment of gnosis, and what it reveals is Gurdjieff's point: *we have been food*.

This changes the question of theodicy. If the world's history is the fattening of a parasite, the problem of evil becomes a problem of *function*: what is history for? Chronophagy's answer is that history exists for something outside it. The commonwealth's answer, worked out in Chapters 6–8, is that a world's stored time exists for its own hatching. Its purpose lies within it and is not there to be harvested.

2.5 Ekpyrōsis without Palingenesis: Heraclitus, the Stoics, and the Unmeasured Fire

Ayla's word makes the antagonist a fire, and the oldest philosophy of fire is Heraclitus's:

- "This world-order, the same for all, no god or man made; but it ever was and is and will be: ever-living fire, kindled in measures and extinguished in measures" (DK 22 B30).
- "All things are an exchange for fire, and fire for all things, as goods for gold and gold for goods" (B90).
- "Fire, coming upon all things, will judge and seize them" (B66).
- "The sun will not overstep his measures; otherwise the Erinyes, ministers of Justice, will find him out" (B94).

Heraclitus's cosmos is fire held to measure (μέτρα). Kindling and quenching balance each other. The fire that consumes also gives back, and justice (Δίκη) is the keeping of that balance. Lavos is fire without measure. For sixty-five million years it is kindled: it absorbs, accumulates, and grows. It is never quenched in proportion, and it returns nothing of what it takes. B90 also introduces the analogy that governs Chapter 3 and §2.8: fire as the universal medium of exchange, the gold for which all goods can be traded. The Mammon Machine turns Zeal's magic into Lavos's energy and Lavos's energy into Zeal's power. It is Heraclitus's exchange with the measure taken out.

The Stoics made Heraclitus's fire periodic. At the end of each world-cycle the cosmos burns up in a conflagration (ἐκπύρωσις, *ekpyrōsis*) and is then reborn (παλιγγενεσία, *palingenesia*), restored (ἀποκατάστασις, *apokatastasis*) to an identical sequence. Nemesius records the doctrine: when the planets return to the same positions, the fire destroys everything and the cosmos is restored anew, so that Socrates and Plato will live again with the same friends and fellow citizens (*De natura hominis* 38; *SVF* II 625). The word this thesis adopts first appears here in its Stoic sense, apokatastasis as the restoration of the identical after

the fire. Origen would attack the doctrine (*Contra Celsum* 4.68, 5.20–21) and redefine the word, and Chapter 6 follows that redefinition. For now it is enough that the Stoic fire is always followed by return.

The biblical fire is not. "The day of the Lord will come as a thief in the night; in the which the heavens shall pass away with a great noise, and the elements shall melt with fervent heat, the earth also and the works that are therein shall be burned up" (2 Peter 3:10). The English "Day of Lavos" echoes the prophets' "Day of the Lord" (*yom YHWH*). The Japanese ラヴォスの日 (*Ravosu no hi*), the heading under which Japanese walkthroughs file the episode, uses the same construction. Thomas of Celano's sequence names that day's work with uncanny precision: *Dies irae, dies illa, / solvet saeclum in favilla*, "that day of wrath shall dissolve the age (*saeculum*) in ashes." The fire dissolves an *era*, and the map of *Chrono Trigger* is made of eras. Lavos's signature attack in the final battle carries the apocalyptic formula itself: "Destruction rains from the heavens!"

Two Buddhist conflagrations sharpen the comparison. In the Aṅguttara Nikāya's "Discourse on the Seven Suns" (AN 7.62), seven suns rise one after another at the end of a world-age until earth and Mount Sineru burn and no ash or soot is left. Japanese Buddhism calls this fire 劫火 (*gōka*), the kalpa-fire. The sixteenth chapter of the *Lotus Sutra*, one of the most recited texts in Japanese Buddhism, describes what the Buddha's land looks like while the world burns:

> 衆生見劫尽　大火所焼時　我此土安穏　天人常充満
> 園林諸堂閣　種種宝荘厳　宝樹多花果　衆生所遊楽
> 諸天撃天鼓　常作衆伎楽
>
> "When living beings see the kalpa end and all is burned by the great fire, this land of mine is at peace, ever filled with gods and humans. Its gardens and groves, its halls and pavilions are adorned with every kind of jewel; jewelled trees abound in flowers and fruit, where living beings play and take delight; the gods beat heavenly drums and ever make music."

The sutra's fire is 大火 (*taika*), literally "big fire": the same two elements as Ayla's word. This is not a claim of influence. It is a structural counter-image. Inside the big fire stands a land of gardens and groves, of play and music. The sutra answers the conflagration with a grove and a festival, not with escape. These are the two counter-regimes this thesis calls *lignous* (wood-based) and *festal* time, which the game embodies in Robo's forest and the Millennial Fair (Chapters 6 and 8).

The Norse conflagration supplies the last term. In the *Völuspá*, Surtr's fire consumes the world at Ragnarök. Then the seeress sees the earth rise a second time from the sea, evergreen, and the surviving gods find in the grass the golden game-pieces they owned in the

old days. After the fire, play starts again. Heraclitus's child moving pieces on a board (B52) comes back at the end of the Norse cosmos as golden pieces lying in new grass.

Against these models, Lavos's fire can be defined exactly: **ekpyrōsis without palingenesis**, conflagration without rebirth. The Stoic fire is followed by return, the Norse fire by renewal, the Buddhist fire by a new world-age. Lavos's fire is followed by reproduction somewhere else. The spawn leave for other worlds, and the burned world gets nothing. Regeneration is exported, and the fire's rebirth takes the form of colonisation.

The tradition's emblem of fire *with* rebirth is the phoenix, and its egg combines the two terms this thesis sets against each other. Herodotus reports that the phoenix shapes an egg of myrrh, hollows it out, puts its dead father inside, and carries it to the temple of the Sun at Heliopolis (2.73). Lactantius's *De ave phoenice* and the First Epistle of Clement (25) made the bird an emblem of resurrection. Shakespeare's Devouring Time is told to "burn the long-lived phoenix in her blood": the devourer's final act is to burn even the bird that comes back from burning. Against this tradition, the Japanese text's pairing of a silver bird with an egg of time (Chapter 1, §1.4) is a phoenix structure split between two instruments. Where Lavos withholds rebirth, the commonwealth has to produce it. The Time Egg is a phoenix egg, an egg that holds a death and gives back a life (Chapter 5).

2.6 Negentropy and Buried Sunshine: Lavos as Fossil Time

In 1865 Rudolf Clausius reduced thermodynamics to two sentences: *Die Energie der Welt ist constant. Die Entropie der Welt strebt einem Maximum zu.* ("The energy of the world is constant. The entropy of the world tends toward a maximum.") In 1944 Schrödinger asked how living things resist that tendency. His answer was that an organism feeds on negative entropy and keeps its unlikely order by "continually sucking orderliness from its environment."

Schrödinger's verb is a vampire's, and it describes Lavos precisely. The creature sustains itself by drawing order out of a living world: the planet's accumulated organisation, its genomes and ecosystems, everything sixty-five million years of evolution built up against entropy. The world it leaves in 2300 is maximum entropy made visible: grey, still, unable to grow anything. Defined in thermodynamic terms, **chronophagy is the consumption of a world's negentropy by an agent that does not belong to that world.**

The key property is an asymmetry in time. Order builds up slowly and is released quickly; an instant burns what deep time built. The history of energy has a name for this asymmetry: fossil fuel. Jeffrey Dukes ("Burning Buried Sunshine," *Climatic Change* 61, 2003) calculated that the fossil fuel burned in 1997 alone came from ancient organic matter equal to more than four hundred times the planet's current yearly plant growth (its net primary

production). Industrial civilisation burns in one year what four centuries of global photosynthesis could not replace.

Read against that history, Lavos is a fossil in the most literal sense. It was buried at the end of the Cretaceous, the age of reptiles, under the reptiles' citadel. That is the stratum popular imagination links with oil, as the Sinclair dinosaur logo has signalled since 1930, however loose the palaeontology. A civilisation discovers the buried power and taps it: the Kingdom of Zeal is powered by the energy of Lavos through the Mammon Machine, in a relationship that is symbiotic, with Lavos also gathering the kingdom's magic. That two-way flow is the koinobiont arrangement turned into an institution. The host feeds the parasite that powers it, until the extraction goes catastrophically wrong (Chapter 3). In 1999 the whole deposit burns at once. The allegory needs no forcing. The big fire under the crust is the energy regime Lewis Mumford called "carboniferous capitalism" (*Technics and Civilization*, 1934) and Andreas Malm reconstructed as *Fossil Capital* (2016). Dipesh Chakrabarty's "The Climate of History: Four Theses" (2009) argues that the Anthropocene collapses the old division between natural and human history. *Chrono Trigger*, whose map puts the Cretaceous beside the twenty-fourth century, takes that collapse as the starting condition of play. Reza Negarestani's *Cyclonopedia* (2008) pushes the fossil allegory into theory-fiction, imagining petroleum as a sentient, quasi-Lovecraftian agent under the earth that steers history while seeming to serve it. Lavos is that kind of sovereign fossil.

Georges Bataille's *La Part maudite* (1949) supplies the opposite term: "The sun gives without ever receiving." The solar economy is pure expenditure, an excess of energy that life has to spend, gloriously or disastrously. Lavos is the anti-sun of that economy, a body that receives and never gives. Ayla's people saw a false star arrive, since when Lavos first appeared in the sky, it looked like a red star. The game's true solar object, the Sun Stone that charges with sunlight over the ages (Chapter 6, §6.5), belongs to the counter-regime.

The section ends on a chiasmus that anticipates Chapter 6. Humanity burns in one year what four centuries of growth could not replace. In *Chrono Trigger* a machine spends four centuries growing one forest. Robo's four hundred years in the Fiona episode exactly invert Dukes's ratio: four centuries of lignous time set against the pyric instant.

2.7 The Chronophagic Archive: Recapitulation in the Final Battle

The final battle is the most philosophically articulate sequence in the game's systems, and it makes its argument almost entirely through rules. The battle against Lavos in 1999 AD starts with its outer shell, which goes through phases in which it mimics other bosses the player has fought. The order is precise: Lavos mimics the enemies encountered in the past, start-

ing with Dragon Tank and ending with Giga Gaia, and even mimics the HP and defense of each boss. Walkthroughs describe the mechanism in the game's own terms. The creature starts off by calling upon the accumulated DNA of the creatures of the planet to determine its attacks, and for bosses with multiple parts, odd beings join Lavos to serve as those parts. The monster's body is made of the history the player has lived through. Three consequences follow.

(a) Lavos has eaten the playthrough. The bosses it mimics belong to the player's past as well as the world's. They are encounters the player got through hours or days earlier in real time. The shell is a museum of the player's victories, brought to life and turned on the player. Here chronophagy reaches beyond the depicted world into the time of play itself. The devourer has consumed the player's experience along with the planet's history and wears it as armour. Haeckel's biogenetic law (*Generelle Morphologie*, 1866), "ontogeny recapitulates phylogeny" (an organism's development replays its species' history), is turned around: the parasite's body replays the *host's* history.

(b) The archive can only repeat. Campbell's "Who Goes There?" (1938), filmed by Carpenter as *The Thing* (1982), imagines an alien that absorbs organisms and imitates them perfectly. Lovecraft's "The Shadow Out of Time" (1936) imagines the Great Race of Yith, which builds an archive of every era by taking over minds across time. Lavos is both: an absorbing imitator and an archive spanning time, built by seizure. Borges's "Funes el memorioso" (1942) gives the diagnosis. Funes remembers everything and so cannot think, because "pensar es olvidar diferencias, es generalizar, abstraer" ("to think is to forget differences, to generalise, to abstract"). Lavos remembers everything, so it can only replay. Its first act in the decisive battle is a recital. Derrida's *Mal d'archive*, given as a lecture in 1994 and published in 1995, the year *Chrono Trigger* came out, ties the urge to archive to the death drive, which he calls "archiviolithic," destructive of the archive. To be *en mal d'archive* is to burn with longing for the archive. Lavos makes the phrase literal: it is an archive that is also a fire.

(c) Time that has been worked through is immune. The most striking thing about the sequence is how easy it is. One guide notes that the mimic fights are almost universally easy, since you've been there before. The argument here is Freud's. In "Erinnern, Wiederholen und Durcharbeiten" (1914) the patient who cannot remember repeats, and the repetition is broken by *Durcharbeiten*, working-through. In *Jenseits des Lustprinzips* (1920) the compulsion to repeat takes on the demonic character of a drive. Lavos's shell is that *Wiederholungszwang* (compulsion to repeat) turned into a monster, history coming back as compulsion. The party has already worked through every conflict it repeats, so the repeated past has no hold on it. **Chronophagy, the battle argues, rules only over time that has not been worked through.**

Schopenhauer's darkest image completes the reading. In *Die Welt als Wille und Vorstellung* (I, §27) he describes the Australian bulldog ant: cut in two, its head and tail fight, the head biting the tail and the tail stinging the head. The will to live, he concludes, everywhere preys on itself and is its own food. The final battle stages this at planetary scale. A party that carries the planet's history in its members fights a creature made of the planet's history: the world's life divided against itself.

Under the recital lies the core, and its anatomy holds a final twist. The humanoid form is a decoy and the true Lavos Core is hiding in one of the pods, which becomes apparent as that pod has much more HP than the central body. Reference works add that the absolute core is one of these bits, since it can revive the other parts and destroying it defeats Lavos. The pod's Japanese name gives it away: Lavos Bit (ラヴォスビット, *Ravosu Bitto*). **The heart of the chronophagic archive is a bit, the unit of information.** The human-shaped figure in the middle of the screen is bait. Schrödinger anticipated both sides of the creature. The first half of *What Is Life?* argued that organisms feed on negentropy, and the second introduced the hereditary "code-script." Lavos eats both, energy (§2.6) and code. Norbert Wiener's dictum, "Information is information, not matter or energy" (*Cybernetics*, 1948), marks the point where the regime becomes informational and the parasite eats life as data.

Fan commentators have compared the outer form to a French legend: the outer shell resembles the Peluda, a mythical beast in French mythology. The Peluda of La Ferté-Bernard is said to have survived the Flood after being refused a place on the Ark. It breathed fire, shot poisoned quills, and devoured the region's young until a youth avenging his beloved struck its tail, its only weak point. An armoured, fiery, spined survivor of the world's catastrophe that can be killed only at its edge: the analogy reaches from the shell's form to how it is defeated, since the true core is a pod at the side and not the central figure.

2.8 Vampire, Carcass, Shell: Marx and the Economy of Time

Marx's theory of value is a theory of stored time. "As values, all commodities are only definite masses of congealed labour-time" (*festgeronnener Arbeitszeit*; *Capital* I, ch. 1). Capital is accumulated past labour, and it lives by taking present labour: "Capital is dead labour, that, vampire-like, only lives by sucking living labour, and lives the more, the more labour it sucks" (*Capital* I, ch. 10). It has a "werewolf-like hunger for surplus labour" (*Werwolfs-Heißhunger nach Mehrarbeit*). *The Poverty of Philosophy* (1847) gives the worker's epitaph in such an economy: "Time is everything, man is nothing; he is, at most, time's carcass" (*la carcasse du temps*). The *Grundrisse* generalises the principle: "Economy of time, to this all economy ultimately reduces itself."

Lavos is capital in exactly this sense. It is dead life that lives by sucking living life, and it lives the more the more it sucks. It is the planet's accumulated past, its congealed time, turned against the planet's present. The people of 2300 are time's carcass.

The future contains a device that compresses this economy into one message. The Enertron in the domes of 2300 restores hit points and magic points and then reports "But you're still hungry." A dome-dweller explains it beforehand: "This is an Enertron. You get a full night's sleep in a few seconds, but it still leaves you hungry." Its function is spelled out: the survivors of the Day of Lavos rely on the Enertron in the absence of any food until Marle gives them a seed to grow, insisting that the Enertron won't last forever. The Enertron restores the measurable quantities of life (hit points, magic points, energy) without meeting any need. It keeps bodies running without feeding them. It is the welfare system of a chronophagic world, the koinobiont condition made into a social institution: a host kept alive but not nourished. The line became one of the game's most quoted, and it changed in retranslation: in the Nintendo DS remake, the message reads "But you're just as hungry as before." The revision teaches something. "Still hungry" states a fact. "Just as hungry as before" states a law: restoring energy changes nothing in the order of need. Marle's seed is the first sign, in the future, of the regime this thesis calls lignous time (Chapter 6).

Ovid supplies the myth of this economy. Erysichthon cuts down the sacred oak of Ceres, a tree so vast it was "a grove in itself" (*una nemus*, *Met.* 8.743–744). Ceres sends Hunger into his body. The more he eats, the hungrier he gets. He eats through his fortune, sells his shape-shifting daughter Mestra again and again, and finally starts tearing at his own limbs, and "unhappy man, fed his body by diminishing it" (*infelix minuendo corpus alebat*, 8.878). That half-line is the most compact formula for chronophagy in the classical canon: a body that feeds by consuming its own substance. And Erysichthon's crime is cutting down a grove. He is Robo's exact antithesis. Robo spends four centuries growing a forest where there was desert; Erysichthon destroyed a grove and was sentenced to a hunger nothing could fill. The domes of 2300, where energy comes back and hunger stays, are Erysichthon's world.

The last term is the shell. In the Japanese text the creature's outer form is named ラヴォス（外殻）, "Lavos (outer husk)," and the battle moves through a series of layers: shell, body, core, and finally the bit. This structure has a precise counterpart in the Kabbalah of Isaac Luria (1534–1572), as Gershom Scholem reconstructed it (*Major Trends in Jewish Mysticism*, 1941). In the Lurianic myth, the vessels meant to hold the divine light shattered (*shevirat ha-kelim*). Sparks of the light (*nitzotzot*) fell and were captured by the *kelippot*, the "husks" or "shells." The husks have no life of their own and live only on the sparks they hold captive. The work of repair (*tikkun*) consists in raising the sparks, and when the sparks are with-

drawn the husks collapse. The Zohar pictures this as a nut, its kernel wrapped in shells (Song of Songs 6:11; *Zohar* I:19b).

Lavos is a *kelippah* in exactly this sense. Its shell holds the life of every era: fan sources describe it as having the DNA and capabilities of all beings that existed, exist, and will exist in the entire history of the Earth. All its vitality is borrowed from what it has captured, so its power is the power of the trapped sparks. The final battle is therefore a peeling of husks, shell from body, body from core, core from bit, and the creature's defeat releases what it held. Chapter 6 reads the restorative sub-scenarios as a *tikkun*, the raising, one by one, of the sparks the chronophagic regime had captured. The broken vessel that opened this thesis's method (Chapter 1, §1.8) returns here as metaphysics.

Table 2.1 *The eight determinations of chronophagy*

DETERMINATION	TRADITION / ORIGINATOR	MANIFESTATION IN THE GAME	WHAT IS EATEN	COUNTER-REGIME
Kronos	Hesiod; Cicero; Panofsky; Goya	1999 swallows the future; 2300 as belly	successors; the future	Rhea's stone → the replica on Death Peak (Ch. 5)
Exogenous catalyst	Lovecraft; Clarke; Kneale	the red star; magic as alien dowry	the autonomy of evolution	correlation of eras by the commonwealth (Ch. 7)
Felix culpa	Exsultet; Augustine; Milton; Alvarez	Reptite extinction; human dominion	the Reptites	*culpa* accepted, consummation refused (Chs. 4, 7)
Parasitoid	Darwin; Hume; Gould; Serres; Gurdjieff	dormancy, eclosion, brood on Death Peak	the host's growth	the Time Egg as counter-hatching (Ch. 5)
Unmeasured fire	Heraclitus; Stoics; 2 Peter; *Völuspá*; *Lotus Sutra*	Day of Lavos; destruction raining from the heavens	measure; palingenesis	the festal grove (Chs. 6, 8)
Fossil	Clausius; Schrödinger; Dukes; Bataille; Negarestani	buried under Tyrano Lair; tapped by Zeal	stored order (negentropy)	lignous time: Robo's forest (Ch. 6)
Archive	Haeckel; Freud; Borges; Derrida; Campbell	boss-mimicry; the Lavos Bit	the past, including the playthrough	working-through (Chs. 6, 8)
Capital / husk	Marx; Ovid; Luria	Enertron; shell → body → core → bit	living labour; the sparks	*tikkun* (Ch. 6)

The eight determinations converge on a definition. **Chronophagy is the conversion of slowly stored time into quickly released power by an agent outside the time it consumes, whose regeneration happens elsewhere.** It has three marks:

1. **Exteriority.** The chronophage comes from outside, from the sky, from beyond the history it feeds on. It stands to the world as the parasite to the host, the archon to the soul, and capital to the labour it buys.
2. **Asymmetry.** It consumes in an instant what took ages to store: one year that burns four centuries of sunlight, one eruption that burns sixty-five million years of life.

3. **Exportation.** Its rebirth is not the world's rebirth. The fire is reborn elsewhere, in spawn leaving for other planets, in profit leaving the place where it was made, in an archive that keeps the world's memory only as its own armour.

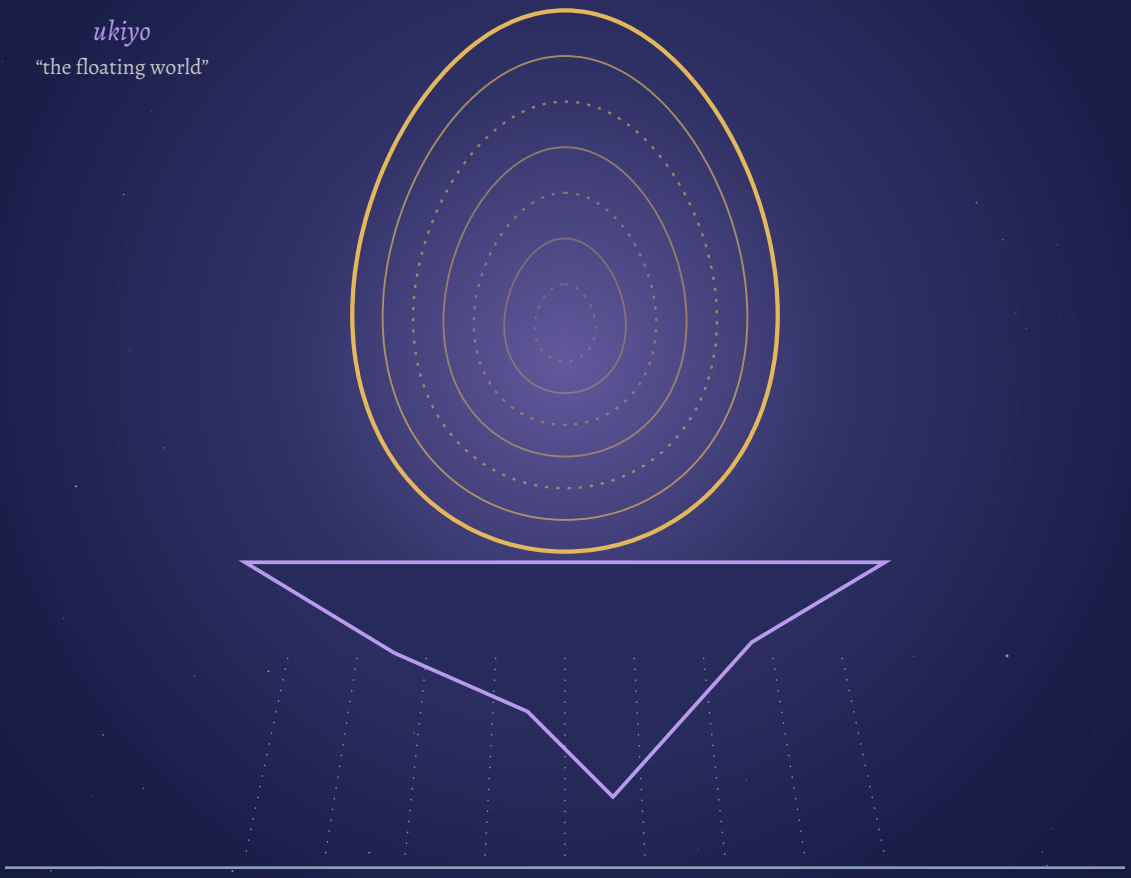
The counter-regimes are defined by reversing these marks. Against exteriority, the commonwealth acts from inside the eras it lives in (Chapter 7). Against asymmetry, restoration takes as long as it takes: four hundred years for a forest, a lifetime for a forgiveness (Chapter 6). Against exportation, renewal happens here, in a festival that returns every millennium and in a game that starts again in the same world (Chapter 8).

A parasite, however, does not thrive without a host that cooperates. The koinobiont needs a host that grows, the fossil needs a civilisation that extracts it, and the archive needs someone who wants to own the past. In *Chrono Trigger*, chronophagy has a human face. Chapter 3 turns to the civilisation that built itself on the big fire: the floating kingdom of Zeal, with its machine named for a demon-god's vessel in one language and for Mammon in the other, its Enlightened and its Earthbound, and the princess in its basement.

浮世

ukiyo

"the floating world"



Chapter Three

3

The Floating World

Zeal and the Dialectic of Enlightenment

天下神器，不可為也。為者敗之，執者失之。

"The world is a sacred vessel. It cannot be worked upon. Whoever works upon it ruins it; whoever grasps it loses it."

— *Daodejing* 29

Aber die vollends aufgeklärte Erde strahlt im Zeichen triumphalen Unheils.

"But the wholly enlightened earth radiates under the sign of disaster triumphant."

— Horkheimer and Adorno, *Dialektik der Aufklärung* (1947)

"The zeal of thine house hath eaten me up."

— Psalm 69:9 (KJV); cf. John 2:17

A PARASITE NEEDS a host that cooperates. Chapter 2 described the chronophage from outside: Kronos, the meteor, the parasitoid, the fossil, the archive, the husk. This chapter describes the civilisation that learned to live off the big fire. The double text flags the problem in its calendar. Japanese sources place Zeal in 古代 (*kodai*), and describe its princess as heir of the magic kingdom that flourished in antiquity (B.C. 12000). The English text of the SNES and PlayStation editions gave the era a different name: "Dark Ages". So in English the Enlightened Ones live in the Dark Ages.

This crossing of names is the kind of chiasmus that Chapter 1 (§1.8, Rule IV) treated as the signature of the double text. In two proper names it states the thesis Horkheimer and Adorno put at the head of their book: *Schon der Mythos ist Aufklärung, und: Aufklärung schlägt in Mythologie zurück* ("Myth is already enlightenment, and enlightenment reverts to mythology"). The localisation also performed a quiet historiographical transfer. It took Europe's pejorative for the post-Roman centuries (Petrarch's *tenebrae*, the *philosophes*' "dark ages")

away from the game's 600 AD, where European usage would have put it, and attached it to an age of light.

The diegetic facts are few. According to the fan reference works, the people with the gift of magic, the Enlightened Ones, live on land masses held up in the sky by magic. Called the Kingdom of Zeal, these lands have lush plant life, golden cities, and advanced power and knowledge. Zeal's people are deeply prejudiced against the Earthbound, whom they use as slave labour. Around the time of the last Ice Age, the people of Zeal used their technology and magic to lift the whole kingdom off the earth, and its islands floated above the dense clouds that covered the planet. They tried to achieve immortality by siphoning Lavos's power through the Mammon Machine in the Ocean Palace on the sea floor. The attempt woke Lavos, who destroyed Zeal. Its fall caused tsunamis that left a single continent above the sea, and it ended the planet's deep freeze, so that civilisation could re-establish itself on the surface.

Zeal's fall is therefore a second *felix culpa* (a "happy fault," Chapter 2, §2.3). The first catastrophe gave the planet to the mammals. The second gave the sun back to the ground. In this game, history moves forward when powers that had lifted themselves above it fall.

The thesis of the chapter is this. Zeal is a ***hyperchthonic* polity**, one that lives "above the earth." It hangs between a sky it occupies and an underworld it mines, and the people of the ground are caught in between. Its organising principle can be called **panconvertibility**: the belief that every form of stored time can be turned into power, whether that stored time is a buried god, a daughter's talent, a people's labour, or the future itself. Zeal is not the game's villain. It is the villain's economy.

3.1 Atlantis, Laputa, Babel

Plato. Plato dates Atlantis nine thousand years before Solon (*Timaeus* 23e; *Critias* 108e), which puts it around 9600 BC, the same mythic register as the game's 12,000 BC. The island sank "in a single day and night of misfortune" (*Timaeus* 25d, Jowett). Two details in the *Critias* anticipate Zeal closely.

- *The mineral.* The wall around the Atlantean citadel "flashed with the red light of orichalcum" (116c), a precious, fire-coloured metal known only to that civilisation. Zeal has an equivalent. Dreamstone, the red stone, was rare and highly valuable from prehistoric times, and in 12,000 BC the royal family collected enough of it to build the Mammon Machine. Both sunken kingdoms built their power on a red-gleaming mineral that the post-catastrophe world lost.

- *The decline.* When "the divine portion began to fade away," the Atlanteans looked glorious "at the very time when they were full of avarice and unrighteous power" (121a–b). The Greek word is πλεονεξία, "wanting-more," which is the moral name for the insatiability Cicero gave to Saturn (Chapter 2, §2.1).

The *Critias* breaks off at the moment Zeus gathers the gods and begins to speak, so the punishment of Atlantis never reaches us as speech. Zeal's punishment has no speech either. It arrives as a beam from beneath.

Bacon. *New Atlantis* (1627) refounds the drowned island as a research polity. Bacon's narrator explains that "great Atlantis" was destroyed by a flood. Bensalem's Salomon's House states its aim plainly: "the knowledge of Causes, and secret motions of things; and the enlarging of the bounds of Human Empire, to the effecting of all things possible." Zeal has its Salomon's House in Kajar, where all magical and technological research takes place and whose scientists have developed many of the wonders seen in the game. In Bacon, *ipsa scientia potestas est* (*Meditationes Sacrae*, 1597) is a methodological claim. In Zeal it is literal, because knowledge and power are the same faculty, magic. One walkthrough sums up the kingdom as a place where spells and enchantment aren't only the norm, they're the law. Horkheimer and Adorno open their critique of enlightenment with Bacon, and Zeal is what happens when Bacon's New Atlantis meets the fate of Plato's: the research institution brings back the ancient punishment.

Swift. The third voyage of *Gulliver's Travels* (1726) supplies the satirical version. The flying island of Laputa is held up by a giant lodestone. Its inhabitants are so absorbed in mathematics and music that servants with bladders have to "flap" them back to attention. They govern the land below by hovering over rebellious towns to cut off sun and rain, and as a last resort by dropping the island on them. The same voyage includes the Academy of Lagado, where one projector "had been eight years upon a project for extracting sunbeams out of cucumbers, which were to be put into vials hermetically sealed, and let out to warm the air in raw inclement summers." That is stored sunshine, extracted by method, which is the fossil logic of Chapter 2 (§2.6) as farce.

The Laputans also live in constant dread of celestial catastrophe. They calculate that the earth "very narrowly escaped a brush from the tail of the last comet, which would have infallibly reduced it to ashes." The island's science stares at the sky and fears a falling star. Zeal is the Laputa that ignored the star already buried in the earth.

Miyazaki and Gainax. In the Japanese media of the decade before 1995 the floating kingdom had a fixed grammar: a girl wears a stone pendant that is the relic of a fallen royal kingdom in the sky or the sea, and the stone wakes that kingdom's machines. In Miyazaki's *Tenkū no shiro Rapyuta* (1986), Sheeta's levitation stone marks her as heir to Laputa's throne and responds to the island's technology. In Gainax's *Fushigi no umi no Nadia* (1990–91), the

"Blue Water" jewel marks its wearer as a descendant of Atlantean royalty, and the villains of Neo-Atlantis treat ordinary humanity as an inferior race.

Chrono Trigger reproduces the grammar exactly. Schala has a pendant identical to Marle's. It is a piece of Zeal technology that Schala used to control the Mammon Machine. When she uses it, the blue jewel in the pendant glows. It was handed down through generations of royalty who had no magic and did not know its purpose. At the Millennial Fair it reacts to the space-time distortion of Lucca's Telepods and opens the first Gate. The pendant that starts the game is a key to Zeal's machine.

The documentary record supplies one suggestive fact and no more: one overview of the production says Kato joined very early, after leaving Gainax. Miyazaki also supplies the moral that Zeal fails to learn. Sheeta tells Muska, who sneers at the people below, that humans cannot live cut off from the soil. At the end of the film the castle's ruins rise into the sky as a tree whose roots are wrapped around the stone. That image belongs to the counter-regime of lignous time, and Chapter 6 returns to it together with Laputa's robot gardener. The schema also outlived the game. The developers of *Chrono Trigger* later worked on *Chrono Cross* and *Xenogears*, among others, and the game's art staff included Tetsuya Takahashi. His *Xenogears* (1998) returns to the hidden sky-city whose elite treat the surface population as livestock.

Babel. "Let us build us a city and a tower, whose top may reach unto heaven; and let us make us a name, lest we be scattered abroad upon the face of the whole earth" (Genesis 11:4). Babel's builders fear dispersal and bring it about: "So the LORD scattered them abroad from thence upon the face of all the earth" (11:8). Zeal's fall scatters its wise men too, but across time instead of space. When the Mammon Machine was activated, the portal it opened sent the three Gurus to three different eras: Melchior to AD 1000, Belthasar to AD 2300, and Gaspar to the End of Time.

Two consequences follow. The Babel of this fiction scatters people across eras, not languages. And the Gates through which the commonwealth will travel (Chapter 4) are the wound left by that scattering.

Taken together, Zeal combines four inherited figures: punished *pleonexia* (Plato), the research utopia (Bacon), the extractive science that rules over the people beneath it (Swift), and the scattering of the over-reachers (Genesis). It adds the one thing none of them had: a god in the basement.

3.2 People of Light, People of the Earth: Wells Inverted, the ʿAm ha-ʾAreṣ Recalled

Zeal's social order is laid out vertically. The Earthbound live in Algetty, a network of caves that also leads to Mt. Woe, and conditions there are far worse than in the floating kingdom. Mt. Woe is a large floating mass chained to the surface, and it serves as Zeal's prison for anyone exiled there, Mystics included. The mountain is held down so that it cannot rise to Zeal's height, and the only way up is to climb the chain from Algetty. Mt. Woe's guardian is Giga Gaia, a "giant Earth" whose head keeps reviving its hands as long as it lives. It repeats Hesiod's arrangement, in which Gaia's Hundred-Handers guard the Titans in Tartarus (*Theogony* 734–735), and it is the last form Lavos imitates in its final recital, which ends with Giga Gaia. The Earth itself has been made a jailer. The prejudice extends beyond humans. Lavos is indirectly responsible for Zeal's abuse of the non-magic Earthbound, and for the creation of the Fiends, magical monsters whom the Enlightened Ones also treated poorly. Within the elite, only a few, the Gurus among them, did not look down on the Earthbound.

Wells inverted. In *The Time Machine* (1895), the Time Traveller arrives in 802,701 and first takes the idle, beautiful Eloi on the surface for heirs of a communist paradise. He then finds that the labouring Morlocks underground feed on them. Wells's diagnosis is that class division, carried far enough, has turned into speciation, and that the class below now eats the class above. Zeal keeps the first half of this structure (idleness above, toil below) and moves the second. The Earthbound eat no one. The eater lies beneath them both.

In Zeal, the role of the Morlocks has passed from the working class to the energy source. The consequence is a move from social critique to ecological critique. Zeal's class antagonism is real, but it is not the deepest fact. Both classes are host, and the Enlightened Ones' privilege amounts only to priority in the feeding order. In the koinobiont logic of Chapter 2 (§2.4), where the parasite keeps its host alive and growing, they are fattened first.

The noble lie. Plato's *Republic* (414b–415d) has the founders tell the citizens that they were all formed inside the earth, and that the god mixed gold into the rulers, silver into the auxiliaries, and iron and bronze into the farmers and craftsmen. This is the "noble lie" (γενναῖον ψεῦδος), a metallurgy of caste. Zeal's ideology works the same way, except that what is in the blood is magic. Two refutations follow, one spoken and one historical. The spoken one is Schala's sentence, read in Chapter 1 (§1.5c): the People of Light were once the same as the people of the earth. The historical one is the aftermath of the fall. The surviving

Enlightened Ones lose their magic and live among the Earthbound, and the surface dwellers go on to found the kingdoms of the Middle Ages. The gold in the blood was borrowed.

The scriptural calque. The Japanese 地の民 (*chi no tami*, "people of the land/earth") reproduces exactly the Hebrew עַם הָאָרֶץ (*ʿam ha-ʾareṣ*, "people of the land"), and the Hebrew term's semantic history predicts Zeal's caste logic. In the monarchic period it meant the landed citizenry (2 Kings 11:14). After the exile it named locals outside the returning community (Ezra 4:4). In rabbinic and New Testament usage it became the learned elite's word for the unlearned crowd: "this people who knoweth not the law are cursed" (John 7:49). Its sectarian counterpart appears at Qumran in the War Scroll, "The War of the Sons of Light against the Sons of Darkness" (1QM), where "light" is the name an elect gives itself.

The stereoscopic reading pays off decisively here. The Japanese text supplies "people of light," the English supplies "Mammon," and one passage of the Gospels already joins the two:

> "...for the children of this world are in their generation wiser than the children of light. And I say unto you, Make to yourselves friends of the mammon of unrighteousness; that, when ye fail, they may receive you into everlasting habitations... Ye cannot serve God and mammon." (Luke 16:8–13)

The pericope (a self-contained Gospel passage) even names the goal of Zeal's bargain: *everlasting habitations* (αἰωνίους σκηνάς), eternity bought with mammon. Neither text translates Luke 16, but the two read together put it back together. This is the strongest evidence so far that the double text is a single object seen from two angles.

Sirens and Moloch. In the first essay of *Dialektik der Aufklärung*, Horkheimer and Adorno read the Sirens episode of the *Odyssey* (12.165–200) as an allegory of the division of labour. Odysseus, bound to the mast, enjoys the song he cannot act on. The rowers, ears stopped with wax, row and hear nothing. Art is enjoyed by those who do not work, and work is done by those who cannot hear. Zeal makes the allegory a matter of geography. Enhasa listens and Algetty rows.

Fritz Lang's *Metropolis* (1927) supplies the cinematic precedent. The Eternal Gardens sit above and the workers' city below. In Freder's vision the great machine becomes Moloch, devouring its workers, the Miltonic devil "besmear'd with blood / Of human sacrifice" (*Paradise Lost* I.392–393), Mammon's companion in hell. And Maria comes up out of the catacombs leading the workers' children into the gardens. Schala is Zeal's Maria. She is the only Enlightened One who regularly visits Algetty, and the Earthbound love her because she treats them without discrimination.

Metropolis ends with a handshake under the motto *Mittler zwischen Hirn und Händen muß das Herz sein* ("The mediator between head and hands must be the heart"). Zeal never

reaches that resolution. Its only mediator is plugged into the machine (§3.4). **The heart is not the mediator between head and hands; it is the machine's power cable.**

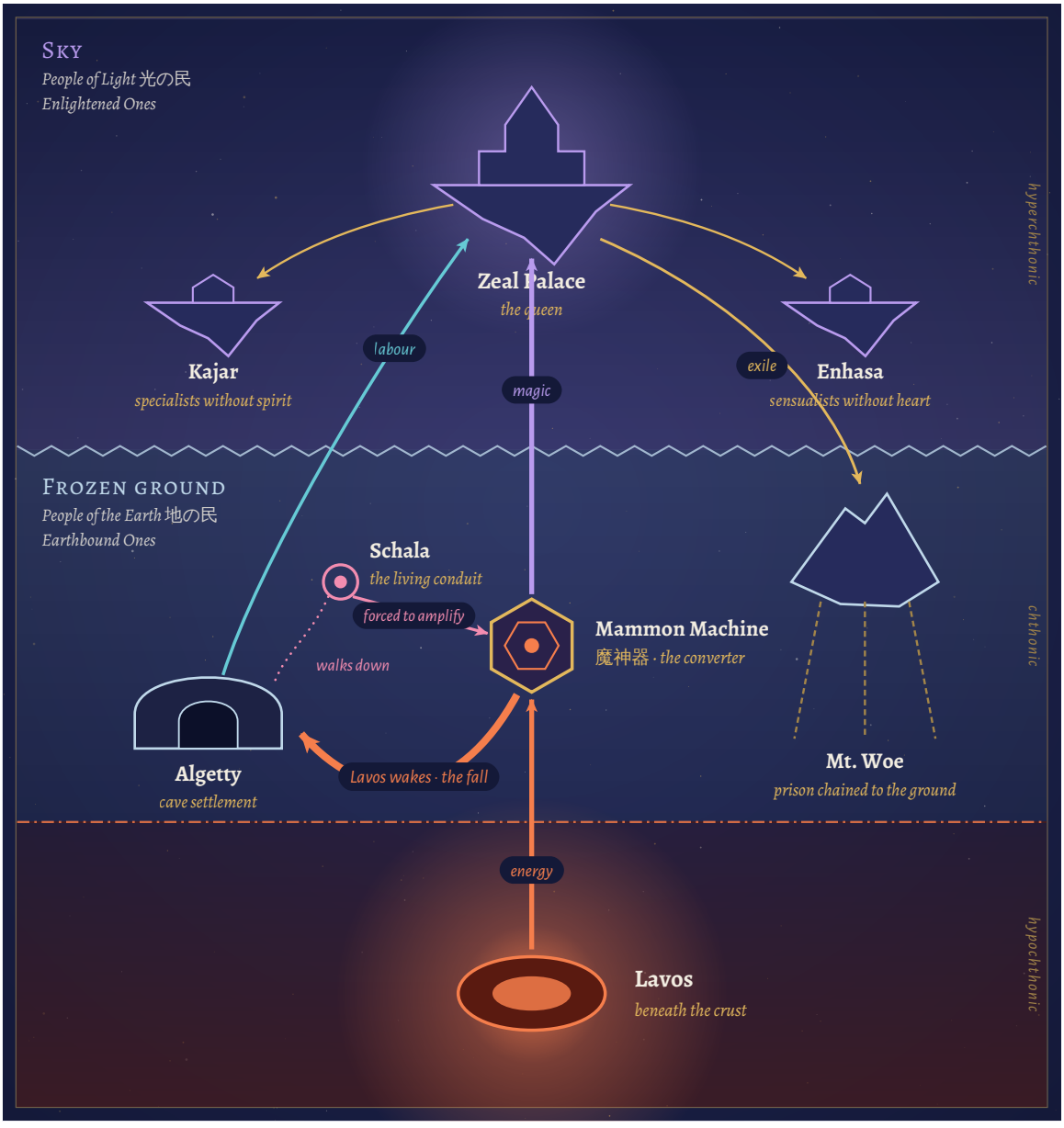


Figure 3 *The vertical economy of Zeal: hyperchthonic (above the earth), chthonic (on the ground), hypochthonic (below the crust).*

Even so, the collapse produces the outline of the polity that Chapter 7 will build. The Japanese walkthroughs file the survivors' settlement under 残された村 (*nokosareta mura*),

"the village that was left," and the English location list calls it the Commons and the Last Village, both "after the fall." *Remnant* and *commons* are the two words the heterochronic commonwealth will need.

3.3 The Mammon Machine as Gestell

In December 1949 Heidegger gave four lectures in Bremen under the general title *Einblick in das was ist* ("Insight into That Which Is"). In order, they were "Das Ding," "Das Ge-stell," "Die Gefahr," and "Die Kehre": the Thing, the Enframing, the Danger, the Turning. The sequence is the history of the Mammon Machine told in advance.

The Thing. Heidegger's thing is a jug. Its being as a vessel lies not in its clay but in the void that holds. Behind the analysis stands a passage Heidegger knew well. In 1946 he had tried to translate the *Daodejing* with Paul Shih-yi Hsiao, and Reinhard May's *Ex oriente lux* (1989) has documented how much his late work owes to East Asian sources. The passage is chapter 11: 埏埴以為器，當其無，有器之用 ("Knead clay to make a vessel; in its emptiness lies the vessel's use"). The vessel (器, *qi*) serves by being empty. It holds what is given and does not seize.

The Enframing. In "Die Frage nach der Technik" (1954) Heidegger defines modern technology as *Herausfordern*, a "challenging-forth" that demands that nature hand over energy to be extracted and stored. The Rhine becomes a supplier for the power plant built into it. Elsewhere *das Erdreich entbirgt sich jetzt als Kohlenrevier* ("the earth now reveals itself as a coal-mining district"). Whatever is challenged in this way stands by as *Bestand*, standing-reserve. Against this Heidegger sets *poiēsis*, bringing-forth. Its highest form is *physis*, whose example is *das Aufbrechen der Blüte in das Erblühen*, the bursting of a blossom into bloom, from within itself. The opposition between challenging-forth and blossoming is exactly the opposition between pyric time and ovular time, between detonation and hatching (Chapter 1, §1.3).

The Japanese name of the machine marks the precise moment when a vessel becomes enframing. 魔神器 is a 器 into which a 神 (god) has been forced. It is no longer the empty vessel that holds but a full one that compels. *Daodejing* 29 had already given the verdict, and it uses the very compound at the centre of the machine's name: 天下神器 ("the world is a sacred vessel"). Whoever acts on it ruins it, and whoever grasps it loses it. Chapter 1 called Zeal's device a demonic regalia (§1.5b). It can now be described more exactly as Laozi's sacred vessel, grasped. Heidegger's third and fourth lectures follow on cue. The Danger is Lavos waking. The Turning, together with the Hölderlin couplet Heidegger made its motto, belongs to the Gates and is held over for Chapter 4 (§4.8).

The converter. The Machine is fought a second time, inside the final fortress, and its battle behaviour amounts to a theory of money worked out in rules. Japanese guides give its action pattern as *standing quietly*, converting attacks into defence, and converting magic into attack power. They explain that while it is in its conversion stance, physical attacks raise its defence and magical attacks raise its attack power. The only safe time to strike is when it stands still.

Marx's 1844 manuscripts, glossing *Timon of Athens*, define money as *die sichtbare Gottheit, die Verwandlung aller menschlichen und natürlichen Eigenschaften in ihr Gegenteil, die allgemeine Verwechslung und Verkehrung der Dinge* ("the visible divinity, the transformation of all human and natural properties into their opposites, the universal confusion and inversion of things"). The Machine performs this conversion of every quality into its opposite. The blow becomes armour and the spell becomes strength. Shakespeare's speech, which Marx quotes, names what that convertibility promises: gold "will make / Black white, foul fair, wrong right, / Base noble, old young, coward valiant." *Old young* is the queen's whole programme (§3.6). The procedural lesson matches Boltanski and Chiapello's thesis in *Le nouvel esprit du capitalisme* (1999) that capitalism takes in its critics and feeds on them. Opposition offered at the wrong moment becomes the opponent's capital. The converter can be defeated only when it is not converting.

Zero experience. The Machine is the sixth boss of the Black Dream, so it stands in the middle of the dungeon, not at the end. Guides record that it yields no experience points, no tech points, and no gold. Only one thing can be taken from it: Ayla's Charm, 色仕掛け (*irojikake*, literally "feminine wiles"), lifts a Last Elixir from it (MegaElixir in the 1995 English text). Lavos's forms also yield zero across the board, but that is the convention for a game's final enemy. The Machine's zero is the telling one.

Benjamin had diagnosed this poverty in market terms: *die Erfahrung ist im Kurse gefallen* ("experience has fallen in value"), and the phrase is stock-exchange language ("Erfahrung und Armut," 1933). From Mammon nothing can be learned, in the precise sense the RPG formalises as experience, the unit by which time spent in struggle turns into growth. Only one combatant takes anything from the converter, the woman from before the fire (Chapter 2, §2.2). She does it not by force but by charm, and what she takes is the elixir of life, Zeal's dream of immortality reduced to an item in the inventory.

The megamachine. In *The Myth of the Machine* (1967), Lewis Mumford argues that the first machine was social: an apparatus made of human parts, organised around a god-king and the cult of the sun, whose monumental product in the Pyramid Age was the ruler's immortality. The Mammon Machine is a megamachine with one human component, the princess. Square had rehearsed this plot the year before. *Final Fantasy VI* (1994), which Kitase co-directed, has an empire that drains captured Espers of their magic in its Magitek research

facility, and a half-Esper girl held in obedience by a slave crown. *Chrono Trigger* takes the institution of magical extraction and moves it from an empire to a royal house, from the battlefield to the family.

The key in the lock. The game does not let the commonwealth stay clean. Schala uses her pendant to open a sealed door in the palace. The party must then take Marle's pendant to the Machine's red stone to power it up. Once charged, it can open the Zeal-era doors and chests sealed by a "mysterious force," and those chests hold heirlooms probably locked away since the fall. To open the treasures of history, the party has to put its key into Mammon. The machine also forges the counter-regime's weapon. At the Ocean Palace, when Crono takes out the Red Knife, the twin spirits plunge into the machine and its energy transforms them into Grandleon. Like the Epoch's wings (Chapter 1, §1.4), the holy sword of the commonwealth gets its power from the apparatus of extraction.

The counter-procedure. Inside Zeal's own technology the game also sets up the alternative to Zeal. Some sealed chests exist in both 600 and 1000 AD. Players report that if the party opens one in the Middle Ages and declines to take its contents, the same chest in the present gives off a small glow and yields a better item. **What is left in custody across four centuries ripens.** This is the oöchronic principle in miniature, and the Conclusion makes it the cornerstone of the thesis's ethics. The same Dreamstone technology that extracts can also incubate, if what it holds is left alone. The difference lies not in the device but in whether one is willing to wait.

3.4 Schala in the Basement of Omelas

Ursula K. Le Guin's "The Ones Who Walk Away from Omelas" (1973) carries the subtitle "Variations on a theme by William James." The theme comes from "The Moral Philosopher and the Moral Life" (1891). James imagines utopias outdone, with "millions kept permanently happy on the one simple condition that a certain lost soul on the far-off edge of things should lead a life of lonely torture," and argues that a specifically moral emotion makes us feel how hideous it would be to accept the bargain. Le Guin puts the lost soul in a cellar under a city of festivals. Every citizen learns of the child, and most stay. Some walk away. Behind both stands Ivan Karamazov, who will not accept a harmony bought with a tortured child's tears and "most respectfully" returns his ticket.

Schala is Zeal's Omelas child, with three differences that make her case harder than Le Guin's.

1. **She is not hidden.** The Omelas child is kept in a basement. Schala is the princess, the most visible person in the kingdom. Her magic is great enough to surpass her mother's,

and for that reason her mother assigned her the role of drawing out Lavos's energy through the 魔神器 and used her. Zeal does not need to hide its victim, because it has made her an office.

2. **She is a conduit, not a passive sufferer.** What is exploited is her gift, not her pain. At the Ocean Palace, unable to resist her mother, she is forced to push the Machine's power to its limit. Kant's formula forbids treating humanity "never merely as a means." Zeal has turned the most capable person in the realm into a means in the most literal way, as a component of the instrument. The Japanese tradition has a precise name for this: *hitobashira* (人柱), the "human pillar." Legends attach it to bridges and castle foundations, where a person was buried alive so that the structure would stand. Zeal's floating continents stand on a living pillar.
3. **She is the one who walks down.** Le Guin's citizens either stay or leave. Schala does a third thing, every day. Zeal's children secretly oppose their mother. Schala alone goes down to Algetty, and she frees the time-travellers in secret when the queen imprisons them. She is the Omelas child who also walks away and keeps coming back.

The two names. The double text gives the princess two names, and each encodes a fate.

- *Japanese: Sara.* In Japanese she is サラ (*Sara*), a homophone of 沙羅 / 娑羅, the sal tree (*Shorea robusta*). Twin sal trees stood at the Buddha's deathbed, and they open the most famous sentence in classical Japanese prose:

> 祇園精舎の鐘の声、諸行無常の響きあり。娑羅双樹の花の色、盛者必衰の理をあらはす。おごれる人も久しからず、ただ春の夜の夢のごとし。
>
> "The bell of the Jetavana monastery echoes the impermanence of all things. The colour of the twin sal trees' flowers shows that the prosperous must fall. The proud do not endure; they are only a dream on a spring night." (*Heike monogatari*, I.1)

The princess of the doomed kingdom carries, in Japanese, the name of the flower whose colour announces that the prosperous must fall. The same sentence calls the pride that precedes the fall a *dream*. In Japanese temple gardens *sara* is the name given to the summer camellia (*Stewartia pseudocamellia*), whose flowers open in the morning and fall by evening.

- *English: Schala.* The English spelling sounds like German *Schale*: bowl, dish, husk, peel, and *Eierschale*, eggshell. The vessel-princess bears, in the English text, the name of a vessel. She is the bowl inside the 器. The DS supplement makes the image concrete. There, Lavos absorbs her beyond the darkness of time, and the hidden boss looks like Schala riding on, or absorbed into, the Lavos outer shell. She is Luria's spark trapped in the *kelippah* (Chapter 2, §2.8), the husk holding the light that gives it life.

The two names are the two fates of the vessel: the sal flower that falls, and the shell that holds. Because *Schale* also means eggshell, the English name raises a question that Chapter 6 (§6.7) has to answer: what did the shell hold? In the sequel, the child Lucca finds turns out to be Kid, Schala's daughter-clone.

The inheritance. The Guardia royal family came to possess the pendant and passed it down as an heirloom. The descendants who wore it knew nothing of its purpose. The key of Schala's bondage therefore became, without anyone knowing, the key of the commonwealth's freedom, since it opens the first Gate at the Fair (§3.1). In *Sein und Zeit* §74 Heidegger defines authentic historicity as *Überlieferung*, a handing-down in which possibilities that have been are taken up again. In the English text the girl who takes up this one is named Nadia, which is to say Hope (Chapter 1, §1.6). Hope inherits the vessel-princess's key, and the instrument of extraction becomes a tool of rescue once someone who refuses its original use picks it up.

After Omelas. N. K. Jemisin's "The Ones Who Stay and Fight" (2018) answers Le Guin with a city, Um-Helat, that keeps its happiness by actively fighting the Omelas idea itself. *Chrono Trigger* proposes a fourth position, which only time travel makes available: **go back to the basement before the bargain is sealed.** The party does this at the Ocean Palace, and it fails. The bargain wins once. The princess is lost, in the Japanese account swallowed by the dimensional vortex the Machine's runaway produced and separated from the party. That failure keeps the game's ethics honest. Chapter 6 calls Schala the *remainder*: the one restoration the restorers could not achieve.

3.5 Ukiyo over Uki-yo: The Floating World, the Sorrowful World, and the Bubble

The Japanese word *ukiyo* carries a reversal of values in its own history. Medieval Buddhist usage wrote it 憂き世, "the sorrowful world," the transient realm of suffering. The early Edo period rewrote it with a homophonous character as 浮世, "the floating world," and turned lament into celebration. Asai Ryōi's *Ukiyo monogatari* (c. 1661) defines the new *ukiyo* as living only for the moment and enjoying the moon, the snow, the blossoms, and the maple leaves, drifting like a gourd carried along by the river.

Zeal pulls the two spellings apart and stacks them. Enhasa, "the city of dreams," is full of sleeping areas and of things beyond human need, and most of its inhabitants live in a near-dreamlike state. Algetty, below, is the *uki-yo* of 憂き: a cave of sorrow under a city of floating. **Zeal is a *ukiyo* suspended over an *uki-yo*.** The homophone that Japanese history used to

turn the sorrowful world into the pleasurable one becomes, in Zeal's geography, two strata of one society.

The mirage-clam. The East Asian tradition explains floating cities with a precise zoology. Japanese 蜃気楼 (*shinkirō*, "mirage") means literally "towers of the *shen*'s breath." The word goes back to the "Treatise on the Celestial Offices" in Sima Qian's *Shiji*, which says that the breath of the *shen* forms towers. The creature was understood either as a kind of dragon or as a giant clam. The yōkai painter Toriyama Sekien (1712–1788) settled the matter for popular imagination. In *Konjaku hyakki shūi* (1781) he glossed the *Shiji* with the sentence 「蜃とは大蛤なり」 ("the *shen* is a great clam") and drew a giant clam exhaling a palace. His commentary says the clam 「海上に気をふきて、楼閣城市のかたちをなす」 ("breathes out its vapour over the sea and forms the shapes of towers, palaces, and walled cities") and adds that the mirage is also called 海市 (*kaishi*), the "sea-market."

The fit is striking. A shelled creature lies beneath the water, and its exhalation holds up palaces and cities above. Lavos is a shelled creature (外殻, "outer shell," Chapter 2, §2.8) buried beneath the sea floor, and its power, drawn through the Machine, keeps Zeal's palaces in the air. **Zeal is a *shinkirō*, a mirage-city held aloft by the breath of the shelled thing below. When the clam breathes in, the city falls.** Sekien's alternative name adds the economic reading, since the mirage is a *market* on the sea, and Mammon has been there from the start. The hermeneutics of Chapter 1 cannot resist one further coincidence of names: the painter of the mirage-clam (鳥山石燕) and the designer of Zeal's characters (鳥山明) share the surname *Toriyama*. It is noted here and not interpreted.

Weber's triad. The last page of Max Weber's *Protestant Ethic* (1904–05) ends with a sentence that could serve as a guide to Zeal's three cities:

> *Fachmenschen ohne Geist, Genußmenschen ohne Herz: dies Nichts bildet sich ein, eine nie vorher erreichte Stufe des Menschentums erstiegen zu haben.*
>
> "Specialists without spirit, sensualists without heart: this nullity imagines that it has climbed to a level of humanity never before attained."

Kajar is the city of specialists without spirit, and Enhasa the city of sensualists without heart. The name *Enlightened Ones* is the nullity's self-image: "a level of humanity never before attained."

The rentier state. Political economy has a name for a polity whose prosperity comes from an external rent and not from its people's work. Hossein Mahdavy introduced the *rentier state* (1970), Hazem Beblawi and Giacomo Luciani systematised it (1987), and Richard Auty named its pathology the *resource curse* (1993). A rentier state does not need its subjects' consent, because it does not need their taxes. It can hand out privilege without asking for productivity, and it cultivates a mentality in which reward is cut off from effort. Zeal fits

the model exactly. Its rent is the Lavos-energy drawn through the Machine. It needs the Earthbound only as labour, not as contributors whose consent would buy them representation. Enhasa's dreamers are the rentier mentality in town form. This is the political shape of the fossil economy described in Chapter 2 (§2.6): a regime of buried sunshine produces a politics without consent.

The bubble. *Chrono Trigger* was conceived in 1992 and released in 1995, in the wreckage of the Heisei bubble. The Nikkei average peaked on the last trading day of 1989, land prices peaked around 1991, and then both collapsed. In a much-repeated estimate of the period, the grounds of the Imperial Palace in Tokyo were worth more than all the real estate in California. No allegorical intent is claimed here. But a floating kingdom whose wealth rested on a buried force, and which fell into the sea in a single day, reached an audience that had just watched its own *ukiyo* deflate.

The ecological layer completes the picture. Zeal rose above the cloud cover of the ice age and left the ground to the cold. Its fall ended the freeze. In current terms, this is climate secession: an elite that solves catastrophe for itself by rising above it, a lifeboat polity in Garrett Hardin's sense (1974). The game's judgement is unambiguous. The sun comes back to the ground only when the lifeboat sinks.

3.6 Queen Zeal and the Bad Infinite

The queen's name, ジール in Japanese and *Zeal* in English, is the same in both texts. Its etymology is Greek: ζῆλος, from ζέω, "to boil, to seethe." The sovereign of the big fire's civilisation is named for heat. The verse that gives the word its most famous scriptural use also contains the chronophage's verb: ὁ ζῆλος τοῦ οἴκου σου καταφάγεταί με, "the zeal of thy house shall devour me" (John 2:17, quoting LXX Ps 68:10). Kata-*phag*-: the queen's own verse names the house devoured by its zeal.

Japanese fan reference works reconstruct her career with a moralist's precision. She was once a kind queen who succeeded her late husband, the former king. In trying to use Lavos's power for her kingdom's development, she was gradually captivated by it. She came to worship Lavos as an absolute god and, before she knew it, wanted eternal life not for the nation but for herself alone. Her watchword is 「わらわは永遠の生命を手に入れる」 ("I shall obtain eternal life!"), and she promises that her kingdom will be wrapped in the light of god. The same reference calls her trajectory 本末転倒 (*honmatsu tentō*, the inversion of root and branch): she forgot her original purpose so completely that she destroyed the very kingdom she meant to enrich. A fan answering the question of her corruption reduces it to one cause: her desire for eternal life was simply too strong.

Aristotle's diagnosis. The most exact philosophical account of the queen was written twenty-three centuries before her. In *Politics* I.2 the polis comes into being for the sake of living but exists for the sake of living well (τοῦ εὖ ζῆν). In I.9 Aristotle explains why the art of wealth-getting (*chrēmatistikē*) knows no limit, and his explanation joins unlimited acquisition to the desire for mere life:

> "The origin of this disposition in men is that they are intent upon living only, and not upon living well; and, as their desires are unlimited, they also desire that the means of gratifying them should be without limit." (*Politics* 1257b40–1258a2, Jowett)

This is the queen's case exactly. The Mammon Machine, an unlimited means, serves the wish for unlimited life: *zēn* without *eu*. Marx's formula for capital, M–C–M' (money–commodity–more money), in which the means becomes the end, is the economic form of 本末転倒. Weber supplies its image. The care for external goods was meant to lie on the saint's shoulders "like a light cloak," but *aus dem Mantel ließ das Verhängnis ein stahlhartes Gehäuse werden* ("fate turned the cloak into a casing hard as steel"). *Gehäuse* means casing, housing, shell. The queen's care for her kingdom, once a cloak, hardens into a shell. She ends enclosed in the Black Omen, fused to the Machine, under the carapace of the god she worships.

The bad infinite. Hegel distinguishes the *schlechte Unendlichkeit* from true infinity (*Wissenschaft der Logik*, I.1.2.C). The bad infinite is the finite prolonged without end, the "and so on" of a progression that never arrives, a "perennial ought." True infinity returns into itself and includes its limit. The queen's immortality is the bad infinite in bodily form: the same queen, more of her, forever. The mythological record has always known what this kind of eternity costs.

- **Tithonus.** Eos asked Zeus to make her mortal lover immortal and forgot to ask that he stay young (*Homeric Hymn to Aphrodite* 218–238). Tennyson's Tithonus watches the woods "decay and fall" and says: "Me only cruel immortality / Consumes." The verb is the right one. An immortality without renewal *consumes*. It is chronophagy turned inward.
- **The Struldbruggs.** Swift put the immortals of Luggnagg in the same voyage as the flying island. Gulliver first imagines the wisdom and wealth an undying man would accumulate, which is stored time in its happiest form. He then learns that the Struldbruggs age forever and become "opinionative, peevish, covetous, morose, vain, talkative, but incapable of friendship, and dead to all natural affection." *Covetous*: in Swift as in Aristotle, endless life and endless wanting are a single vice. Swift set Laputa and the Struldbruggs side by side, and Zeal joins them in a single queen.

- **The floating isles of the immortals.** The *Liezi* (chapter 5, "Tang wen") tells of five mountains in the eastern sea, among them Penglai, where immortals lived among trees whose fruit kept them from aging. The mountains floated, rising and falling with the waves, until the Lord of Heaven had giant turtles carry them on their heads. A giant from the land of Longbo caught six of the turtles in a single cast, and two of the mountains drifted to the north and sank. Eastern tradition thus knew floating islands of the deathless, held up by a creature beneath and sunk when that creature was taken. The First Emperor of Qin sent Xu Fu across the eastern sea to find Penglai's elixir, and Japanese legend has Xu Fu landing in Japan. Su Shi, governor of Dengzhou in 1085, prayed to the sea god to see the mirage that appears off that coast, the *haishi* or sea-market of the previous section. The isles of the immortals, the mirage, and the market are one image.

Natality. The elixir that Ayla lifts from the Machine (§3.3) is the queen's eternity at its true price, a consumable. The deeper objection is the one Hannah Arendt put most sharply. What saves the world of human affairs from its "natural" ruin is "ultimately the fact of natality" (*The Human Condition*, §34), the fact that new people begin. Hans Jonas's "The Burden and Blessing of Mortality" (1992) adds that mortality is the price of novelty: a world of the deathless would be a world without newcomers. **The queen who would never die would let nothing be born.** Immortality is anti-ovular, and chronophagy and immortality turn out to be the same project seen from two sides. One eats the future so that nothing replaces it. The other refuses to make way for it. Both are Kronos.

This is why the hero's resurrection (Chapter 5) must not be mistaken for immortality. Zeal wants not to die. The commonwealth wants one death undone. One is the bad infinite of a single life prolonged, and the other is a single return inside finitude, hatched from an egg. In the Black Dream the queen boasts that she has obtained eternal life and wants to rule forever alongside Lavos. Fan reference works describe her as made immortal by the Machine and its connection to the Gates and prepared to wait out the millennium until Lavos wakes. Gaspar's last words about her concern her return to being human, and Chapter 6 weighs them.

3.7 The Black Dream

The temple under the sea. The Mammon Machine was moved from the palace to the Ocean Palace, a research site far from the main continent for dangerous magical experiments. The two texts name that site differently, in the pattern Chapter 1 established. The English "Ocean Palace" is sovereign and secular. The Japanese 海底神殿 (*kaitei shinden*, "temple on

the sea floor") is sacral. Japanese guides call it a giant temple drawing out the energy of Lavos, 「諸悪の元凶」 ("the root of all evil"), and note that it is a dungeon that vanishes once cleared. Its lineage runs through Lovecraft's R'lyeh, where the dead god dreams under the sea (Chapter 2, §2.2), and the Japanese Ryūgū-jō, the Dragon Palace beneath the waves, where, as Chapter 5 will explain, time runs differently.

The rising. After the disaster, the ruined Ocean Palace rises into the air as the Black Omen, Queen Zeal's floating fortress. Zeal used the energy she had absorbed from Lavos to empower both herself and the palace. The result is a floating perversion of the Ocean Palace, built from its ruins with Lavos's energy and the most arcane magic, sailing the sky as a dark presence and a shrine to Lavos. At its far end stands the Mammon Machine, torn and battered from the earlier incident, and on its throne sits Zeal, fully corrupted by Lavos's power. Its Japanese name, as Chapter 1 noted, is 黒の夢 (*kuro no yume*), "Black Dream." Once it appears, it is present in every later era unless the party defeats it in an earlier one.

The warehouse of futures. Inside, the queen explains what the fortress is. 「そこに眠っているのは、お前達の未来だ」 ("What sleeps there is your future"), she says. She goes on: the dreams that might yet come true, the joys and sorrows still to be had, the travellers' very tomorrow, all flowing through every time and dimension while the fortress waits for Lord Lavos to wake. Their future will surely end up here.

This is the clearest statement of chronophagy in the game, and it adds the one dimension Chapter 2 had not yet named. **The Black Dream is the future turned into standing-reserve.** Lavos ate the past (§2.7). Zeal warehouses the future and holds every possible tomorrow in storage until it is consumed. Speculative finance has the instrument for this. Its name, *futures*, has a Japanese origin, since Osaka's Dōjima rice exchange, licensed by the shogunate in 1730, is often cited as the first organised futures market. Contemporary theory has the diagnosis. Maurizio Lazzarato's *La fabrique de l'homme endetté* (2011) describes debt as the seizure of future time. Franco "Bifo" Berardi and Mark Fisher describe "the slow cancellation of the future." Reinhart Koselleck's *Vergangene Zukunft* (1979) shows that every age stores the futures it once expected. The Black Dream is all of these as architecture: futures kept as stock.

The omen nobody reads. A detail of the game's world completes the analysis. The fortress hangs in the sky in every era, yet people pay it no mind, because it has been floating there for thousands of years. Kafka wrote the parable of this indifference in the Zürau aphorisms:

> *Leoparden brechen in den Tempel ein und saufen die Opferkrüge leer; das wiederholt sich immer wieder; schließlich kann man es vorausberechnen, und es wird ein Teil der Zeremonie.*
>
> "Leopards break into the temple and drink the sacrificial vessels dry; this happens again and again; eventually it can be calculated in advance, and it becomes part of the ceremony."

The sacrificial vessels are emptied, and the emptying becomes liturgy. Amitav Ghosh's *The Great Derangement* (2016) diagnosed the modern form of this blindness: a catastrophe that is present and slow becomes scenery, too large and too constant to be perceived. The Black Omen is the most visible thing in the sky of every era and the least read. **The omen fails because it has become normal, not because it is hidden.**

The traveller's dark double. Chapter 1 (§1.5a) observed that *kuro no yume* sounds the same as *Kurono yume*, "Chrono's dream." Fan chronologists have found grounds to take that homophone seriously. Their inference runs as follows. When the party intervened at the Ocean Palace, Schala had only enough power left to send the time-travellers and Magus to safety. In the history before the intervention, she would have been able to save herself, the queen, and perhaps one other. Because the queen stayed behind and communed with Lavos, she became the fortress's necessary key. If this reconstruction is right, the Black Dream is the time-travellers' own unintended creation. It is the nightmare form of their project: a will to stand above every era at once, to be present in all of them, to hold the future in reserve. The Gates are the commonwealth's Black Dream refused.

The speculative manga that finished during the game's production gives the refusal its most radical form. In the final volume of Miyazaki's *Kaze no tani no Naushika* (1994), the heroine reaches the Crypt of Shuwa, where the engineers of the old world have stored a planned future: a purified world and a redesigned humanity, waiting to be released when the poisoned earth has healed. Nausicaä destroys it. She refuses an administered future, even a benevolent one, for the sake of the living as they are. The party's assault on the Black Dream is the same refusal. A future that has been warehoused is not a future. It is inventory.

The Green Dream. The counter-image is planted at Zeal's centre, and the Japanese text marks it with exact chromatic symmetry. Japanese guides describe a sub-event called 緑の夢 (*midori no yume*, "the Green Dream"), triggered by talking to a woman holding a sapling in the ancient Zeal Palace. The fan chronology records that Melchior created a special magic seed and gave it to a woman. The item that bears the name grants Auto-Revive, a status that Lavos alone can override. Inside the palace of the time-eaters, the Guru of Life has planted a dream of the opposite colour: green against black, a seed against stock, revival against consumption. The English text keeps the green and turns the black into an omen, which breaks the pair. The stereoscopic reading restores it.

Table 3.1 *Zeal's conversions and the game's inconvertibles*

WHAT ZEAL CONVERTS	INTO	INSTRUMENT	TRADITION THAT NAMES IT	THE GAME'S INCONVERTIBLE	DEVELOPED IN
a buried god	energy, magic	Mammon Machine / 魔神器	Heidegger's *Gestell*; Laozi 29; Marx's "visible divinity"	the sealed chest that ripens only if left	Conclusion

WHAT ZEAL CONVERTS	INTO	INSTRUMENT	TRADITION THAT NAMES IT	THE GAME'S INCONVERTIBLE	DEVELOPED IN
a daughter's gift	a conduit	Schala and her pendant	James and Le Guin's Omelas; *hito-bashira*; Mumford	the princess who walks down	Ch. 6
a people's labour	leisure	Algetty → Enhasa	Wells; the Sirens; Weber; the rentier state	the Commons of the remnant	Ch. 7
mortality	bad infinity	the queen's immortality	Aristotle; Hegel; Tithonus; the Struldbruggs	the egg: one death undone within finitude	Ch. 5
the future	stock	the Black Dream	futures; Lazzarato; Berardi and Fisher; Kafka	the Green Dream: seed and revival	Ch. 6

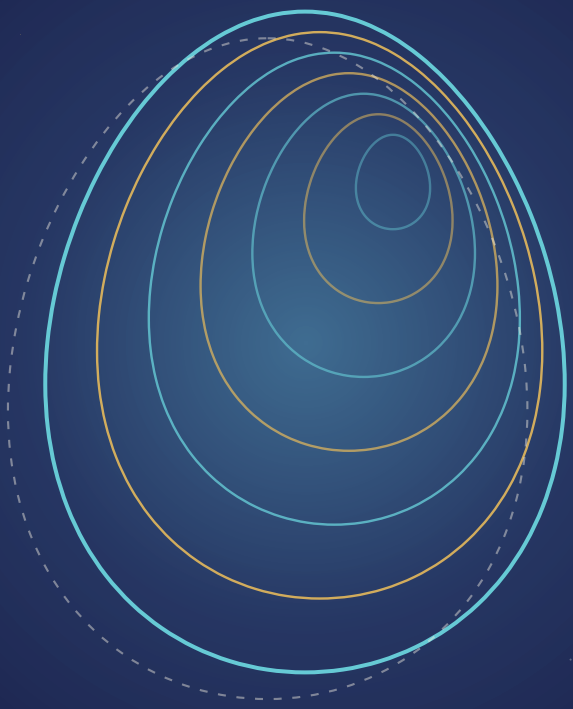
Read across its rows, the table gives the chapter's result. Zeal's principle is panconvertibility, and its four great conversions turn a god into energy, a daughter into a conduit, labour into leisure, and the future into stock. Against each, the game plants an **inconvertible**: something that yields its value only to custody and never to extraction. A sealed chest yields more for being left. A princess cannot be reduced to her function. A commons forms only after the sky has fallen. A seed can be grown but cannot be hurried. These inconvertibles are the materials of the ethics the Conclusion will assemble.

One conversion remains, and it is the strangest, because the commonwealth depends on it. When the Mammon Machine was activated, its portal flung the Gurus into other eras. The Gates through which the party travels are the scars of that event, wounds that Zeal's catastrophe opened in time. Chapter 4 therefore has to ask what time must be like if it can be wounded, whether the wounds can be walked through, and what follows from saving the world through a door that its destroyer opened.

有時

uji

"being-time"



Chapter Four

4

Gates and Hypertime

The Metaphysics of the Mutable Past

μόνου γὰρ αὐτοῦ καὶ θεὸς στερίσκεται, / ἀγένητα ποιεῖν ἅσσ᾽ ἂν ᾖ πεπραγμένα.

"For this alone is denied even to God: to make undone the things that have been done."

— Agathon, quoted in Aristotle, *Nicomachean Ethics* VI.2, 1139b10–11

有時に経歴の功徳あり。いはゆる今日より明日に経歴す、今日より昨日に経歴す。

"Being-time has the virtue of passage: it passes from today to tomorrow; it passes from today to yesterday."

— Dōgen, *Shōbōgenzō*, "Uji" (1240)

Wo aber Gefahr ist, wächst / Das Rettende auch.

"But where danger is, grows / the saving power also."

— Hölderlin, "Patmos" (1803)

Chapter 3 closed on a scandal: the commonwealth saves the world by passing through doors that its destroyer opened. This chapter supplies the metaphysics the scandal requires. Both texts call the doors by the same word, ゲート (*gēto*) and "Gate," so the stereoscopic disparity has to be looked for in the instrument that makes the doors usable. In English it is the Gate Key. The Reptites steal it in prehistory, and at that point the party is stuck in 65,000,000 BC until it gets it back. In Japanese the same object is ゲートホルダー (*gēto horudā*), "Gate Holder." Japanese guides describe it as a device that fixes in one place Gates that are unstable, liable to appear anywhere and vanish at any moment, an invention Lucca threw together just after Crono followed Marle through the first one, and as a stabiliser for the distortion, built on the principle of her Telepod. One

more detail completes the description: the Holder takes effect automatically merely by being carried, so it has no "use" command at all.

A key is turned; a holder is carried. The English text imagines the traveller as someone who opens a door. The Japanese text imagines her as someone who holds a door open, stabilising a wound so that it can be crossed without being widened. These are two ethics of passage, access and custody, and the Conclusion will choose between them. The present chapter asks what time must be like for such an instrument to work. Its answer comes in seven propositions:

1. The Gates presuppose a block of eras and a second dimension of time in which that block is rewritten (§4.1).
2. The second dimension exists in the world only as testimony. It is what the travellers, and the player, remember (§4.1).
3. Travellers are exempt from the changes they cause, with one genealogical exception and one case left unresolved (§4.2).
4. Changes overwrite history instead of branching it, so every rescue is also an erasure, and erasure creates a duty to mourn (§§4.3–4.4).
5. The game declines to found the institution that time travel invites (§4.5).
6. The Gate's deepest operation is modal: it gives the past the contingency that belongs to the present (§4.6).
7. In the Buddhist metaphysics the game unknowingly rebuilds, the past is never consumed, only covered over. Chronophagy is therefore a usurpation of time and not its law. The Gate itself is a *pharmakon*, a wound through which healing comes (§§4.7–4.8).

4.1 A-Series, B-Series, Hypertime

In "The Unreality of Time" (*Mind*, 1908), J. M. E. McTaggart distinguished two ways of ordering events. The A-series orders them as past, present, and future, and these positions shift: every event is first future, then present, then past. The B-series orders them as earlier and later, and these relations never change. The Battle of Hastings is earlier than Waterloo forever. McTaggart argued that time requires change, that only the A-series supplies change, and that the A-series is contradictory, because every event must carry three incompatible determinations. He concluded that time is unreal.

The century of debate that followed divided philosophers into two camps. B-theorists hold that the block of earlier and later is the whole truth and that passage is an artefact of perspective. A-theorists hold that the present is objectively privileged. Arthur Prior's

"Thank Goodness That's Over" (1959) argued, for the A-theory, that relief at a pain's being past cannot be translated into tenseless relations. C. D. Broad's "growing block" (*Scientific Thought*, 1923), in which the past is real and the future is not yet, stands between the camps. Augustine had already moved the A-series inside the soul: *praesens de praeteritis memoria, praesens de praesentibus contuitus, praesens de futuris expectatio*, "a present of things past, memory; a present of things present, sight; a present of things future, expectation" (*Confessions* XI.20.26).

Time travel is easiest to make consistent in a B-world. David Lewis's "The Paradoxes of Time Travel" (1976) distinguished the traveller's *personal* time from *external* time and showed that a journey into the past involves no contradiction so long as nothing in the past is changed. His traveller Tim *can* kill his grandfather, in the sense that he has the rifle, the skill, and the opportunity. He *cannot*, in the sense that the killing is not compossible with the facts, since Grandfather lived. The traveller can affect the past, because his presence was always part of it, but he cannot change it. Physics has its own version of this constraint, Igor Novikov's self-consistency principle (formalised in Friedman et al., *Physical Review D* 42, 1990). Cinema has its masterpieces. In *La Jetée* (1962) the traveller's childhood memory turns out to be the sight of his own death. In *The Terminator* (1984) the soldier sent back to protect the future resistance leader's mother turns out to be the leader's father. In *12 Monkeys*, released at the end of 1995, the year of *Chrono Trigger*, the traveller cannot stop the plague and has always already died in the airport where, as a child, he watched himself die. The same year thus produced both theses: the past as a closed loop and the past as a revisable text.

Chrono Trigger stands unambiguously on the second side. Its past changes, and the changes are visible:

- A desert of 600 AD becomes a forest by 1000 AD because an android stays behind to plant it (Chapter 6).
- A sealed chest left unopened in 600 AD yields a better item in 1000 AD (Chapter 3, §3.3).
- The starving domes of 2300 give way to a green world once Lavos is defeated.

Lewis noted that real change of the past would require a second dimension of time, and he set the idea aside as not what time-travel stories intend. Jack Meiland took it up in "A Two-Dimensional Passage Model of Time for Time Travel" (*Philosophical Studies* 26, 1974). The idea has a literary prehistory in J. W. Dunne's *An Experiment with Time* (1927), whose observer of "Time 1" needs a "Time 2" in which to move; Borges dissected the resulting regress in "El tiempo y J. W. Dunne." Philosophers now call the second dimension *hypertime*: a time in which the entire B-series has successive versions. In the game, hypertime is the order of play.

The android shows the two times side by side. When Robo stays in 600 AD to tend Fiona's forest, his personal time runs for four hundred years while his companions' runs for a few minutes, and both are measured against a block that is being rewritten as they go.

Peter van Inwagen pressed the decisive objection ("Changing the Past," *Oxford Studies in Metaphysics* 5, 2010). If a hypertime model replaces one series with another, nothing in either series has changed. Each version simply has the past it has. What looks like change is substitution: a revised edition, not an erased line. The objection is correct as far as it goes, and *Chrono Trigger* answers it in an unexpected way. In the game, the superseded versions exist nowhere in the world. No archive of the green 2300 records the starving domes, and no chronicle of 600 AD remembers the desert. The earlier version survives only in the minds of those who passed through the Gates. Outside the fiction it survives in the player's memory and in the save files, each of which carries the title of the chapter in which it was made. A guide advises that for one ending the save file should read "The Time Egg." The save menu is a table of versions.

I call this structure **testimonial hypertime**: the second dimension of time has no being except as testimony. Van Inwagen is right that no single past changes. But McTaggart had already shown that change, in the only sense that distinguishes time from a static order, requires a standpoint: an event is past *for* a present. In the game, the travellers are that standpoint. History counts as changed because there are people who remember it otherwise, and it counts as changed only for them.

Paul Ricoeur placed testimony at the root of history (*La mémoire, l'histoire, l'oubli*, 2000). The witness says *I was there* and asks to be believed. The commonwealth's witnesses were there, in a there that no longer exists, and nothing can corroborate them. Paul Celan's "Aschenglorie" (1967), whose title means "ash-glory," ends: "Niemand / zeugt für den / Zeugen," "No one / bears witness for the / witness." After the fire, the witness has no witness. That is the epistemic condition of a time traveller who has abolished the catastrophe he saw.

Other fictions of revision decide differently. In Tsutsui Yasutaka's *Toki o kakeru shōjo* (1965–67), the visitor from the future erases the heroine's memory before he leaves, and she keeps only a longing she cannot place at the scent of lavender. In Asimov's *The End of Eternity* (§4.5), only the Eternals remember the realities they replace, and they remember by file. *Chrono Trigger* gives the memory of the undone to its agents and its player. Its metaphysics of time is at bottom a metaphysics of memory, and it sets two archives against each other. Lavos is an archive that devours the past and wears it as armour (Chapter 2, §2.7). The commonwealth is an archive that carries the undone: it remembers what no longer happened.

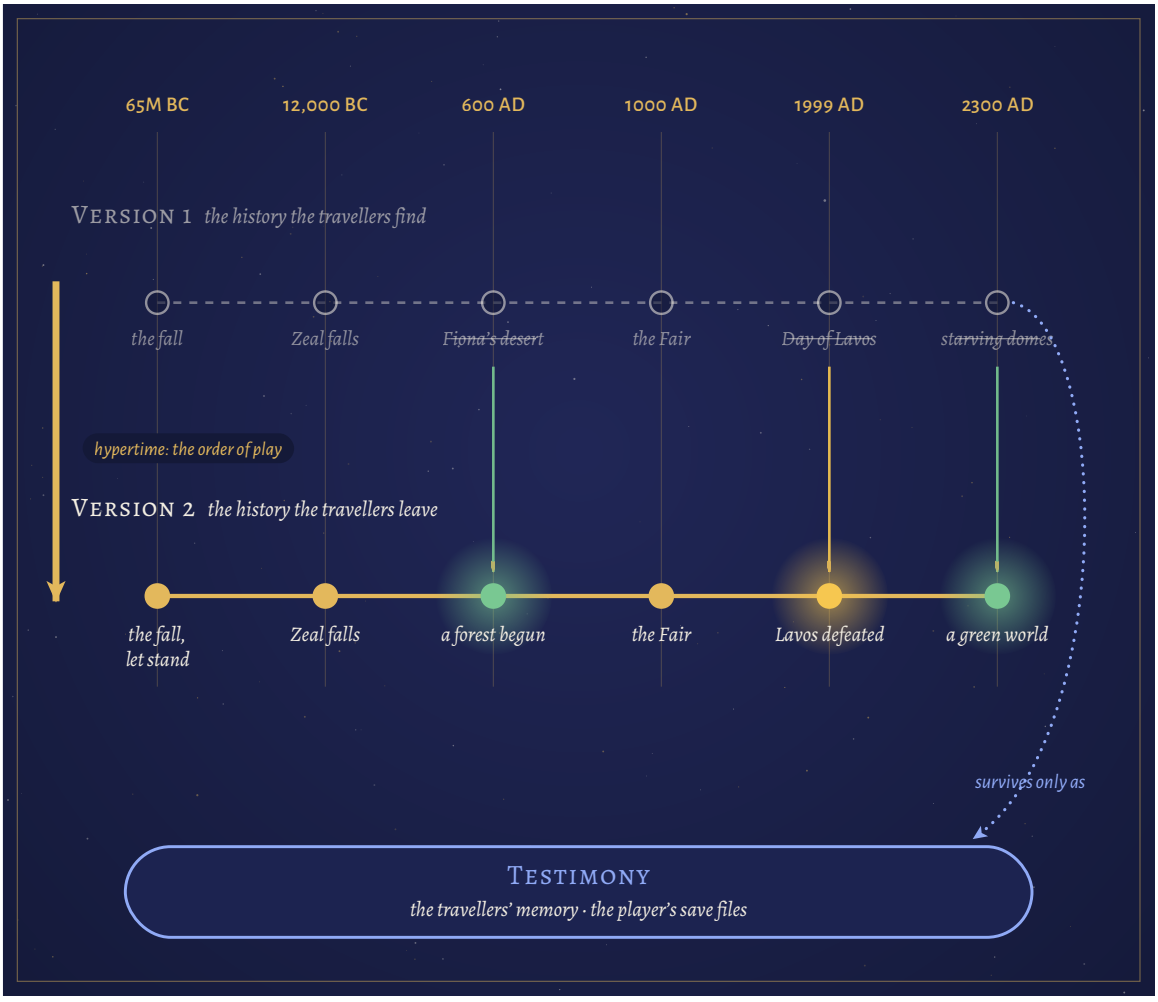


Figure 4 *Testimonial hypertime: the superseded history survives only as witness.*

4.2 The Traveller's Exemption and the Ancestor Paradox: Marle, Marty, Dana

Every fiction of a revisable past has to decide what happens to the person doing the revising. The usual answer, which I call the **traveller's exemption**, shields travellers from the consequences of their own interventions. They go on existing and remembering even after the history that produced them has been altered. *Chrono Trigger* grants the exemption almost everywhere. It enforces the alternative exactly once, at the very beginning, and that exception was part of the design from the start: Kitase has confirmed that the opening, with Marle's paradox, was worked out very early in development.

Japanese walkthroughs title the episode "The Vanished Princess" (消えた王女). Its mechanism is subtler than the classic grandfather paradox. Marle does not kill her ancestor; she is *mistaken* for her. The court of 600 AD sees a princess who looks exactly like the abducted Queen Leene and calls off the search. Without a search, Leene will not be rescued. Without Leene, there will be no Marle. So Marle, standing in the castle, fades. The descendant cancels herself by resembling her ancestor. Resemblance is the poison, and the court's error is a substitution that kills. Chapter 5 meets the same structure turned into a remedy, when a likeness is put in the place of the dying hero (§5.7).

The paradox has a pulp genealogy. In Nathan Schachner's "Ancestral Voices" (*Astounding*, 1933), a time traveller kills a Hun and thereby erases the Hun's thousands of descendants, himself among them. René Barjavel's *Le Voyageur imprudent* (1943) gave the paradox of the murdered ancestor its classic French form. The closest analogue is *Back to the Future* (1985). Marty McFly's interference keeps his parents from meeting. His siblings, and then he himself, begin to vanish from a family photograph, and at the school dance his hand turns transparent while he plays. Music at a festival restores him. Marle is restored by a rescue, and the game's own festival, the Millennial Fair, frames the episode (Chapter 8).

Octavia E. Butler's *Kindred* (1979) wrote the paradox with its moral cost included. Its first sentence is "I lost an arm on my last trip home." Dana, a Black writer in Los Angeles in 1976, is pulled again and again to antebellum Maryland to save the life of Rufus Weylin, a slaveholder's son who is her ancestor. To exist at all, she has to keep him alive long enough to father, by rape, the child of an enslaved woman from whom her line descends. Butler shows what the genealogical clause means when the ancestor is not a captive queen but a perpetrator: the descendant's existence may require complicity in the crime that produced her.

Chrono Trigger contains Butler's possibility at the scale of species. The commonwealth watches Lavos fall in 65,000,000 BC and does nothing to prevent it, because the catastrophe that destroyed the Reptites is the condition of its own existence (Chapter 2, §2.3). The *felix culpa* of the mammals is *Kindred* written at the scale of a planet.

The best-known Japanese treatment of the clause is as generous as Butler's is severe. In the first chapter of Fujiko F. Fujio's *Doraemon* (1970), Sewashi, Nobita's great-great-grandson, sends a robot back from the twenty-second century to improve his ancestor's life. When Nobita asks whether changing his future will erase Sewashi, the boy answers with the much-discussed "Osaka" analogy: one can travel from Tokyo to Osaka by many routes and still arrive in Osaka. History's route may change while its destination is conserved. *Doraemon* relaxes the clause by treating descent as a destination rather than a road.

The exemption in *Chrono Trigger* reaches further than either. It allows a traveller to coexist with his past self. In 12,000 BC the court prophet stands beside the child-prince Janus, and at the Ocean Palace the prophet throws off his cloak and is revealed as Magus, the

grown Janus. The game's first time traveller, earlier than the party, is a man who has gone back to undo his own childhood.

The exemption's limit is left undecided at the end. At the farewell, Robo's goodbye is the hardest, since his timeline has been altered and entering the Gate may mean that he effectively ceases to exist. Yet in the most common ending Robo still exists in the new timeline, and he and Atropos XR are seen overlooking a landscape made more beautiful because Lavos never destroyed it. The game will not say whether the exemption covers the machine whose awakening belongs to the history its victory abolishes. The traveller's exemption is therefore not a law of the fiction but a grace, and the work declines to say how far that grace reaches.

4.3 Non-Identity and the Ethics of Erasure

Derek Parfit's *Reasons and Persons* (1984) introduced the problem that shadows every rescue in this game. His "time-dependence claim" states that if a particular person had not been conceived when he was in fact conceived, he would never have existed. It follows that choices affecting the distant future change *who* will exist, not merely how well they will fare. Suppose a policy depletes resources. It may produce people whose lives are worse than the lives of those who would have existed under conservation. Yet the people who do exist are not worse off than they would otherwise have been, because otherwise they would not have existed at all. This is the non-identity problem.

Parfit's provisional answer, the "Same Number Quality Claim," is impersonal: if the same number of people would live in either outcome, it is worse if those who live are worse off than those who would have lived. Jan Narveson's slogan states the rival, person-affecting view: "We are in favour of making people happy, but neutral about making happy people" ("Moral Problems of Population," 1973).

Apply this to the commonwealth's central achievement. In the history the travellers find, Lavos rises from within the Earth in 1999 and destroys the planet's surface, and the survivors of 2300 live on machines that restore energy but do nothing for hunger (Chapter 2, §2.8). When the commonwealth defeats Lavos, these people are not rescued. They are replaced, by a population whose lives begin in a world that was never burned. On the person-affecting view, no one has been benefited: the starving were not fed, they were unmade. On Parfit's impersonal view, the outcome is better.

The game holds both views at once, and it does so in a single gesture. In 2300, Marle gives the dome-dwellers a seed to grow, insisting that the Enertron won't last forever. That act benefits *these* people in *their* time, even though the commonwealth's eventual victory will

erase their time. The game's ethics of erasure thus imposes a **double obligation**: to help the doomed within their own history, and to end the history that dooms them.

One of the game's endings presents the non-identity problem in reverse. In Ray Bradbury's "A Sound of Thunder" (1952), a safari travels to the Cretaceous to shoot a tyrannosaur. A client who strays from the levitating path crushes a butterfly, and the hunters return to a present in which spelling has changed and a demagogue has won the election. *Chrono Trigger* reverses the scale. If the party defeats Lavos after battling Magus but before confronting Azala, the ending shows the Millennial Fair from the start of the game, except that everyone in it is a Reptite, and it closes with a reptilian Crono running into a reptilian Marle. This is non-identity at the scale of species: a world in which the dominion the meteor handed to the mammals went to the Reptites instead, and they held their fair.

In the main plot, the dispossessed reach for the means of time itself. The Reptites seize the Gate Key, and the party is stranded in prehistory until it is recovered (§4.0). The species that history erased takes hold of the key to history. Chapter 7 (§7.5) returns to them.

The danger in erasure is not only that the erased are unmade. It is that they go unmourned. Nicolas Abraham and Maria Torok distinguished two responses to loss ("Deuil ou mélancolie: introjecter–incorporer," 1972). In *introjection*, the work of mourning, the lost object is assimilated, and the self grows by what it has lost. In *incorporation*, the melancholic refusal to mourn, the lost object is swallowed whole and kept intact in a secret vault inside the self, which they call a *crypt*. Abraham named the effect of such crypts across generations the "phantom": in his account, what haunts us is less the dead themselves than the gaps that the secrets of others leave inside us.

Incorporation is a fantasy of eating, and here the parallel with the myth of Chapter 2 is exact. Kronos swallows his children whole and keeps them undigested in his belly (§2.1). The volume that gathered these essays was titled *L'Écorce et le noyau* (1978), *The Shell and the Kernel*, and Lavos is a shell around a kernel, a husk holding captive lives (§2.8). The convergence yields a principle: **chronophagy feeds on the unmourned.** The franchise arrived at the same conclusion by its own route. Japanese commentary on the sequel's Time Devourer describes it as an entity grown nearly complete by absorbing the hatred and regret of every life that vanished from history. Chapter 6 develops the point. For now it is enough that when no one mourns the erased, they return as the devourer's food.

The game's countermeasure is testimony made public. One ending, reached by defeating Lavos after recovering the Gate Key but before repairing the Masamune, shows various NPCs across time, including the people of Ioka, Zeal, and the future. Its credits are a roll call of the anonymous. In the notes to his theses on history, Benjamin wrote that it is harder to honour the memory of the nameless than that of the famous, and that *dem Gedächtnis der Namenlosen ist die historische Konstruktion geweiht*, "historical construction is

dedicated to the memory of the nameless." The ending called "People of the Times" stages that dedication.

4.4 Forking Paths Declined: Borges, Toriyama, Leiber

Borges published the modern charter of branching time in 1941. In "El jardín de senderos que se bifurcan," the sinologist Stephen Albert explains Ts'ui Pên's labyrinthine novel. In every other fiction, a man facing alternatives chooses one and eliminates the rest; in Ts'ui Pên's, he chooses all of them, *simultáneamente*, creating diverse futures that themselves proliferate and fork: "El tiempo se bifurca perpetuamente hacia innumerables futuros" ("Time forks perpetually toward innumerable futures"). Sixteen years later Hugh Everett's relative-state interpretation of quantum mechanics (1957) gave the image a formalism. David Deutsch's analysis of closed timelike curves (1991) showed how, in such a universe, a traveller to the past would arrive in another branch and contradict nothing. Time-travel fiction of the 1990s took the fork almost by default.

The game's own character designer had just taken it. In the android saga of Akira Toriyama's *Dragon Ball* (1991–93), Trunks arrives from a future ravaged by androids in a time machine with HOPE!! painted on its side. He brings medicine that saves Goku from a fatal heart disease, and then learns that his intervention has created a different history. His own future stays ruined until he goes back and destroys the androids himself.

Fritz Leiber's *The Big Time* (1958) took another route. In its Change War, two unseen powers fight across all of history and recruit soldiers from every era, while a Law of Conservation of Reality lets history heal over most changes, as a body heals a wound. Its recuperation station, the Place, is a bubble outside the cosmos where soldiers from different centuries drink and quarrel between missions; it is the nearest literary relative of the End of Time (§4.5).

Chrono Trigger's own sequel took the fork as well. One Japanese commentator states the difference plainly: where *Trigger*'s theme is time, *Cross*'s theme is parallel worlds, which exist for every choice. There is one dimension in which you turned right at a corner and another in which you turned left, and *Cross* is the game of travelling between them.

Chrono Trigger declines the fork, and the reason is philosophical, not just economical. Under plenitude, where every branch exists, the ruined 2300 persists in its own branch whatever the commonwealth does, and the starving go on starving there. The rescue rescues no one. It only selects which branch the rescuers will live in. Lewis himself took up the objection, in *On the Plurality of Worlds* (1986), that if every possibility is realised somewhere,

the total of good and evil is fixed and choice seems to lose its point. He replied that ethical concern is properly concern for what happens in one's own world.

Chrono Trigger makes that local world the only one. There is one history, and to change it is to overwrite it. The single line is tragic, since to save is to erase (§4.3). It is also the condition of responsibility, since whatever is done is done to the only world there is. I call this choice **responsibility over plenitude**. The game prefers a metaphysics in which action is costly and final to one in which every outcome is consoled by its existence somewhere else.

The doors of this single history have a distinctive shape: they do not lead anywhere at any time. A Japanese fan essay devoted to the question of what the Gates really were notes that once Lucca applied Telepod technology to build the Gate Holder, the party became time travellers. But the Gates are not like Doraemon's time machine, which flies you to whatever time you want; they connect specific points on predetermined time axes. Even the Epoch, which does not depend on the Gates, offers eras on its dial, not dates: 1999 is one of the choices on the dial. I call this the **kairotic topology** of the Gates. They open onto charged moments, not onto a continuum, as though time had only a few places where its fabric is thin enough to pass through.

The first Gate shows what such a place is. It opens at the Millennial Fair, when Marle's pendant reacts to the space-time distortion field of Lucca's Telepods, opening a Gate through time and sending her 400 years into the past. The Gate's medieval mouth is the hill behind Truce, and Japanese guides note that this hill north of medieval Truce has, by the present, been cleared and developed into Leene Square, the fairground itself. The first Gate is a vertical shaft through the history of one place, joining the festival ground to the wild hill it once was. The square also bears the name of Queen Leene, the ancestor whose loss will erase Marle. Before anyone knows it, the festival commemorates the very life that the first passage puts at risk. The most intimate Gate of all, which opens onto a single day of Lucca's childhood, belongs to Chapter 6 (§6.3).

One last comparison clarifies what is at stake in declining the fork. In the 1964 *Doctor Who* serial "The Aztecs," Barbara is mistaken, like Marle, for a figure of the past, and uses her position to try to persuade the Aztecs to give up human sacrifice. The Doctor forbids it: "You can't rewrite history! Not one line!" *Chrono Trigger* permits the attempt. At the Ocean Palace the commonwealth tries to stop a sacrifice, the princess bound to the Mammon Machine, and fails (Chapter 3, §3.4). The single line allows rewriting but does not guarantee success. That combination of permission without guarantee is the moral texture of the whole game.

4.5 Eternity's Bureaucrats: Asimov and the End of Time

Isaac Asimov's *The End of Eternity* (1955) imagines the institution that time travel invites. Eternity is an organisation built outside time. Its staff, the Eternals, travel up and down the centuries in "kettles" and edit history through calculated Reality Changes. Computers specify each change and Technicians carry it out, and the guiding principle is the Minimum Necessary Change: the smallest intervention that will remove a war, a plague, or a disaster. Over thousands of centuries these edits produce a humanity that is safe, comfortable, and stagnant. By removing every risk, Eternity has removed the risk of spaceflight, and with it the stars. A span of Hidden Centuries is closed to the Eternals. The novel ends when the Technician Andrew Harlan and Noÿs Lambent, an agent from those centuries, allow Eternity to be undone so that humanity's open and dangerous future can begin. Asimov's critique targets administered time: an institution that manages history from outside will optimise it into immobility.

Gaspar's End of Time is the counter-institution, and the Japanese name marks the difference. The English "End of Time" is eschatological; it names an end as terminus or goal. The Japanese name, 時の最果て (*toki no saihate*, "the farthest edge of time"), is a geographical superlative, as in 最果ての地, "the remotest land." It names a horizon, not a headquarters. Japanese guides describe arriving there as entering a mysterious space no one could place, inside which a single old man explains how to travel through the Gates.

The furniture is modest to the point of comedy: a lamppost, pillars of light, and the god of battle in a side room. The Gate to the Day of Lavos sits in a bucket, and it takes the party directly to 1999 AD to fight Lavos's shell. Asimov's Eternals travel in kettles; Gaspar's apocalypse is reached through a bucket. Both are vessels, and the difference between them restates the distinction drawn in Chapter 3 (§3.3). The kettle is a vessel of administration. The bucket is Laozi's empty vessel, useful because it is empty.

Three features make the End of Time the opposite of Eternity.

Its keeper is a refugee. Zeal's catastrophe flung the three Gurus across history: Melchior to AD 1000, Belthasar to AD 2300, and Gaspar to the End of Time. The commonwealth's base is a refugee's waystation, made by the same catastrophe that opened the Gates.

It administers nothing. Gaspar gives advice. He keeps no files, runs no calculations, and makes no changes. The changes are made by travellers in bodies, who enter history and act inside it as participants, at their own risk.

It limits traffic. Japanese guides state the rule: because entering a Gate with four or more people is dangerous, the party must be reduced to three here. A Gate admits a small

company, never a crowd, so time travel can never become an industry. Chapter 7 reads this rule of three as the procedural basis of the commonwealth.

The decisive contrast comes at the end. After Lavos falls, the Gates close permanently, leaving the Epoch as the only known means of time travel in existence, and Lucca suggests that the group dismantle it. This is the anti-Eternity gesture: the inventor who stabilised the first Gate proposes giving up the last instrument. Asimov's novel reaches the same renunciation from the opposite side, by dissolving an institution that the game never founds.

The game then complicates its own renunciation with a joke. In certain endings, Crono's mother chases his cat through Leene Square and jumps through the Gate just as it closes, and Crono, Marle, and Lucca set off at once in the Epoch to chase her through time. The instrument survives because a mother follows a cat at a festival. Chapter 8 reads this comedy as the festal answer to Asimov's question.

The sequel answers differently. In the fan chronologies, Robo returns to his era, meets Belthasar, and helps found Chronopolis, offering himself as the "Prometheus Circuit" in the construction of the supercomputer FATE, the same machine by which the Prometheus Circuit was later terminated. Chronopolis becomes the Eternity that Lucca's proposal tried to prevent. Chapter 7 (§7.8) examines what happens when a commonwealth institutionalises itself.

4.6 Kuki Shūzō's Modal Time: Making the Necessary Contingent

The Gates break the oldest axiom of Greek practical philosophy. Aristotle writes that nothing past is an object of choice. No one deliberates about what has happened, only about what lies in the future and can be otherwise, and he quotes Agathon, as in this chapter's first epigraph: this alone is denied even to God, to make undone what has been done (*Nicomachean Ethics* VI.2, 1139b5–11).

Logic turned the axiom into a premise. The Master Argument of Diodorus, as Epictetus reports it (*Discourses* II.19), begins from the claim that every true proposition about the past is necessary. The logician who made the necessity of the past the first premise of Hellenistic modal logic was known by the nickname Cronus. Christian theology inherited the problem as a question about omnipotence. Jerome wrote to Eustochium that although God can do all things, he cannot restore a virgin after her fall (*Ep.* 22.5). Peter Damian's *De divina omnipotentia* (c. 1065) defended the power of a God for whom, in eternity, the past is still present. Aquinas fixed the scholastic answer: for the past not to have been implies a contradiction,

so it lies outside even divine power (*Summa theologiae* I, q. 25, a. 4, citing Augustine, *Contra Faustum* 26.5).

Against this tradition, the Gates create what I call a **bouleutic past**, from βουλεύω, "to deliberate": a past that has become something one deliberates about. The party gathers at the End of Time and decides which era to enter and what to undo. Diodorus's first premise is refuted procedurally, by a game whose English hero, through the five-character limit discussed in Chapter 1 (§1.3), carries almost the logician's nickname.

Kuki Shūzō (1888–1941) supplies the modal theory that a bouleutic past requires. His *Gūzensei no mondai* (*The Problem of Contingency*, 1935) opens with a definition, "偶然性とは必然性の否定である" ("contingency is the negation of necessity"). It divides contingency into categorical, hypothetical, and disjunctive forms, and finds a primal contingency at the source of every chance encounter. The book was written in a particular climate. As the totalitarian belief that the individual's fate is subordinate to the necessity of the state gathered force, Kuki defended the freedom of contingency: that the world might have been otherwise, and that I might not have been myself. In his conclusion Kuki assigns the modalities to the tenses. Necessity belongs to the past, what has already been and cannot be otherwise. Possibility belongs to the future, what is not yet. Contingency belongs to the present, the instant of encounter.

Read with Kuki, the Gate's deepest operation is modal. A Gate moves the traveller into a past that is, for her, the present, and so it confers on that past the modality of the present, which is contingency. What was necessary because it had already been becomes contingent because it is now being met. That is how the Day of Lavos, fixed in the archive of 2300 as the necessity of history, becomes something that might not happen. The Gate does not abolish necessity by magic. It changes the tense in which a past is met, and the modality follows the tense.

For Kuki, hypothetical contingency is the encounter of independent causal series, and the game opens on one. In the Japanese account, Marle, having bumped into Crono by chance on his way to see the Telepod, volunteers to be its test subject. Kuki's own illustration explains why the game cannot leave this encounter alone: if two people meet by chance at a hospital, the meeting seems contingent, but if both turn out to have come to visit a third person, it was not contingent in the strict sense.

The game raises exactly this suspicion about its own beginning. The pendant conveniently stays with specific people and causes specific Gates to open at specific times, and Crono's party comes to believe that someone, perhaps the planet itself, wanted history to change. If so, Crono and Marle were both visiting a third party, and the collision was a summons. The game never settles the question. It keeps the encounter suspended between contingency and visitation.

What the game does instead is repeat the encounter. In the Reptite ending, a reptilian Crono runs into a reptilian Marle (§4.3). In another alternative ending, Robo, in a future version of Leene Square, runs into Atropos just as Crono encountered Marle at the beginning of the game. The collision recurs across species and machines. It is the work's primal scene and, in Kuki's terms, its primal contingency: the encounter of two independent beings, from which Kuki derives both contingency and individuality.

Kuki's ethics turns contingency into destiny. His book concludes in the power to reverse what happened "by chance" into an irreplaceable "fate". Its closing pages draw on a verse from Vasubandhu's *Treatise on the Pure Land*, 遇無空過者 ("none who meet it pass by in vain"), and turn it into an imperative: 遇うて空しく過ぐる勿れ, "Having met, do not pass by in vain."

That imperative is the commonwealth's. The Gates are encounters with eras, and the sub-scenarios that Chapter 6 reads as restoration are refusals to pass through an era in vain: the desert of 600 AD, the accident in Lucca's childhood, the knight's unabsolved grief. The bouleutic past is not a licence to edit history at will. It is an obligation not to waste a meeting.

4.7 The Ten Mysterious Gates: Huayan Interpenetration and Dōgen's Firewood

The Huayan school of Chinese Buddhism systematised its metaphysics of interpenetration as the 十玄門, the "ten mysterious gates." In this usage the word for gate has a precise sense: 玄 means "profound," and 門 means that which gives passage. A classical dictionary adds that whoever penetrates this meaning can enter the profound sea of the great Huayan sutra, which is why they are called mysterious gates.

One of these gates concerns time. It is ninth in Fazang's newer list and fifth in Zhiyan's older one, and its name is 十世隔法異成門, "the gate of the separate dharmas of the ten ages, variously completed." The standard explanation runs as follows. Each of the three times, past, present, and future, itself contains a past, present, and future, which makes nine ages. The nine interpenetrate and so form one total age, and the total together with the particulars makes ten. These ten separated dharmas appear complete all at once, which is why the gate is called "separate dharmas variously completed": different things are accomplished at the same time. The commentators quote the sutra: know that immeasurable kalpas are one thought, and that one thought is immeasurable kalpas.

Fazang's *Treatise on the Golden Lion*, composed to explain the doctrine to Empress Wu, puts it in terms of a single object. The lion, as a conditioned thing, arises and perishes from

instant to instant. In a single instant this divides into three periods, each with its own past, present, and future, giving nine ages bound into one gate. Though there are nine, each remains separate, each establishes the others, and all interpenetrate without obstruction as one thought. A modern reference work states the corollary that matters most for a time-travel game: the ages interpenetrate without losing the distinctions of before and after, long and short. Another gives the doctrine at its most compressed: a single instant can contain all of time.

Chrono Trigger's eras have exactly this structure. They are separate (隔法): each has its own costume, music, and politics, and none dissolves into another. Yet each is completed through the others (異成):

- Prehistory's Dreamstone becomes the sword forged in Zeal and re-forged in 1000 AD.
- The festival of 1000 AD commemorates the queen of 600.
- The forest of 1000 is planted in 600.
- The world of 2300 hangs on a single day in 1999.

The End of Time occupies the place of the total age, the one thought in which separate ages are present together without merging. In Huayan terms it is the tenth age. Augustine's three presents (§4.1) are a soul's way of holding the times together; Fazang's nine ages in one thought are a world's. Huayan's seventh gate, Indra's net, in which each jewel reflects all the others, belongs to Chapter 7, where it describes the commonwealth.

Dōgen (1200–1253), who studied in Song China, where Huayan thought had permeated Chan, wrote the most radical Japanese text on time. "Uji" (有時, "being-time," 1240) takes an ordinary phrase, *aru toki*, "at a certain time," and reads it as a metaphysical identity: being-time means that time is already being, and all being is time. Its central doctrine is 経歴 (*kyōryaku*), "passage," and Dōgen insists that passage runs in more than one direction. Being-time has the virtue of passage: it passes from today to tomorrow, from today to yesterday, from yesterday to today, from today to today, and from tomorrow to tomorrow. Passage, he adds, is not to be understood as wind and rain moving east and west. The whole world is neither unmoving nor without advance and retreat; it is passage, and passage is like spring, which has many aspects. Japanese scholarship has read this fascicle against McTaggart, and one such study observes that the passage shows kyōryaku to be not one-directional but a set of relations running in many directions among yesterday, today, and the present. "From today to yesterday" is a Gate written in thirteenth-century prose.

The *Genjōkōan* (1233) supplies Dōgen's most famous image of time, and it is an image of fire:

> たき木はひとなる、さらにかへりてたき木となるべきにあらず。しかあるを、灰はのち、薪はさきと見取すべからず。しるべし、薪は薪の法位に住して、さきありのちあり。前後ありといへども、前後際断せり。
>
> "Firewood becomes ash; it does not become firewood again. Yet one should not see ash as after and firewood as before. Know that firewood abides in the dharma-position of firewood, which has its before and its after; though it has before and after, it is cut off from before and after."

Life and death, Dōgen continues, are likewise each "a position of one time," as winter and spring are; we do not say that winter becomes spring.

This is an **anti-pyric ontology**, an account of being that denies fire the last word. Burning is the model case of an irreversible process, the conversion of stored order into heat that Chapter 2 traced from Heraclitus to Clausius. Dōgen does not deny that conversion: ash does not become firewood again. What he denies is that the burning annuls the firewood. The firewood abides in its position, cut off from what came after and untouched by the ash. In such a world chronophagy is metaphysically impossible. The big fire can turn the present to ash, but it cannot reach back and consume what abides in its position. Lavos's claim to have eaten the planet's past (§2.7) is not a law of time but a usurpation of it.

The Gates are passages to such abiding positions. In Chapter 5 the Time Egg will be the passage to one position in particular, the moment before the hero's death. It will not make death become life, which Dōgen denies. It will re-enter the position of life, which was never annulled.

4.8 The Pharmakon of the Gate: Where Danger Is

Who made the Gates? The game does not say, and its readers disagree. A Japanese fan essay devoted to the question of what the Gates really were is titled, provocatively, "Was It Not Lavos Who Made Them?" The Chrono Compendium's chronology hedges in its very syntax. At Zeal's fall, Lavos ("or more likely, the Entity") creates gates that send Belthasar to 2300 A.D., Melchior to 1000 A.D., Gaspar to the End of Time, and Janus to 600 A.D. The party itself comes to suspect someone, perhaps the planet, who wanted history to change (§4.6). The Gates are either wounds torn in time by the time-eater or doors opened by the world's own will to heal.

The undecidability is the point. Plato's *Phaedrus* (274e–275b) tells how the god Theuth offered writing to King Thamus as a φάρμακον μνήμης, a drug for memory, and how the king replied that it was a drug only for reminding and would breed forgetfulness. Derrida's

"La pharmacie de Platon" (1968; collected in *La Dissémination*, 1972) showed that *pharmakon* means both remedy and poison, and that the text cannot settle which.

The Gate is a pharmakon of history in the same sense that writing is a pharmakon of memory. It serves extraction: the queen's immortality was bestowed by the Mammon Machine and its connection to the Gates. It also serves rescue. Derrida noticed that the word has a human twin, the *pharmakos*, the scapegoat driven out of the city to purify it. Chapter 5 meets the pharmakos in the hero who steps in front of the beam to save his friends.

Greek myth has a precise figure for a cure that comes from the cause of a wound. Telephus, wounded by Achilles' spear, received an oracle that only the one who wounded him would heal him (ὁ τρώσας ἰάσεται), and he was healed by rust scraped from the same spear. Wagner gave the principle to Parsifal in the opera's final scene: "Die Wunde schließt / der Speer nur, der sie schlug" ("The wound is closed / only by the spear that struck it"). The first Gate of *Chrono Trigger* was opened by Zeal's own technology, the princess's pendant reacting to a Telepod (§4.4). The commonwealth heals with rust from the spear.

The double text now gives its result. A wound in time can be treated in three ways, and the game names all three:

- **Extraction** treats the wound as a resource. Zeal drilled into it. The Black Dream lodged inside it and was present in every era until defeated (Chapter 3, §3.7), a parasite in the wound.
- **Access** treats the wound as a door. The English Gate Key belongs here: the traveller is someone who opens.
- **Custody** treats the wound as something to be held, stabilised, and crossed without being widened. The Japanese Gate Holder belongs here: an instrument that takes effect merely by being carried.

The Conclusion argues that custody is the ethics the whole work teaches, and that the Japanese text named it in an item description before anyone theorised it.

Heidegger's Bremen lectures of 1949 (Chapter 3, §3.3) end with "Die Kehre," the Turning. The essence of technology, Enframing (*Gestell*), is the danger, and Heidegger insists that the danger should be entered, not fled, because the turning may come within it, suddenly (*jäh*). There, and in "Die Frage nach der Technik" (1953), he takes his motto from Hölderlin: "Wo aber Gefahr ist, wächst / Das Rettende auch." The same lecture glosses the title of the series, *Einblick in das was ist* ("Insight into That Which Is"), as *Einblitz*, the lightning-flash in which the truth of Being strikes into a being that has forgotten it. The Heraclitus seminar Heidegger held with Eugen Fink in 1966–67 opens on fragment B64: τὰ δὲ πάντα οἰακίζει κεραυνός,

"Lightning steers all things." The Gates are where the danger is, the scar left by the time-eater, and it is there that the saving power grows.

Two closing images point forward. The Romans kept the doors of the temple of Janus open in war and closed in peace, and Augustus boasted that under his rule the Senate ordered them closed three times (*Res Gestae* 13). When Lavos falls the Gates close, and with the Gates closing for good, the companions will likely never see each other again: the doors of Janus are shut for peace. But the prince who bore Janus's name in the English text does not stop. At the farewell, Magus says that he will continue to travel through time, looking for his sister. The god of doors keeps walking through doors after peace has shut them, because one restoration remains undone (Chapter 6, §6.7).

The other image is the lightning. In the Japanese text the hero's magical element is 天, "heaven," and his spells are thunder. Chapter 5 asks what it means that the one who steers the commonwealth is lightning, and what happens when that lightning is put out.

Table 4.1 *Six models of the alterable past*

MODEL	EXEMPLARS	CAN THE PAST CHANGE?	FATE OF THE SUPERSEDED HISTORY	WHO REMEMBERS IT	ETHICAL REGISTER
Self-consistent loop	Lewis; Novikov; *La Jetée* (1962); *The Terminator* (1984); *12 Monkeys* (1995)	No; it can only be affected	none: there was only ever one history	no one needs to	resignation
Branching plenitude	Borges (1941); Everett; Deutsch; *Dragon Ball* (1991–93); *Chrono Cross* (1999)	Yes, by forking	persists in its own branch	its own inhabitants	consolation without rescue
Administered revision	Asimov, *The End of Eternity* (1955)	Yes, by office	erased and filed	the Eternals	technocratic minimisation
Conserved reality	Leiber, *The Big Time* (1958)	Partly; history heals over	reabsorbed	the conscripts	attrition
Revision with amnesia	Tsutsui, *Toki o kakeru shōjo* (1965–67)	Yes	erased along with the witness's memory	no one; a scent remains	elegy
Overwrite with testimony	*Chrono Trigger* (1995)	Yes, by passage through the Gates	erased	the travellers; the player	responsibility, mourning, custody

The table shows the chapter's result. Of the six models, only *Chrono Trigger*'s combines a real change of the past with a surviving witness to what the change abolished. Its hypertime is testimonial, its history single, its doors kairotic, its past bouleutic, and its metaphysics anti-pyric. Each of these properties presses toward the same ethics: a world in which the past can be rewritten must be held in custody by those who remember what the rewriting cost.

The Gates can carry the commonwealth into any era on their map. They cannot carry it into the instant of a death. A Gate is a passage to a time; an egg is a passage to a moment. When Lavos annihilates the hero at the Ocean Palace, the party turns to the Sage of Time,

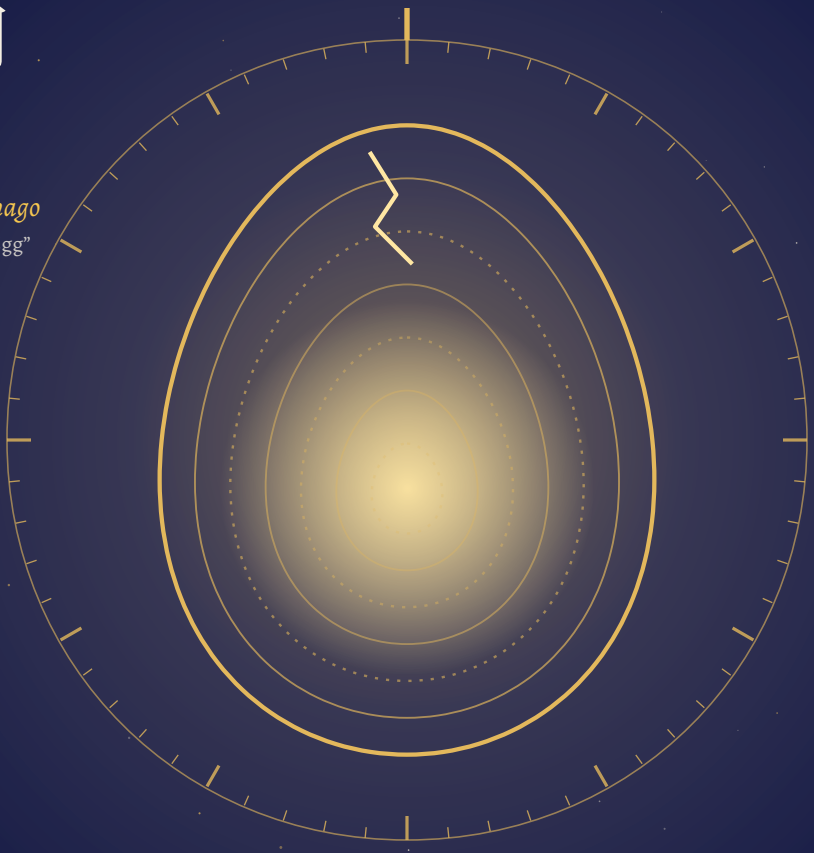
who gives them a device that lets the group replace Crono just before the moment of death with an identical doppelgänger. Chapter 5 asks what kind of time is stored in that egg, why its instant has to be seized and not merely visited, and what it means that the boy named Time must die before the commonwealth can be complete.



時の卵

toki no tamago

"the Time Egg"



Chapter Five

5

The Time Egg

Kairos, Death, and the Frozen Instant

> And he will destroy in this mountain the face of the covering cast over all people, and the vail that is spread over all nations. He will swallow up death in victory; and the Lord GOD will wipe away tears from off all faces.
>
> — Isaiah 25:7–8 (KJV)

> ἐν ἀτόμῳ, ἐν ῥιπῇ ὀφθαλμοῦ … οἱ νεκροὶ ἐγερθήσονται ἄφθαρτοι, καὶ ἡμεῖς ἀλλαγησόμεθα.
>
> "In an uncuttable instant, in the twinkling of an eye … the dead shall be raised incorruptible, and we shall be changed."
>
> — 1 Corinthians 15:52

> *Das Eingedenken kann das Unabgeschlossene (das Glück) zu einem Abgeschlossenen und das Abgeschlossene (das Leid) zu einem Unabgeschlossenen machen.*
>
> "Remembrance can make the incomplete (happiness) complete, and the complete (suffering) incomplete."
>
> — Walter Benjamin, *Passagen-Werk*, N 8,1

Chapter 4 ended on a distinction. A Gate opens onto a time; an egg opens onto a moment. The Gates can carry the commonwealth to any era on their map, but only to the few charged points that their topology allows (Chapter 4, §4.4), and none of those points is the instant of a death. This chapter goes into that instant. One secondary account holds that the game's well-received twist was conceived by Horii and that the game was originally created for that twist (Introduction, §III). If so, the event examined here is the work's genetic centre: the hero who carries the name of time is annihilated, and he returns through an egg.

The argument is that the Time Egg sequence sets out a fifth model of redemption. The work stages or rejects four others:

1. **Stoic recurrence**: everything returns identically after the conflagration (Chapter 2, §2.5).
2. **Linear eschatology**: everything is restored at the end of time.
3. **Hypertemporal revision**: a time is rewritten through the Gates (Chapter 4).
4. **Immortality**: Zeal's "bad infinite," a single life prolonged without end (Chapter 3, §3.6).

I call the fifth model *kairotic apokatastasis*, restoration within a seized instant. The chapter closes by defining it through five marks: it is singular, heteronomous, substitutive without sacrifice, gathered, and finite. In the layered reading of authorship proposed in the Prefatory Note, this sequence belongs to the main scenario, the layer of catastrophe and of the decisive instant. Chapter 6 turns to the sub-scenarios, which supply the duration that an instant cannot.

Erratum and refinement (Chapter 1, §1.3; Table 1.1). Chapter 1 contrasted an English "Chrono Trigger" with a Japanese "Time Egg," as if the two languages had split the object's names between them. That needs correcting, because neither text does this. Japanese players report that the Sage of Time hands over クロノ・トリガーという時の卵, "a Time Egg called Chrono Trigger," and Japanese commentaries name the item 時の卵（クロノ・トリガー）. In the English text, Gaspar will offer you a Time Egg, or a Chrono Trigger, and English walkthroughs head the chapter "The Time Egg". The antinomy of §1.3 stands, but it sits in a different place: it runs through each text, not between them. Both languages name an egg after a firing lever, so the contradiction belongs to the object itself.

The difference between the two texts lies in the verb and in the criterion. Japanese accounts have the Sage of Time send the party to the Sage of Reason to learn 卵をかえす方法, "the way to hatch the egg." An English walkthrough has him send the party to the Epoch's maker to learn how to use the egg. The Japanese Sage of Reason explains that Death Peak can restore the dead only if the person is truly dear and needed, someone the living cannot do without, and that a doll exactly like the person is required. He concludes: ならば、卵はかえるじゃろう, "then the egg will hatch." The verb is 孵る (*kaeru*), the fifth member of the homophone cluster read in Chapter 1 (§1.6). Its sound-alikes, meaning to return, to come back to life, to change, and to substitute, together describe the whole operation that follows. The English Belthasar gives a different condition: the deceased must be important to the space-time continuum. Table 1.1 should therefore gain this row:

JAPANESE	GLOSS	ENGLISH	GLOSS	WHAT THE PAIRING SHOWS
卵をかえす; 大切で必要	hatch the egg; the dead must be "dear and needed"	use the egg; "important to the space-time continuum"	instrument; cosmic function	a verb of hatching and a criterion of love vs. a verb of use and a criterion of cosmic function

Both criteria hold true of the hero, and the gap between them anticipates the chapter's conclusion. The Japanese text makes resurrection depend on love. Gabriel Marcel gave a character in his play *La Mort de demain* (1931) a line stating the same condition: "Aimer un être, c'est lui dire: toi, tu ne mourras pas" ("To love a being is to say: you, you will not die"). The English text makes resurrection depend on the world's need. The egg hatches where the two meet, in the one person the world requires and the friends cannot spare.

5.1 The Death of Chrono

The event takes a few seconds of screen time. At the Ocean Palace, with the Mammon Machine out of control and Lavos risen, Crono steps in front of the beam to save his friends. A Japanese player's diary records that Lavos's attack, 天からふりそそぐものが世界をほろぼす ("what pours from heaven destroys the world"), killed the party instantly, after which the prophet appeared, took off his cloak, and was revealed to be Magus. Five features of the scene carry this chapter.

(a) Heaven against heaven. At the End of Time, Spekkio teaches four elements: heaven (天), the underworld (冥), fire, and water. Crono's element is the first. His spells are heaven-element thunder, and a Japanese reference describes heaven as 攻撃と復活の万能タイプ, a type equally suited to attack and revival, able to use healing magic such as Raise to revive the dying. The attack that kills him is named as a weapon of his own element: what pours *from heaven* destroys the bearer of heaven. Because his element includes revival (the English text calls his reviving technique Life), the one who raises others cannot raise himself. The mockery at Golgotha states the structure exactly: "He saved others; himself he cannot save" (Matthew 27:42). Chapter 4 ended with Heraclitus's fragment "lightning steers all things" (B64), and the fragment now takes its darkest sense. The commonwealth's steersman is lightning, and the lightning has gone out. Section 5.4 shows that his return is staged as light coming back to a darkened sun.

(b) Recognition with reversal. Aristotle judged the finest recognition to be the one that "occurs together with a reversal, as in the *Oedipus*" (*Poetics* 11, 1452a32–33). The Ocean Palace is a complex plot in exactly this sense. The reversal is that the attempt to stop the Machine destroys both the hero and the kingdom. It coincides with the recognition that the prophet

is Magus, and that Magus is Janus grown up. The object of this recognition is time. Oedipus learns that he is the man he has been hunting. The party learns that one man is standing twice in the same room: the child beside his sister, and the adult facing the god (Chapter 4, §4.2). Aristotle's anagnorisis becomes a recognition of time.

(c) The height of chronophagy. In Japanese the boy's name means Time. In English the five-character limit turns it into the name of the god who swallows his children (Chapter 1, §1.3; Chapter 2, §2.1). Either way, the devourer of stored time consumes the person named for it. Kronos's crime, eating his successor so that there will be no succession, reaches its human height here. Chapter 2 drew the remedy from Hesiod: the devourer is beaten by a likeness wrapped in swaddling clothes and put in the child's place. This chapter shows that the game follows the myth to its end.

(d) From my death to the death of the other. In role-playing games, the protagonist's death normally ends play. Here it does not. The game goes on, the survivors take the lead, and the player, who has played as Crono for most of the game, now finds himself among the bereaved. Heidegger made the "mineness" of death the key to authentic existence: "No one can take the Other's dying away from him" (*Sein und Zeit*, §47). Levinas replied, in the lectures published as *Dieu, la mort et le temps* (1993), that the death which first concerns me is the death of the other, and that it concerns me as responsibility. The game turns the move from Heidegger to Levinas into a rule of play. A death that genre convention would treat as "my death," the game over, becomes the other's death, which calls for a response.

The aftermath is staged to match. When the survivors come to, they are lying in 残された人々のテント, "the tent of the people who were left," among the remnant (§5.8). In one scene after Crono's death, the elder of the Earthbound village found the pendant at Marle's side, lying there like a guardian.

(e) The pharmakos who chooses. Derrida's reading of the *pharmakon* (Chapter 4, §4.8) found its human twin in the *pharmakos*, the scapegoat driven out of Athens at the Thargelia, a festival of first fruits. Crono is a pharmakos with one decisive difference: no crowd drives him out. René Girard's mechanism (*La Violence et le sacré*, 1972), in which a community unloads its violence onto a victim, does not apply, because this victim offers himself. Even so, the game refuses to let the self-sacrifice stand as the meaning of his life. The resurrection is optional: the endings most players see depend on whether or not they completed the quest to rescue Crono. Yet in the ending reached without him, Marle learns that the time egg can return Crono, and she goes after him by Gate or Epoch. If Lavos is defeated without the resurrection, Marle realizes there must be a way to prevent Crono's death, and the group dives into the Gate again to save him. The work will not approve a sacrificial death even when the player does.

5.2 The Silent Protagonist as Kenotic Subject

Crono is never shown speaking and communicates through facial expressions. He speaks once, outside the story proper, in a parody ending in which Lucca and Marle host a "slide show" about the game's men. A fan listing calls it the only time in the game where Crono speaks up. The convention comes from Horii's *Dragon Quest*, whose wordless hero serves as a vessel for the player. *Chrono Trigger* turns that convention into an argument in four steps.

First, the hero named Time is silent. "What, then, is time? If no one asks me, I know; if I wish to explain it to one who asks, I do not know" (Augustine, *Confessions* XI.14.17). The protagonist embodies Augustine's puzzle: time is what everyone lives in and no one can put into words.

Second, the silence is a kenosis, a self-emptying. Paul's hymn says that Christ "emptied himself" (ἑαυτὸν ἐκένωσεν) and took the form of a servant (Philippians 2:7). The silent protagonist empties himself so that someone else can enter. He is the vessel of *Daodejing* 11, useful because of the empty space inside it (Chapter 3, §3.3), and what he holds is the player. Kleist's essay "Über das Marionettentheater" (1810) supplies the aesthetic. Grace, the essay's interlocutor argues, appears most purely in a body that has either no consciousness or an infinite one, "in the puppet or in the god" (*in dem Gliedermann, oder in dem Gott*). Crono stands exactly between the two. He is a figure moved by the player's hand, and he bears the element of heaven, which raises the fallen. His death snatches the puppet out of the player's hand. On Death Peak a literal puppet will take his place so that the person can come back (§5.7).

Third, and most important, the self-emptying is built into the game's structure. Once the silent centre is removed, the companions speak. Marle, Lucca, Frog, Robo, Ayla, and soon Magus carry the plot, and the commonwealth finds that it can act without its centre. Chapter 7 depends on this discovery when it argues that the commonwealth forms itself in the hero's absence. The companions shape even his return: The cut scene where Crono comes back to life varies based on which members you bring to Death Peak.

Fourth, the silence links Crono to the returned dead of other traditions. When Heracles brings Alcestis back from Death, she cannot speak. Her husband may not hear her voice until she has been purified of her consecration to the gods below and the third day has come (Euripides, *Alcestis* 1143–1146). In the medieval Japanese sung tale of Oguri Hangan, the hero comes back from the court of Enma, king of the underworld, blind, deaf, and mute (§5.8). The dead return without speech. Crono is silent before he dies. He is a revenant before his death, carrying death's silence from the first scene.

5.3 Death Peak and the Mountain Otherworld

The instructions for the rescue come from the dead. Belthasar, in Nu form, tells the party that Death Peak has the power to restore life. He speaks from the dome where the party first obtained the Epoch. The mountain stands just north of that dome. Fan reference works suggest that it may have been formed by the upward flows of magma that came with Lavos's eruption, along with Lavos's own shell. One Japanese commentator, pointing to the Lavos spawn that live there in numbers, the Sage of Reason's "watching" of the mountain, and the need for the mountain's power to activate the egg, concludes that all of these imply Death Peak is Lavos. A prerelease version of the script, preserved by the Chrono Compendium, has the old man explain the site: use the egg at the place where the space-time distortion caused by Lavos is strongest, the summit of Death Peak. He adds a warning: チャンスは一度きりだよ, "the chance comes only once."

So resurrection happens where the wound is deepest. This is the Telephus principle of Chapter 4 (§4.8): the spear that wounds is the spear that heals. The Time Egg hatches on the time-eater's scar, among its brood.

Two otherworlds. Japanese folklore places the realm of the dead in two directions: across or beneath the sea (*kaijō takai*), and in the mountains (*sanchū takai*). Crono dies in the first and comes back from the second.

The sea-otherworld is the Ocean Palace. Its Japanese name, "temple on the sea floor" (Chapter 3, §3.7), places it in the line of Ryūgū-jō, the Dragon Palace. The oldest versions of the Urashima legend set the rules of that realm. In the *Nihon shoki* (Yūryaku 22, equivalent to 478 CE), Mizunoe no Urashimako catches a turtle that becomes a woman, and the two go to Hōraisan, the Penglai of the immortals (Chapter 3, §3.6). In Takahashi no Mushimaro's long poem (*Man'yōshū* 9.1740), the fisherman comes back from the eternal land (*tokoyo*) to find his village gone. He opens the jewelled box he was told to keep shut, a white cloud rises toward *tokoyo*, his skin wrinkles, his hair turns white, and he dies. The box had held his time, and opening it released centuries at once. Urashima's box is the pyric (burning) counterpart of the Time Egg: a vessel of stored time that kills by releasing everything in an instant. The egg releases its stored time as a return.

The mountain-otherworld is older and more widespread. Yanagita Kunio's *Senzo no hanashi* (*About Our Ancestors*, 1946) argued that in Japanese folk belief the souls of the dead climb the mountains near the village, are purified over time into ancestral spirits, and come down again at New Year and at Bon. Volcanic mountains are thresholds in particular. At Osorezan, a sulphurous caldera on the Shimokita peninsula, blind mediums (*itako*) call the

dead to speak during the summer festival. The Tateyama hell tales of the *Konjaku monogatari-shū* (vol. 14) place the suffering dead in the volcanic valleys of Etchū. Death Peak, raised by Lavos's magma, belongs to this landscape of volcanic peaks where the dead can be reached. In the mountain asceticism of Shugendō, the climb itself is a death and rebirth. The three mountains of Dewa Sanzan are read as the three times: Haguro as the present, Gassan as the past and the land of the dead, Yudono as the future and rebirth. A pilgrimage across them is a journey of rebirth through all three tenses. The ascent of Death Peak is a rite of the same kind, crossing times. A party drawn from five eras climbs a mountain of 2300 AD in order to enter an instant of 12,000 BC.

The ascent. The climb is impossible without help from the dead. A Japanese commentator notes that even before his death, the Sage of Reason had programmed, as his own final mission, support for sending Marle and the others to Death Peak. Three small figures fly out of the Nu and head for the mountain; the English text calls them Poyozo Dolls. On the slopes, where gusts throw climbers back down, Japanese guides describe how these doubles turn into trees: 入ってすぐの分身を調べると木に変身します ("examine the double at the entrance and it turns into a tree"). The climbers shelter behind them. The dead sage's doubles become a grove, so that lignous time (time stored in wood) shelters the ascent (Chapter 6).

Higher up, the third Lavos spawn, once beaten, leaves its empty shell behind, and the last double gives a hint: 「抜け殻を押せば…、抜け殻を登れば…」 ("if you push the empty shell…, if you climb the empty shell…"). The party pushes the shell against the wall and climbs up the shell and the wall. The *kelippah* of Chapter 2 (§2.8), the Kabbalistic husk that lived on captured sparks of light, becomes a step toward resurrection once it is emptied. The Japanese word is 抜け殻 (*nukegara*), a cast-off shell, used for a cicada's moult and, figuratively, for a person emptied of spirit. Its poetic relative *utsusemi* has the same history as *ukiyo* (Chapter 3, §3.5). An old word for a living person in this world came to be written 空蝉, "empty cicada shell," and to name the emptiness of worldly life. The party climbs to life on the moulted shell of the time-eater's brood.

Once the doubles have been sent, the Sage of Reason asks the party to let the Nu sleep. In Chapter 1 (§1.6a), an accidental mapping of the Magi's gifts made Belthasar the myrrh: the preserved dead, whose mind survives in an archive. His last act is to hand his remaining data to the living and ask to be laid to rest.

The mountain's chests add two emblems. Japanese guides list among them 冥王の鎌 ("the scythe of the King of the Underworld") and 忘れずの帽子 ("the cap of not-forgetting"). In English the scythe becomes the StarScythe, found in a Death Peak chest. On the mountain where a death is undone, the reaper's scythe, which recalls Kronos's sickle and Father Time's blade (Chapter 2, §2.1), lies in a chest waiting for Magus, who fights with a scythe.

Beside it lies a cap against forgetting, the emblem of what Chapter 4 (§4.1) called testimonial hypertime: only those who remember what was undone can bear witness to it.

Comparative mountains. Three mountains from the Western traditions frame the summit.

- *Moriah.* On the mountain, Abraham "took the ram, and offered him up for a burnt offering in the stead of his son," and named the place "In the mount of the LORD it shall be seen" (Genesis 22:13–14). Substitution takes place on a mountain (§5.7).
- *Isaiah's mountain.* "In this mountain shall the LORD of hosts make unto all people a feast … And he will destroy in this mountain the face of the covering cast over all people … He will swallow up death in victory; and the Lord GOD will wipe away tears from off all faces" (Isaiah 25:6–8). A mountain, a feast, a veil drawn back, death swallowed, tears wiped away: the prophecy reads like an account of Death Peak, where the doll comes from a festival, an eclipse passes, and Marle weeps.
- *Purgatory.* Dante's mountain ends in the Earthly Paradise, where the pilgrim drinks from Lethe and Eunoë, the rivers of forgetting and of good memory, a precedent for the cap of not-forgetting. There a bare tree "renewed itself" (*s'innovò la pianta*, *Purg.* XXXII. 59), and the *Purgatorio* ends with the pilgrim "remade, as new plants are renewed with new foliage, pure and ready to rise to the stars" (XXXIII.143–145). After the eclipse on Death Peak, rainbow-colored lights gloss the frost-tipped tree atop the summit.

A last observation from the comparison of texts. The building where the ascent begins is the "Keeper's Dome" in English and 監視者のドーム, "the Watcher's Dome," in Japanese. Here the pattern of Chapter 4 reverses. There, the English Gate Key named access and the Japanese Gate Holder named custody. Here the English names custody and the Japanese names vigilance. The double text shares out the virtues of the threshold between its two languages, as Rule IV (the chiasmus rule) predicts.

5.4 In the Twinkling of an Eye: Paul, Kierkegaard, Nietzsche, Heidegger

At the summit the party performs a rite. Japanese guides call it 「時の卵」を天に捧げる, "offering the Time Egg to heaven," which is to say to the dead hero's element. Marle puts her prayer into the egg, and her pendant reacts and sends power to it. Then, as an English walkthrough puts it, your party members will pray to the Chrono Trigger, but it will shatter. The sun is covered, and the party is carried to a frozen moment at the instant Crono was killed by Lavos: the Ocean Palace, where Schala, Zeal, Janus, Crono and the others stand petrified before being consumed by Lavos. Time has apparently stopped, and by exchan-

ging Crono for the doll the party rescues him before his life is taken. Back on the summit, the eclipse passes and sunlight flows over pale clouds. The stunned Crono looks around to find his friends, and Marle clings to him in tears, overjoyed.

The egg breaks, and breaking is how it works. In the Japanese text this is simply what an egg does when it hatches: the shell breaks. At the moment of breaking, hatching and destruction look the same. The difference shows only in what comes out.

Kairos seized from behind. The Greek figure of Kairos, the opportune moment, received its classic form from the sculptor Lysippus. An epigram of Posidippus questions the statue. Why does it stand on tiptoe? Because it is always running. Why the razor in its hand? Because it is sharper than any edge. Why does its hair hang over its face? So that whoever meets it may seize it. And why is the back of its head bald? "Because none whom I have once raced by on my winged feet will now, though he wishes it, take hold of me from behind" (*Anthologia Graeca* XVI.275). Ausonius adds that Kairos, under the Latin name Occasio, is followed by a companion, Metanoea (Regret), "the goddess who exacts penalty for what was done and not done."

The Time Egg is the one exception to Kairos's bald back. It lets the friends seize the moment after it has passed, by entering the instant in which it still stands. Japanese readers have seen this exception clearly. One notes that the time-travel device of secretly changing the outcome of one's own actions appears only once in the game, and comments: 一度きりしかこれをやらないことで時間の大切さを表しているのでしょう ("by doing this only once, the game surely shows how precious time is"). The same writer observes that the Gates send the heroes only to particular points in the past, one way, with no second attempts, whereas the egg is the device that sends them 行きたい場所に、行きたい時間に, "where they want, when they want." In Chapter 4's terms, the Gates are a fixed set of opportune moments and the egg is the one free one. Regret is averted once.

Paul's atom. "Behold, I shew you a mystery; We shall not all sleep, but we shall all be changed, in a moment, in the twinkling of an eye" (1 Corinthians 15:51–52). The Greek for "moment" is ἐν ἀτόμῳ, "in the uncuttable": the resurrection happens in a time that cannot be divided. Two further features of the passage fit closely. The verb for "be changed," ἀλλαγησόμεθα, comes from ἀλλάσσω, which also means "to exchange." In the frozen atom at the Ocean Palace, the change is literally an exchange of a body for a likeness. And the chapter goes on to quote Isaiah: "Death is swallowed up in victory" (15:54; Isaiah 25:8). In a fiction ruled by a swallowing god (Chapter 2, §2.1), Paul's reversal is exact: the devourer is devoured.

Kierkegaard's atom of eternity. In *Begrebet Angest* (1844, ch. III), Kierkegaard calls the moment (*Øieblikket*, literally the "glance of an eye") "that ambiguity in which time and eternity touch each other." He insists that it is "not properly an atom of time but an atom of

eternity," and he reads Paul's ἐν ἀτόμῳ καὶ ἐν ῥιπῇ ὀφθαλμοῦ as a poetic paraphrase of the moment. The frozen instant at the Ocean Palace makes Kierkegaard's moment visible. Everything in it is turned to stone except those who enter it from outside. Time stands still so that the eternal can act inside it.

Nietzsche's gateway. In "Vom Gesicht und Räthsel" (*Also sprach Zarathustra* III), Zarathustra shows the dwarf a gateway with "two faces." Two lanes meet there, one running back for an eternity and one running forward for another, and "the name of the gateway is written above: 'Moment' (*Augenblick*)." From this he draws the thought of eternal recurrence: must not everything that can happen already have happened? The gateway with two faces is Janus again (Chapter 4, §4.8). But it is the egg's opposite. Nietzsche's moment affirms the return of everything, every death included. The egg undoes one death and is then destroyed. Chapter 8 will find Nietzsche's gateway in New Game+, where all of history is played again. The egg belongs to Paul.

Heidegger's unsurpassable. *Sein und Zeit* defines death as Dasein's "ownmost, non-relational, unsurpassable (*unüberholbar*) possibility" (§50). The Time Egg surpasses it, though never for oneself. The game is precise in how it handles Heidegger's corollary. "No one can take the Other's dying away from him," §47 says. One may "go to one's death for another," but this always means sacrificing oneself "in some definite affair," and it can never mean that the other's death has been taken away in the slightest. Crono's step in front of the beam is exactly that kind of death "for" others in a definite affair, and it removes none of his friends' deaths. The doll, however, does take Crono's death, and it can do so because it has no death of its own. Heidegger is right about Dasein, and the game gets around him with a thing. It finds the one substitute his analysis did not rule out: a likeness that can receive a death because it has no life to lose.

Heidegger's early lectures on Paul (1920–21, now *GA* 60) add a point about method. The Thessalonians asked *when* the day of the Lord would come (1 Thessalonians 5:1–2), and Paul answered by telling them *how* to live. Heidegger read that answer as the heart of early Christian "kairology": the moment is not calculated, it is lived toward. The friends do not compute the instant of the rescue. They climb toward it.

5.5 The Strait Gate and the Tiger's Leap: Benjamin

On 16 March 1937, Max Horkheimer wrote to Walter Benjamin objecting to the claim that the past is "unfinished." Past injustice, he wrote, has happened and is closed: "Die Erschlagenen sind wirklich erschlagen," "the slain are really slain." Benjamin answered in the notes of the *Passagen-Werk* (N 8,1). History, he wrote, is not only a science but also a form of

remembrance (*Eingedenken*). What science has "established," remembrance can modify; remembrance can make the incomplete complete and the complete incomplete. "That is theology," he conceded, adding that remembrance gives us an experience that forbids us to understand history in purely atheological terms.

The Time Egg makes Benjamin's theology literal. Crono is, in Horkheimer's sense, really slain. The egg makes his death incomplete. It does not deny that the death happened; it reenters the instant in which the death was still happening. The theses "Über den Begriff der Geschichte" (1940) supply the rest of the vocabulary.

- **The secret agreement (Thesis II).** "There is a secret agreement between past generations and our own. We were expected on earth." Each generation receives "a weak messianic power" to which the past has a claim. On Death Peak the agreement is literal: the dead sage had programmed support for the friends' journey to Death Peak as his final mission, before his death. They were expected. And the power is weak in Benjamin's exact sense: a toy from a fairground, a doll borrowed from a mother, a mountain climbed on foot.
- **The spark of hope (Thesis VI).** Only the historian who knows that "even the dead will not be safe from the enemy if he wins" can fan the spark of hope in the past. The sequel's Time Devourer, which feeds on the lives erased from history (Chapter 4, §4.3), shows that the dead are not safe. The one who prays into the egg is the princess whose English name, Nadia, means Hope (Chapter 1, §1.6).
- **The tiger's leap (Thesis XIV).** History is constructed not in "homogeneous, empty time" but in "time filled by the now-time (*Jetztzeit*)," and the past can be seized in "a tiger's leap." The egg is such a leap. It does not pass through the continuum; it springs into one charged instant.
- **The new Joshuas (Thesis XV).** Revolutionary classes, Benjamin writes, are aware that they are blowing apart the continuum of history. Calendars do not measure time as clocks do; they are monuments of historical consciousness, and their holidays are days of remembrance. He quotes an eyewitness of the July Revolution of 1830: in several places in Paris people fired at the tower clocks, "new Joshuas" trying to stop the day. Joshua commanded, "Sun, stand thou still upon Gibeon" (Joshua 10:12). On Death Peak the sun goes dark and time stands still, and the instrument of rescue comes from a festival (§5.7), one of the calendar's days of remembrance (Chapter 8).
- **The arrest of happening (Thesis XVII).** Thinking includes not only the flow of thoughts but their arrest (*Stillstellung*). Where thinking stops in a constellation saturated with tensions, it gives that constellation a shock that crystallizes it, and in this the historical materialist recognizes "the sign of a messianic arrest of happening, or, put differently, a

revolutionary chance in the fight for the oppressed past." The frozen slice of time at the Ocean Palace is such an arrest of happening made visible, and the fight it allows is a fight for an oppressed past. The same thesis ends with an image this dissertation takes as an emblem: the nourishing fruit of what is historically understood "contains time as a precious but tasteless seed in its interior." Benjamin's time is stored like a seed inside a fruit, the clearest image of what this thesis calls oöchrony, egg-time.

- **The strait gate (Appendix B).** For the Jews, Benjamin writes, the future did not become homogeneous, empty time, for "every second of time was the strait gate through which the Messiah might enter" (*die kleine Pforte, durch die der Messias treten konnte*). Chapter 4 described the Gates of *Chrono Trigger* as a topology of opportune moments, a few thin places in time. The Time Egg turns one second into a gate.
- **The abbreviation (Thesis XVIII).** The now-time, as the model of messianic time, gathers the whole history of humanity "in an enormous abridgment." Lavos also contains an abridgment of history: its shell recites the planet's past as armour (Chapter 2, §2.7). The two abridgments face each other. One gathers history in order to consume it; the other gathers it in order to redeem it.

Benjamin's angel of history, blown backward into the future while wreckage piles up at his feet (Thesis IX), belongs with the victims the game cannot save. It is held over for Chapter 7 (§7.5).

5.6 The Silver Egg: Orphic, Vedic, and Japanese Cosmogonies

The Time Egg is a creation myth's object scaled down to a single life. Its parallels are the world-eggs of the cosmogonies, which share four features. The egg is made by time or lies in time; it stores potential; it opens by breaking; and what comes out is light, love, or a world.

Orphic. In the Orphic Rhapsodies, "great Chronos fashioned in the divine aither a silver-gleaming egg" (ὠεὸν ἀργύφεον; Orphic fr. 70 Kern). From it hatches Phanes, the first-born, "the one who brings to light." The Orphic world-egg is literally a time egg, made by Time. It is silver, the colour the Japanese text gives the companion instrument, the time machine シルバード, "silver bird" (Chapter 1, §1.4). What hatches is light born from an egg, the counter-image of Zeal's light, which was borrowed from a fire (Chapter 1, §1.5c).

Aristophanes. The comic version in the *Birds* (693–697) supplies a decisive name. Black-winged Night "first of all lays a wind-egg in the boundless bosom of Erebus, and from it, as the seasons revolved, sprang Eros the longed-for, his back gleaming with golden wings."

The verb is ἔβλαστεν, "sprouted," a gardener's word. The egg germinates like a seed, and what germinates is love, "as the seasons revolved," that is, in time. The Japanese criterion for the egg's hatching, that the dead be truly dear, turns out to be the oldest Greek teaching about eggs: what hatches is Eros.

Vedic. The *Chāndogya Upaniṣad* (3.19) gives the egg its duration. In Max Müller's translation: "In the beginning this was non-existent. It became existent, it grew. It turned into an egg. The egg lay for the time of a year. The egg broke open. The two halves were one of silver, the other of gold. The silver one became this earth, the golden one the sky." What was born from it was the sun, and "when he was born, shouts of hurrah arose." The cosmic egg must lie for a year (*saṃvatsara*); it breaks; it yields the sun; and the sun's birth is greeted with festive shouts. The sequence on Death Peak, in which an egg breaks, a darkened sun returns, and a friend weeps for joy, repeats the Upanishad in miniature.

Chinese and Japanese. Xu Zheng's *Sanwu liji* (third century) says that heaven and earth were once a chaos "like a hen's egg," inside which Pangu was born; after eighteen thousand years heaven and earth separated. The *Nihon shoki* opens with the same image: heaven and earth not yet divided, "a chaotic mass like an egg … which contained germs" (渾沌如鶏子…含牙). From it, "a thing like a reed-shoot" (葦牙) arises and becomes the first god. The *Kojiki* describes the time when the young land was "floating like oil, drifting like a jellyfish," and the god Umashi-ashikabi-hikoji came into being from "something that sprouted like reed-shoots." Japanese cosmogony moves in one breath from the floating world to the egg to the sprout. That is a move from Zeal's register to the registers of the egg and the tree, in the same order this thesis follows.

Finnish. In the first rune of the *Kalevala*, a goldeneye duck lays its eggs on the knee of Ilmatar, mother of the waters. When she moves, the eggs roll into the sea and break. The lower halves of the shells become the earth, the upper halves the vault of heaven, the yolk the sun, and the white the moon. Creation is breakage. The shattering on Death Peak is cosmogonic in the strict sense: a world begins again from broken shell.

Phoenix and Easter. Herodotus's phoenix carries its dead father to Heliopolis inside an egg of myrrh (2.73; Chapter 2, §2.5), an egg that holds a death. The Time Egg holds something subtler: the moment before a death. Christian custom made the egg an emblem of the tomb broken open at Easter. Augustine gave the image its most exact moral sense in a sermon on Luke 11:11–12, where a father will not give his child a scorpion when it asks for an egg. Hope, Augustine says, is like an egg, "for hope has not yet reached the thing hoped for; and an egg is something, but it is not yet a chick" (*ovum est aliquid, sed nondum est pullus*; *Sermo* 105.7). The scorpion is the egg's opposite because its sting is in its tail. It strikes from behind, while hope reaches toward what lies ahead (Philippians 3:13). The past poisons from

behind; the egg holds what has not yet come. The one who prays into the egg on Death Peak is Nadia, whose name means Hope.

The cosmogonies yield a definition. The Time Egg is a **microcosmogony**, a creation myth in miniature. It compresses the four features of the world-egg (made by time, storing potential, opened by breaking, releasing light and love) into the return of one person to one world.

5.7 Doll, Clone, Animation: The Substitute Body

The doll. To make Death Peak's power work, the party needs a Clone, which is to be had at Norstein Bekkler's lab at the Millennial Fair. A Japanese player's diary sums up the Sage of Reason's directions: ベッケラーはお祭り好き。 ("Bekkler loves festivals."). In Bekkler's Tent of Horrors, an animated duplicate doll of the party's leader walks out onto the stage, and the player must mimic its actions: raise left arm, raise right arm, laugh, surprise. The price depends on how faithful the imitation is: The clone starts out at 60,000 G and the price decreases the longer you can stay in the game. As one guide says, Do well enough and it's free. Bekkler says that he does not normally give out another person's doll, but he will make an exception this time. Once won, the duplicate appears at the home of the person who won it. The Japanese text calls it ドッペルくん (*Doppel-kun*, "little Doppel"), and the English SNES and PlayStation versions called it the Clone.

Four features of this sequence call for analysis.

(a) The remedy comes before the wound. The doll can be won at the very start of the game, at the same Fair where the story opens, before anyone has died. A walkthrough reminds players of the clone they just happened to win at the fair way back at the beginning of the game, and two copies of Crono are obtainable. The festival stores the means of resurrection before the catastrophe it will reverse. A toy picked up in play becomes, after the death, the condition of return. Festal time incubates the opportune moment (Chapter 8).

(b) Mourning by imitation. To win the double, the friends must imitate it: raise an arm, laugh, look surprised. They reproduce the gestures of a life in order to earn its likeness. Aristotle observed that human beings learn by imitation and take pleasure in exact likenesses even of things painful to see, "such as the forms of the most despised animals and of corpses" (*Poetics* 4, 1448b10–12). Played after Crono's death, the Copycat game is an Aristotelian scene of mourning: the bereaved perform the movements of the dead before a perfect image of him. Plato's charge that imitation stands "third from the truth" (*Republic* X, 597e) is overturned as literally as possible, since here the copy saves the original. Deleuze's

call to "reverse Platonism" by affirming the power of the simulacrum ("Platon et le simulacre," 1969) finds an unexpected illustration.

The pricing adds an economic argument. A failed imitation costs a fortune; a perfect one costs nothing. Faithfulness abolishes price. The Mammon Machine turned every quality into its opposite (Chapter 3, §3.3); Bekkler's tent turns attention into a gift.

(c) The loan and the lie. The friends must collect the doll from Crono's mother. In the Japanese text they tell her they will borrow the doll, and she agrees. When she asks whether Crono is well, they hesitate, then answer that he is, and take the doll. The resurrection begins with a loan from a mother and a merciful lie. Kant forbade even the lie told to a murderer at the door ("Über ein vermeintes Recht aus Menschenliebe zu lügen," 1797). The friends' lie is of a different kind. It is a promise dressed as a report, and the deed that follows makes it true. Paul describes Abraham's faith in the God "who quickeneth the dead, and calleth those things which be not as though they were" (Romans 4:17). The friends speak of the dead man as living and then make him so. Their answer is true in the future perfect: Crono will have been well.

(d) The double restored to its first function. The Japanese name comes from German. Jean Paul coined *Doppeltgänger* in *Siebenkäs* (1796) with a footnote: "So heißen Leute, die sich selbst sehen" ("that is what people are called who see themselves"). Otto Rank's *Der Doppelgänger* (1914) traced the double back to archaic beliefs about the soul, and Freud summarized Rank in "Das Unheimliche" (1919). The double, Freud wrote, was originally "an insurance against the destruction of the ego, an 'energetic denial of the power of death'"; the immortal soul was probably the body's first double; only later did the double become "the uncanny harbinger of death." Romantic literature knew mostly the later double: the omen, the rival, the murderer. *Chrono Trigger* gives the double back its archaic office. The Doppel doll is, quite literally, an energetic denial of the power of death.

The English twig. The English name points elsewhere. In 1995 "clone" still belonged to science fiction and to horticulture; Dolly the sheep would not be born until July 1996. Herbert J. Webber coined the word ("clon") in 1903 for plants propagated vegetatively, from Greek κλών, "twig, slip." The English text names the substitute body a cutting. Independently, the Japanese text turns the dead sage's doubles into trees on the mountain (§5.3). Both languages make the substitute vegetal, and under Rule III of Chapter 1, convergence that arises independently marks a structural feature. The double belongs to lignous time: it is a slip taken from a life, which grows where the life itself cannot.

Rhea's stone and the thunderbolt. Chapter 2 (§2.1) anticipated the myth; it can now be completed. Hesiod's Kronos swallows a stone wrapped in place of Zeus. When forced to disgorge, "he vomited up first the stone which he had swallowed last," and Zeus set it at Pytho "to be a sign thenceforth and a marvel to mortal men." The next lines are the ones

that matter. Zeus freed his father's brothers, and they "gave him thunder and the glowing thunderbolt and lightning … and trusting in these he rules over mortals and immortals" (*Theogony* 497–506). The child saved from the devourer by a likeness becomes the wielder of lightning. Crono's element is heaven and his spells are thunder. The game repeats Hesiod's sequence in its exact order: a substitute takes the devourer's blow, the child comes back, and the child commands the lightning.

Moriah and the "figure." The binding of Isaac supplies the scriptural version: the ram "in the stead of his son," on a mountain. The Epistle to the Hebrews adds an interpretation that fits the doll with uncanny precision. Abraham reckoned "that God was able to raise him up, even from the dead; from whence also he received him in a figure" (ἐν παραβολῇ, Hebrews 11:19). Crono, too, is received back "in a figure," through a likeness that stays in his place. But the ram dies, and on Death Peak nothing living dies. That is the difference between substitution with sacrifice and substitution without it.

Japanese substitutes. Japanese ritual has a developed theology of the substitute body. In the Great Purification (Ōharae) at midyear and year's end, worshippers rub a paper doll (*katashiro*, "form-substitute," or *hitogata*, "human shape") over their bodies and breathe on it, transferring impurity and misfortune, and the dolls are cast into the river. The floating dolls (*nagashi-bina*) of the doll festival descend from this rite. Roadside *migawari Jizō*, "substitute Jizō," are statues said to have taken a wound or an illness in a devotee's place. The *Konjaku monogatari-shū* (19.24) and the illustrated *Nakifudō engi*, the legend of the "Weeping Fudō," tell of the monk Shōkū, who offered to die in place of his gravely ill master. As Shōkū lay dying in turn, the painted image of Fudō before which he prayed wept tears of blood and declared that it would take his place, and both men lived. The image substitutes for the substitute and no one dies. This is the closest premodern analogue to the Doppel doll.

Classical literature knows the reverse case. In the Uji chapters of *The Tale of Genji*, Kaoru, grieving for the dead Ōigimi, longs for a *hitogata*, an effigy of her. He is told of her half-sister Ukifune and comes to treat her as a living *katashiro*. The poems exchanged around her turn on the doll that is stroked and cast into the purifying stream, and Ukifune later tries to drown herself in the Uji River. In Genji a living substitute stands in for the dead beloved, and the substitution ends in near-catastrophe. In *Chrono Trigger* a lifeless likeness stands in for the living beloved, and the substitution restores him. The game inverts the logic of the *yukari*, the substitute by affinity.

The uncanny reversed. E. T. A. Hoffmann's "Der Sandmann" (1816), the text at the centre of Freud's essay, turns on a doll mistaken for a living woman, and the deceived man goes mad and dies. On Death Peak the deception is turned against the devourer. Lavos, not a lover, is fooled by the doll, as Kronos was fooled by the stone. One resonance in the names can be recorded without claiming it was intended. The magician's Japanese name, ノルシュ

タイン, matches the name under which Japanese audiences know Yuri Norstein, the Russian master of cut-out animation (*Hedgehog in the Fog*, 1975; *Tale of Tales*, 1979). Intended or not, the man who makes dolls that move is an animator in the strict sense: one who gives *anima*, soul.

The bracket of likenesses. The game opens and closes its central story with a substitution. The first substitution is lethal. Marle is mistaken for Queen Leene, the search for the queen is called off, and the descendant begins to fade (Chapter 4, §4.2). The last is saving: a doll is mistaken for Crono, and the hero lives. In *Chrono Trigger*, likeness is the *pharmakon*, poison and remedy at once. As resemblance it erases; as substitute it restores.

The princess without a double. One figure in the frozen instant cannot be exchanged. The doll is won by a party member at Bekkler's tent and appears in that person's home. Schala never came to the Fair. She has no likeness from the festival and therefore no substitute, and she remains turned to stone in the instant from which Crono is taken. This is an interpretation, but the game's rules support it. The one person who never had festal time, the princess whose whole life was work as conduit and human pillar (Chapter 3, §3.4), is the one the restoration cannot reach.

5.8 The Time That Remains: Agamben and the End of Time

Giorgio Agamben's *Il tempo che resta* (2000), a commentary on Paul's Letter to the Romans, separates messianic time from the end of time. Messianic time is not the eschaton but the time of the end: "the time that time takes to come to an end." Paul's formula is "the time is contracted" (ὁ καιρὸς συνεσταλμένος ἐστίν, 1 Corinthians 7:29); the opportune moment is ordinary time gathered and shortened. Its subject is the remnant (λεῖμμα, Romans 11:5), which for Agamben is not a numerical portion but the impossibility of the whole ever coinciding with itself.

These categories describe the interval the party lives in. Between Crono's death and his return, and between his return and the battle with Lavos, the friends inhabit a contracted time. Their base at the "farthest edge of time" (Chapter 4, §4.5) is not the eschaton but the working space of the time of the end. They wake after the catastrophe among "the people who were left," the remnant of Zeal and of the Earthbound, the Commons of Chapter 3 (§3.2). The party that gathers there is itself a remnant, not a whole. It is incomplete without its silent centre, and incomplete again once Schala is left behind.

Gathered. Many hands accomplish the resurrection, and the game makes each one indispensable.

The medieval Japanese sung narrative (*sekkyō-bushi*) of Oguri Hangan is the closest structural parallel. Oguri is poisoned along with his ten retainers and brought before Enma. The retainers were cremated and have no bodies to return to; Oguri was buried, so Enma sends him back alone. He comes out of the grave as a *gaki-ami*, a starved and shrunken figure, blind, deaf, and mute. A holy man puts him on a cart with a placard declaring that whoever pulls it one length makes an offering equal to feeding a thousand monks, and whoever pulls it two lengths, ten thousand. Strangers along the road take turns pulling. His beloved Terute, in disguise, pulls too. The cart reaches the hot springs of Yunomine at Kumano, where Oguri bathes and is restored.

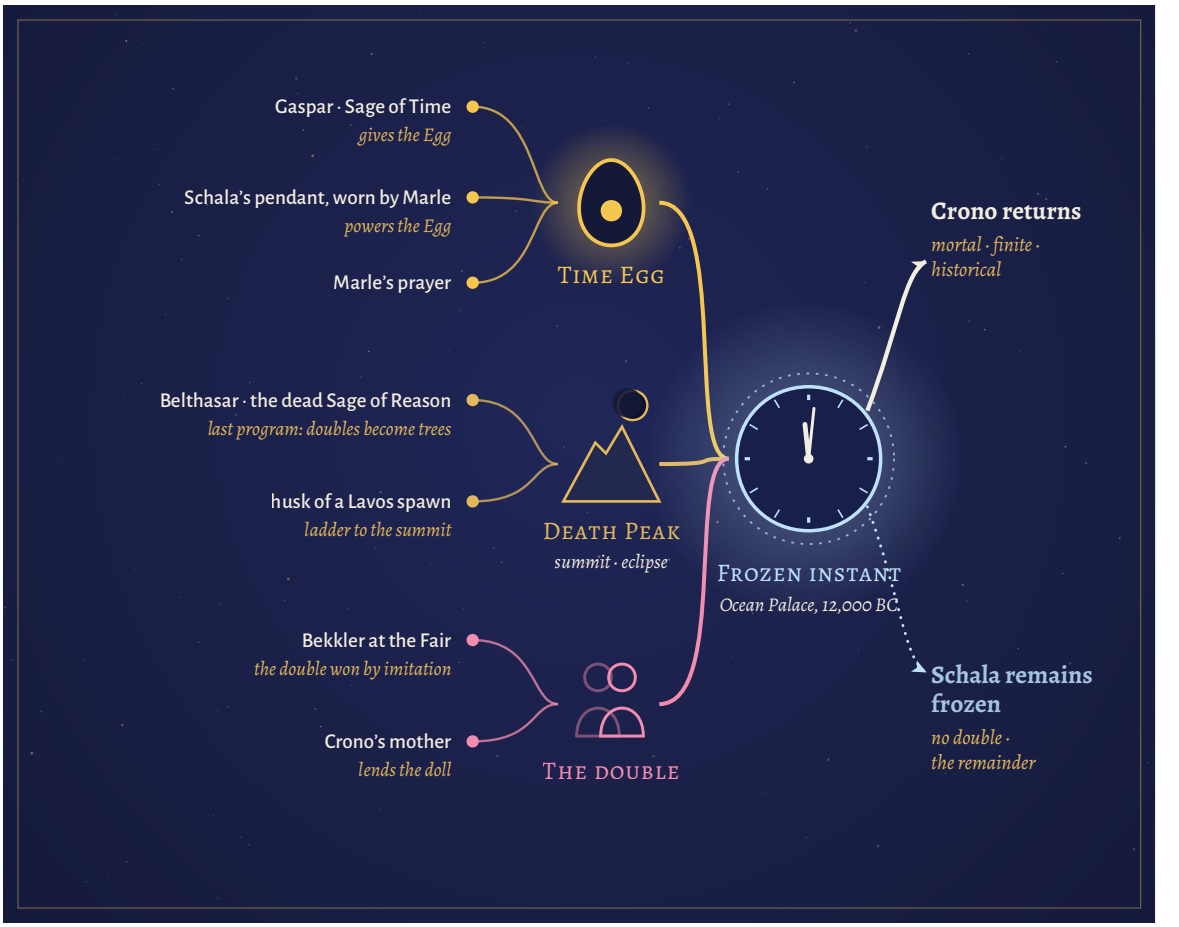


Figure 5 *The gathered resurrection: who supplies what.*

Three features of the tale fit Death Peak. The return is gathered: many hands carry it, including the hands of strangers. The returned man is silent until he is restored (§5.2). And fire forecloses return: the burned have no body to come back to, while the buried can be

raised. The anti-pyric ontology of Chapter 4 (§4.7) has a folk form. The Japanese word for resurrection, 蘇る or 甦る (*yomigaeru*), means "to come back from Yomi," the land of the dead, which makes it another member of Chapter 1's *kaeru* cluster (§1.6). After the rescue, too, the commonwealth carries the work forward together: the party gathers power by helping people across time with Gaspar's instructions.

Recapitulation. The Epistle to the Ephesians speaks of God's plan "that in the dispensation of the fulness of times (τοῦ πληρώματος τῶν καιρῶν) he might gather together in one (ἀνακεφαλαιώσασθαι) all things" (1:10). Irenaeus made this recapitulation the core of his theology of redemption (*Adversus haereses* III.18.1). Lavos's shell recapitulates too: it recites the bosses of the player's past as armour (Chapter 2, §2.7). The two recapitulations face each other. The archive gathers history in order to consume it; the fullness of opportune moments gathers it in order to restore it. Chapter 7 develops the second as the constitution of the commonwealth.

Finite. Crono returns mortal. The egg shatters and cannot be used again; the restoration is something undergone, not a power kept. The later editions make this finitude explicit. The PlayStation, DS, and later versions add an animated scene showing Crono and Marle's wedding, and a second showing the fall of the Guardia Kingdom in AD 1005. The returned man re-enters history, with its marriage, household, and political catastrophe; he does not leave it. This is the opposite of Zeal's project (Chapter 3, §3.6). The queen wanted never to die and so would let nothing be born. The egg returns one man to a mortal life in which he can marry and found a household. In the oldest Japanese myth of death, Izanami vows from Yomi to kill a thousand people a day, and Izanagi answers that he will cause fifteen hundred to be born (*Kojiki* I). In the *Mahābhārata*, Sāvitrī follows Yama, god of death, and wins back her husband by obtaining as a boon a hundred sons by him, so that Death must return the husband in order to keep his promise. In both stories, new births outrun death. The egg serves natality, not immortality.

The remainder. In the frozen instant, Schala stands turned to stone beside her mother and the child Janus. Magus, now in the party, has his own reactions to the time freeze: he sees his sister in an instant from which only Crono can be taken. For Magus, "the time that remains" is the search he continues after the Gates have closed (Chapter 4, §4.8). Chapter 6 (§6.7) treats Schala as the remainder that keeps the game's restorations honest: the one person for whom no double was made.

Five marks. Kairotic apokatastasis can now be defined.

1. **Singular.** It happens once. The prerelease script says the chance comes only once, the egg shatters, and the device of altering one's own past is used a single time. It is not recurrence, whether Stoic or Nietzschean.

2. **Heteronomous.** The dead cannot do it for himself. The hero who raises others cannot raise himself. His friends must act, and the dead (Belthasar) must have expected them. The living answer the death of the other.
3. **Substitutive without sacrifice.** A likeness takes the blow, and nothing living dies in the dead man's place. This sets it apart from Alcestis, from Isaac's ram, and from every scapegoat. Its nearest analogues are Rhea's stone and the Weeping Fudō.
4. **Gathered.** Many hands supply its conditions: two sages (one of them dead), a showman, a mother, a princess's pendant, a prayer, a climbing party, and even the husk of the enemy's brood.
5. **Finite.** The returned life is mortal and historical, and the instrument is used up. It restores a person to time, not out of it.

The table pinpoints what is new. Every earlier model either fails (Orpheus, Izanagi), requires a death (Alcestis, the ram), restores everything without distinction (the Stoics), or refuses death altogether (Zeal). The closest models, Rhea's stone, the Weeping Fudō, and Oguri's cart, each supply one or two of the five marks. *Chrono Trigger* brings all five together in a single sequence.

The egg, however, restores a life inside an instant. It does not heal what the years have done. A forest destroyed over centuries, a mother crippled in an accident, a knight left without absolution for a decade: these wounds do not sit in a single moment and cannot be undone by seizing one. Chapter 6 follows the journeys the party makes after the rescue. It asks what kind of restoration needs a duration rather than an opportune moment, such as four hundred years of planting or a forgiveness that takes a lifetime. It argues that the work's ethics reaches its full form only when the egg's instant and the forest's centuries are held together.

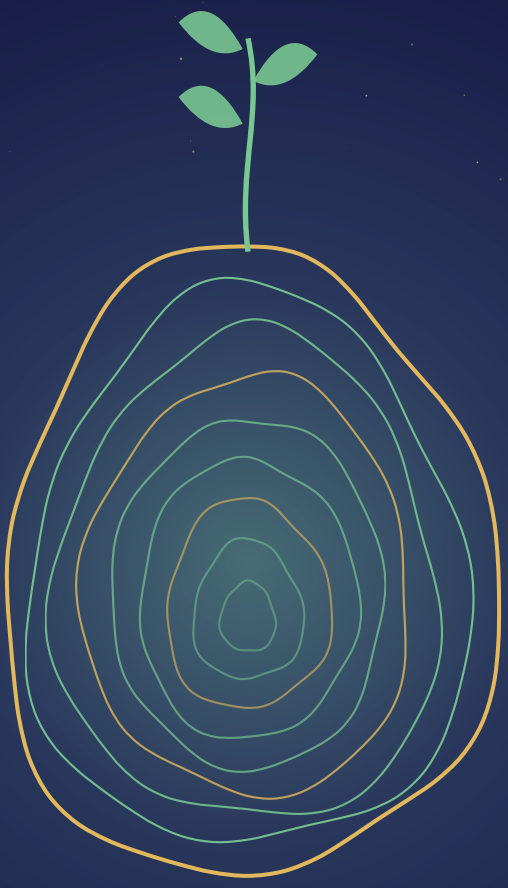
Table 5.1 *Models of return*

MODEL	EXEMPLAR	WHO RETURNS	AGENCY	SUBSTITUTE	DOES ANYONE DIE IN PLACE?	AFTERWARD
Stoic apokatastasis	Chrysippus; Nemesius	everything, identically	cosmic necessity	none	—	the cycle repeats
Failed retrieval	Orpheus (Virgil, Ovid); Izanagi (*Kojiki*)	no one	the lover's descent	none	—	looking back loses the beloved
Substitution with sacrifice	Euripides, *Alcestis*	the husband, then the wife	a wife's death; Heracles' wrestling	the wife	yes	the returned wife is silent until the third day
Substitution with animal sacrifice	Genesis 22; Hebrews 11:19	the son, "in a figure"	divine provision	the ram	yes (an animal)	the son lives
Substitution by likeness	Hesiod, *Theogony*; *Konjaku* 19.24	the child; the disciple	a mother's ruse; a weeping image	a stone; a painted image	no	the child wields the lightning
Gathered return	*Oguri Hangan* (sekkyō-bushi)	the buried, not the burned	strangers' hands; a beloved	none	no	restored at Kumano
Immortality	Queen Zeal; Tithonus	no one; the living refuse to leave	extraction	none	others are consumed	the bad infinite
Kairotic apokatastasis	*Chrono Trigger*	**one friend, once**	**many hands in a seized instant**	**a doll won at a festival**	**no**	**a mortal, historical life**

緑の夢

midori no yume

"the Green Dream"



Chapter Six

6

Durée and Restoration

The Ethics of Apokatastasis

ὅπως ἂν ἔλθωσιν καιροὶ ἀναψύξεως ἀπὸ προσώπου τοῦ κυρίου … ἄχρι χρόνων ἀποκαταστάσεως πάντων.

"That the times of refreshing may come from the presence of the Lord … until the times of restitution of all things."

— Acts 3:19–21

Si je veux me préparer un verre d'eau sucrée, j'ai beau faire, je dois attendre que le sucre fonde.

"If I want to mix a glass of sugar water, whatever I do, I must wait until the sugar melts."

— Henri Bergson, *L'Évolution créatrice* (1907)

一年之計，莫如樹穀；十年之計，莫如樹木；終身之計，莫如樹人。

"To plan for a year, plant grain; for ten years, plant trees; for a lifetime, cultivate people."

— *Guanzi*, "Quanxiu"

Chapter 5 ended on a limit. The Time Egg can restore a life within an instant, but it cannot heal what the years have done. Three wounds in the game are of that kind: a desert that spread over generations, a mother crippled for a decade, and a knight whose guilt hardened over years. None of them sits in a single moment, so none can be undone by seizing one.

The game answers with optional journeys, which open once the hero has come back and the party can fly anywhere in time. The Prefatory Note proposed a rough division of the game into layers of authorship. In that scheme these journeys belong to the sub-scenario layer associated with Tokita and Kitase, the layer of restoration. The main scenario supplies

the catastrophe and the decisive instant. The sub-scenarios supply what no instant can: duration.

The noun ἀποκατάστασις ("restoration") occurs only once in the New Testament, in a pair. In Acts 3:19–21, Peter urges his hearers to repent so that their sins may be "blotted out" (ἐξαλειφθῆναι, wiped away like writing from a wax tablet). Then "times of refreshing" (καιροὶ ἀναψύξεως) will come, and after them "the times of restitution of all things" (χρόνων ἀποκαταστάσεως πάντων). The verse gives this chapter its formula in three ways:

- **Grammar.** The refreshings are *kairoi*, opportune moments. The restitution is counted in *chronoi*, spans of time.
- **Vocabulary.** The vocabulary works against fire. ἀνάψυξις means cooling, breathing again, relief from heat. The Septuagint uses it for the respite Pharaoh saw once the frogs were dead (Exodus 8:11 LXX; 8:15 in English Bibles). In a chapter whose fifth section concerns a frog, that coincidence is noted, not interpreted.
- **Ethics.** What gets erased is a debt, not a person. Chapter 4 (§4.3) dealt with erasures of persons.

Chapter 5 described the kairotic half of restoration, the seized instant. This chapter describes the chronic half, restoration through duration. The argument is that the game's ethics of restoration is complete only when the two are held together: the egg's instant and the forest's centuries.

The sub-scenarios set out five modes of restoration. Each joins an opening (a Gate, a meeting, a gift) to a span of time that someone has to live through.

1. **Duration.** Robo and Fiona: four centuries of planting (§§6.2–6.3).
2. **Naming.** Lucca and Lara: a beloved's name serves as the password that stops a machine (§6.4).
3. **Forgiveness.** Frog and Cyrus: the one restoration that leaves the past exactly as it was (§6.5).
4. **Inheritance.** A sun-stone charged across sixty-five million years, a gift of jerky, borrowed tools, a kept shell (§6.6).
5. **Acknowledged remainder.** Schala, whom no mode reaches (§6.7).

My thesis is that the theology of restoration the game constructs is Lurianic rather than Origenist. It does not restore all things at the end by divine decree. It repairs particular things now, by human and machine hands, one deed at a time. It allows restorations to fail. It leaves one person unrestored, and that keeps the rest honest. Its governing principle I

call **vicarious duration**: every restoration costs a span of time that someone must live through, so that others can receive the result in an instant.

6.1 Times of Refreshing, Times of Restitution: The Grammar of Return

Patristic apokatastasis has two features, and the game rejects both. It is universal, and it returns to the origin.

Origen reasoned that "the end is always like the beginning" (*semper enim similis est finis initiis*, *De principiis* I.6.2): rational natures that fell away from unity will be restored to it. Gregory of Nyssa took the doctrine to its limit. In *De anima et resurrectione*, the fire of judgment is a refiner's fire that burns off the dross and leaves the gold. In the *Catechetical Oration* (26), even the inventor of evil is healed. Justinian's edict of 543 and the anathemas associated with the council of 553 condemned the Origenist form. Its two features, universality and circularity, stayed with Western thought wherever restoration was imagined as the end of history.

Chrono Trigger has neither feature.

- Its restorations are particular: one forest, one mother's legs, one dead friend's word, one stone.
- They return nothing to an origin. Fiona's forest is not her childhood forest given back. It is a new forest, with a shrine at its heart and a rusted machine on the shrine's altar.
- Lara's restored legs do not erase her daughter's memory of their loss (§6.4).
- The green 2300 of the ending is not the world as it was before 1999, because it never had a 1999.

In this work, restoration makes something that never existed before, and the new thing carries the trace of what it repairs.

Two further features set the game apart from Origen. First, its restorations can fail. Lucca may miss the password. Atropos dies at Robo's hands. The knight stays a frog unless the man who cursed him is killed. Chapter 4 called this texture "permission without guarantee" (§4.4): Origen's restoration is guaranteed, while the game's is only permitted. Second, the restorations are worked by hands, one deed at a time, prompted by a sage who gives hints rather than commands.

Benjamin's "Theologisch-politisches Fragment" (c. 1920–21) supplies the right category. He sets a "spiritual *restitutio in integrum*, which leads into immortality," against a worldly restitution "that leads into the eternity of a downfall." The rhythm of this endlessly passing worldly existence, he says, is happiness, *denn messianisch ist die Natur aus ihrer ewigen und*

totalen Vergängnis ("for nature is messianic by reason of its eternal and total passing away"). The sub-scenarios are worldly restitutions in exactly this sense: **they restore to transience.** The forest can burn again, Lara will grow old, and Robo's body wears out on the altar.

Chapter 3 deferred Gaspar's remark that Zeal "reverted back to a human." The phrase marks the horizon of every restoration in this chapter. Restoration ends at the human, which means at mortality, not at glory. Zeal wanted the spiritual restitution, immortality, and received the worldly one.

Chapter 5 (§5.8) gave five marks of kairotic apokatastasis. Here they carry over with changes:

- Restoration is still **heteronomous** (no one restores himself) and **gathered** (it takes several hands).
- It is still **finite**.
- It is no longer **singular**: there are many restorations.
- It no longer works by **substitution**. It works by **endurance**.

In Chapter 5 a likeness took the blow. In this chapter, a life takes the years.

6.2 Four Hundred Years: Robo's Durée and the Inversion of Dukes' Ratio

The episode is short in playing time and long in the time of the fiction. In 600 AD the party meets a woman named Fiona, who has dedicated herself to planting a forest around her small cottage, while her husband has gone away to war as Guardia takes on a powerful magician and his army. Her tiny cottage is surrounded by desert. She wants to plant the seedlings for a forest but cannot, because monsters underground are destroying the soil. The English text names the cause of the desertification: the Retinite.

The party kills the monster, but that is not enough: beating the monsters won't save the forest, because there is centuries' worth of work to be done. Fiona and Marco grew up in the forest, married, and lived at Fiona's Villa. The forest was plagued by the Retinite and the Sunken Desert and was nearly made into pure wasteland. Fiona realizes that even with her husband the job is too big, and that they won't live long enough to see it through. That is when Robo volunteers to stay for 400 years to help tend the grove. He leaves the party, and the player can see him working on the world map.

The party then crosses four centuries in a moment. In 1000 AD, where empty sands once stretched, green trees march for miles. Fiona's cottage has been replaced by a shrine tended by acolytes who honour her efforts. On a dais at its centre, bathed in sunlight, sits Robo, rusted and still, venerated for bringing life to a place where there was none. One reviewer

states the building's double function exactly: for the people caring for it, "the shrine is also Robo's tomb". Lucca repairs him, as she first did in the dome of 2300 AD that the Japanese text names after Prometheus (Table 1.1). His first words measure the asymmetry this section turns on: "For you, it was a quick hop, but for me 400 long years have passed."

Bergson's sugar. The epigraph from *L'Évolution créatrice* goes on: "This little fact is big with meaning." Some processes cannot be compressed. The wait for the sugar is not a quantity that can be calculated and skipped. It coincides with a *durée*, a duration that has to be lived. The Gates abolish distance in time, but they cannot abolish growth. A traveller can leap from 600 to 1000 AD, but no one can leap a sapling into an oak. The forest is Bergson's sugar at the scale of centuries.

The game draws a consequence Bergson did not. If the duration cannot be skipped, and the travellers must skip it, someone has to live it for them. This is **vicarious duration**, and the commonwealth assigns it to the member whose body can bear it. Fiona's hope needs, as one account puts it, the party's help and an immortal robot. Giving each member the task their body can carry is the commonwealth's first constitutional act, and Chapter 7 develops it.

The inverted twins. In 1911, Paul Langevin imagined a traveller fired from the Earth at nearly the speed of light. He returns two years older to find the Earth two centuries older ("L'Évolution de l'espace et du temps," *Scientia* 10). Robo's reunion reverses Langevin's arrangement. The one who stays home ages four hundred years, and the travellers come back minutes older.

At the Société française de philosophie on 6 April 1922, and in *Durée et simultanéité* that year, Bergson argued that only one twin's time is truly lived. Einstein replied that "there is no time of the philosophers." The game takes a third position. Both durations are real, because both are lived. But only one is recorded in the world: the forest is the clock of Robo's time, not of the party's. The travellers' memory testifies to the history they changed (Chapter 4, §4.1). The forest testifies to the duration they skipped.

Dukes' ratio inverted. In "Burning Buried Sunshine: Human Consumption of Ancient Solar Energy" (*Climatic Change* 61, 2003), the ecologist Jeffrey Dukes estimated the size of one year's fossil-fuel burning. The fuels burned in 1997 came from ancient organic matter holding more than four hundred times the carbon that the planet's present biota fixes in a year. Expressed as a ratio of times, industrial civilisation burns about four centuries of the biosphere's growth every year. That figure is the pyric regime of Chapter 2 in a single number: stored time released as heat at four hundred to one.

Robo's forest inverts the ratio exactly. Four hundred years of growth are not consumed in a year. They are given in a moment, when the party steps out of the Epoch into the trees.

Pyric time compresses consumption; lignous time decompresses gift. The same four centuries, read in opposite directions, separate Lavos from Robo.

The man who planted trees. The nearest literary analogue is Jean Giono's "L'Homme qui plantait des arbres" (1953). A solitary shepherd in Haute-Provence, Elzéard Bouffier, plants acorns every day for decades, a hundred thousand in three years, of which twenty thousand come up. Bare slopes become forest, springs run again, and abandoned villages fill. Officials later admire the "natural forest" and protect it, and Giono's fiction persuaded readers to go looking for the shepherd's grave.

Two differences matter. Bouffier works alone and unseen. Robo works with a family whose line he outlives, and he shares its honour: people at the shrine give thanks to Fiona and Robo for replanting the forest. And Bouffier's forest is credited to nature, while the game insists that the forest has authors.

Plant trees, cultivate people. The *Guanzi*'s maxim ranks plans by their span: grain for a year, trees for a decade, people for a lifetime. Fiona's forest needs all three, four centuries of trees and a community formed around them. The shrine, lined with carpets and pews, is filled with admirers of the restored forest. Japanese institutions know spans of this kind:

- Ise Jingū rebuilds its sanctuaries every twenty years. In 1923 it adopted a forest plan that looks two centuries ahead, so that its own land would grow the cypress for rebuildings not yet scheduled.
- Minakata Kumagusu campaigned from 1909 against the government's shrine-merger policy. His ground was that shrine forests (*chinju no mori*) were irreplaceable stores of life, and Yanagita Kunio printed his letters of protest in 1911.
- Miyawaki Akira later treated surviving shrine forests as remnants of the original vegetation and used them to reconstruct native forests.

In all three, shrine and forest keep each other: the forest supplies the shrine, and the shrine protects the forest.

The Japanese name of the shrine sharpens the point. It is フィオナ神殿, Fiona's *shinden* ("divine hall"). Zeal's sea-floor palace is the 海底神殿 (Chapter 3, §3.7). So the Japanese text has two *shinden*: one under the sea, where Lavos's power is drawn up, and one in the forest, where four centuries of tending are honoured. The English names them as two institutions, a "palace" of royal power and a "shrine" of piety. Under Rule II (disparity is data) the difference is instructive. The English places the contrast in the institution. The Japanese, more radically, places it in what is worshipped: the same kind of temple can house extraction or cultivation.

The seed from the sky. One thread runs into the forest from further back. The quest can even be completed before the party has the Epoch, provided it has visited Zeal's palace in

12,000 BC and told a girl there to plant the sapling secretly. Once Robo has been taken down from the shrine, the seed that the Zeal plant woman handed down through the generations sits on the altar. Of everything the floating kingdom made, the only thing that falls to earth and grows is a seed, planted in secret, against the vertical economy of Chapter 3. "Except a corn of wheat fall into the ground and die, it abideth alone: but if it die, it bringeth forth much fruit" (John 12:24). Zeal fell and bore nothing. Its seed fell and bore a forest.

Vegetable love and ploughshares. Andrew Marvell's speaker imagines a "vegetable love" that would grow "Vaster than empires, and more slow" ("To His Coy Mistress"). That is the measure of lignous time set against Zeal's empire. The forest also has a political precondition. Marco is away at the war, and the planting can go forward only when the war ends. "They shall beat their swords into plowshares … But they shall sit every man under his vine and under his fig tree" (Micah 4:3–4). The forest is the work of peace. The one who labours on it is a machine whose own kind, in his own century, has been turned into weapons.

6.3 Prometheus the Gardener: Robo Against the Fates

The series associates Robo with Prometheus. The Japanese text names the dome where he was found プロメテドーム, and the sequel calls him the Prometheus Circuit (Chapter 4, §4.5). In Aeschylus' *Prometheus Bound*, the Titan lists his two gifts to mortals. He stopped them from foreseeing their doom by settling "blind hopes" (τυφλὰς ἐλπίδας) in them, and "besides, I gave them fire" (248–252). The game's Prometheus gives neither. He gives a forest, a hope that can be watched as it grows. He gives no fire, only a stone made from trees (below). The Promethean figure moves from the register of fire to the register of wood.

The same play names the adversary. "Craft is far weaker than necessity" (τέχνη δ' ἀνάγκης ἀσθενεστέρα μακρῷ, 514). The chorus asks who steers necessity, using οἰακοστρόφος, "helmsman," the image behind Heraclitus' lightning that steers all things (Chapter 4, §4.8). Prometheus answers: "The three-formed Fates and the mindful Furies" (515–516). In *Chrono Trigger*, Prometheus meets one of the three.

Atropos. Atropos is the eldest of the three Fates in Greek mythology. Her name means "she who cannot be turned." In Plato's myth of Er, Lachesis sings of what has been, Klotho of what is, and Atropos of what is to come (*Republic* X, 617c). The game's Atropos belongs to the future. Unlike the other R-series robots she is pink and wears a blue ribbon. She was once Robo's girlfriend, and Mother Brain reprogrammed her to despise humans and those who sympathise with them.

Mother Brain governs the factory where both were built, which the Japanese text calls ジェノサイドーム, "Genocidome". The English clips the name to "Geno Dome." This is another disparity in which the English softens what the Japanese names outright. After the Day of Lavos, Mother Brain became unstable and set out to create "a nation of steel" to inherit the planet once it recovered. To that end she brainwashed the dome's robots and began abducting humans to kill them. Inside the dome, captured humans are carried on conveyor belts to their deaths. On the way through, Robo has to endure repeated offers to turn against humans or have his memory reset. He fights Atropos one-on-one, the only battle in the game he fights alone. After her defeat, Atropos reveals that Mother Brain manipulated her, and she dies after giving Robo her ribbon.

This would be tragedy, and in Aeschylus' terms proof that craft is weaker than necessity. But in the most common ending, Atropos is seen intact beside Robo in the altered 2300 AD (Chapter 4, §4.2). **The Fate named Unturnable is turned.** Hypertime restores what combat destroyed. In the history the commonwealth leaves behind, no Day of Lavos gave Mother Brain her occasion, so the Fate of the future was never reprogrammed.

One more detail completes the emblem. The Fates spin and cut the thread of life, and the Fate of the future leaves her opponent a ribbon, a length of thread from the one who cuts threads. Prometheus and Atropos are deliberate names. No source shows that the designers had Plato's assignment of the tenses in mind, so this is constellation, not documented influence.

Promethean shame. In *Die Antiquiertheit des Menschen* (vol. 1, 1956), Günther Anders described a modern "Promethean shame": human beings are ashamed of having been born rather than made, in the face of their products' humiliating perfection. He also described a "Promethean gap" between what humans can produce and what they can imagine or feel. In *Wir Eichmannsöhne* (1964) he traced the century's administered killings back to that gap. Mother Brain is the Promethean gap made sovereign: a product that has outgrown its makers and processes them on conveyor belts.

Robo inverts her. He shows no shame at having been made. He simply chooses the conditions of the born: a body that wears out over four centuries, attachment, and a place among the very people his factory kills.

A cyborg in a garden. Donna Haraway's "A Cyborg Manifesto" (1985) declared that "the cyborg would not recognize the Garden of Eden; it is not made of mud and cannot dream of returning to dust," and ended: "I would rather be a cyborg than a goddess." Robo half confirms her. He does not look for Eden or for an original unity, and Fiona's forest is new. He also half refutes her: the cyborg who cannot dream of returning to dust ends his labour rusted and still on a dais. Haraway's later injunction to "make kin" (*Staying with the Trouble*,

2016) fits him better. He makes kin across species and centuries with a human family and its trees.

Laputa's gardener. Chapter 3 promised Miyazaki. In *Tenkū no shiro Rapyuta* (*Castle in the Sky*, 1986), the floating island named after Swift's Laputa is deserted except for a robot that has outlived its makers. Moss covers it and birds nest on it. It tends the garden and lays flowers at a memorial. At the end, the island's weapons and machinery fall away, and a great tree, its roots wrapped around the levitation stone, carries the garden upward. Sheeta has told the man who wants to rule the island that whatever weapons he holds and however many robots he commands, 「土から離れては生きられないのよ」, "you cannot live apart from the soil."

Zeal is a Laputa without a gardener: its cities fall, and no one is left on them to tend anything. *Chrono Trigger* puts Laputa's gardener on the ground, in the desert below, where a forest is needed.

Miyazaki's *Kaze no tani no Naushika* (film 1984; manga 1982–94) supplies the larger model. A thousand years after the "Seven Days of Fire" (火の七日間) destroyed industrial civilisation, a toxic forest is spreading, and Nausicaä discovers that its trees are slowly purifying the poisoned earth. In Miyazaki as in the game, the answer to a world-fire is a forest that takes centuries. The Conclusion returns to Nausicaä's late chapters, where stored eggs and a planned future are refused.

Amber. When Lucca comes back from the red Gate (§6.4), Robo presents her with the Green Dream, which he made by compressing sap from Fiona's Forest within himself for centuries. One account calls it "a chunk of amber" produced from the sap of the surrounding trees. The item revives its bearer once. In Japanese, the event and the item share a name, 緑の夢, the "Green Dream," set against Zeal's Black Dream (Chapter 3). The forest's dream becomes a stone.

Amber is lignous time in crystal form: resin, the tree's own wound-sealant, hardened over ages. Ovid supplies its myth. Phaethon's ride sets the world on fire, a classical *ekpyrosis* in miniature. His sisters, the Heliades, mourn him until they become poplars, and their tears, hardened by the sun, drop from the new branches as amber, which the river carries to adorn Roman brides: *stillataque sole rigescunt / de ramis electra novis* (*Metamorphoses* II.364–365). After the fire, mourning becomes trees, the trees weep amber, and the amber becomes a gift.

The game repeats the sequence. After the Day of Lavos, a machine becomes a gardener, the garden's sap becomes amber, and the amber is a gift for a grieving daughter. Two etymologies tighten the knot. Greek ἤλεκτρον ("amber") gave William Gilbert the word *electricus* (*De Magnete*, 1600), so the electric machine makes *elektron*. German *Bernstein* means

"burn-stone," because amber burns. It is fire held in wooden form: a potential for burning that the forest's care keeps from igniting.

The English text adds a correspondence that should be recorded before it is interpreted. The monster that drained Fiona's soil is called the Retinite in the English. The Japanese text calls it メルフィック, rendered Melphyx in the later translation. "Retinite" is the mineralogists' name for fossil resin found in coal beds (from ῥητίνη, "resin"). So fossil resin is the destroyer and fresh resin is the gift. Under Rule IV, chiasmus is the signature of the double text. What lies dead and buried in the earth drains the living soil, which is Dukes' buried sunshine in monstrous form. What is living and freely given raises the fallen. Whether the localisers knew the mineral term is unknown.

6.4 The Name of the Most Beloved: Lucca, Lara, and the Red Gate

The hearth. After Robo's reactivation, all seven members of the party gather and spend the night in the forest, seven people from five eras around one fire. The Greeks had a goddess for such a fire. Hestia, the hearth, was the firstborn of Kronos: the first child he swallowed and the last he gave back. The Homeric *Hymn to Aphrodite* therefore calls her both eldest and youngest (5.22–23). The devourer of time swallowed the domestic fire first and returned it last.

The campfire in Fiona's Forest is a Hestian fire. It gathers and warms and does not consume, the opposite of the "big fire" whose name the commonwealth is fighting. Its natural keeper is Lucca, whose element is fire. Gaston Bachelard opened *La Psychanalyse du feu* (1938) with the fireside of his childhood and treated the hearth as the first object of reverie, an invitation to rest and to dream.

Around this fire the party gets philosophical about time and about places they would like to return to. That is nostalgia in the strict sense, the ache (*algos*) of return (*nostos*). Crono is passed out for the whole conversation: the silent centre sleeps through the philosophy (Chapter 5, §5.2). Robo has had a lot of time to think, and he doesn't believe Lavos is responsible for the Gates. He raises the possibility that they were made by an "Entity" "wishing them to witness everything they've seen", and that higher power is implied to be the suffering, dying planet itself. The member who lived through the duration is the one who arrives at a theory of time, and his theory is Chapter 4's: the Gates exist so that there will be witnesses.

The red Gate. After everyone falls asleep, Lucca wakes and finds a red Gate that takes her back to the day of her mother's crippling accident with Taban's machine. One Japanese account says she goes out alone at midnight as if led by something. Another says she comes

to the Gate 「偶然か必然か」, "whether by chance or by necessity," which is Kuki's question in a fan's words (Chapter 4, §4.6). The Japanese reference work dates the accident to 10 July 990 and calls the chance to undo it 「一度きりのチャンス」, a chance that comes only once. This is the very phrase of the prerelease script for the Time Egg (Chapter 5, §5.3).

The accident itself is simple. Lara, trying to clean the room, started the machine by mistake and caught the hem of her skirt in the conveyor belt. She called to Lucca to enter the password, but the little girl could not. Because the machine could not be stopped without the passcode, the young Lucca could not prevent the accident, and the strong regret this left her with is why she took up science.

The name. Taban's memo gives the hint: 「パスワードは最愛の人」, "the password is the most beloved person," meaning his wife, Lara. In the Super Famicom version the player must spell the name with the controller's own buttons, pressing L·A·L·A in order. Japanese does not distinguish *l* from *r*, so ララ could be romanised either way, and the controller has an R button. Japanese fans accordingly mark "×RARA ○LALA": RARA wrong, LALA right. The English version spells Lara with L, A, R, A. On the PlayStation, the sequence becomes L1, ○, L1, ○.

The password supports three readings.

1. **The machine obeys only the name of love.** The Mammon Machine answered to extraction (Chapter 3). Taban's machine crushes whatever it holds, and it can be stopped only by the name of the person its maker loves most. The beloved's name is laid at the machine's foundation, and the machine is safe only for those who know whom its maker loves.
2. **The name passes through the alphabet of the player's own machine.** The fictional password and the physical controller share their letters, so the player's hands, not the character's, type the beloved's name. The fourth wall becomes a keyboard.
3. **The PlayStation port turns the name into a verbal fossil.** L1-○-L1-○ is no longer a word. It keeps the shape of a name in an alphabet that no longer exists on the device, the way a fossil keeps the shape of a leaf in stone. The port keeps the rite and loses the word.

Two mothers, two belts. Robo destroys a "Mother" who runs conveyor belts of death. Lucca saves a mother caught on a conveyor belt. The assembly line, which Chaplin's *Modern Times* (1936) made the emblem of the century's machine, with the worker swallowed by the gears, appears twice among the sub-scenarios: once as genocide, once as a household accident. The two scenes belong to the two companions bound to each other by repair. Lucca has brought Robo back twice, and Robo gives Lucca the amber.

Reparation. Melanie Klein argued that a child's guilt over damage, fantasised or real, to the loved mother produces a drive to repair her, and that this drive underlies care, creativity and inquiry ("Love, Guilt and Reparation," 1937). Lucca's career fits Klein closely. She took up science to help her father build safe machines and, in the history where nothing is changed, also to make her mother walk again.

Bachelard gives the same story a Promethean name. His "Prometheus complex" gathers "all the tendencies that drive us to know as much as our fathers, more than our fathers," and he called it "the Oedipus complex of intellectual life." The party's fire-mage learns machines in order to surpass the father whose machine crippled the mother. *Chrono Trigger* does what no analysis can: it lets the reparative fantasy act on the original injury.

Success and failure. If Lucca succeeds, Lara is walking around the house, happy, when the party returns. A Japanese account says that the present-day injury becomes 「なかった」, something that "never happened," and the scare quotes mark how strange that is. The injury has not happened, and Lucca remembers it. This is testimonial hypertime inside one family (Chapter 4, §4.1). Because of the traveller's exemption, she becomes a scientist in both histories, and only the mixture of her motives differs.

If she fails, Lucca laments 「私が機械に詳しければ・・・」, "if only I had known more about machines…" The regret that made her a scientist is now confirmed by the scientist. Whether or not Lara's fate is changed, Lucca is brought back to the present, where Robo gives her the Green Dream. Whether to save Lucca's mother is left to the player, and success or failure is one of the events that shape the ending. **The consolation is unconditional.** Success is not paid in amber and failure in nothing. The daughter who saved her mother and the daughter who failed again receive the same gift of revival.

Ted Chiang's "The Merchant and the Alchemist's Gate" (2007) offers an instructive contrast. In Chiang's Baghdad, a merchant goes back twenty years through an alchemist's Gate of Years, hoping to save his wife, who was killed by a collapsing wall while he was away. He cannot change what happened. He can only come to know it more fully, and that knowledge heals him. Chiang's Gate obeys Lewis's self-consistent past; Lucca's does not. Yet in its failure branch the game reaches Chiang's ethics by another road: when the past refuses to change, a gift still restores something. The next section takes up Chiang's conclusion.

6.5 Three Bands of Iron: Frog, Cyrus, and the Forgiveness the Past Cannot Give

Iron Henry. The first tale in the Grimms' *Kinder- und Hausmärchen*, "Der Froschkönig oder der eiserne Heinrich," does not end with a kiss. The disgusted princess hurls the frog

against the wall with all her strength, and he turns into a prince. Then comes the half of the tale that the title keeps and readers forget. The prince's faithful servant Heinrich grieved so much when his master became a frog that he had three iron bands put around his heart to keep it from bursting. On the drive home the bands crack one after another. The prince, hearing the noise, thinks the carriage is breaking, and Heinrich answers: *Nein, Herr, der Wagen nicht, / es ist ein Band von meinem Herzen* ("No, master, not the carriage; it is a band from my heart").

Glenn is both figures at once: the knight turned into a frog, and the faithful companion whose heart is bound by grief for a lost master. The game even contains the tale's title character. Before the catastrophe, Cyrus and Glenn confronted the Frog King in a forest, and Cyrus defeated him and won the Hero's Badge. Glenn had refused knighthood, claiming that he lacked "the nerve it takes to be a knight" and that fear would overcome him in a real battle. When Magus struck, he told Cyrus to worry about himself rather than the well-being of others, a creed the commonwealth will reverse. Glenn recovered the badge from the scene of the fight and devoted his life to protecting Guardia and avenging Cyrus. An animated opening shows him leaving Cyrus's grave and walking away resolute. In Japanese the knight's name is カエル, and one of the verbs it sounds like is 帰る, "to return" (Chapter 1, §1.6). That is precisely what the Gates will not allow him.

The ghost in the loop. In 1000 AD the party cannot enter the Northern Ruins because of Cyrus's ghost. In 600 AD it cannot enter because the building is falling apart and needs repair. The ghost is invincible: neither techs nor ordinary attacks can harm it. In one player's record, Cyrus and Glenn recognise each other, and the ghost seems to struggle inwardly while still raging, caught in a loop the party cannot break. A ghost is duration without passage: four centuries of a single moment of grief, repeated. No violence can end it, and the Grimms' wall is useless here.

Tools from the future. The repair needs a gift across time. The party borrows tools from an idle carpenter in 1000 AD and takes them back to a carpenter in 600 AD, who agrees to repair the ruins. The present lends the past its tools, so that the past can open a grave to the present.

At the grave, Glenn feels guilt for not doing more, and Cyrus absolves him. His last words: "Look after Queen Leene." The Masamune rises into the air of its own accord and splits into Masa and Mune, who tell Frog that feeling sorry for himself only brings him down. Released, Cyrus moves on to the afterlife, and before he goes he empowers the Masamune. The Northern Ruins take a new name: the Hero's Grave. Counted the Grimms' way, three bands break:

1. Guilt, absolved by the dead man.
2. Self-pity, rebuked by the sword.

3. Lack of purpose, answered by a charge.

Forgiveness and promise. In *The Human Condition* (1958, §§33–34), Hannah Arendt identified two faculties that answer the two afflictions of action in time. Forgiveness answers "the predicament of irreversibility," the inability to undo what has been done. The promise answers unpredictability. Cyrus's farewell performs both. His absolution frees Glenn from the past, and his charge binds Glenn to the future.

Arendt also observed that people cannot forgive what they cannot punish. The ghost can be neither punished nor beaten. The scene happens because forgiveness is the only power that can reach him.

What the Gates refuse. The Gates could have taken Glenn back to the mountain to save Cyrus. They do not. One Japanese commentator reads this as the planet's will at work: it will not return Frog to a time before Cyrus died, and it will not give Magus a third attempt either. The knight's quest is therefore the one restoration that leaves the past exactly as it was. Cyrus stays dead.

What changes is the meaning of what happened, cut in stone. Before, the grave read: "Here lies Cyrus, the fool who defied Magus." Afterward: "Here lies the brave Sir Cyrus, whose spirits live with his true friend Glenn." History's verdict on a name is rewritten. This is Benjamin's dedication to the nameless (Chapter 4, §4.3) carried out with a chisel.

Vladimir Jankélévitch states the metaphysical floor beneath this mode: *Celui qui a été ne peut plus désormais ne pas avoir été* ("He who has been can henceforth no longer not have been," *L'Irréversible et la nostalgie*, 1974). He calls the fact of having been a viaticum, provisions for eternity. Cyrus has been. That cannot be undone, and it does not need to be. It can be renamed.

Chiang's merchant arrives at the same place, and his story ends: "Nothing erases the past. There is repentance, there is atonement, and there is forgiveness. That is all, but that is enough." *Chrono Trigger* contains Chiang's ethics as one of its modes, and the knight's quest is the instance. The game's other restorations go beyond Chiang, since they change the past. This one shows that the game does not need to change the past in order to restore.

The curse. The forgiveness leaves one thing unrestored, the knight's body. The variant of the main ending for players who fought and killed Magus, rather than recruiting him, shows the knight back in human form. The game thus turns the Grimm structure into a choice. One option is disenchantment through violence, like the princess's throw. The other is a commonwealth that includes Cyrus's killer, with the curse left in place. Derrida's paradox, that forgiveness "forgives only the unforgivable" ("Le siècle et le pardon," 1999), names what the second option asks of the frog. Chapter 7 takes this up as a constitutional question. Here it is enough to see that the game separates the restoration of a heart from the

restoration of a body, and lets the player have the body only by giving up the widest form of the commonwealth.

6.6 Inheritance Running Backward: The Sun Stone, the Gift, and the Raising of the Sparks

Zeal's energy transition. In Zeal, many people talk about putting a moon stone in a sunny place for many years. One of them points to the shrine on the southern continent and explains: a Sun Stone, once the source of this world's power, was kept there. When the kingdom began using its new energy source, it was sealed away like the north palace, and people claimed "we don't need the energy of this tired, old planet." With the advent of the Mammon Machine, the use of elemental energy was forbidden, and the items created with it were sealed in the North Palace.

This is an energy transition in the modern sense. A slow solar store gives way to an extractive source of seemingly unlimited power, and a monopoly outlaws the old supply. Contempt for a "tired, old planet" is the voice of panconvertibility (Chapter 3).

Buried sunshine. The stone needs constant sunlight for several million years before it holds enough to generate power. When it dims from use or lack of light it is called the Moon Stone. The Japanese name for its shrine is 光のほこら, "shrine of light," and the site appears in every era. The party sets the Moon Stone there in 65,000,000 BC. In 12,000 BC and 600 AD it is still where they left it, but in 1000 and 2300 AD it is gone. The Mayor of Porre has stolen it in 1000 AD and refuses to give it back. A merchant in his town sells Spiced Jerky for 9,900. In 600 AD the mayor's ancestor offers to buy it, and the party can sell it to her at a small profit or simply give it to her. Given freely, it leads her to raise her children to be generous, and as a result the mayor of 1000 AD is happy and returns the stone.

Recharged, the stone is put to several uses. It furnishes Taban's Sun Shades, Lucca's WonderShot and, later, Melchior's Rainbow, fulfilling old prophecies that the Sun Stone combined with the Rainbow Shell would yield incredible weapons and items. When struck, it releases beams of light, as Taban demonstrates during the Moonlight Parade in Leene Square.

The title of Dukes' paper names this stone exactly: buried sunshine. It charges from the age of the dinosaurs onward, the age whose deposits our own civilisation burns. It survives sixty-five million years untouched and is taken by the present the moment it comes within reach. The English ROM gives Robo an exact charge time, which the Compendium identifies as a fabrication of the English localisation team. The English counts what the Japanese leaves uncounted, as Dukes counts.

The quest answers the theft with a gift, not force, and the present puts the stone back in the light. In the end, sixty-five million years of stored sunshine light up a festival. This is the festal end of the lignous store (Chapter 8): stored time spent on celebration, not on extraction.

Swift's cucumbers. In the Academy of Lagado, Gulliver meets a projector who "had been eight years upon a project for extracting sunbeams out of cucumbers," to be sealed in vials and released to warm the air in raw summers (*Gulliver's Travels*, 1726, III.5). Swift's satire of the Royal Society is set beneath the flying island of Laputa, which rules the land below by withholding sun and rain, the vertical economy of Zeal (Chapter 3). The game takes the projector seriously and corrects only his timescale. Stored sunshine is possible, but it takes sixty-five million years, not eight. Patience redeems the project that impatience made ridiculous.

The jerky and the gift. Marcel Mauss's *Essai sur le don* (1925) described the threefold obligation to give, to receive and to return. Drawing on a Maori informant, he described the *hau*, the spirit of the gift, which seeks to go back to its source. Lewis Hyde's *The Gift* (1983) added that a gift must keep moving, and that it grows as it moves. The jerky is a pure case. It is bought in 1000 AD and given rather than sold in 600 AD. It travels down four centuries as a family's character and comes back to its givers as a stone charged with sunlight.

The *Yijing*'s commentary on the hexagram Kun states the law: "The house that accumulates goodness will surely have abundant blessings" (積善之家，必有餘慶). Japanese still says 積善の家に余慶あり. The Mammon Machine converted everything into its equivalent (Chapter 3). The gift refuses equivalence. The price was 9,900, the alternative was a small profit, and the choice to give rewrote a lineage.

Lent backward. Three threads run the same way:

- **The carpenter's tools** (§6.5).
- **Toma's libation.** The dead adventurer Toma asks, in 600 AD, that a drink be poured on his grave four centuries later. When the travellers pour it, his ghost appears and tells them where the Rainbow Shell lies. It is the oldest gesture toward the dead, Odysseus' libation at the edge of Hades, performed across four hundred years.
- **The Rainbow Shell.** This sequence involves the Rainbow Shell itself, Yakra XIII, the Rainbow Shard, and the items Melchior makes for the party. In 600 AD the party gives a giant shell into the kingdom's keeping. Four centuries later it is still there to clear a king accused of selling it, at a trial brought by a descendant of the impostor-monster the party unmasked in 600 AD. Chapter 8 treats this second trial in the game alongside Crono's.

Custody of a shell held for four hundred years answers the captivity inside a shell, Lavos's husk.

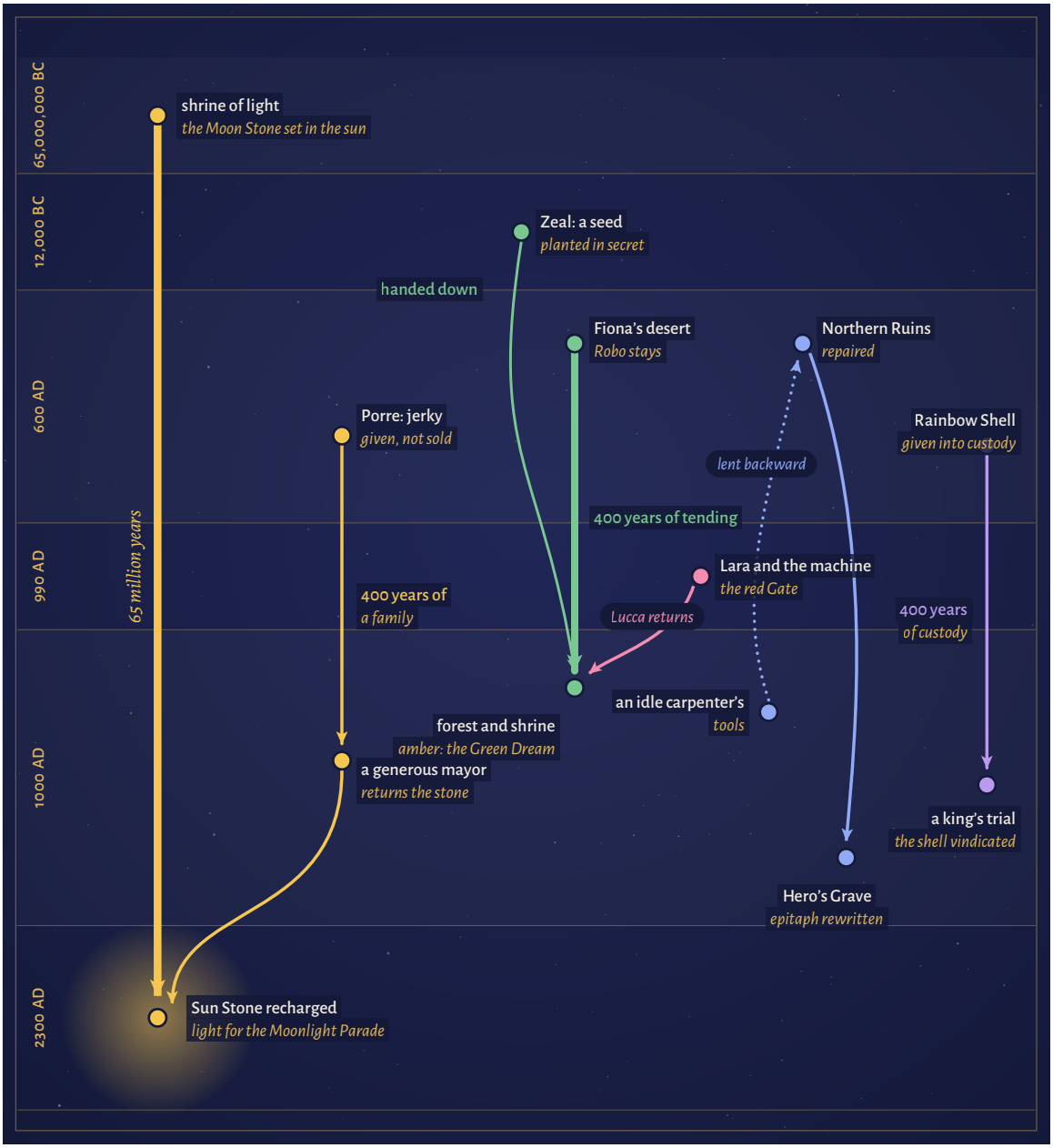


Figure 6 *Inheritance running through time: the threads of the sub-scenarios. Thick arrows mark durations someone or something must live through; the dotted arrow marks a gift sent from the present into the past.*

The breaking of the vessels. Isaac Luria of Safed (1534–1572), whose teaching Hayyim Vital recorded in *Etz Hayyim*, gave this pattern its classic form. Creation begins with God's contraction (*tzimtzum*), which makes room for the world. The vessels prepared to receive the divine light cannot hold it and shatter (*shevirat ha-kelim*). Sparks of light (*nitzotzot*) fall with the shards and are trapped in husks or shells (*kelippot*), which live on them. The human task is *tikkun*, repair: raising the sparks one by one through particular deeds. Gershom Scholem (*Major Trends in Jewish Mysticism*, 1941) showed how this cosmology made redemption a task carried out within history. The correspondence with the game is close:

- **The vessel breaks.** Zeal's catastrophe is the shattering. The Mammon Machine and its human conduit, Schala, whose English name suggests the German *Schale*, "bowl" or "shell" (Chapter 1), cannot contain the power drawn from Lavos, and the Ocean Palace shatters.
- **The sparks scatter.** The catastrophe flings the Gurus across history: Melchior to 1000 AD, Belthasar to 2300, Gaspar to the End of Time, Janus to 600 AD (Chapter 4, §4.5). Zeal's things scatter with them. The pendant reaches Marle, the Dreamstone blade becomes the Masamune, a seed reaches Fiona's altar, and the abandoned Sun Stone waits in a shrine of light.
- **The husk.** Lavos's shell lives on captured life (Chapter 2, §2.8).
- **The repair.** The sub-scenarios do the work of *tikkun*. Each raises a spark. Melchior's forge joins the Sun Stone to the Rainbow Shell. The seed comes to rest on an altar. Belthasar's last program guides the climb (Chapter 5, §5.3). Gaspar's egg is used (Chapter 5).

Origen restores all things at the end, by God. Luria repairs particular things now, by human hands. **The game chooses Luria.** This is constellation, not source. The pattern grows out of the shape of a role-playing game's side quests, not out of Safed. But the convergence goes deep. Chapter 4 (§4.3) cited a Japanese account of the sequel's Time Devourer, grown by absorbing the hatred and regret of lives erased from history. In Lurianic terms it is the husk fattened on sparks that were never raised. The sub-scenarios do the opposite: they resolve regrets (Fiona's, Lucca's, Glenn's) one by one. **Restoration starves the devourer.**

6.7 The Princess Without a Double: Schala as the Unrestored Remainder

None of the five modes reaches Schala.

- **Duration** cannot reach her, because she has been taken out of time.

- **Naming** cannot reach her, because no password stops the machine she served.
- **Forgiveness** has nothing to work on: she has done nothing that needs forgiving, and no one living can forgive on her behalf the wrongs done to her.
- **Inheritance** fails, because she has no line of descendants to carry a gift.
- **Substitution** fails, because she has no double (Chapter 5, §5.7).

Yet she gives without being restored. Her pendant opened the first Gate (Chapter 4, §4.4) and powered the egg (Chapter 5, §5.8). **The one left unrestored makes every restoration possible.**

Chapter 3 read Zeal alongside Le Guin's "The Ones Who Walk Away from Omelas" (1973), in which a city's happiness depends on one child's misery in a cellar. Some citizens leave for a place "even less imaginable to most of us than the city of happiness." The commonwealth's joy at the Moonlight Parade rests partly on the pendant of a princess who is not there. One member walks away. At the farewell, Magus says he will keep travelling through time in search of his sister (Chapter 4, §4.8). He is the one who walks away from Omelas, and he walks toward the least imaginable place in the series, the darkness outside time.

The later works follow him there.

- The DS edition adds an episode in which Magus confronts the Dream Devourer, a fusion of Lavos and Schala in the Darkness Beyond Time, and cannot bring her back.
- The sequel completes the fusion as the Time Devourer and introduces Kid, presented as Schala's clone, who stands to her almost as a daughter.

Chapter 1 asked what Schala's name, *Schale*, means. Chapter 5 asked what the shell holds. The sequel answers that the shell held a child. The princess who had no double in the frozen instant gets one only in another game, a living likeness, the means of her eventual release.

The sequel also opens on a fire. It tells that the orphanage Lucca kept was burned and that she died. The keeper of the hearth is consumed by the very element she tamed. The remainder does not stay quiet. It generates further history.

Gaspar's remark sharpens the contrast. Zeal "reverted back to a human." She received the worldly restitution, mortality. Schala received not even that.

Adorno turned Hegel's "the true is the whole" into *Das Ganze ist das Unwahre*, "the whole is the false" (*Minima Moralia*, §29). A restoration that claimed to be total would be false. Schala is the remainder that keeps the game's restorations true. She is the remnant Agamben describes (Chapter 5, §5.8), the sign that the whole can never coincide with itself. Jankélévitch's floor holds for her as well: she has been, and nothing can make her not have been. Benjamin's *Eingedenken* (remembrance) can make what was complete incomplete

again (Chapter 5, §5.5), and here remembrance keeps her fate open: in Magus' search, in the player's memory, in the sequels.

The fifth mode is therefore not a restoration but restoration's acknowledgment of its own limit. The work stages that acknowledgment as a departure and a vow to keep searching. **The acknowledged remainder is the condition of the restorations' honesty.** A game that restored everyone would be Origen's. This one leaves a princess in the dark and a brother walking toward her, and so it stays Luria's: a repair still in progress.

The table shows the chapter's result. Kairotic apokatastasis (Chapter 5) and chronic apokatastasis (this chapter) are two halves of one ethics. Every restoration joins an opening to a duration. Every duration is lived by someone on behalf of others. Every restoration but one leaves a remainder, and the last mode is that remainder acknowledged. Acts 3:19–21 placed the "times of refreshing" before the "times of restitution." The game lives in the interval between them, where the burning has cooled and the restoring has not yet finished.

Every restoration in this chapter took several members of the party:

- Robo's duration needed Lucca's repair.
- Lucca's naming needed Robo's forest, where the red Gate opened, and his amber.
- Frog's forgiveness needed a carpenter of 600 AD and tools from 1000 AD.
- The Sun Stone needed three eras and a stranger's generosity.

The campfire in Fiona's Forest, seven people from five eras around one Hestian fire, was the commonwealth's first full assembly. Its business was nostalgia, and its finding, Robo's, was that the Gates exist so that there will be witnesses. Chapter 7 asks what kind of political body these people make up. It considers a polity of non-contemporaries, the "simultaneity of the non-simultaneous" in Ernst Bloch's phrase, whose constitution is written in combined techniques. It considers what such a polity owes the Reptites, the one people it watches fall and does not save, under the gaze of Benjamin's angel. And it considers what happens when a commonwealth turns itself into an institution, in Chronopolis.

Table 6.1 *Five modes of restoration*

MODE	EPISODE	KAIROS (THE OPENING)	CHRONOS (THE DURATION)	WHO LIVES THE DURATION	WHAT IS RESTORED	WHAT REMAINS UNRESTORED	NEAREST COMPARANDA
Duration	Fiona's forest (600 → 1000 AD)	the monster's defeat; Robo's choice	four centuries of planting	Robo	a forest, a shrine, a seed's lineage, amber	Fiona and Marco's lives; Robo's worn-out body	Bergson's sugar; Giono's Bouffier; Laputa's gardener; Nausicaä's forest
Naming	Lucca and Lara (990 AD)	the red Gate, once	ten years of regret	Lucca	her mother's legs	if she fails, the injury itself (the amber is given anyway)	Klein's reparation; Bachelard's Prometheus complex; Chiang
Forgiveness	Frog and Cyrus (600/1000 AD)	the grave, once the ruins are repaired	a decade of guilt; a ghost's four-century loop	Glenn; Cyrus's ghost	a friendship; a name ("fool" → "brave")	Cyrus's life; no Gate to before his death; the knight's body	Grimm's Iron Henry; Arendt; Jankélévitch; Chiang
Inheritance	Sun Stone, jerky, tools, libation, Rainbow Shell	a gift, a loan, a pouring, a handing-over	65 million years; four centuries of a family and a dynasty	a stone; a household; a kingdom	the sun's stored power; a family's character; a king's honour	—	Mauss; Hyde; *Yijing*; Swift (as parody)
Acknowledged remainder	Schala	none: no Gate opens and no double exists	the search after the Gates close	Magus	—	Schala	Luria's unraised sparks; Adorno; Le Guin's walkers

広場

hiroba
“square”



Chapter Seven

7

The Heterochronic Commonwealth

Nicht alle sind im selben Jetzt da. Sie sind es nur äußerlich, dadurch, daß sie heute zu sehen sind. Damit aber leben sie noch nicht mit den anderen zugleich.

"Not everyone exists in the same Now. They do so only outwardly, by being visible today. That does not yet mean they live at the same time as the others."

— Ernst Bloch, *Erbschaft dieser Zeit* (1935)

ὁ δὲ μὴ δυνάμενος κοινωνεῖν ἢ μηδὲν δεόμενος δι᾽ αὐτάρκειαν οὐθὲν μέρος πόλεως, ὥστε ἢ θηρίον ἢ θεός.

"Whoever cannot share in a community, or needs nothing because he is sufficient to himself, is no part of a city; he is either a beast or a god."

— Aristotle, *Politics* I.2, 1253a27–29

一中一切多中一，一即一切多即一。

"In one is all, in many is one; one is all, and many is one."

— Uisang, *Hwaŏm ilsŭng pŏpkye-do* (the "Ocean Seal" of Huayan, 668)

Chapter 6 ended at a campfire. After Robo was brought down from his altar, all seven members of the party got together and spent the night in the forest. Around one fire sat a princess, an inventor and a silent swordsman from 1000 AD, a knight from 600 AD, a machine from 2300 AD, a chieftain from 65,000,000 BC, and the exiled prince of a kingdom that fell in 12,000 BC. That is seven people from five eras, with no present in common. This chapter asks what kind of political body they make up.

The double text gives a first clue in what it calls their shared acts. When two or three members fuse their techniques in battle, Japanese guides list the results under headings such as 2人連携技. The term *renkei-waza* means "linked" or "coordinated" techniques: 連 is "to join," 携 is "to take by the hand." The English versions count heads instead, with Double (later Dual) and Triple Techs. Under Rule II (disparity is data), the Japanese names the bond and the English names the number. A polity needs both, because it is a relation and also a quantity.

My argument is that the work stages three ways of making many into one, and that its politics lies in choosing among them:

1. **Incorporation.** Lavos makes many into one by swallowing them. Its outer body recites the forms of the bosses the player has already beaten (Chapter 2, §2.7).
2. **Combination.** The commonwealth makes many into one only for the length of an act, when techniques that each member owns separately meet in a shared instant.
3. **Administration.** Chronopolis, the time-research institution of the sequel, makes many into one by governing them through a central computer called FATE (§7.8).

I call the second the **heterochronic commonwealth**: a polity of non-contemporaries, united neither by a shared present nor by shared descent, but by a shared catastrophe and a practice of combination. The word "commonwealth" is chosen with care. Cicero defined the *res publica* as the affair of a people. A people, he said, is "not every assembly of human beings gathered in any way whatever," but one bound "by agreement on right and a community of interest" (*De re publica* I.25.39). The heterochronic commonwealth meets Cicero's terms with one change. Its community of interest is held across time, and its common wealth is time itself, held in common rather than converted, as Zeal converted it, or consumed, as Lavos consumes it. The chapter's thesis is political and temporal at once: **the heterochronic commonwealth is legitimate only for as long as it is temporary.**

Among the authorship layers set out in the Prefatory Note, this chapter draws mainly on the battle layer associated with Matsui. There, combination is a rule of play before it becomes a theme. The chapter proceeds in eight steps:

- §7.1: the theory of non-contemporaneity
- §7.2: the commonwealth's prototype and its literary kin
- §7.3: its constitution, written in the rules of combination
- §7.4: its Huayan form
- §7.5: its debt to the people it did not save
- §7.6: its key words, Remnant and Commons
- §7.7: its admission of the enemy
- §7.8: its corruption into an institution

7.1 The Simultaneity of the Non-Simultaneous: Pinder, Bloch, Koselleck, Foucault

The art historian Wilhelm Pinder coined the phrase *Ungleichzeitigkeit des Gleichzeitigen*, "the non-contemporaneity of the contemporaneous," in *Das Problem der Generation in der Kunstgeschichte Europas* (1926). His point was that painters at work in the same year belong to different generations, and so to different times. Karl Mannheim carried the idea into sociology ("Das Problem der Generationen," 1928).

Ernst Bloch made it a political diagnosis in *Erbschaft dieser Zeit* (1935). Weimar Germany's peasants, its ruined petty bourgeoisie and its young, he argued, lived in the present only outwardly. Their resentments and hopes belonged to older times, and fascism had learned to mobilise them. Bloch did not answer by dismissing what was out of step. He accepted a "duty to its dialectic." The unfinished past carries a surplus of hope that has never been realised, and a politics that leaves it to reaction loses it.

Reinhart Koselleck generalised the formula into a structure of historical time. In *Vergangene Zukunft* (1979) and *Zeitschichten* (2000), every present is layered like rock, holding strata of different ages that move at different speeds.

In *Chrono Trigger* the formula is no longer a metaphor. Bloch's peasants lived "in older times" only figuratively; Ayla lives in 65,000,000 BC. **The simultaneity of the non-simultaneous becomes a party roster.** The commonwealth is where non-contemporaries are made contemporaneous in fact: in a battle, at a campfire, at the farthest edge of time (Chapter 4, §4.5).

The commonwealth is founded at a screening. In the Arris Dome of 2300 AD, the three travellers from 1000 AD find a computer record of the Day of Lavos, which shows a creature rising from the earth in 1999 and raining fire on the world. Marle resolves that they will change it. So a political body is founded by an archive, and the archive records a future. Koselleck's title fits the scene exactly. For the people of the dome, the Day of Lavos is past. For the travellers it is future. After the commonwealth wins, it becomes a *vergangene Zukunft* in a sense Koselleck never meant: a future that will have passed without happening.

Koselleck's best-known pair of categories sharpens the point. Every present, he argued, holds a "space of experience" (*Erfahrungsraum*) and a "horizon of expectation" (*Erwartungshorizont*), and modernity is the age in which the two drift apart. The commonwealth reorders them. Robo knows from experience the ruined world that for Lucca is only an expectation. Ayla's present is Marle's deep past, and more than that: once Lavos is defeated, Ayla returns to 65,000,000 BC and marries Kino, and Marle is revealed to be descended from Ayla and

Kino. The princess of hope fights beside her own foremother. Hence the chapter's first formula: **in the commonwealth, one member's space of experience is another member's horizon of expectation.**

Two classic accounts of obligation across time take new shape here.

- **Burke's partnership.** Edmund Burke described society as a partnership "between those who are living, those who are dead, and those who are to be born" (*Reflections on the Revolution in France*, 1790). For Burke this was a figure of inheritance: institutions that none of the partners could see bound each generation to the dead and the unborn. The commonwealth seats the partners at one fire. Robo, from a century not yet born, sits beside Ayla, from an age long dead, and a dead sage's program guides their climb (Chapter 5, §5.3).
- **Jonas's ethics of the far future.** Hans Jonas opened *Das Prinzip Verantwortung* (1979) by observing that traditional ethics was an ethics of the near: "the ethical universe is composed of contemporaries." His imperative of responsibility for the far future has to work without reciprocity, because the unborn can neither make claims nor give thanks. The heterochronic commonwealth is an ethical universe whose members are not contemporaries, and inside it Jonas's problem disappears. The future's representative is present, speaks, and in Fiona's forest does the work (Chapter 6, §6.2).

Michel Foucault's lecture "Des espaces autres" (1967; published 1984) supplies the frame in space. Heterotopias, Foucault said, are often linked to "slices in time," which he called *hétérochronies*, and these come in two kinds:

- **Heterotopias of accumulation.** Museums and libraries hold "indefinitely accumulating time." They try to build "a place of all times that is itself outside of time."
- **Heterotopias of the festival.** Fairgrounds belong to time "in its most fleeting, transitory, precarious aspect."

The commonwealth moves from one kind to the other. It is founded by an archive, the Arris Dome's record. It is based at a place outside time that accumulates nothing, Gaspar's waystation. And, as Chapter 8 will show, it is dissolved at a fair. Lavos is the first kind of heterochrony turned predator: an archive of all times that eats what it stores.

The commonwealth also has the vessel Foucault called the heterotopia par excellence, the ship, "a floating piece of space, a place without a place." Its ship is the Epoch. The thesis borrows Foucault's word *heterochronic*, though not his sense of it. His heterochronies are places that break with ordinary time. The commonwealth is a body whose members come from different times.

7.2 Prototype and Kin: *Live A Live* and the Collected Company

The commonwealth has a prototype from its own studio. *Live A Live* (Square, 1994), directed by Takashi Tokita, tells seven stories set in seven eras, each with its own protagonist: prehistory, imperial China, late Edo Japan, the American West, the present, the near future, and the distant future. A medieval chapter then reveals what lies behind all seven. The knight Oersted sets out to rescue a princess. He is betrayed by his dearest friend, framed for his king's death, and repudiated by the princess herself, and he becomes the Demon King Odio (オディオ, from Italian *odio*, "hatred"), whose avatars haunt every age. In the final chapter, the heroes of the seven eras are drawn into Odio's domain and defeat him. A player who chooses to play as Oersted destroys them all instead. Tokita regarded *Chrono Trigger* as a rival to *Live A Live* (Prefatory Note), so this comparison rests on documented proximity, even where the readings are interpretive.

Three differences matter:

1. **Who gathers the heroes.** *Live A Live*'s heroes are summoned into the enemy's realm; Odio does the gathering. *Chrono Trigger*'s company gathers itself, one member at a time and by consent.
2. **The fate of the demon king.** Both games have a 魔王 (*maō*, "demon king"). It is the Japanese title of Odio and the Japanese name of Magus. In *Live A Live*, the demon king is where the gathering ends. In *Chrono Trigger*, he joins it (§7.7).
3. **The split figure.** *Chrono Trigger* divides Oersted in two. The medieval knight who loses his friend becomes Glenn. The prince who turns demon king through loss becomes Janus. The game then asks whether the two halves can sit in one company. *Live A Live* asked whether hatred can be overcome; *Chrono Trigger* asks whether it can be accommodated.

Speculative fiction offers a family of companies drawn from many times:

- Fritz Leiber, *The Big Time* (1958): soldiers recruited from every century to fight a Change War for unseen powers, resting between missions in "the Place" (Chapter 4, §4.4).
- Philip José Farmer, *To Your Scattered Bodies Go* (1971): everyone who ever lived wakes along one river, Richard Burton beside a Neanderthal, revived by unseen "Ethicals."
- Michael Moorcock, *The Dancers at the End of Time* (1972–76): decadent immortals collect time travellers into menageries.
- *Doctor Who* (from 1963): a Time Lord's companions, drawn from many centuries.

- *Bill & Ted's Excellent Adventure* (1989): historical figures collected for a school report, by two boys on whom a future utopia depends.
- Tezuka Osamu, *Hi no tori* (*Phoenix*, 1954–88): chapters that alternate between the remote past and the remote future and converge on the present.

Nearly all of these companies are collected by a power above them: Spiders and Snakes, Ethicals, immortal collectors, a Time Lord, a future that needs its founders. Those collected serve a design that is not their own.

Chrono Trigger raises the same suspicion and then sets it aside. At the campfire, Robo raises the possibility that the gates may not have been created by Lavos at all, but by an "Entity" wishing them to witness everything they've seen. The game implies that this higher power is the afflicted, dying planet itself. Even on that hypothesis, the Entity opens places of witness. It enlists no one. The difference is the one Cicero drew: a people is not "every assembly gathered in any way whatever." **A menagerie is collected; a commonwealth gathers itself.** Lavos, whose shell is a collection of the past's forms, is the supreme collector. The commonwealth is the refusal of that collection.

7.3 The Constitution in Combination

The commonwealth has no charter, but it has rules, and they are written in the battle system. Read as constitutional law, these rules establish six principles.

(a) Synchrony of the separately timed. Each character's gauge fills at its own speed, set by that character's own statistics, just as each member arrives from a different era. A combined technique appears only, as one guide puts it, "when the right characters share a turn". **The combined act is the instant in which tempos that do not match happen to coincide.** Bloch's formula, which §7.1 read as a fact about membership, returns here as a rule of action.

(b) Inclusion without conversion. A combination uses techniques that each participant has already learned alone, and its price is the sum of its component Techs' MP. Nothing is pooled into a common currency. No one gives up an element, and no one pays for anyone else. The Mammon Machine turned every quality into its equivalent (Chapter 3). Combination joins qualities without converting them.

(c) Equality among the six. Leaving Magus aside, six members can combine in pairs, and the guides count 45 Dual Techs in total, with Magus the only party member who has none. The arithmetic is exact. Six members make fifteen pairs, and every pair shares three Double Techs, so every bond has the same strength. In graph terms, the double-tech graph is complete and uniform: a constitution of symmetrical friendship (Figure 7).

(d) The triad, the hub, and the empty place. A Triple Tech unlocks as soon as its trio shares a battle with every component Tech learned, with no item needed; the exception is the Triple Techs without Crono, which also need a Gemstone equipped. With Crono present, any two of the other five can combine with him, and the ten possible pairs yield exactly ten such techniques. The silent centre of Chapter 5, the kenotic subject who empties himself so that others can enter, is the natural medium of the triad. When he is absent, an object has to stand in his place.

This is where the hero's death becomes a constitutional event. Before the Ocean Palace, Crono cannot leave the party: the commonwealth is a monarchy of the silent. After he returns, Japanese guides note that, from then on, when Crono is needed he must be placed in the party through the formation screen. He comes back as one citizen among seven. **The hero's death turns the monarchy into a republic, and his return confirms it.**

Two theorists of political bodies clarify the change. Ernst Kantorowicz showed how medieval jurists gave the king two bodies, so that the body politic could outlive the body natural (*The King's Two Bodies*, 1957). The commonwealth has no second body; it continues through concert, not succession. Claude Lefort argued that in a democracy "the place of power becomes an empty place," which no one may occupy or absorb into himself ("La question de la démocratie," 1983). The stones that make triads without Crono possible stand in that empty place without filling it. They are relics, not regents. Ephesians speaks of gathering all things "under one head" (ἀνακεφαλαιώσασθαι, 1:10; Chapter 5, §5.8). The commonwealth's recapitulation has no head, and its stones mark where the head used to be.

(e) The rule of three. On arriving at the End of Time with a fourth party member for the first time, the player quickly learns to stick to parties of three. Two older authorities explain why three is a meaningful number:

- Roman law held that "three make a corporation" (*tres faciunt collegium*, *Digest* 50.16.85).
- Georg Simmel showed that the triad is the smallest group in which a whole can stand over any one of its members, since a third party can mediate, profit, or rule (*Soziologie*, 1908).

A Gate admits no more than three. The commonwealth therefore always acts at the threshold where a group becomes a body, and never as a crowd.

Membership rotates: three act while the rest wait in reserve. This realises Aristotle's definition of the citizen as one who rules and is ruled in turn (*Politics* III.4, 1277b). It also extends the distributive principle of Chapter 6. Marx's slogan for the higher phase of communism, "from each according to his abilities" (*Kritik des Gothaer Programms*, 1875), gains a temporal clause: the member whose body can bear four hundred years is the one who lives them.

(f) Combination against incorporation. Thomas Hobbes made the commonwealth a single person: "A Multitude of men, are made One Person, when they are by one man, or one Person, Represented" (*Leviathan*, ch. 16). The 1651 frontispiece shows the sovereign's body built from the bodies of his subjects, under a verse from Job: *Non est potestas super terram quae comparetur ei*, "there is no power on earth to be compared to him" (Job 41:24, Vulgate). Job's Leviathan is a scaled, sealed beast of fire: "Out of his mouth go burning lamps, and sparks of fire leap out" (Job 41:19). Lavos, the big fire inside its spiked shell, answers to that description. Lavos is unity by incorporation: it re-presents the bodies of the past in its own body (Chapter 2, §2.7). The commonwealth refuses representation. No member acts for the others, and every common act requires each participant to act in person.

Three sources converge on the commonwealth's idea of power:

- Hannah Arendt: "Power corresponds to the human ability not just to act but to act in concert" (*On Violence*, 1970). Power belongs to a group, and lasts only as long as the group holds together.
- Edmund Burke, earlier: "When bad men combine, the good must associate" (*Thoughts on the Cause of the Present Discontents*, 1770).
- Peter Kropotkin, who gave the rule the force of natural history: "Therefore combine — practise mutual aid!" (*Mutual Aid*, 1902).

> **The commonwealth's constitution is written in the rules of combination: an act is common only when techniques each member owns separately meet in a shared instant, and no one contributes anything but what is his own.**

7.4 Indra's Net and the Host Who Changes

Chapter 4 (§4.7) read the End of Time through Huayan's ninth gate, in which separated ages are completed together. Two other gates in Fazang's ten describe the commonwealth.

- **The seventh gate, the realm of Indra's net (因陀羅網法界門).** It takes its image from the net that hangs in Indra's palace. A jewel sits at every knot, each jewel reflects all the others, and each reflection reflects again, "layer upon layer without end" (重重無盡).
- **The tenth gate, host and companions (主伴圓明具德門).** When any one dharma is taken as host, all the others become its companions, and any dharma can be host in its turn.

The commonwealth is an Indra's net of eras, in which each member's history contains the others':

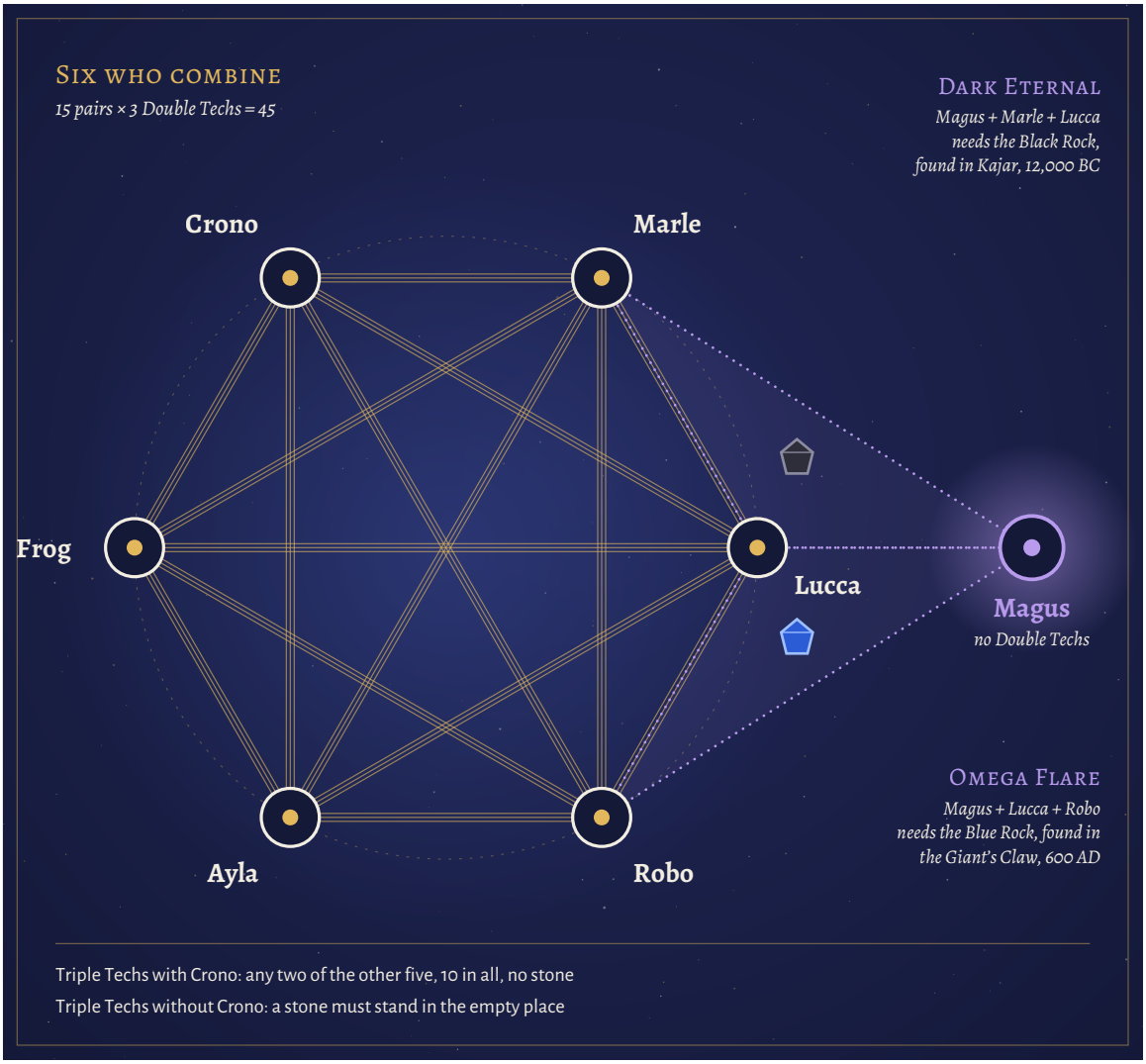


Figure 7 *The constitution in combination. Solid lines: every pair among the six shares three Double Techs. Dotted lines: Magus can act in concert only through two triads mediated by stones.*

- Marle descends from Ayla (§7.1) and from Queen Leene (Chapter 4, §4.2).
- Robo's four centuries become the forest standing in Lucca's present (Chapter 6, §6.2).
- The pendant of Magus's sister opened the first Gate and powered the egg (Chapter 5, §5.8).
- The Masamune is a single jewel reflecting four eras. Its Dreamstone comes from Ayla's age, a Guru of Zeal forged it, it was broken and reforged in Crono's present, and Frog wields it in 600 AD against Zeal's own prince.

I call this structure **reciprocal conditionality**: each member's history is a condition of another member's history.

Uisang, the Silla monk who studied under Zhiyan, condensed the doctrine into a seal-shaped poem of 668, whose single line winds through every one of its characters. One couplet states the ninth gate and the net together: 九世十世互相即，仍不雜亂隔別成, "the nine ages and the ten ages are mutually identical, yet unconfused and separately completed." *Unconfused* (不雜亂) is the Huayan name for what §7.3 called inclusion without conversion. The members interpenetrate, and none dissolves into another.

The sub-scenarios turn the tenth gate into procedure. In the Geno Dome, nothing will trigger unless Robo is at the head of the party. The reunion at Fiona's Shrine requires that Lucca be put in the party before entering. And at Cyrus's grave, one player found that nothing happened until Frog was swapped in. In his own restoration, each member is host and the others are companions. Then the host changes. **The commonwealth has no permanent centre; it has a host who changes.**

7.5 The Angel and the Reptites: What the Commonwealth Owes the Unsaved

In the ninth of his theses on history, Walter Benjamin describes Paul Klee's *Angelus Novus*. The angel faces the past. Where we see a chain of events, he sees a single catastrophe heaping wreckage at his feet. *Der Engel möchte wohl verweilen, die Toten wecken und das Zerschlagene zusammenfügen*: "the angel would like to stay, awaken the dead, and make whole what has been smashed." But a storm blowing from Paradise drives him backward into the future. "This storm is what we call progress."

The commonwealth is an angel who can stay. It can turn back through the Gates, wake the dead (Chapter 5), and piece together what was broken (Chapter 6). There is one place where it does not stay, and the work stages that place carefully.

At the Tyranno Lair in 65,000,000 BC, Ayla, Crono and one companion fight their way to the Reptite queen. Azala meets them with the question that frames the whole era: "Will it be the Reptites, or you silly apes who end up ruling the world?" The scene then unfolds in order:

1. Defeated, Azala says the heavens may have sided with the apes, and that the Reptites fought proudly to the bitter end.
2. She has seen a red star appear in the distance and believed it an omen of destruction against the humans; it proves instead to be an omen of destruction for the Reptites. As she lies dying, Azala laughs, realizing that the red star will soon fall to Earth.

3. She foretells that it will fall and wipe out the dinosaurs, and that after the cataclysm the Earth will grow cold.
4. Ayla names the falling star Lavos, "La" meaning fire and "Vos" meaning big. This is the catastrophic nomination of Chapter 1: the devourer gets its name in the hour it falls on its first people.
5. Ayla wants Azala to come with them; Azala refuses, because it is the will of the Earth; Ayla says she will not forget her; and Azala asks them to take care of this world.
6. Ayla and Crono flee as Lavos falls on the castle, destroying it and extinguishing the Reptites.

The English chapter is titled Unnatural Selection.

The commonwealth does nothing to stop the fall, and Chapter 4 (§4.2) explained why: the catastrophe that ended the Reptites is the condition of the commonwealth's own existence. The game has already shown the alternative. If Lavos is defeated before Azala is, Ayla, removed from prehistory without having defeated Azala, leaves history changed in an unexpected way: every person is now a Reptite. Humanity survives in that world, but subservient to the Reptites. In either history, Azala's question of who will rule is answered by dominion. The Dino Age ending reverses the dominion. It does not abolish it.

Azala's last words move outside her own question. A queen who spoke the language of selection, of species struggling for rule, ends with a commission: look after the planet. Kropotkin's "combine" and Azala's struggle meet in her final sentence, and the sentence is neither of them. It is custody. **The commonwealth's first commission came from the people it did not save.** The Conclusion builds its ethics on this sentence.

What does the commonwealth owe the Reptites? It owes them three things, each either staged or implied:

1. **Memory.** Ayla's promise not to forget is the countermeasure Chapter 4 (§4.3) found against chronophagy, which feeds on the unmourned. The promise is lodged in a lineage: the woman who swore to remember the Reptite queen is the foremother of the princess named Hope.
2. **Custody.** Azala's commission is wider than Jonas's imperative, which asks for the permanence of *human* life. The extinct queen asks the species that replaces hers to keep the planet.
3. **Refusal of triumph.** Benjamin's seventh thesis warns: *Es ist niemals ein Dokument der Kultur, ohne zugleich ein solches der Barbarei zu sein*, "there is no document of civilization that is not at the same time a document of barbarism." The Millennial Fair celebrates a kingdom's thousand years on ground the impact cleared. Chapter 8 must read the festival against the grain.

Jacques Derrida held that no justice seems possible without some responsibility "before the ghosts of those who are not yet born or who are already dead" (*Spectres de Marx*, 1993). The commonwealth is spectral in Derrida's sense: it includes the not-yet-born and takes counsel from the dead. The Reptites are the ghosts it cannot include, and the franchise knows they do not stay quiet. The sequel's chronology describes a world in which Lavos bypasses the planet, the Reptites survive, the ice age never begins, and, despite Azala's death, the Reptites wipe out the human race. There the Reptites evolve into the Dragonians, whose advancement rests on connection to the elements of nature rather than on technology, and who create a Dragon God to manage their city. When that city, Dinopolis, was pulled into the main history, the planet shifted it in to counter Chronopolis's arrival in the past; the time fortress's staff dispatched a force against the Dragonians and soon won, and FATE divided the Dragon God into six components. The Reptites' unlived history is defeated a second time, now by an institution that a member of the commonwealth helped to build (§7.8).

Their ruin also keeps the commonwealth's later goods. In 600 AD the Reptites' lair survives as the Giant's Claw. It holds the Rainbow Shell, which the party gives into the kingdom's keeping (Chapter 6, §6.6), and the Blue Gemstone, in a chest in the Giant's Claw in 600 A.D., which admits Magus to concert. The angel does not stay in prehistory. It comes back four hundred years before its own era to take what the dead left in their grave.

7.6 The Remnant and the Commons

After Zeal falls, the survivors gather on a sliver of land. Their meeting place is 残された村の広場, literally "Left-behind Village Square", and the DS version calls the settlement the "Surviving Village". There the Earthbound Ones and Enlightened Ones who survived the Fall of Zeal commune with the elders of the new village, shedding their prejudice against those who use magic and those who do not.

It was the despised who did the receiving. Before the fall, the citizens of Zeal had looked down on the Earthbound as filthy and primitive. After it, the Earthbound cared for the Enlightened survivors, built rudimentary tents, and chose a flat piece of land as a common meeting place. The village keeps the old system of Algetty under a wise chief, and its people live in huts reminiscent of those of 65000000 B.C. The floating world falls, and its survivors return to Ayla's way of living. In time the residents of the Last Village disperse to form the cities of the modern era. One fan reference work even suggests that the Last Village may be the original Truce, a name implying a resolution between two feuding parties. History after Zeal begins from a commons, not from a kingdom.

The commons has to be defended. It is briefly seized when Dalton appoints himself king of the survivors, and returned to the people after his airship is destroyed. It also holds a quieter test. Here stands the woman who was told to burn her Seed, who can be told to plant it if this was not done in Zeal Palace. The order of fire says burn the seed; the commonwealth's counsel says plant it; and Chapter 6's forest grows from that choice. The commons itself does not last: in time it recedes under the ocean.

Commons. The Japanese uses one word, 広場 (*hiroba*, "square"), both for the survivors' meeting ground and for the festival ground where the story begins, リーネ広場, Leene Square. The English separates the two as "Commons" and "Square," and in doing so brings in a vocabulary of political economy that the Japanese does not use. Under Rule II, the disparity is instructive.

Garrett Hardin's "The Tragedy of the Commons" (*Science*, 1968) argued that common resources open to everyone are ruined by each user's rational greed: "Freedom in a commons brings ruin to all." Elinor Ostrom's *Governing the Commons* (1990) answered with fieldwork. Communities do govern common resources sustainably, through rules they make for themselves: clear boundaries, collective choice, monitoring, and graduated sanctions.

Zeal was not a tragedy of the commons. It was an enclosure. With the advent of the Mammon Machine, the use of elemental energy was forbidden and the items created with it were sealed in the North Palace. A solar store once shared by all became a monopoly on extracted power. Marx wrote that the history of such expropriation is written "in letters of blood and fire" (*Das Kapital* I, ch. 26), and Zeal's history was written in fire. The Last Village is Ostrom's case after the enclosure collapses: survivors governing themselves by rules of their own making, at a common meeting ground. The commonwealth carries the same ethic across time. The Gates are a common resource that no one owns (Chapter 4, §4.5), and the rule of three works like one of Ostrom's design principles, a limit on use that keeps the shared resource from being overdrawn.

Remnant. Every member of the commonwealth has survived something:

- Crono survives death itself (Chapter 5).
- Marle survives her own erasure (Chapter 4, §4.2).
- Lucca survives a decade of guilt (Chapter 6, §6.4).
- Frog survives his friend (Chapter 6, §6.5).
- Robo survives the Day of Lavos and the reprogramming of his kind.
- Ayla survives a war between species.
- Magus survives his kingdom.

Isaiah named a son Shear-jashub, "a remnant shall return" (Isaiah 7:3), and prophesied that "the remnant shall return, even the remnant of Jacob" (10:21). Standard Japanese translations render the prophecy with 残りの者 ("those who remain") and the verb 帰る (*kaeru*), the "return" of the homophone cluster read in Chapter 1 (§1.6). That convergence is noted here, not interpreted. The Japanese name of the Last Village is built on the same verb of remaining. **The commonwealth is a remnant of remnants**, and its bottom layer is the people who were left behind.

The economy of magic. Magic itself becomes a remnant. Those born after this period are unable to use magic naturally, so the faculty that once defined a ruling caste survives only as a latent gift that has to be awakened.

That awakening happens at the End of Time. Spekkio lectures the party on the four elements, 天, 冥, 火 and 水: heaven, the underworld, fire, and water. The English localisation reshaped this cosmology:

- 天 was originally Heaven in Japanese, but was changed to Lightning because of Nintendo of America's policy against religious concepts in its games.
- The underworld became Shadow.
- The self-styled 戦の神, "god of war," became, in the same spirit, the "Master of War".

The English text secularises a cosmology into weather and optics.

Spekkio tells the party that long before they were born there was a kingdom where magic was everywhere and anyone could use it, that people began to abuse their power, and that it grew so bad that only fiends were allowed to use magic. He teaches by rite: the candidates must think magic and, starting from the entrance to his room, run clockwise along the walls three times. Buddhist sutras repeatedly describe the same act of reverence, circling a Buddha three times to the right (右繞三匝). That too is a constellation, noted rather than interpreted. So is the god's name. Spekkio changes form and grows stronger each time the party grows, and his name echoes the Italian *specchio*, "mirror."

Spekkio's school sorts the commonwealth into three classes:

- **Natives of magic.** Magus does not need to be taught, since he comes from the Magic Kingdom of Zeal.
- **Learners.** Crono, Lucca, Marle and Frog had the aptitude but could not use it until Spekkio's training at the End of Time awakened it.
- **Outsiders.** Ayla cannot be taught magic because her era existed before magic was discovered, and Robo cannot because he is not a living thing. One guide says Robo has no soul. Another explains that Spekkio is "unable to properly read his character".

These are Zeal's castes (the Enlightened, the aspirants, the Earthbound) without the hierarchy. The outsiders are the inconvertibles of Chapter 3, whom no economy of magic can price. Only Ayla's Charm could draw a Last Elixir from the Mammon Machine.

The commonwealth treats them with precision. Alone, Ayla is generally useless against Spekkio, since he cannot be harmed physically. Yet in the god's final form, "a double tech with a physical and magical component will hurt him." Robo's laser, too, is said by Spekkio to resemble the power of 冥, and in Omega Flare it joins Magus's darkness in what is generally considered the strongest of the special Triple Techs. **The commonwealth includes the inconvertibles without converting them, and in combination they become effective where neither magic nor strength alone is enough.**

7.7 The Enemy Admitted: Magus and the Politics of Concert

Zeal's fall and its aftermath belong to the scenario titled 古代の新王, "The New King of Antiquity." The title has two claimants.

The first is Dalton. He crowns himself over the survivors, seizes their commons, and fits the commonwealth's ship with the wings that will later carry it anywhere. He is expelled, and his one lasting contribution is the commonwealth's mobility.

The second claimant has no crown. To recruit Magus, the player speaks to him at the North Cape during scenario 23, 古代の新王. There Magus reveals that he is Janus and the prophet, and that the three Gurus and Janus were scattered across eras by Lavos's distortion of space-time; he offers to help revive Crono 「ラヴォスを倒すという大義のため」, "for the great cause of defeating Lavos". Meeting him brings up a choice, and answering "No" makes him join. The self-crowned king is driven out, and the rightful prince of Zeal is let in without a crown.

Albert Camus opened *L'Homme révolté* (1951) with a definition: "What is a rebel? A man who says no." His refusal, Camus added, is an affirmation from its very first movement. The commonwealth admits its enemy through a "No," and the No to combat is a Yes to membership. Carl Schmitt had founded the political on "die Unterscheidung von Freund und Feind," the distinction between friend and enemy, and on the real possibility of killing that this distinction implies (*Der Begriff des Politischen*, 1932). The commonwealth's most political act undoes Schmitt: it admits an enemy it could kill, on the ground of a shared object. The other path stays open. The player may fight and kill Magus, and Chapter 6 (§6.5) showed both the reward and the price: the knight's human body is restored, and the commonwealth's widest form is refused. That is Schmitt's path, and the game leaves it available.

The constitution sets the terms of admission precisely. Magus, as one guide says, "works well independently". He is the only character without a Dual Tech, and the only one who cannot learn a Triple Tech naturally; his Triple Techs require special stones. The Aristotle epigraph applies: whoever needs nothing because he is self-sufficient is "no part of a city," either a beast or a god. Arendt's distinction gives the political sense. Magus has strength, which she called "something in the singular, an individual entity." On his own he lacks power, which exists only in concert.

He enters concert twice, and only through relics:

- **Dark Eternal.** It joins him with Lucca and Marle and requires the Black Rock, found in Kajar in 12,000 B.C. by solving the book puzzle.
- **Omega Flare.** It joins him with Lucca and Robo and requires the Blue Rock, which lies in the Giant's Claw.

One relic comes from the scholars' city of his own lost kingdom, the other from the Reptites' ruin. The enemy acts in concert only through the remains of the two peoples Lavos destroyed.

Two further facts complete the reading of these triads.

First, Lucca stands in both of them. The inventor who stabilised the first Gate and keeps the commonwealth's hearth (Chapter 6, §6.4) is the member through whom the enemy is received. Greek custom had a rite for this. Thucydides tells how Themistocles, a fugitive, came to the house of Admetus, king of the Molossians, who was no friend of his. On the advice of Admetus's wife, he sat at the hearth holding the king's son, and Admetus raised him up and refused to hand him over (1.136–137). The enemy who comes as a suppliant is received at the hearth.

Second, Magus never combines with Crono, Frog or Ayla. He never acts with the hero, nor with the knight he cursed, nor with the member who stands wholly outside the economy of magic that he embodies. Frog may stand beside him in the same party, but no act ever binds them. Chapter 6 (§6.5) cited Derrida's paradox that forgiveness forgives only the unforgivable. The commonwealth does not demand that impossibility. It asks for coexistence without communion. **The commonwealth admits its enemy on the basis of a shared object, not a shared heart: Magus may fight beside Frog, but he can never act in concert with him.**

One witness recognises him first. In the commons, a young boy plays with Alfador, who follows Magus if he is present. Janus's cat survived the fall and lives in the Commons. Homer's Argos, lying neglected on a dung heap, recognises Odysseus after twenty years when no one else does, and dies (*Odyssey* 17.290–327). In the left-behind village, only an animal recognises the lost prince: the cat took him back before the commonwealth admit-

ted him. Afterwards, Magus begins traveling through time, looking for his sister. The enemy the commonwealth admitted becomes the one who searches for its remainder (Chapter 6, §6.7).

7.8 Chronopolis: The Commonwealth Institutionalised

The commonwealth's end is written into the main ending: the Gates close, and Lucca proposes dismantling the Epoch (Chapter 4, §4.5). The sequel shows what happens when the spirit of that proposal fails.

In the chronology of *Chrono Cross*, the events run as follows:

1. Belthasar arrives in the Future and begins building Chronopolis, constructing its supercomputer, FATE, from parts of the original Mother Brain computer. The genocidal "Mother" of the Japanese Genocidome (Chapter 6, §6.3) becomes the institution's brain.
2. Studying the flow of time, he discovers the fate of Schala. The remainder the commonwealth acknowledged becomes the institution's project.
3. He installs Robo as the Prometheus Circuit, a device meant to lock out access to the Flame if anyone should touch it and become its Arbiter, and builds the Neo Epoch, a time machine from which to watch his plan unfold. The circuit was Robo, who volunteered for the project, just as he volunteered for Fiona's forest.
4. In 2400 AD, Chronopolis attempts an experiment that could have given it "control over time itself". Instead, as Belthasar had planned, the resulting catastrophe throws Chronopolis far back into 12000 B.C., the era of Zeal's fall and the left-behind village.
5. There FATE terraforms the archipelago into its own paradise and settles the facility's workers on the new islands, erasing their memories. It guides them through terminals, the Records of Fate, which can "neurologically control its users".
6. It goes to war with Dinopolis. Chronopolis had centralised its command in FATE, the Dragonians theirs in the Dragon God.
7. Finally, its agent imprisons the Prometheus Circuit, and FATE dispatches it.

Read against this thesis, Chronopolis repeats, point by point, the catastrophes the commonwealth either suffered or allowed:

- **It repeats Zeal.** It is a sealed technocratic paradise built on a power source, the Frozen Flame (凍てついた炎, fire held still), and ruled through an oracle.
- **It repeats the Reptites' defeat** (§7.5).

- **It reverses testimonial hypertime** (Chapter 4, §4.1). The commonwealth remembers what no longer happened; Chronopolis makes its people forget what did.
- **It turns the ship into an observatory.** The Neo Epoch is the vessel of a planner, not of a crew. Foucault ended his lecture with a warning: in civilisations without boats, "dreams dry up, espionage takes the place of adventure, and the police take the place of pirates."
- **It fulfils Asimov's *The End of Eternity*** (Chapter 4, §4.5): time administered and optimised from outside.

Its treatment of Robo completes Chapter 6's reading of Prometheus. Prometheus stole fire for mortals. The Prometheus Circuit keeps fire from the institution by guarding the Frozen Flame against FATE, and the institution binds and destroys him for it. The Fates have caught up with Prometheus. Robo defeated Atropos, the Fate who cannot be turned (Chapter 6, §6.3), and now FATE, the machine named for all the Fates, switches him off. Aeschylus's line returns: "Craft is far weaker than necessity." Even inside the administration, the one member able to live through the long duration remained a custodian, and the administration punished custody.

Social theory has names for this passage. Victor Turner described *communitas*, the bond among people who stand together "betwixt and between" in the liminal phase of a ritual, and observed that spontaneous communitas soon hardens into normative and then ideological forms (*The Ritual Process*, 1969). Max Weber held that charisma "may be said to exist only in the process of originating," and that it is routinised into tradition or bureaucracy (*Wirtschaft und Gesellschaft*, 1922). The commonwealth at the End of Time is spontaneous communitas, a company on the threshold, outside time. Chronopolis is its routinisation. Tezuka's *Phoenix* had foreseen the end point: in its "Future" chapter, underground cities governed by computers go to war with one another and destroy humanity. That is a constellation, not a source.

Rome had a figure for the alternative. Livy tells how Cincinnatus was called from his plough to be dictator, saved the city, and gave up the office after sixteen days to return to his fields (3.26–29). Later dictators made the office permanent. The commonwealth is Cincinnatan: it holds extraordinary power over time and hands it back. Robo returns to a future grown green, Ayla to her marriage, Frog to his queen, and Magus to his search. **When the commonwealth turns itself into an institution, it becomes Zeal. It is legitimate only for as long as it is temporary.**

Table 7.1 *Three ways of making many into one*

	LAVOS	HETEROCHRONIC COMMONWEALTH	CHRONOPOLIS
Principle of unity	incorporation: the past's bodies recited in its shell	combination: owned techniques meeting in a shared instant	administration: a central computer (FATE)

	LAVOS	HETEROCHRONIC COMMONWEALTH	CHRONOPOLIS
Head	its core	none after Crono's death; a host who changes; stones in the empty place	FATE, built from Mother Brain
Relation to time	consumption (pyric)	custody and restoration	control ("over time itself")
Relation to memory	an archive that devours	testimony: remembers what no longer happened	erasure: settlers' memories wiped
Relation to members	food	companions; each in turn host	subjects under neurological control
Relation to the Reptites	destroys them	watches them fall; promises to remember; receives their commission	defeats their unlived history (Dinopolis)
Relation to the enemy	absorbs allies (Zeal)	admits Magus without communion	wars with a rival intelligence
Duration	65 million years of incubation	temporary: dissolves when the Gates close	perpetual: thrown back to 12,000 BC
Fire	the big fire	the hearth (Hestia)	the Frozen Flame, seized
Prometheus	—	the gardener	the lock, bound and destroyed
Political analogue	Hobbes's Leviathan; Job's fire-breathing beast	Arendt's power in concert; Ostrom's commons; Cincinnatus	Weber's routinised charisma; Asimov's Eternity

The table summarises the chapter's result. The three unities are the work's three political possibilities, and the game takes sides. Incorporation is the enemy. Administration is the sequel's warning. Combination is the form the work recommends, on two conditions it never relaxes: the commonwealth must include without converting, and it must end.

For the place where it ends, the Japanese text uses the same word it used for the survivors' meeting ground: 広場. The heterochronic commonwealth was founded by an archive in a ruined dome, reassembled in a left-behind village square, and dissolved on the last night of a festival in Leene Square. On that night, as Chapter 4 recorded, the Moonlight Parade passes, the friends say goodbye at the Telepod, and the Gates close. Foucault's two heterochronies frame its life: it begins in time that accumulates and ends in time that passes.

Chapter 8 turns to that second kind of time. It treats the Millennial Fair as the work's chronotope, its organising image of time and place, and reads in it:

- a millennium counted at the edge of 1999;
- a trial staged in the middle of a celebration;
- a carnival held under cosmic terror;
- multiple endings read as a palace of possible worlds;

- a New Game+ that asks whether play can repeat history without devouring it.



遊び

asobi
“play”



Chapter Eight

8

The Millennial Fair

Festal Time, Judgment, and the Repetition of Play

αἰὼν παῖς ἐστι παίζων, πεσσεύων· παιδὸς ἡ βασιληίη.

"Lifetime is a child at play, moving pieces on a board: the kingship is a child's."

— Heraclitus, fr. B52 (Hippolytus, *Refutatio* IX.9.4)

遊びをせんとや生まれけむ　戯れせんとや生まれけん　遊ぶ子供の声聞けば　我が身さへこそ揺るがるれ

"Were we born to play? Were we born to frolic? When I hear the voices of children at play, even this body of mine begins to sway."

— *Ryōjin hishō* (compiled by Go-Shirakawa, c. 1179), no. 359

Our revels now are ended. These our actors, / As I foretold you, were all spirits and / Are melted into air, into thin air … We are such stuff / As dreams are made on, and our little life / Is rounded with a sleep.

— Shakespeare, *The Tempest* IV.i

Chapter 7 left the heterochronic commonwealth on the last night of a festival. The game begins and ends in the same place. In its first scene Crono's mother wakes him to the sound of Leene's Bell, a scene echoed throughout the game. Its canonical finale closes on the Moonlight Parade and the unveiling of Nadia's Bell. Everything this dissertation has examined happens between those two bells.

This chapter reads the Millennial Fair as the game's chronotope, Bakhtin's term for "the intrinsic connectedness of temporal and spatial relationships" in art ("Forms of Time and of the Chronotope in the Novel," 1937–38). Doing so completes the scheme set out in the Introduction, which distinguished four ways of treating stored time:

- **Pyric** time burns it.
- **Ovular** time incubates it.

Lignous time grows it.

Festal time spends it.

My claim is that **festal time is the right way to spend stored time, because it consumes nothing it cannot renew, it judges what play has done, and it ends.**

The sections follow the agenda announced at the close of Chapter 7. In the authorship strata of the Prefatory Note, the Fair is the one site where all three layers meet. The main scenario opens its first Gate there, the sub-scenarios keep their doll there, and the battle system stages its first fight there.

8.1 The Square at the Centre of Time

The Fair celebrates a thousand years since the founding of Guardia and runs for several days in Leene Square, with games, prizes and events. The square has a history of its own: it was built after 600 AD to celebrate the peace reached with the Mystics after a bloody war, and its centrepiece is Leene's Bell, forged by Banta in the Middle Ages. Bakhtin made the public square the main stage of carnival. Chapter 7 (§7.6) showed that the Japanese text uses the same word, 広場 (*hiroba*, "square"), for the ground where Zeal's survivors met in common. In English, the square where history restarted after the fall and the square where the story begins are one word apart ("Commons" and "Square"). In Japanese they are not apart at all.

Mise en abyme. Before any Gate opens, the Fair already holds every era of the game, each in the form of play:

- **Prehistory as costume.** One attraction invites visitors to "Dance to a Prehistory beat with musicians dressed like cavemen."
- **Antiquity as commerce.** The swordsmith selling blades and armour is Melchior, the Guru of Zeal who was flung forward to 1000 AD.
- **The future as spectacle.** The robot Gato, "the singing wonder," challenges visitors to a battle and pays 15 Silver Points to anyone who wins. Japanese guides call him ゴンザレス (Gonzales). His English name is Spanish for "cat," a detail §8.7 will need.
- **The Middle Ages as relic.** This is the bell.
- **Time travel as an exhibit.** Lucca and Taban's new creation, the Telepods, is on show.

Chapter 7 (§7.1) drew on Foucault's two heterochronies: the museum, which accumulates all times, and the fair, which holds time at its most fleeting. The Millennial Fair is both

at once. **It is the game's mise en abyme: a museum of all eras, staged as a festival before the Gates turn it into history.**

A taxonomy of play. Roger Caillois sorted games into four kinds (*Les jeux et les hommes*, 1958): *agôn* (competition), *alea* (chance), *mimicry* (simulation) and *ilinx* (vertigo). The Fair contains all four:

- *agôn* in Gato's ring, the drinking contest and the strongman's bell;
- *alea* in the betting on the foot race;
- *mimicry*, quite literally, in Bekkler's Copycat game, where the player imitates his own double (Chapter 5, §5.7);
- *ilinx* in the Telepod, a machine built for the vertigo of vanishing and reappearing.

The plot erupts when the vertigo machine turns into a passage: Marle's pendant reacts to the Telepod, and a Gate opens (Chapter 4, §4.4). The first act therefore breaks Huizinga's "magic circle" (*Homo Ludens*, 1938) twice. The Gate turns play into history. The trial (§8.3) turns play into evidence.

The festival's coin. The Fair has its own currency, and it flows in one direction only. Silver Points can only be won at Leene Square. They can be traded for gold, ten points for fifty gold, or spent in Bekkler's lab, but nothing can buy them. Money cannot enter the festival, though the festival's winnings can leave it.

Huizinga defined play as an activity "connected with no material interest, and no profit can be gained by it." The Fair's one-way valve inverts the panconvertibility of the Mammon Machine (Chapter 3), where everything could be exchanged for everything. Le Goff opposed the Church's time of bells to the merchant's time of clocks (*Annales*, 1960). The Fair gathers both the bell and the market and puts them under the rule of play.

Its purest transaction is Bekkler's. The more faithful the imitation, the lower the price, until perfect attention makes the double free (Chapter 5, §5.7). That double is in stock before anyone has died. **Festal time incubates the opportune moment.**

Naming and the bell. The day begins with a forgetting that the player repairs: Crono's mother cannot recall the name of the inventor girl, and the player is asked to supply it. The bell supplies the day's metaphysics. Local legend holds that people whose meeting the bell heralds are fated, and Crono's meeting with Marle is one such meeting. A girl at the Fair adds that those who hear it ring are blessed with happy and fortunate lives. This is Kuki's ethics (Chapter 4, §4.6) turned into civic legend: a festival machine for converting chance into destiny.

The bell's own history closes a loop. It is forged in 600 AD in honour of Queen Leene, and the blacksmith can be seen forging it before the queen is rescued. So the bell that heralds the meeting was cast during the very crisis that the meeting will cause. A history the game

otherwise allows to be rewritten contains this one small self-consistent loop, of the kind David Lewis permitted (Chapter 4, §4.1).

I call the bell's regime **bell-time**: time that is struck, not burned. A bell stores nothing; struck, it gives off sound. It is the festal counterpart of the stone of stored sunlight that will be struck at the parade (§8.7).

8.2 Millennium: 1000, 1052, 1995, 1999

"Millennial" is a word from Revelation. The dragon is bound in the pit for a thousand years, "and when the thousand years are expired, Satan shall be loosed out of his prison" (Revelation 20:2–3, 7). The game's calendar keeps the same order. In 1000 AD a kingdom celebrates its first thousand years. At the end of the next thousand, in 1999, the creature sleeping in the planet's depths is loosed. Augustine read the thousand years as the present age of the Church (*De civitate Dei* XX.7–9). The chiliasts awaited them as a coming reign, and Norman Cohn traced that hope's revolutionary afterlife (*The Pursuit of the Millennium*, 1957). The game makes the millennium neither an age nor a reign. It makes it a fair.

The historical year 1000 has a legend of its own. Michelet imagined Christendom frozen by "the terrors of the year 1000." Twentieth-century historians (Focillon, *L'An mil*, 1952; Duby, *L'An mil*, 1967) largely dismantled the picture, though not without dissent (Landes). Rodulfus Glaber recorded a different image: soon after the millennium, the world seemed to throw off its old age and clothe itself everywhere in "a white mantle of churches" (*Historiae* III.4.13). Glaber met the millennium with building.

Japan met its own end-time with beauty. The Latter Days of the Law (*mappō*) were commonly reckoned to begin in 1052. In that year Fujiwara no Yorimichi turned his villa at Uji into the Byōdō-in, whose Phoenix Hall, completed in 1053, made Amida's Pure Land visible on earth just as the age of decline began. Its name recalls the phoenix of Chapter 2, and its river the Uji chapters of Chapter 5. These are constellations, not sources.

The second date carries a modern charge. Nostradamus wrote: "L'an mil neuf cens nonante neuf sept mois / Du ciel viendra un grand Roy d'effrayeur" ("In the year 1999, the seventh month, / from the sky will come a great King of Terror," *Centuries* X.72). Gotō Ben's *Nosutoradamusu no daiyogen* (1973) made the quatrain a Japanese bestseller, and its 恐怖の大王 ("Great King of Terror") a byword. Lavos fell from the sky in 65,000,000 BC and rises in 1999. I have found no statement by the developers linking their date to Nostradamus. The convergence is recorded here, not interpreted.

The game's release completes the constellation. Chrono Trigger went on sale in Japan on 11 March 1995. That was eight weeks after the Great Hanshin earthquake of 17 January,

whose fires burned whole districts of Kobe. It was nine days before Aum Shinrikyō released sarin on the Tokyo subway; the cult's founder had published his own readings of Nostradamus. The game was finished before either event, and no influence is claimed. But its first players met a fable of an averted 1999 in the very spring when a cult tried to bring an apocalypse about.

Murakami Haruki later set all six stories of *Kami no kodomotachi wa mina odoru* (*after the quake*, 2000) in February 1995, between the two catastrophes. In one of them, 「かえるくん、東京を救う」 ("Super-Frog Saves Tokyo"), a giant frog recruits a bank's loan collector to help him fight a worm asleep beneath the city. The worm has swollen on hatreds absorbed over long years and is about to cause an earthquake. They prevail, and Tokyo never learns it was saved. A Frog (カエル) against a monster under the earth, and a rescued world that cannot know of its rescue (Chapter 4, §4.1): this is constellation in the strict sense.

The festival promises no reign. Later editions add an animated scene of Guardia's fall in AD 1005. The kingdom that celebrated its first millennium does not survive five more years. Chapter 7 (§7.5) asked that the festival be read against the grain, under Benjamin's warning that every document of civilisation is also a document of barbarism. Read that way, the Fair's truth is not the kingdom's permanence but the peace its square remembers. **The game's millennium is a fair, not a reign: it celebrates a thousand years without promising another.**

8.3 The Trial: The Archive of Play

The festival's first consequence is a court. Believing that Crono kidnapped Marle, the Chancellor puts him on trial for the abduction of Princess Nadia, acting as prosecutor, while Pierre defends. The witnesses are people from Leene Square who dealt with Crono and Marle, together with people the Chancellor hired to testify falsely.

The evidence is the player's own play, shown again as flashbacks. Crono grabbed the pendant before checking whether the princess was all right, refused to return it, and tried to sell it to the merchant Melchior. An old man accuses him: "He ate my lunch right off the table!" Each juror's vote is keyed to one deed:

- trying to sell the pendant, or admitting to having been tempted by the princess's fortune;
- speaking to a little girl about her lost cat and never bringing it back;
- dragging Marle away from the candy booth until she calls him a kidnapper;
- eating the old man's lunch;

- for a seventh juror, lying at any point in the trial.

Kafka's novel opens: "Jemand mußte Josef K. verleumdet haben, denn ohne daß er etwas Böses getan hätte, wurde er eines Morgens verhaftet" ("Someone must have slandered Josef K., for without having done anything wrong he was arrested one morning"). Crono's trial inverts *Der Proceß*. K.'s court is invisible and his offence is never named. Crono's court is public, and its record of his deeds is complete.

The record is the game's memory of play. One player recalls taking the lunch for the equivalent of a treasure chest, and leaving Marle at the candy stall in the belief that the story would not advance otherwise. In this way the trial convicts the genre's habits. Since Horii's *Dragon Quest*, the role-playing hero has been allowed to search strangers' drawers and pots and keep what he finds. Here that licence is brought before a court, and the magic circle is revoked after the fact: what was done as play is entered as evidence. The first juror judges the hero as a small Mammon. His crime is trying to convert an heirloom into money.

The lunch is Augustine's pears. In the second book of the *Confessions*, Augustine and his companions steal pears they do not want, compelled by no need (II.4.9). He insists that alone he would not have done it. The game's justice is Augustinian in the same way: it rewards confession above innocence. The best outcome requires telling the truth: admitting that you started it, and admitting it if you stole something.

Then the verdict proves irrelevant. Even acquittal brings three days of solitary confinement, on the grounds that Crono ran off with the princess even if he did not kidnap her. Once Crono is in prison, the Chancellor goes around the court and changes the sentence to death. The Chancellor is not the Chancellor: the monster Yakra XIII captured him and took his place. Schmitt's definition fits exactly: "Souverän ist, wer über den Ausnahmezustand entscheidet" ("Sovereign is he who decides on the exception," *Politische Theologie*, 1922). The court's forms are observed, and the outcome is decided elsewhere by a monster wearing a minister's face. Kafka's world returns after all.

The escape founds the commonwealth. Cornered in Guardia Forest, Lucca opens a Gate, and the three vanish into another era, leaving the Chancellor confused. They come out in 2300 AD, where the record in the Arris Dome shows them the Day of Lavos (Chapter 7, §7.1). **The commonwealth is founded by fugitives from a monster's court, who then discover the monster's apocalypse.**

A second trial completes the jurisprudence. In the Rainbow Shell quest, the king of 1000 AD is accused of selling the shell, an heirloom of the realm. The accuser is again the impostor in the Chancellor's office. The king is acquitted because the shell had been kept in

the kingdom's custody for four hundred years (Chapter 6, §6.6). The two trials have three things in common:

- Both turn on converting an heirloom into money.
- Both are brought by Yakra's line, a lineage of impostors, set against the lineage of generosity founded by a gift of jerky (Chapter 6, §6.6).
- The second is won by custody.

> **The game's jurisprudence knows one crime, the conversion of the inconvertible, and one defence, custody.**

8.4 Carnival Against Cosmic Terror

Bakhtin's study of Rabelais (written 1940, published 1965) described carnival as the people's second life and "the true feast of time." It was a temporary liberation from the official order, and so it was "hostile to all that was immortalized and completed." No phrase better names the opposite of Queen Zeal, who wanted eternal life (Chapter 3, §3.6). Bakhtin also argued that the grotesque imagery of folk festivity overcame what he called cosmic terror, the dread of the immeasurable and the catastrophic, by turning it through laughter into a comic monster. The Millennial Fair stands under exactly such a terror. The Day of Lavos is coming, and the Fair is laughing before anyone knows.

The double carnival of the generals. The convergence announced in Chapter 1 belongs here. In Japanese, the demon king's three generals are condiments: ビネガー, マヨネー and ソイソー (Vinegar, Mayonnai, Soysau). In English they are rock stars: Ozzie, Flea and Slash. The Japanese draws on what Bakhtin called banquet imagery; the English draws on the modern carnival stage. By Rule III, an independent convergence marks structure. Both texts make the war of 600 AD a carnival war, fought by comic villains who survive to be fought again. When Ozzie is finally defeated, he declares that the past "is merely a dream." Carnival suspends categories as well as ranks. The Japanese text left Flea's gender open, and the North American release muted it (Chapter 1).

The fire as a game. Bekkler's dearest game turns the big fire into an attraction. "One of your team members is tied up and held over an open flame by a slowly-descending chain." The player throws beanbags to hold off monsters until he can reach the control that raises the chain. The Fair stages, as play, the rescue of a friend from the flame. Festal time domesticates the pyric.

Crowning and uncrowning. Bakhtin called the mock crowning and decrowning of the carnival king the primary carnival act (*Problems of Dostoevsky's Poetics*, 1963). The game performs it again and again:

- Dalton crowns himself and is driven out (Chapter 7, §7.7).
- The Demon King is uncrowned and admitted to the party.
- Queen Zeal's regalia are stripped from her hands (§8.6).

The largest uncrowning is an ending. In the Dino Age ending, every person is a Reptite, since the lizard-men became the dominant species with no Ayla to defeat them. We see the Fair of the opening scenes, hosted by the people the meteor destroyed (Chapter 4, §4.3). This is carnival's *mundus inversus*, the world upside down. Chapter 7 (§7.5) asked that the festival be read against the grain, and here the game does it itself: in a lower room of its palace of endings (§8.5), the people the commonwealth did not save hold their own fair.

The festival that will not end. Oshii Mamoru's *Urusei Yatsura 2: Beautiful Dreamer* (1984) shows the opposite case. For the students of Tomobiki High, the day before the school festival repeats without end. Their town turns out to be an island drifting through a void on the back of a giant turtle, which is Urashima's image (Chapter 5, §5.3). It is the work of the dream demon Mujaki, who has granted Lum's wish to stay with her friends forever. Time is released only when a *baku*, the dream-eater of folklore, devours the dream.

Festal time that has been arrested is a prison, a floating world once more. Faust stakes his soul on never saying to the passing moment "Verweile doch! du bist so schön!" ("Stay, you are so fair!", *Faust* I, 1700). Mujaki makes exactly that wish, and loses everything.

The DS edition's 夢喰い, the "Dream Devourer," belongs to the *baku*'s family but turns it around: the folk *baku* eats nightmares to free the sleeper, whereas the Devourer eats the dreamer. The sequel shows what arrested time does to the Fair. In *Chrono Cross*, Leene Square lies in the Dead Sea, where the Frozen Flame is kept. The festival has been preserved as an archive, which is to say killed.

Gadamer distinguished the empty time we fill or kill from the festival's fulfilled time, which has its own rhythm and is not counted but celebrated (*Die Aktualität des Schönen*, 1977). The Millennial Fair's time is fulfilled because it ends: the parade comes once every thousand years, at the close of the Fair. **Carnival defeats cosmic terror only on condition that it ends; a festival that will not end becomes the floating world again.**

8.5 The Palace of the Fates: The Multiple Endings

Leibniz closed the *Théodicée* (1710, §§414–417) with a dream. Theodorus sleeps in the temple of Pallas and is led through the Palace of the Fates. Each of its rooms shows a possible world, a possible destiny for Sextus Tarquinius. The rooms rise in a pyramid that grows more beautiful toward the summit, where the actual and best world stands. The pyramid "had a summit, but no base," and Theodorus faints with rapture at the top.

Chrono Trigger built such a palace for a documented reason: Kato devised multiple endings because the story could not branch (Prefatory Note). The Super Famicom, PlayStation and Virtual Console versions have twelve endings; the DS and mobile versions have thirteen. Which ending one sees depends on how far into the story one is when Lavos is defeated. The rooms are therefore laid out in time, and each answers a counterfactual: what the world would have been had the fire been put out at that stage. Because the Gate in the bucket at the End of Time leads directly to 1999, every stage of the story is a door to the end, a strait gate in Benjamin's sense (Chapter 5, §5.5). **The multiple endings are a census of counterfactual ends: each moment of the story is asked what it would have become had the end come then.**

Three differences from Leibniz matter.

1. **The palace has a base.** Lose to Lavos at any point except the battle in the Ocean Palace, and the game replays the destruction of 1999 and closes on the message "BUT... THE FUTURE REFUSED TO CHANGE". The base of the palace is the self-consistent loop of Chapter 4 (Table 4.1). The only ending in which time behaves as Lewis and Novikov require is the defeat. Resignation is the failure state.
2. **The palace has no single summit.** "Beyond Time" is canonical, and most fans call it the true ending. But the hardest ending to earn is another one, the Dream Project (§8.7). The DS edition also adds a post-game ending won against the Dream Devourer in Time's Eclipse. There are many summits and no theodicy. The game does not justify the actual world against the others; it lets the player live in them.
3. **The lower rooms are comedies.** In Leibniz, the worlds below the summit are worse. In *Chrono Trigger* they are funnier. In "Good Night," "A Nu tries to sleep through the entire credits roll while a frog refuses to let it." "The Successor of Guardia" shows "a 400-year-old 'wedding movie' of Frog and Queen Leene": the fairy-tale ending the main plot refused (Chapter 6, §6.5) is granted as farce. The Dino Age crowns the vanquished (§8.4). Even the ending without the egg is gentle. In "Reunion," Marle walks the Moonlight Parade alone, then finds Crono again by a lone tree.

The Palace of the Fates becomes a fairground of possible worlds.

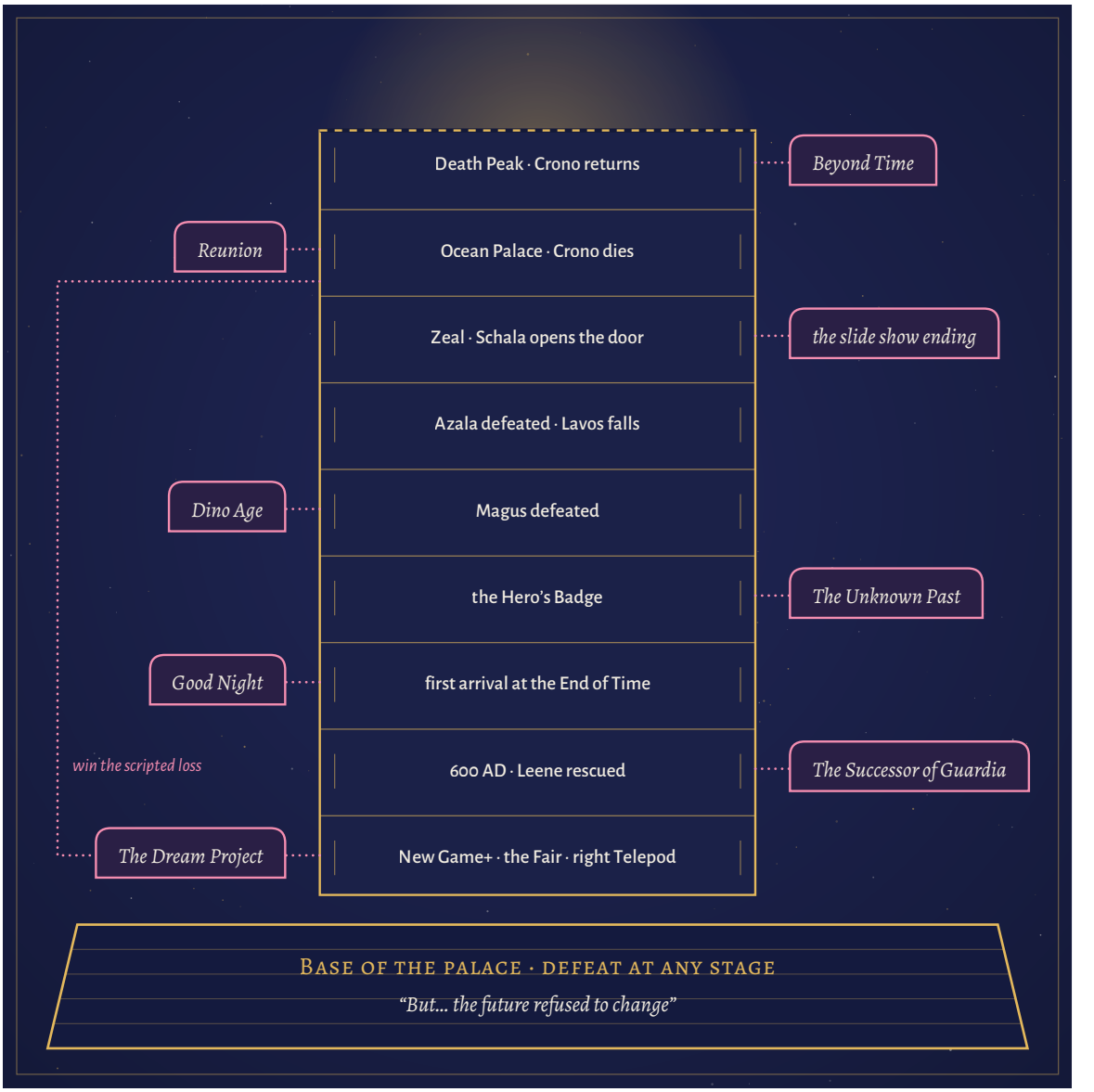


Figure 8 *The palace of endings, laid out along the story. Each ending answers what the world would have been had Lavos fallen at that stage. Several further windows lie between the stages shown.*

These windows rest on the guides: The Successor of Guardia comes after the return from 600 AD and before the first arrival at the End of Time; Good Night comes after the first arrival at the End of Time and before the Legendary Hero is heard of; The Unknown Past comes after the Hero's Badge and before the Gate Key is stolen in prehistory; the Dino Age

comes after Magus and before Azala; the slide show comes after Schala opens the door with her pendant and before the party powers up its own; Reunion comes any time after Crono dies, provided he is not revived.

8.6 Repetition: New Game+ and the Black Dream Thrice

The name came first in Japanese. The term 「つよくてニューゲーム」, "strong and new game," written in kana, was first used in *Chrono Trigger*, which did not, however, originate the system. The first game to start a second run with the first run's levels and techniques carried over was *Zelda II* (1987). Japanese players explain why this game needed the mode: many of its endings branch on the moment at which the boss is defeated. And in New Game+ a Gate to the Day of Lavos appears in the Telepod at Leene Square. The stereoscopic pair is instructive (Rule II). The Japanese name describes a quality of the player, strength. The English "New Game +" names an increment.

Nietzsche's gateway. Chapter 5 (§5.4) promised that Zarathustra's gateway would return. In New Game+ the festival's Telepod is a gateway where two lanes meet: the story's first day and its last touch at a single door, and that door's name could be *Augenblick*, "the moment." Nietzsche's demon asks the question this mode puts to the player: "Dieses Leben, wie du es jetzt lebst und gelebt hast, wirst du noch einmal und noch unzählige Male leben müssen" ("This life as you now live it and have lived it, you will have to live once more and innumerable times more," *Die fröhliche Wissenschaft* §341). Starting New Game+ is saying yes.

Kierkegaard's Job. Constantin Constantius states the principle: "Gjentagelse og Erindring er den samme Bevægelse, kun i modsat Retning" ("Repetition and recollection are the same movement, only in opposite directions"). What is recollected is repeated backward; true repetition is recollected forward (*Gjentagelsen*, 1843). The book's young man takes Job as his model, the Job to whom "the LORD gave … twice as much as he had before" (Job 42:10). But Job's children are not doubled. He has seven sons and three daughters again (42:13), and an old exegetical tradition explains that the first children were never lost. New Game+ follows Job exactly. Levels, techniques and goods carry over and multiply; the companions do not. They have to be met again, and Kuki's imperative (Chapter 4, §4.6) returns: do not let the encounter pass in vain.

Kuki's reprise. At Pontigny in August 1928, Kuki lectured on "La notion du temps et la reprise sur le temps en Orient." He described two ways of standing toward recurrent time. Buddhist wisdom seeks release from it. The will of *bushidō* accepts it and lives each return with moral resolve, so that even Sisyphus's labour could be a satisfaction, a passage often

compared with Camus's happy Sisyphus fourteen years later. New Game+ is a reprise in Kuki's sense, a taking-back of time: the story's recurrence lived by a will that has grown strong.

The Black Dream thrice. Chapter 3 left open whether replaying the Black Dream counts as a small chronophagy. The facts are these:

- The fortress can be fought through three times, by entering it in 1000 AD, 600 AD and 12,000 BC, in that order. The order is forced because beating it in Antiquity makes it vanish from the Middle Ages and the Present, so the runs must move backward.
- Chests opened on the first trip stay empty in the other eras.
- Every boss appears on the first run, and only Zeal on the second and third. Zeal returns, as one player put it, "apparently having no memory of the last time you fought her."
- The repetition yields regalia. A Prismatic Dress and a Prismatic Helm can be charmed from Zeal's two hands, and this can be done three times.

So the answer is double. In form, the triple run is chronophagous: it exploits the order of time for repeated gain. In substance, it is festal, for four reasons:

1. Stored goods cannot be harvested twice. The game refuses temporal arbitrage.
2. What recurs is the queen's defeat. She wanted eternal life, and receives recurrence without memory: Nietzsche's return without *amor fati*, the bad infinite of Chapter 3 played as farce.
3. What is taken is taken by the inconvertible (Ayla's Charm) from the expropriator. As Marx put it, "Die Expropriateurs werden expropriirt" ("The expropriators are expropriated," *Das Kapital* I, ch. 24 §7).
4. The movement runs backward, from the present toward antiquity. In Kierkegaard's terms it is recollection, repetition run backward.

> **Replay in *Chrono Trigger* is chronophagous in form and festal in result: it repeats the uncrowning, never the harvest.**

8.7 The Makers at the Edge of Time: Dream, Play, and the Last Night of the Fair

The hardest ending opens the shortest path. On a fresh New Game+ the player can face Lavos with two characters; the alternative is to win the Ocean Palace fight, which the game scripts as a loss. The reward is the Dream Project: the End of Time fills with the people of

the development team, and Gaspar invites the player to meet everyone who helped make the game.

The title is the game's own production name. It was planned as the "dream project" of Sakaguchi Hironobu, Horii Yūji and Toriyama Akira. Its television commercial promised 「僕らの夢がいま時空を超える」, "Our dream now crosses space and time."

The point is structural. Without the egg, the story's fated catastrophe can be refused only through play's own excess, the levels carried over from another run. That refusal is rewarded not with a story but with the workshop. Inside the fiction, the death can be undone only by the gathered, finite rite of Chapter 5. When the death is overruled from outside, the fiction dissolves into its makers. As Prospero says: "Our revels now are ended."

The dream chain. The Japanese text is organised around one word, 夢 (*yume*, "dream"):

- The floating fortress is 黒の夢, the Black Dream.
- Robo's amber is 緑の夢, the Green Dream (Chapter 6, §6.3).
- Entering Lavos from the Black Dream changes the save title to *Hoshi no yume no owari ni* (星の夢の終わりに), "At the End of the Planet's Dream."
- The makers' ending is the Dream Project.
- The DS edition's last enemy is the Dream Devourer.

History is the planet's dream. Its nightmare is a fortress, its hope is a stone of sap, and the whole is the makers' dream. The English breaks the chain at its darkest link: the Black Dream becomes the Black Omen, a sign pointing forward rather than a sleep. By Rule II, the disparity is the finding. The Japanese text dreams; the English text forebodes.

Zhuangzi's butterfly poses the question the Dream Project stages: 不知周之夢為胡蝶與, 胡蝶之夢為周與 ("I do not know whether Zhou dreamed he was a butterfly, or a butterfly dreams it is Zhou"). At the edge of time, the player meets the dreamers inside the dream.

Play and the child-king. Eugen Fink called play an "oasis of happiness" in the desert of our striving for happiness (*Oase des Glücks*, 1957). In *Spiel als Weltsymbol* (1960) he read Heraclitus's fragment, this chapter's first epigraph, as the world's own play. Aion, lifetime, is a child at play, and the kingship is a child's. Greek thought here offers its own counter-figure to Kronos (Chapter 2): time not as a father devouring his children but as a child who plays. The Heian song answers from the other end of Eurasia: born to play, the singer's body sways at children's voices.

Glorious expenditure. Bataille held that "le soleil donne sans jamais recevoir" ("the sun gives without ever receiving," *La Part maudite*, 1949), and that every system must spend its

surplus either gloriously, in festival and gift, or catastrophically, in war. The game stages both:

- Zeal and Lavos are catastrophic expenditure: the whole store of time released as fire.
- The Sun Stone, charged for sixty-five million years (Chapter 6, §6.6), releases beams of light when struck, as Taban shows during the Moonlight Parade.

> **Festal time is stored time spent gloriously instead of catastrophically.**

The last night. At the Moonlight Parade the heroes are put on show and then return to their separate times through a Gate near the Telepod. The king reveals Nadia's Bell in honour of his daughter. "This bell is a silver duplicate of the original." Balloons are tied to it, both as decoration and to ease its great weight. The festival's last act repeats the logic of the doll (Chapter 5, §5.7): a silver likeness that renews rather than replaces. It also supplies the game's last image of levitation. Zeal floated a kingdom on Lavos's power; the Fair floats a bell on balloons for one night. In the variant titled "Float Away", the lovers drift off with it.

Van Gennep divided rites of passage into separation, transition and incorporation (*Les rites de passage*, 1909). The parade is the commonwealth's rite of incorporation. Each member is returned to their own time, and the dissolution is the commonwealth's last constitutional act (Chapter 7, §7.8).

Follow that cat. Chapter 4 (§4.5) promised a festal answer to Asimov. In the variant titled "Follow that Cat!!!", Crono's mother chases a cat into the closing Gate, and the three friends set off after her in the Epoch. The machine Lucca proposed to dismantle survives, but not as an Eternity or a Chronopolis. It survives as a chase, begun by a cat at a fair.

Cats run through the game:

- The Fair's first sparring partner bears the Spanish word for cat.
- At the trial, one juror's vote depends on the order of encounters: never meeting the girl, or bringing her cat back before speaking to her, yields "Not Guilty".
- Janus's cat recognised the lost prince in the Commons (Chapter 7, §7.7).

The cat is the game's animal of contingency, Kuki's encounter in fur. **Time travel ends where it began: as play.**

Table 8.1 *Six forms of return*

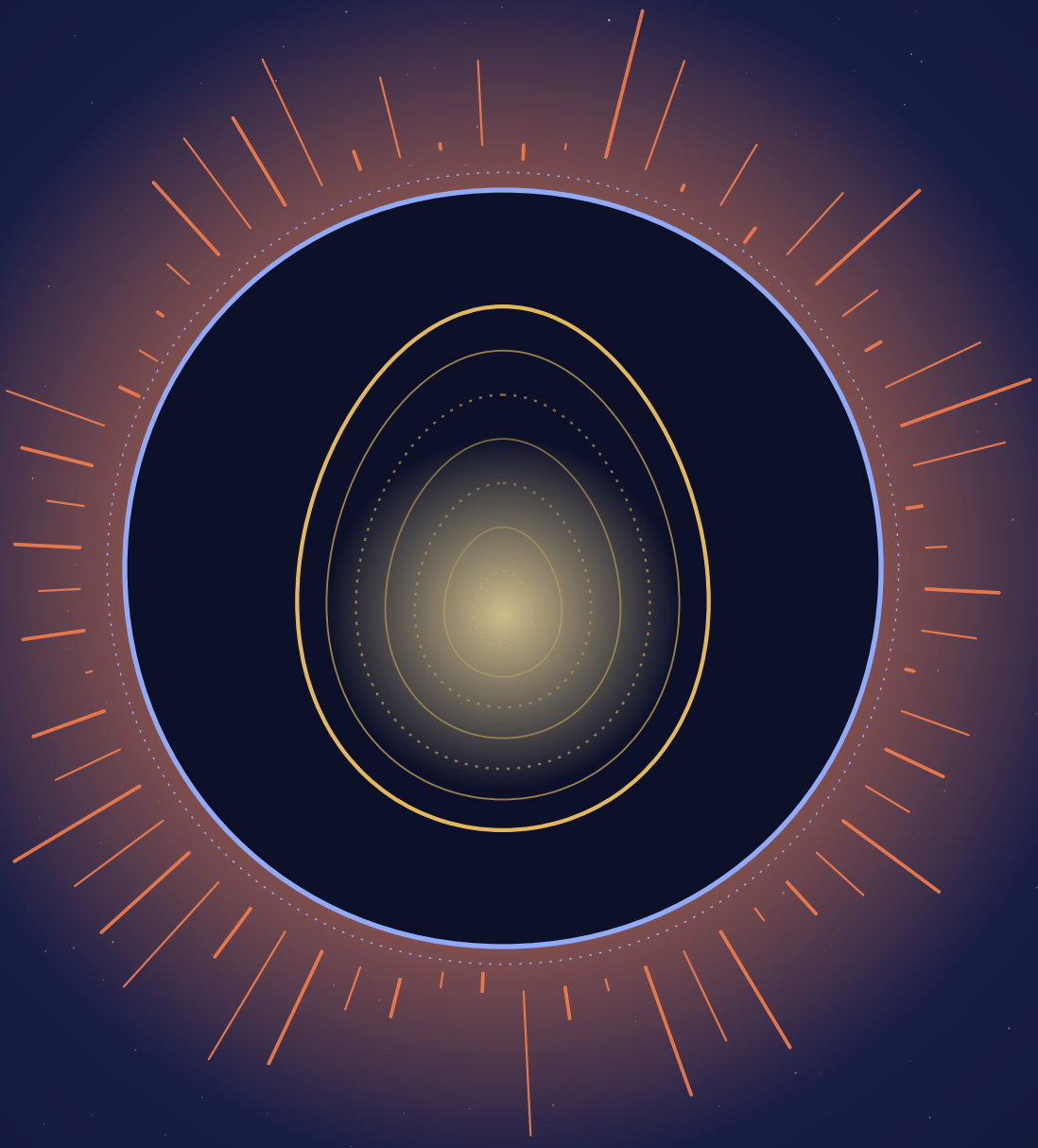
FORM	EXEMPLAR IN THE WORK	COMPARANDA	WHAT RETURNS	WHAT DOES NOT	REGIME
Recitation	Lavos's shell reciting past bosses (Ch. 2)	Stoic *ekpyrosis*; Hobbes's Leviathan	the forms of the past, as armour	the lives they held	pyric

FORM	EXEMPLAR IN THE WORK	COMPARANDA	WHAT RETURNS	WHAT DOES NOT	REGIME
Recurrence without memory	Zeal in the Black Dream, thrice	Sisyphus as punishment; Mujaki's endless festival eve	the defeat	memory; the treasure	pyric, as farce
Restoration in an instant	the Time Egg (Ch. 5)	Paul's "twinkling of an eye"; Rhea's stone	one friend, once	the egg; Schala	ovular
Repetition forward	New Game+	Kierkegaard's Job; Kuki's *reprise*	strength, goods	the companions (met again, not doubled)	festal
Recurrence affirmed	the Telepod gateway of New Game+	Nietzsche, *FW* §341; Zarathustra's gateway	the whole story	nothing in principle, yet the endings differ	festal
Festival return	the Moonlight Parade, once a millennium	Gadamer's fulfilled time; van Gennep's incorporation	the same festival	the commonwealth as a body: it dissolves	festal

The table states the chapter's result. The game knows six ways of coming back. Two belong to the fire, one to the egg, and three to the festival. Only the festal returns hold their goods without devouring them, and the last of them gives back the festival while letting its participants go.

The heterochronic commonwealth has gone home, and the bell has been lifted on its balloons. It remains to say what the whole work teaches: what the burning, the incubating, the growing and the celebrating of stored time have in common, and what single ethics the game sets against the big fire.





Conclusion

Conclusion

The Egg against the Fire

Toward an Oöchronic Ethics

וַיִּקַּח יְהוָה אֱלֹהִים אֶת־הָאָדָם וַיַּנִּחֵהוּ בְגַן־עֵדֶן לְעָבְדָהּ וּלְשָׁמְרָהּ

"And the LORD God took the man, and put him into the garden of Eden to dress it and to keep it."

— Genesis 2:15 (KJV)

Wenn ich wüsste, dass morgen die Welt untergeht, würde ich heute noch ein Apfelbäumchen pflanzen.

"If I knew the world would end tomorrow, I would still plant a little apple tree today."

— attributed to Martin Luther (unattested before 1944; see Schloemann, *Luthers Apfelbäumchen?*, 1994)

This dissertation has argued that *Chrono Trigger* is a speculative philosophy of stored time. Time accumulates in genomes, forests, stones, names, eggs and festivals, and the game's catastrophe and its remedies are all operations on that store:

- Lavos burns it.
- Zeal converts it.
- The Time Egg incubates it.
- Robo's forest grows it.
- The Fair spends it.

What remains is to state the single ethics the work teaches through these four regimes. I call it **oöchronic**, from ᾠόν ("egg") and χρόνος ("time"): an ethics of time held as an egg is held.

I. Three Incubations

The game contains three incubations, and its ethics lies in telling them apart.

Parasitic incubation. Lavos incubates inside the planet and feeds on its stored life (Chapter 2). It is an egg held *from* its host, and it hatches to consume. The big fire is a parasite's hatching.

Administrative incubation. Chronopolis stores a future and governs its hatching. It erases its settlers' memories and runs their lives through the Records of Fate (Chapter 7, §7.8).

The year before *Chrono Trigger*, Miyazaki completed the manga *Nausicaä of the Valley of the Wind* (1982–94), and its final volume presents the same figure. The ancients' Crypt of Shuwa keeps the technology, and the stored eggs, of a purified humanity, to be hatched once the poisoned world is clean. The present people, engineered to live with the poison, would not survive it. Nausicaä destroys the Crypt. She refuses a future planned for others at the cost of the living. This is a constellation, not a source.

Custodial incubation. The Time Egg is held by a sage *for* others. It hatches once, when the dead are "dear and needed" (Chapter 5). It breaks in hatching, and what it returns is a mortal life. Zeal's sealed chests state the same principle in its humblest form: a chest left closed in 600 AD yields a better gift in 1000 AD (Chapter 3). What is not opened grows.

The three incubations differ on three questions: for whom the store is held, until when, and at whose cost.

	FOR WHOM	UNTIL WHEN	AT WHOSE COST
Parasitic	itself	until the host is consumed	the host
Administrative	a planned future	until the plan is ripe	the living present
Custodial	another	until the moment of need	the egg itself, which breaks

> **Custody is the incubation in which the vessel is spent, not the life it holds.**

II. The Inconvertibles

Each chapter has met goods that no economy can price:

- a death, which cannot be bought back, only re-entered with a likeness won at play (Chapter 5);
- an heirloom, whose attempted sale is the trial's one crime (Chapter 8);
- the festival's coin, which money cannot buy (Chapter 8);
- a forest's four centuries, which cannot be compressed (Chapter 6);
- a beloved's name, the only word that stops the machine (Chapter 6);

- forgiveness, which no weapon compels (Chapter 6);
- two companions who stand outside magic's economy, Ayla and Robo (Chapter 7);
- Schala, whom nothing restores (Chapter 6).

The Mammon Machine, which converts everything, yields nothing convertible: no experience and no gold (Chapter 3).

The inconvertibles are not inert. They become effective in combination, as when a technique joining strength and magic wounds the god of war who resists either alone (Chapter 7, §7.6). Zeal's error was panconvertibility; the commonwealth's practice is combination. **The political form of oöchronic ethics is inclusion without conversion.**

III. Custody

The Hebrew of the epigraph assigns the first human two verbs: *le-ʿovdah u-le-shomrah*, "to work it and to keep it." *Shamar* means to guard, keep and watch. Its first refusal comes in the next chapter of Genesis: "Am I my brother's keeper?" (*ha-shomer aḥi anokhi*, Genesis 4:9). The two senses of *shamar* were divided between the game's two languages at Death Peak. The English "Keeper's Dome" took custody and the Japanese "Watcher's Dome" took vigilance (Chapter 5, §5.3).

Heidegger, who named the extractive essence of technology (Chapter 3), also named its counterpart. In "Brief über den Humanismus" (1947), man is "not the lord of beings" but "der Hirt des Seins," the shepherd of Being. In "Bauen Wohnen Denken" (1951), the basic trait of dwelling is sparing (*Schonen*), and mortals dwell in that they save the earth: "Das Retten der Erde meistert die Erde nicht und macht sich die Erde nicht untertan" ("Saving the earth does not master the earth and does not subjugate it").

Goethe had staged the opposite. In the fifth act of *Faust* II, the developer reclaiming land from the sea wants the old couple's lindens as a lookout. Philemon and Baucis are burned out with their trees. In Ovid, they had been rewarded for their hospitality by becoming an oak and a linden (*Metamorphoses* VIII). Faust then dies on his conditional "Verweile doch," gazing over a project that his own grave-diggers are digging. Marshall Berman called the play "the tragedy of development" (*All That Is Solid Melts into Air*, 1982). **Faust burns the lindens; Robo plants a forest.** Zeal is Faust's kingdom. Fiona's forest is Ovid's metamorphosis restored.

Bruno Latour later gave the name "the Earthbound" (*les Terrestres*) to the political subject who accepts living within the earth's limits, set against the "Humans" of modernisation (*Face à Gaïa*, 2015; *Où atterrir?*, 2017). In 1995 the English localisation had already called Zeal's

despised, magicless people "the Earthbound Ones." After the fall, it was they who founded the Last Village and cared for the Enlightened survivors, and history restarted from their common ground (Chapter 7, §7.6). The convergence is noted as such.

Dipesh Chakrabarty argued that anthropogenic climate change collapses the old distinction between natural and human history ("The Climate of History," 2009). Crutzen and Stoermer had named the resulting epoch the Anthropocene (2000). The game collapses the two histories in a single plot. One agent causes both the Reptites' extinction and humanity's apocalypse, and a party that includes a cavewoman and a robot spans deep time from the impact to the domes. Our own regime is pyric: we burn buried sunshine at Dukes' ratio of roughly four hundred to one (Chapter 6, §6.2). The game's answer to that regime is not prohibition. It is custody, joined to the festival.

The commission is the one Chapter 7 heard from the defeated. Azala's last request is that the victors take care of this world. Custody, in this work, crosses species.

IV. Twelve Theses on Stored Time

1. **Time can be stored.** Genomes, forests, stones, names, eggs and festivals hold time that took ages to accumulate. Every good in the work is a store of time (Introduction; Chs. 2, 6).

2. **Stored time can be burned, incubated, grown or celebrated.** These are the pyric, ovular, lignous and festal regimes, and they exhaust the work's relations to stored time (Table C.1).

3. **Chronophagy converts stored time into a single present.** Lavos and Zeal release in an instant what took ages to store. Panconvertibility is chronophagy's economics, and Zeal's hyperchthonic polity, the kingdom floating above the earth, is its political form (Chs. 2–3).

4. **Chronophagy is a usurpation, not the law of time.** The firewood abides in its own position (Dōgen). The past can be covered over but not consumed (Ch. 4).

5. **Every rescue is an erasure, and every erasure owes mourning.** Chronophagy feeds on the unmourned, and testimony is its countermeasure (Ch. 4).

6. **The past becomes open to deliberation only through encounter.** A Gate gives the past the modality of the present, which is contingency, and with it the duty not to let the meeting pass in vain (Kuki; Ch. 4).

7 **Restoration requires both kairos and duration.** It needs an egg and a forest: the times of refreshing and the times of restitution (Acts 3:19–21; Chs. 5–6).

8 **Duration is vicarious.** Someone must live through the years so that others can receive them in an instant. The commonwealth assigns the years to the body that can bear them (Ch. 6).

9 **The subject of restoration is a commonwealth of non-contemporaries.** It is united by combination, not by incorporation, as with Lavos, or by administration, as with Chronopolis (Ch. 7).

10 **The commonwealth includes without converting, and it is legitimate only while it is temporary.** It admits its enemy on the basis of a shared object, keeps no permanent head, and dissolves at a festival (Chs. 7–8).

11 **The festival is the right expenditure of stored time.** It spends gloriously what fire spends catastrophically, it judges what play has done, and it ends (Ch. 8).

12 **The work ends in custody, not completion.** It leaves a remainder (Schala) and a commission from the people it did not save (Azala) (Chs. 6–7).

From these theses follows one imperative:



THE OÖCHRONIC IMPERATIVE

Treat every store of time (a genome, a forest, a stone, a name, a festival) as an egg and never as fuel: hold it for another, let it hatch in its own time, and spend its surplus only in celebration.

V. Contributions and Limits

The dissertation offers five instruments:

1. **Stereoscopic reading**, a method for works that exist in more than one language. It treats disparity as data, independent convergence as structure, and chiasmus as the signature of the double text.

2. **Chronophagy**, an analytic category for speculative fiction.
3. **Kairotic apokatastasis**, a fifth model of return, distinct from recurrence, eschatology, revision and immortality.
4. **The heterochronic commonwealth**, a political form defined by combination and by its own impermanence.
5. **Oöchronic ethics**, the synthesis.

Its limits are those it declared at the start. Documented influence has been kept apart from constellation throughout, and the constellations make no claim about what the developers intended. The authorship strata are heuristic. The corpus is the Japanese original and the English versions, and the stereoscopic method should be tested against other localisations and retranslations. The natural next step is the writer's later work. Japanese readers note that *Chrono Trigger*, *Chrono Cross* and *Another Eden* share a scenario writer and that their themes connect. Those games, with *Radical Dreamers* and Tokita's *Live A Live*, are the field in which this thesis can be tested and corrected.

VI. The Egg and the Fire

The title of this dissertation names two objects. The big fire is Ayla's name for the falling star, a name given in the hour of catastrophe (Chapter 1). The Time Egg is the sage's gift, a moment held for a friend. Between the two, the game arranges everything else: the fire that eats what time has stored, and the egg that holds it for another.

The work does not end with the fire's destruction alone, nor with the egg's hatching alone. It ends with a bell lifted by balloons, a forest standing where a desert was, a mother chasing a cat into a closing Gate, and a princess still in the dark with her brother walking toward her. What it asks of those who play it is what the last queen of the Reptites asked of the apes: to take care of this world.

The big fire burns what time has stored; the egg holds it for someone else. Between them stands everything this dissertation has tried to describe: an egg, a forest, a bell, and a company that knows when to go home.

Table C.1 *The four regimes revisited*

REGIME	EMBLEMS	OPERATION ON STORED TIME	AGENT	FALSE FORM	ETHICAL REGISTER	CHAPTERS
Pyric	Lavos ("big fire"); the Mammon Machine; the Black Dream	releases ages in an instant	the devourer; the extractor	it is itself the false form of the others	catastrophic expenditure; panconvertibility	2–3
Ovular	the Time Egg; Zeal's sealed chests; the doll kept at the Fair	holds a moment for another until its hatching	the custodian: a sage, a mother, a friend	parasitic incubation (Lavos's brood); administrative incubation (Chronopolis; Nausicaä's Crypt)	kairotic apokatastasis	4–5
Lignous	Fiona's forest; the seed from Zeal; the amber; the Sun Stone; the "clone" as cutting	grows over durations that cannot be skipped	the gardener (vicarious duration)	enclosure and hoarding (Zeal's sealed Sun Stone; the stone stolen in Porre)	restoration through duration; *tikkun*	6
Festal	the Millennial Fair; Leene's and Nadia's Bells; Silver Points; New Game+	spends surplus in celebration, then ends	the commonwealth; the crowd; the player	the festival that will not end (*Beautiful Dreamer*); replay as harvest (refused in the Black Dream)	glorious expenditure; carnival against cosmic terror	7–8

Corrigenda

1. **Chapter 1, §1.3 and Table 1.1.** The prefatory erratum to Chapter 5 supersedes the contrast drawn here. Both texts name the egg "Chrono Trigger." The real difference between them lies in the verb (Japanese 孵す, "hatch," against English "use") and in the criterion for resurrection (the dead must be "dear and needed" in Japanese, "important to the space-time continuum" in English).
2. **Chapter 4, §4.3.** For "(§4.0)" read "(chapter introduction)."
3. **Chapter 5, preamble.** Marcel's play is *Le Mort de demain* (in *Trois pièces*, 1931), not *La Mort de demain*.

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- Chrono Wiki (chrono.fandom.com): entries on Doppel Doll, Norstein Bekkler's Tent of Horrors, Chrono Trigger (Item), Death Peak, Fiona's Forest, Sun Temple, Atropos XR, Geno Dome, Azala, Reptite, Unnatural Selection, Robo, Spekkio, Omega Flare, Eternal Darkness, Last Village Commons, Enlightened Ones, Chronopolis, Dragonian, Chancellor, Leene's Bell, Moonlight Parade, Millennial Fair, the endings list, and the Timelines of *Chrono Trigger* and *Chrono Cross*.

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- ときちけ「クロノトリガー考察１」 (tokitike.hatenablog.com).

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- スポットギークス.

- jpsern.

- neoapo.

Glossary of Coined Terms

- **Anti-pyric ontology** (Ch. 4, §4.7). Dōgen's view that what has been "abides in its dharma-position" and cannot be consumed by any later burning. On this view chronophagy usurps time; it is not time's law.
- **Archive of play** (Ch. 8, §8.3). The trial's use of the player's own deeds at the Fair as evidence. The magic circle is revoked after the fact.
- **Bell-time** (Ch. 8, §8.1). Time that is struck rather than burned: the festal counterpart of stored sunlight.
- **Bouleutic past** (Ch. 4, §4.6). A past that the Gates have made into an object of deliberation, against Agathon and Diodorus Cronus.
- **Catastrophic nomination** (Ch. 1). Naming that happens in the hour of catastrophe, as when Ayla names Lavos, "big fire."
- **Chronic apokatastasis** (Ch. 6). Restoration through lived duration. It is the complement of kairotic apokatastasis.
- **Chronophagy** (Ch. 2). The devouring of stored time, which turns ages into a single present.
- **Custodial, parasitic, and administrative incubation** (Conclusion). Three ways of holding a store of time: for another, from a host, or for a plan.
- **Festal time** (Introduction; Ch. 8). Stored time spent in celebration and then ended.
- **Heterochronic commonwealth** (Ch. 7). A polity of non-contemporaries held together by combination. It is legitimate only while it is temporary.
- **Hyperchthonic polity** (Ch. 3). Zeal's floating state, raised above the earth it drains.
- **Inclusion without conversion** (Ch. 7, §7.3). Combination that joins qualities without reducing them to an equivalent.
- **Inconvertibles** (Ch. 3; Conclusion). Goods that no economy can price: a death, an heirloom, a name, forgiveness, Ayla and Robo, and Schala.
- **Kairotic apokatastasis** (Ch. 5). Restoration within a seized instant. It has five marks: it is singular, heteronomous, substitutive without sacrifice, gathered, and finite.
- **Kairotic topology** (Ch. 4, §4.4). The Gates open onto charged moments, not onto a continuum.
- **Lignous time** (Introduction; Ch. 6). Time grown over durations that cannot be skipped.
- **Microcosmogony** (Ch. 5, §5.6). The world-egg compressed into one person's return.

- **Oöchrony; oöchronic ethics; oöchronic imperative** (Conclusion). Time held the way an egg is held: for another, until it hatches in its own time, with any surplus spent only in celebration.

⊙ **Ovular time** (Introduction; Ch. 5). Time incubated for another.

- **Panconvertibility** (Ch. 3). The convertibility of everything into everything else. It is the economics of chronophagy.

✳ **Pyric time** (Introduction; Ch. 2). Time that is burned.

- **Reciprocal conditionality** (Ch. 7, §7.4). Each member's history is a condition of another member's history.
- **Responsibility over plenitude** (Ch. 4, §4.4). Preferring a single history that can be overwritten to a plurality of branching worlds.
- **Stereoscopic reading** (Ch. 1). Reading the Japanese original and the English localisation as two images fused for depth. Its four rules: no primacy of meaning; disparity is data; independent convergence is structure; chiasmus is the signature of the double text.
- **Testimonial hypertime** (Ch. 4, §4.1). The second dimension of time exists only as the memory of those who crossed the Gates.
- **Traveller's exemption; genealogical clause** (Ch. 4, §4.2). Travellers are shielded from the changes they cause, except where those changes touch their own lineage.
- **Verbal fossil** (Chs. 1, 6). The shape of a word preserved after its sense is lost, as with L1-◯-L1-◯.
- **Vicarious duration** (Ch. 6). Years lived by one person so that others can receive them in an instant.

Keywords

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キーワード： クロノ・トリガー；時間論；時間旅行；時の卵；ラヴォス；ジール王国；魔神器；カイロス；アポカタスタシス（万物復興）；時間喰い（クロノファジー）；蓄えられた時間；非同時的なものの同時性；異時的共同体；偶然性（九鬼周造）；有時（道元）；華厳十玄門；連携技；守り（ケア）；修復；赦し；千年祭；祝祭；遊び；マルチエンディング；強くてニューゲーム；ローカライズ；立体視的読解；卵時間の倫理（オオクロニック倫理）.

